Play It With Feeling

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Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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M/M

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崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

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Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei & Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice & Cipher & Mydei & Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
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Play It With Feeling

by xxacheronrules69xx

Summary

In his sophomore year of college, Mydei's life goes so downhill that he stops persuing his piano performance degree entirely and drops out, breaking up with his boyfriend of six months in the process so that they can both continue to follow their true dreams.

A year and a half later, Mydei practically has everything he could possibly want: a feature with the biggest pop star in the world, a band that healed him from the darkest parts of his life, and one hit that he pretends he doesn't hate. He hasn't touched a piano in years and it's the happiest he's ever been, so why can't he shake the feeling that he's missing something?

Chapter 1: Overture (let the light in)

Chapter Notes

this stupid fucking fic has officially ruined my life to the point that my grades are slipping so i'm finally posting it to get it over with. it's nearly done, so after these first two chapters are posted updates will be posted every sunday evening.

disclaimer: i USED to be a pianist but quit when i was in middle school to focus more on violin instead, which i play to this day. therefore...i'm not really an expert on it at all. i'm not even a music student and my theory knowledge is severely lacking because i had an awful ap theory teacher in high school. but i'm passionate about music like i'm passionate about little else, i love rock music and classical music and everything in between and i hope that comes across with the way i've written these characters.

thank you so much for deciding to give this fic a chance and i hope you enjoy it as much as i enjoyed creating it. (for the most part, anyway...)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

albumoftheyear.org

CALAMITY - **Infinity**

Critic score: **80**
Based on 16 reviews

User score: **59**
Based on 5,283 reviews

DETAILS

March 12th, 3868 / release date
EP / format
IPC / label
Pop Rock, Alternative Rock, Alternative Metal / genre
Veritas Ratio, Dan Dewitt, Roseth Flowers, CALAMITY / producer
Oswaldo Schneider, Skott Veliche, Feinman Wilder / writer

TRACK LIST

1. The Undying **77**
2. Anything Goes **80**
3. Teeth **57**
4. Spirithief **66**
5. Glass Ghost **50**
6. Midnight **61**

USER REVIEWS

User: *deliverthedawn*
Rating: 68

Okay. It's good. But we already know CALAMITY is capable of writing incredible music after their debut EP, so why did their label insist upon pushing their creativity aside in favor of shoving their prewritten slop down our throats? It's not bad, of course, but it's not theirs, and it's glaringly obvious.

Favorite tracks: Anything Goes, Glass Ghost

Least favorite tracks: Midnight (seriously, I know Mydei would never put a trumpet in one of his songs…)

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August 29th, 3868. Eleven months before the release of Dreamscape.

Phainon's tablet dings loud enough for the shrill notification sound to cut through his practice session. He instantly stops, hands forming a dissonant sort of chord as he leans forward and squints so he can read his new notification more clearly.

It's from Hysilens. Her first text message is a link, and the second reads "New calamity interview. I think you gotta watch this one."

Phainon sighs. He's already made his decision before he thinks about it, really, and immediately presses on the notification. It takes him directly to their chat, sheet music long forgotten as he pulls open the link Hysilens sent. He rummages through his tote bag for his earbuds, pulling them out and connecting them to his tablet as the video loads. It opens with the interviewer's obnoxious voice cutting through his ears far too loud as she introduces her guests.

Cipher, bassist and co-producer; Hyacine, guitarist and sub-vocalist; Castorice, drummer and songwriter; and finally Mydei, lead singer, producer, songwriter—every title under the sun. Phainon feels his blood run cold as she lists off his many talents. Someone who doesn't even *know* Mydei, or his talents, not even in the slightest. She probably didn't even know the first thing about music to begin with.

Her first question is about the band name. It's a question Phainon can answer in a heartbeat—CALAMITY isn't big enough for it to be common knowledge, but he was *there*. When it was just Mydei, Castorice, and Cipher, and they were all laying on the floor of Aglaea's basement, laughing about their shared histories. The three titans of calamity, from Castrum Kremnos, Dolos, and Aidonia. So they named their band after old Amphorean mythology. Of course, Castorice answers this just as eloquently as ever, but leaves out the part where Phainon was there with them, too.

It's not relevant. He knows that. *He* is not relevant.

Phainon stares at Mydei while Castorice and the interviewer engage in a casual back-and-forth about mythology. He looks different, and Phainon

hates it. More rugged than he was in their undergrad years. His hair is longer, he has more tattoos, and he's grown even more muscular. He watches Castorice speak patiently, nodding along to what she's saying. Phainon hates that he's still attracted to him. He wishes *that*, at least, would change.

They talk about instrument origins next—why they all play what they play, why they decided to start a band. Phainon doesn't want to hear what Mydei has to say. His fingers linger beside his tablet, itching to turn it off, to switch back to his sheet music and keep practicing like nothing ever happened. But it's like he can't look away, as Cipher chimes in to talk about Aglaea adopting her and how she started playing upright bass for her orchestra.

Phainon knows the whole story inside and out, because he was there for that, too. He met her through Aglaea, when she started paying him to play with her orchestra. He knew her all throughout her rebellious streak, as her and Aglaea's arguments grew more and more frequent, and more and more heated. He knew her when she left for Paperfold, and when he eventually followed her. She's a talented musician, even if Aglaea would disagree due to where she's wound up. She has an ear for little things most people don't, and is much more intuitive than one might expect.

Hyacine answers next, with a story Phainon is not familiar with in the slightest. He doesn't know her like he knows the rest of them, and was shocked when he discovered that she was a part of the band after Mydei signed with his new label. Last he saw her, she was his chemistry TA and was a pre-med student. He didn't even know she played an instrument, and he thought he had known every musician at Paperfold.

Castorice explains how she, too, started playing drums with Aglaea's orchestra, but Phainon already knows the details of how she and Cipher grew close after joining the Grove's jazz band.

"I've been surrounded by music my whole life," Mydei starts, and Phainon feels his chest lurch. It's unfair. He knows the details of Mydei's upbringing like he knows every key of the piano; not because he was there, but because Mydei trusted him with it like he trusted no one else. And now he tells the

story like it’s no big deal. Not the details, but the story, and that’s bad enough. It feels like every last bit of Mydei that Phainon could hold onto are slipping through his fingers, slowly becoming someone else’s to hold.

“I got into rock music when I was a kid, started making it myself when I was a teenager. That’s when I taught myself guitar and started singing, but I didn’t actually work on my voice until it got serious and we actually started recording music.” Bullshit. Mydei always had a beautiful voice.

“You started on piano, correct?” The interviewer asks. Phainon groans out loud, resting his tablet against the keys so he can slam his forehead into the piano lid in front of him. For a brief second, Phainon thinks he can see the slightest hint of discomfort in Mydei’s face—which is a lot of discomfort by Mydei’s standards—but it goes away just as quickly as it was there. He still hates the interviewer all the same. “And you attended Paperfold University for a degree in piano performance?” As if it couldn’t get any worse. Phainon feels his distaste so deeply it hurts.

Mydei gives her a little curt nod. “We were all going to do something different,” he starts. “Cas was going to be an author, Hyacine was going to be a doctor, and Cipher…well, I don’t know—”

“Phishing scams,” she says without much thought. Mydei snorts a little bit at that, which doesn’t do much to alleviate the pit in Phainon’s stomach.

“Right,” he continues. “Anyways, I was going to be a pianist.”

“What changed?”

Mydei purses his lips, blinking a few times as he tries to come up with a suitable answer. Phainon could answer that for him a thousand times. He knew exactly what changed, because he was there. He was one of the things that changed. “We got the record deal,” is the answer he gives. Phainon bites his tongue so hard he thinks he might draw blood. “Being a rock musician was always my true dream.”

Of course it was. Phainon knows that. He always had. And he would have been there to support Mydei through all of it if he could have. But now their

lives are too different, too separate, to ever make it work.

“Of course,” the interviewer says with a smile. “Will we ever see you showcase your piano talent in the future?”

Phainon freezes. He doesn’t know what he wants Mydei to say. *No* would mean no one else ever got to hear his prowess ever again. But *yes* meant that *he* could, because he wasn’t a part of Mydei’s life anymore, and never would be ever again. At least if he played it with his band, Phainon could watch from afar. It would mean that leaving wasn’t all for nothing.

Mydei doesn’t answer immediately. He opens his mouth, hesitant.

Cipher cuts in for him: “No.”

Hyacine backs him up, too, and Phainon’s jaw tightens.

“For now, no.” Is Mydei’s final answer. He doesn’t elaborate anymore than that, even though Phainon wishes he would.

Phainon knows he should respect that answer. But piano was far more than just an instrument to the both of them, and both of them knew it. Phainon hates seeing Mydei able to throw it away so easily, like it didn’t mean anything more than it was. Like it wasn’t the whole reason they had met, or fallen in love, like Mydei hadn’t poured a decade and a half of his life into perfecting it.

Phainon stares down at the keys and for the first time in his life, he wishes he could throw it away as easily as Mydei had. Maybe if he had left with Mydei when he’d asked, things would still be okay for him. He hates himself for yelling at Mydei for daring to ask such a thing. Now, he wishes he had just packed everything up and gone.

When the interviewer brings up *Don’t Cry*, Phainon considers turning it off for the second time. The only song of Mydei’s he could ever hate. The only song he turned off, where he would rather sit in his car and listen to silence instead of listening to that godforsaken song. It was devastating, when their debut EP came out, to listen to the way Mydei sang about the break up that

was still fresh in Phainon's mind, like rubbing salt in an open wound. He didn't care what Mydei had to say—he could blame himself and claim he still loved Phainon all he wanted, but it wouldn't make it any better. The only song Mydei had ever written for Phainon was about their break up, while he dug up old love songs about Hephaestion to rework in his EP. Phainon hated that more than anything.

The worst part of all was that it was public knowledge that Mydei had dated "piano virtuoso Phainon Khaslana" in his college days. Anyone that knew anything about Mydei knew that. Mydei was a private person, but that wasn't. For whatever reason, he didn't want to keep Phainon hidden.

Mydei explains the break up again now, though it lacks details and is watered down. He calls it amicable, mutual, a good thing for both of them. He says they both needed to follow their own dreams, and they couldn't do that if they continued dating.

Phainon wishes more than anything that that was the full truth. He wishes they hadn't fought, but at the same time he wishes he had fought more. He shouldn't have allowed Mydei to walk away from him in the state he was in. He should have been there, no matter how much he had his own dreams to chase. He hates that he lacked the strength to abandon them for Mydei.

More than anything, he wishes it wasn't devastating. The way Mydei talks about it now makes it seem like it wasn't for him. *Don't Cry* is a song full of pity, like Mydei could see the way Phainon took their break up horribly but still didn't feel the same.

"This song is speculated to be about your ex-boyfriend, Phainon Khaslana," the interviewer continues. "Is this true?"

Phainon wants nothing more than to throw his tablet across the room. He does not, though, and keeps watching. Mydei's eyes flick towards the camera for a split second, and that's all Phainon gets to imply that this is anything more to him. "Yes, it was."

Phainon stops breathing. Mydei isn't done, but he pauses regardless. None of his bandmates want to take this from him, and the interviewer doesn't

want to interrupt him were he to give away more information.

“Phainon is the most talented musician I have ever met. I respect and admire him immensely.”

Respect and admiration. That’s it.

If Phainon wanted *respect*, he would have gone to the little kids from his old village. If he wanted *admiration*, he would have spoken to the undergraduate piano students he was helping to tutor. Not someone who had seen him at his worst, who had seen every single part of him laid bare. He would have hoped he was a little more than just a talented musician to Mydei, even if they’ve both moved on.

Who was he trying to fool? Only one of them has moved on.

He turns his tablet off before he can hear what else Mydei has to say about him. He doesn’t want to know any of it. He doesn’t want Mydei to continue to reinforce Phainon’s deepest fear: that Mydei simply doesn’t love him anymore.

He should’ve known, and that’s the worst part. It had been *years*, and it was only normal to move on from a break up in that time. Phainon’s experience is abnormal, the only reason he kept any semblance of hope that Mydei might share his old feelings. His hope should have died at Rach 2. The piece Phainon can’t even listen to anymore.

He closes the tab when he turns on his tablet again, and tells Hysilens to go fuck herself. He regrets it immediately and apologizes, a message Hysilens instantly reacts to with a laughing emoji. And then he turns back to his sheet music, and pretends nothing ever happened.

“Do you have somewhere to be?”

The concert hall is empty at this hour. Things weren't clicking in Anaxa's office, so they walked to the stage to see if the issues would fix themselves. Evidently, they did not.

"No, Professor," Phainon says. He runs his hands through his hair, trying to tame the mess for the nth time that day. He had forgotten to brush it this morning.

"Then why are you rushing?" Anaxa sits in the middle of the auditorium, arms crossed over his chest. Phainon thinks it's somehow worse playing for one audience member than a thousand.

"My mind is elsewhere," Phainon admits. "I'm sorry. I'll get it done, I promise."

"I know you will, that's not the issue," Anaxa answers. "If you're distracted tonight, we should stop. It's not worth either of our time."

Phainon remembers the day Madam Herta kicked Mydei out of their lesson when he didn't practice. That was the catalyst, wasn't it? One of them, anyway. He knows Anaxa doesn't suggest this from a place of malice, although maybe Herta hadn't, either. Still, he shakes his head. He can't allow Mydei and his stupid media-trained bullshit to win.

He sighs as he puts his hands on the keys. Remembers the concert clips he had watched just the night before, of Mydei's closing show in Castrum Kremnos from a month ago. It was a performance Phainon was already all too familiar with, because he had already watched it a hundred times.

He always thought Mydei looked incredible on stage, but this was on a different level. Mydei was *beautiful* under the colored stage lights, as a crowd of thousands sang his own lyrics back to him. Phainon would never get that glint in his eye out of his head. The way Mydei grinned, all teeth, the way his hair flowed behind him, the way he looked so *alive* and *carefree* in the way Phainon had never seen before.

Mydei always loved performing, even when he was a piano student, but it was never like that. He came alive on stage, but he was always still trapped

—he could never lose himself entirely when he didn't really want it. He never *wanted* to be a pianist, and he and Phainon were always different in that way.

When Phainon stops playing, he already knows it wasn't good. He doesn't look at Anaxa as he takes in his feedback, which isn't much different from what he just got. "Are you sure you don't want to leave early tonight?"

This time, Phainon accepts his offer. It wasn't like Anaxa was kicking him out. He wasn't like Herta, not at all. He would never treat Phainon the way Herta had treated Mydei.

He's never felt so alone as he trudges back upstairs, the repertoire folder hugged tight to his chest. He doesn't allow himself to feel like a failure. He knows his talent, and he knows Anaxa won't abandon him.

He meets Hysilens in the locker bay, fresh out of her own practice session. She raises an eyebrow when she sees him, closing her own locker and watching him begin to put in the code to his own.

"Someone's in a bad mood."

"Wasn't a productive session," Phainon mumbles.

"Have you looked at the Monti lately?"

Phainon glares at her as he pulls the lock open, and shoves his folder inside.

"That's a no."

Phainon slams the locker shut a little too loud. "My part of *Csardas* is easy. It's you who should be looking at it." He pushes the lock back through his locker and finally turns to leave.

"Okay, ouch," Hysilens starts, trailing behind him as he heads for the fire exit. "Who's fault is it if I can't keep in time, then?"

Phainon shoots her a look over his shoulder. "It's not a counting issue."

“Well, I *have* been looking at it—a lot, actually. It’s a fun piece, unlike the Bartok.”

Phainon mutters something unintelligible under his breath as he pushes the fire exit open, holding it open just enough for Hysilens to get through, because no matter how frustrated he is, he’s not going to let the door slam on someone.

“Okay, I feel like I should apologize,” Hysilens starts, following him as he heads towards the fire exit. “I probably shouldn’t have sent you that video. I didn’t know you were still, well, you know.”

Phainon was never angry with *her* specifically, so the fact that she’s apologizing is rather surprising. “We can’t all marry our high school sweethearts.”

Hysilens turns, raising an eyebrow at him. “Are you comparing Mydei to Cerydra right now?”

“You don’t think they’d get along?”

“Stop changing the subject,” Hysilens answers, “and stop thinking about him.” They arrive at the bottom floor, so she pushes open the exit door and they leave, hit with the cool late summer air. Campus is peaceful at night, but they turn towards the parking lot and walk to Hysilens’ car instead.

“Like you’d know,” Phainon mutters, a little bitter. “This is your first and only relationship. If you don’t marry her one day, I don’t know what to believe.”

“I think I know well enough that you should be over someone nearly three years after your break up.”

Hysilens unlocks her car, and Phainon climbs into the passenger seat. “Stop.”

“Stop what?”

“Pretending like you wouldn’t be in the same boat if you and Cerydra broke up after everything.”

“Well, we won’t,” Hysilens starts, turning her key in the ignition as she sheds her jacket and tosses it to the back seat. “Besides, Phainon…you weren’t even dating Mydei for a year.”

Phainon knows this, and he knows that she’s right. There’s no reason for him to be as hung up about it as he is, but he can’t watch all of Mydei’s dreams come true and not feel the same way he did before.

“Why don’t you just go after him?” Hysilens suggests, after they’ve sat in their shared silence for too long and she pulls out of the parking lot. “Maybe you’ll get lucky and he’ll go after his favorite groupie.”

“I won’t,” Phainon pouts, and he knows he does. “His girlfriend.”

“*Girlfriend?*” Hysilens yelps, nearly speeding through a stop sign in her shock. “Sorry,” she says, after Phainon jolts forward when she slams on the brakes. “I think you neglected that minor detail.”

Phainon groans, leaning forward to rest his head in his hands. “He brought her to the Rach 2 concert.”

“Phainon, you *never* told me this.”

“I know.”

A beat of silence passes on her end. “Was it serious?”

“Is two months serious?”

“Oh, Kephale.”

“What!”

“Remind yourself where you were when Mydei promised you he’d watch you play Rach 2,” Hysilens says, reaching over the console to pat his thigh. “Yeah?”

Now Phainon leans back into the headrest, throwing his forearms over his eyes so Hysilens won't see the way he blushes. "*Stop*, Hysilens. This is like torture to me."

Hysilens clicks her tongue in disapproval. "Seriously, though. I know you're somehow still mourning your first love, but you need to—okay, fine, we *both* need to work on the Monti."

"The concert will be fine," Phainon says, leaning his head all the way back against the headrest. Two weeks from now, in Okhema. They'd practiced throughout the whole summer, but rarely since returning to Paperfold. It wasn't looking good, but they'd pulled together worse programs before.

"Let's switch instruments and see how you feel about it, then," Hysilens shoots back, giving him a quick glare before turning back to the road.

"Oh, god no. Never again."

Hysilens laughs brightly, and Phainon can't find it in himself to be upset again. Even though he knows that as soon as they've eaten dinner and he's alone in his room, finishing up his homework or laying in bed wide awake, Mydei will inevitably occupy his thoughts again. As he always did these days.

"Are you alright?"

Phainon nearly jumps out of his skin as he sees Madam Herta standing before him, looking as polished as ever in her blazer. She still holds her baton as the student orchestra disperses around them, going to pack up while Phainon stays at the piano, alone. It had been a terrible rehearsal for him. He was planning on going over his music alone until he was inevitably kicked out of the concert hall.

"Yes," Phainon scrambles to say, when he realizes he was silent for too long. "Yes, I—I apologize for my performance tonight. I will be prepared

for the next rehearsal, I promise."

"Alright," Madam Herta says, and for a moment Phainon is shocked that she might simply leave it at that, but she looks at him like she has something more to say. "You're an extremely talented pianist, Phainon. I wouldn't want to repeat my past mistakes with you."

"Right," Phainon says carefully. "I understand," he adds, so she's aware that he knows exactly what mistakes she refers to.

"If you would like to come to my office hours to go over some things together, feel free."

"Of course. Thank you."

"Well then. I'll leave you to it." She walks off after that, and Phainon watches her go, left with a sense of odd bewilderment. He had both seen and heard of the worst parts of her. Like how she hardly ever applauded unless she was thoroughly impressed by someone's performance, that time she kicked Mydei out of her office when he didn't practice enough, how strictly she values her own time. He had seen her ask students to leave when they were out of tune, make the strings play stand by stand, and call on individuals to make sure they knew technical things on the spot. But no matter how much Phainon disliked her, she was damn good at her job. He had played five concertos with her orchestra and was currently on his way to a sixth, and every time her ear and interpretation of the music was impeccable. She got results. That was why she was still around.

To think Mydei had managed to pierce through her icy heart is a realization Phainon didn't expect to have now, of all times. He had often suspected that Mydei was one of her favorite students, and that was why she treated him the way she had. She wasn't the reason he dropped out—Mydei was far too headstrong to succumb to something as trivial as a mean teacher—but she must have felt deep regret for allowing it to happen.

Phainon curses as he leans his head forward, falling into his sheet music. To think he would feel camaraderie with Madam Herta, of all people. They both let Mydei leave. They both regret it.

His phone dings, and he digs it out of his back pocket, lifting his head and attempting to rub the exhaustion out of his eyes as he reads the preview of the email he was sent.

It's from a music news channel he was subscribed to, following Anaxa's instructions to keep up with music updates around the world. Even as a classical musician, it was important to keep up with the mainstream music industry as well, he claimed. Phainon wasn't sure when that would actually become important for him, but he liked all types of music just as well and didn't mind receiving updates about what was happening in the world. It was easy for him to become too laser-focused on his current project, pouring all of his time into his piano practice and forgetting what the bigger picture was.

Now, though, he regrets his decision to listen to Anaxa terribly. It's innocent, on a first glance: the subject of the email reads "Anticipating Robin Oak's fourth studio album…" and when he clicks on it, the rest of the subject line expands to show that she is titling said album *Why Does Life Slumber?* It's an interesting album title, and with Robin being the biggest pop star in the world, Phainon is enough of a casual fan to skim through its contents once.

He's known about the album since before this article, because Hysilens was featured on one of the songs. Robin had been looking for a classical violinist to feature on her track, and with Hysilens making rounds in the classical music industry last year, it was no big surprise that she would catch Robin's eye.

She had been instructed to keep it a secret, but told Phainon anyway. It wasn't hard for him to become suspicious on his own anyway, after he overheard her practicing music that was very obviously *not* classical over the summer. Still, he knows very little about the album as a whole.

He's excited for its release, anyways. In the article, she claims to be working with lots of different artists, exploring genres and collaborating with all of her favorite musicians, leaving the album with more songs with features than not. Phainon, being the music lover that he is, couldn't be more in support of the idea of her exploring her sound a little more. Mydei

would always say there wasn’t a song or genre out there that Phainon didn’t like, which was one of the truest things that had ever been said about him.

Speak of the devil. Phainon can feel the blood rush from his face as he scrolls down to the end of the article, where Robin speaks about the different artists she’s working with. She mentions the High Cloud Quintet, and Phainon immediately knows where this is going.

“...she found a new band popular in Amphoreus, who cite the High Cloud Quintet as one of their biggest inspirations.”

CALAMITY isn’t mentioned by name. But Phainon knows immediately—how could he not? They’re a rock band, they’re talented, and they’re incredible, of course Robin would want to work with them. Who *wouldn’t?*

Phainon turns his phone off before he can finish the article, consumed with a whirlwind of emotions so conflicting he feels sick.

This was their way forward, their path to success. Being featured on a Robin album was the greatest thing that could befall a growing musician. This meant bigger stages, brighter lights—millions of fans screaming Mydei’s name. They would all know him. They would see his talent and appreciate it, just as Phainon had done first.

Mydei wasn’t *his* anymore. He needed to accept that once and for all.

Chapter End Notes

> i watched project hail mary yesterday. good good good movie. maybe new top 5. i need to read more sci fi, not sure why i'm not that big a fan of it considering im literally studying to become a scientist. anyways. good bye. i need to post the second chapter now

▶ references/yap

Chapter 2: Why Does Life Slumber?

Chapter Notes

cw: brief mentions of gun violence

See the end of the chapter for more notes

***Penacony Music*, "Anticipating Robin Oak's Fourth Studio Album 'Why Does Life Slumber?'"**
20 September 3869
O.W.L. Bert

Exclusive! Robin Oak makes her first public appearance in years to talk about her upcoming album, 'Why Does Life Slumber?'

With the release of Robin's debut album almost a decade ago, it was clear that the music industry would never have a pop star like her ever again. Her music had all the creativity listeners were craving, with the vocal talent to back it up.

Three years ago, the singer was tragically shot during a fundraising concert in Kasbelina. Thankfully, she survived, but was forced to take a hiatus from making music for an undisclosed amount of time, mainly to heal. Fans were unsure whether she would ever return, as she hadn't been seen in public in years.

Rumors that she might have been coming back to music started swirling on Monday morning, where her marketing team posted on social media for the first time since the tragedy occurred. Today, she sits with us now, prepared to clear up any rumors and discuss the new album.

Robin claims that surviving such a tragedy was an experience she is ultimately grateful for. “My creativity was dwindling,” she explains. “This new album will explore these themes of mortality that I had never thought about before.”

Not only does she intend to explore thematically, but sonically, as well. While she loves the pop music she made in the past and everything it did for her, she’s ready to see what else is out there. “I’m working with all sorts of different artists,” the singer reveals. “There are a few songs I wrote and composed by myself, but most of them feature different groups.”

As for the identities of these groups, there are only a handful that she was able to reveal today. For example, the Astral Express, the jazz troupe her brother, Sunday, actually ended up joining. “They were so, so easy to work with, and welcoming, as well,” she says. “I love jazz. And I learned through working with them that I don’t know anything about it, either.”

Besides jazz, Robin also intends on exploring a genre of funk popularized in Edo Star. She visited the nation when her album was just being conceptualized. “There is so much music there, and it’s all so amazing,” she laughs. “It was so hard to decide which ideas I wanted to use.” In the end, she met a group of street performers more than happy to help her, and so it was decided.

It was a known fact that one of Robin’s favorite genres of music is rock, and everything under that umbrella. Now, she claims that she would have loved to work with the High Cloud Quintet but never got a chance before their notorious break up in 2016. Instead, though, she found a new band

popular in Amphoreus, who cite the High Cloud Quintet as one of their biggest inspirations. “I’m most excited to work with them,” she says. “I love their music, and I’m ready for the world to love them too.”

Robin says she was extremely honored at the opportunity to work with so many talented musicians, and that she hopes the world loves her new album as much as she does. “It’s experimental, for sure, but it’s the album I needed to make. Even if it doesn’t do well, I’ll be glad I did it anyway.”

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September 12th, 3868. Ten months before the release of Dreamscape.

The whole team joins the band on their flight to Penacony’s west coast. It’s only been a couple weeks since they got home from their first tour, and somehow Mydei can’t find it in himself to be even remotely exhausted.

The possibilities of what this collab might bring him are all difficult to process. He has fame, and he had it growing up, too—but this could bring an unprecedented amount of fame. The world might know his name. Even if they don’t like his music, they would know him as a rockstar, and not a pianist.

Their team boards the plane after them. Aventurine first, their manager ever since they’d signed with the IPC. He was always the image of perfection: not a strand of hair out of place, with a different designer suit on every day. He used too much cologne and wore two luxury watches everyday. He was rich, had more money than he ever knew what to do with, and if he was trying to hide it, he was doing a terrible job. Sometimes, the sight of him brought Mydei back to his childhood, living in the mansion that was more a museum than a home. His father never let him wear the same suit twice. Mydei couldn’t help but think Aventurine must follow that same stupid rule.
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Out of all of them, though, Mydei knew Aventurine the best. Despite what he had come to believe about the company they'd signed with, Aventurine at least made an effort to appear genuine. He was always in person for their meetings. Always flew with them, attended every concert with few exceptions. He listened to all of their gripes and did his best to appease them. When he couldn't, Mydei could still believe him when he said he was sorry.

Jade boards next. She's the band's publicist—who probably is the publicist of a hundred other IPC musicians, because Mydei rarely ever sees her. Any message she has is always delivered to them through Aventurine. Now is only the second or third time he's actually seen her in person, and "perfect" isn't even an accurate enough word to describe her. She's beautiful, in the way that tells Mydei he should stay away from her. Jade's very presence on this plane is enough to send shivers down his spine. She ensures she's the most important person in every room she enters, even if the reality is that she isn't.

Topaz is right behind her, chattering away on her phone. Mydei hasn't met her very many times either, but she's much friendlier than Jade, which is interesting because the two of them seem to have a very close relationship. She's fluent in four languages and greeted Mydei in Kremnoan when they first met, even though she only knew a couple words. Out of the three of them, while she does appear somewhat intimidating when you first meet her, she's without a doubt the most approachable of them all. But behind her warm brown eyes and girlish haircut, her skills in business are not to be underestimated. She's the kind of person Mydei's father would have nothing but the utmost respect for. This alone makes Mydei more wary of her.

Ratio boards last, a minute or so after Topaz. He gives Mydei a curt nod as they make eye contact and moves to sit next to Aventurine. The two of them have an unlikely friendship: IPC's star producer and CALAMITY's manager. As far as Mydei knows, they only started working together when CALAMITY signed to the IPC, and even then, their fields don't overlap very often.

Ratio—or Dr. Ratio, his producer tag—was thorny when Mydei first met him, but they were eventually able to bond over their shared love of music once they found common ground. Ratio is simply someone who is very passionate about his craft, and it shines through in the way he interacts with his clients. Sometimes, he reminds Mydei of his old piano teacher from college: a musical genius.

Jade enters into a virtual meeting on her laptop mere minutes after she's boarded, and Mydei can't help but wonder why she's even here. It must be a seriously important opportunity if she was willing to make the trip out in person. Topaz is still on her own call, and Ratio takes out a book to read while Aventurine scrolls on his own phone, no doubt doing something equally important.

Mydei sighs, leaning against the window as he takes out his headphones. He's never particularly enjoyed flying, but this job forced him to get comfortable with it, and fast. He's a quarter of the way through his third listen of the new Stellaron Hunters album as the plane takes off, before he pulls his phone out of his pocket and searches for Robin instead.

He's never considered himself someone who dislikes any kind of music, but he'd always thought that Robin's genre was not his first choice. He had nothing against pop music, he just thought a lot of it could be rather bland. But "bland" is not a word that comes to mind as he listens to her debut, and most popular, album. Of course, he knew a majority of the songs from hearing them on the radio, but he'd never actually sat down and *listened* to it.

The first song on the album is her most famous single, *If I Can Stop One Heart From Breaking*, the pop song you couldn't escape if you tried. Mydei had heard it in department stores, on every local radio station, in the soundtrack of every movie released around that time. It was overplayed, but it had to be good to get to that point first. The only criticism Mydei would have is that the lyrics are surface level at best, as she sings about some optimistic crap Mydei doesn't really believe in. But then he thinks about their most recent EP, and the things his ghost writers made him sing about—maybe it's not really his place to criticize the depth of her hit single, when the masses clearly didn't care about that.

The second song strikes him because it wasn't one he'd heard before. Instead of the generic pop beat he was expecting, it opens up with a balladic piano solo. He freezes, thumb hovering over the pause button. He can tell it was recorded live, by an actual pianist. They're good, incredibly so, and the song just improves when Robin joins in, like whoever is on piano plays their best in collaboration with Robin.

He opens the internet, identifying who is credited for the piano part after a quick search. Sunday Oak. A name he had never heard before, but it's clear that this is Robin's brother. How he didn't know him, Mydei has no idea, and he blanches when he opens images and sees the face of this mystery pianist. The resemblance is so uncanny it's almost cruel. Mydei stares at Sunday's image for longer than he should, pinpointing every difference he can put his finger on. His eyes are light brown, not blue. His hair is longer. He looks more subdued, like there's a great weight on his shoulders. His smile is more offputting than charming.

And, of course, his *playing.* Mydei pauses the song so he can open a video link, watching a live performance of him with Robin. He's good, and it annoys him. Mydei can't stop thinking of the picture he saw, with that stupid condescending smile on his face. He probably thought he was the shit. Just because he could play Robin's little pop song.

Mydei exits out of the video, turning his music back on again. He skips the song. Fuck Sunday, and his pretty face, and methodically perfect piano playing. He was *nothing* like Phainon.

Late summer heat hits Mydei square in the face as soon as he steps out of the airport. He's used to the heat, having grown up in Amphoreus' hottest city-state, but living in the eastern region of Penacony had forced him to grow accustomed to its milder climate. Regardless, he still prefers heat to cold, so he doesn't mind all that much.

Still, the cold air of his hotel room is a welcome feeling after being outside. It's late when they arrive, with no obligations until tomorrow morning, so

Mydei drops his suitcase on the floor, takes a shower, and immediately gets into bed.

He hates sleeping in hotels. The bedding is scratchy and uncomfortable, and the pillows are always too hard for his liking. He tosses and turns all night, never getting more than an hour of sleep at a time. Each time he wakes up, he can't stop thinking about what meeting Robin would be like. To write a song with her. The inevitable fame that would come his way afterwards.

Eventually, his clock reads a time where it wouldn't be unreasonable to be awake, so he gets out of bed. He takes his time, killing an hour and a half in the empty hotel gym before showering and heading to the lobby for breakfast. He piles a plate high with eggs and breakfast meats, then sits by himself in the corner. Barely five minutes pass before Aventurine slides into the booth across from him, nothing but a single coffee cup in hand.

"Good morning," he says, too cheerily for this hour.

"Morning," Mydei answers, currently emptying three packets of hot sauce over his eggs.

"You're up early. Didn't strike me as the type." Aventurine takes a sip of his coffee. Black, it appears. Mydei fights the urge to make a face.

"Couldn't sleep." Mydei yawns, as if proving his point. "It'll be a while before the rest are up. At least two hours for Cipher."

"Well, your session with Robin isn't until noon, so you have time."

Mydei gives him an affirmative grunt before taking his first bite of breakfast. The eggs are hard and rubbery, and the sausage tastes more like plastic than meat. They should let him into the kitchen instead. "How'd you get into this industry?" Mydei asks. He really would rather eat his breakfast in silence, but Aventurine is here now, so he might as well make conversation.

He doesn't show it outwardly, but it's clear that the question upsets him a little bit. He shrugs in response, opening his mouth and closing it again

before he finally answers. “Luck,” he starts. “I’ve always been good at doing business. If it wasn’t the IPC, it would be some other corporation.”

Mydei nods. “You’re not a musician.”

“God, no. Not in the slightest. I have no talent for it, like you, or…Ratio.”

“It’s reassuring to know you think we’re talented.” Mydei opens a fourth packet of hot sauce and drowns his eggs even more.

“We wouldn’t have signed you if we didn’t think you were worth the investments.”

“Huh,” Mydei says. He takes another bite—it tastes a little better, now that the base flavors are completely drowned out by hot sauce. “Ratio, too. He knows his shit.”

“Of course he does,” Aventurine says, doing that soulless little laugh of his. “Before he got into music production, he was a professor at Paperfold.”

Mydei nearly drops his fork. “*What?*”

Like clockwork, Ratio slides into the booth next to Aventurine. “Good morning, you two,” he says, seemingly uncaring about the look of shock on Mydei’s face. He has a single croissant on a plate, and a cup of tea.

“Morning, Doc,” Aventurine says, giving Mydei a knowing smile. “We were just talking about you.”

“You worked at Paperfold?” Mydei asks, as calmly as possible.

“Oh,” Ratio says, raising an eyebrow. “Yes, for a few years, before I realized their music department didn’t align with my goals.”

“Did you know Madam Herta?” The question leaves his mouth before he can stop himself, and he clamps it shut afterwards, like it would change the fact that he had already said it.

Ratio clicks his tongue. “Herta, Herta, Herta.” He shakes his head, ripping the croissant in half. It looks too dry and dense in the middle, and once again Mydei wishes he was the one in the kitchen.

“So yes.”

“Naturally.” Ratio hands Aventurine half of his croissant, who takes it wordlessly. “Was she your piano coach?”

“Unfortunately.” Mydei shoves another bite into his mouth and tries not to think about it. “She was…very talented.”

“Talented, undoubtedly, but I doubt whether her talent is as helpful as she seems to think it is.”

Mydei doesn’t immediately respond, too busy mulling over Ratio’s words. He couldn’t place all the blame on Herta’s shoulders, but she was part of the reason he had dropped out, in the end. He couldn’t keep up with all her standards. He couldn’t ever live up to who she wanted him to be, to *what* he wanted him to be.

“Herta’s opinion of you doesn’t matter,” Ratio continues, when he doesn’t say anything. “Can she comment on your music now? No, because it’s not her field. But I can.”

There’s something Mydei wants to say, about how it’s technically not *his* music, and of course Ratio would think it’s good because he was the one putting most of the work in. He keeps his mouth shut, though, and nods instead.

The rest of Mydei’s breakfast is accompanied by boring small talk: Ratio’s PhD studies, Aventurine’s past education, Mydei’s life back in Kremnos. He talks about his friends, Krateros, how he met the rest of the band. Nothing that could be exploited for later, even though he thinks the IPC probably has the means of learning everything about his past if they really wanted to. He does not bring up Phainon. He doesn’t even *think* about Phainon.

He excuses himself when he’s done, cleaning his plate away before getting on the elevator and heading back up to his room. On the way, he passes by Topaz, who gives him a quick wave, once again busy taking a call.

When he was a kid, his father made it clear to him that he would either study piano performance and become a world famous maestro, or study business so he could take over as CEO of Kremnos Pianos. The second option flew out the window when he and his mother left, and Mydei couldn’t be more ecstatic that he would never have to worry about anything business related. Topaz seems to enjoy her job well enough, but such enjoyment is difficult for Mydei to wrap his head around.

Mydei returns to his hotel room with too much time to kill. There’s nothing planned for the band until noon, even though his managers probably all have packed schedules. He’s not entirely sure what any of them do all day, but they’re always busy.

Mydei makes his bed. Sits in the middle of it and turns on the TV, listening to the news for ten minutes before switching to a cartoon and eventually turning it off. He paces. He connects his wireless headphones and stares out the window. He wanders through the hotel hallways until he finds the pool, and, in his insurmountable boredom, considers swimming a few laps. But then he dips a toe in, almost slips, and retreats back to his hotel room in shame. Sometimes—rarely, but still sometimes—he wishes he was a good swimmer. Unfortunately, he’d have to stick to land sports until he learned to face his fears.

He scrolls through social media. He doesn’t follow very many people, so his feed is always boring except for Cipher’s horrible posts. She had been told multiple times to tone down her social media presence, and never seemed to listen.

As if he’s in a trance, he opens up the search tab and clicks on the most recent result: phainonkhaslana. He stares at the profile before him like he hasn’t already memorized it: the profile picture that looks like a model shoot, no doubt Aglaea’s doing. His thousands of followers, the following count that’s nearly double that. Nothing has changed, except he’s uploaded

a new post since the last time Mydei stalked him. He clicks on it without a second thought.

The first slide is a professionally done program photo: Phainon, donning a sleek black tuxedo, stands in the background with his hands in his pockets. He's facing to the left, with a somber look on his face. Completely unlike his usual dimples and boyish charm. Hysilens is in the foreground, facing the right, with a long black dress on. She holds her violin, hair tied back into a long ponytail. They look incredible, both of them almost inhumanly attractive.

The second slide features both of them on stage, standing side by side. There's a piano behind them. Hysilens holds her violin, free hand joined with Phainon's. They have their joined hands raised in the air, both of them smiling wide at the audience.

The last slide is a picture of Hysilens alone, presumably taken by Phainon. She stands in what looks like a practice room of sorts, though it's much nicer than the ones Mydei is used to. Her violin has a string loose and she glares at the camera with murderous intent.

Mydei's eyes flick down to the caption:

Bartok violin sonata 2 👍 Csardas 👍 So so fun playing with @hysil.phagousa last week. Thank you Okhema, always a pleasure :)

Against his better interest, he opens the comments. The top thread was started by Hysilens, mere hours ago.

hysil.phagousa: I hate this piece

phainonkhaslana: @hysil.phagousa csardas?

hysil.phagousa: @phainonkhaslana don't insinuate that I have any criticisms of csardas ever again.

Mydei scrolls through the comments until he finds one that comments on how good they look together, which makes him upset enough to turn his

phone off. He knows better than anyone that Phainon and Hysilens are merely close classmates and good friends. But he doesn't like that not everyone knows that.

He orders room service and eats in silence, letting his annoyance simmer. By the time he's finished, it's finally late enough that he can leave. Even so, he's the first one in the lobby, and is forced to wait as patiently as possible even as his nerves get worse every second.

They're driven to Robin's house alone, where she told them they would meet. Aventurine, Topaz, Jade, and Ratio have a different meeting they need to attend, as far as Mydei's aware. Robin had requested that they meet alone to work out the creative vision at first.

The drive isn't very long, likely less than ten minutes, but it feels like an eternity. Mydei spends it staring out the tinted window and listening to Hyacine converse with the driver in the background. He can't drown out his nerves, no matter how hard he tries. What if they don't get along, and their visions don't align? What if Robin doesn't like them, or their music? What if her team had the wrong idea?

He's pulled from his thoughts when the car stops, and he sees Hyacine get out of her seat. He climbs out expecting to see a lavish mansion similar to the one he grew up in, but finds a house much more modest than what he was envisioning. It's still big and beautiful, but it doesn't give the impression that Robin has allowed all her fame to get entirely in her head. It's his first actual impression of her, and it's a good one.

They walk to the front door, but it opens before they have to knock, and Mydei thinks his heartbeat nearly doubles when he sees the woman at the other side of the door.

He's seen a hundred pictures of Robin—she's at the level of fame where you can't *not* see her, but seeing her in person is a completely different thing. Her long dyed blue hair is tied back into a bun, and you can see the roots of her natural hair color coming in. Her green eyes sparkle as she takes them in, and Mydei finds that the warmth each of her photos seem to emulate wasn't fabricated at all. She wears long white feathers from her

ears and has big blue-framed glasses on. She's even prettier in person than she is in a photoshoot, where she's meant to embody perfection.

"Hi!" she starts, her voice soft and unbearably genuine as she fully steps outside to greet them. "I'm Robin, it's so nice to finally meet you all! You must be Mydei?" she asks, and Mydei's heart nearly jumps out of his throat. "Can I call you that?"

"Of course," Mydei says, throat a little dry as he speaks. A beat of silence passes, and he offers his hand as an afterthought. She takes it, and he can't help but note how soft her hands are.

"Hyacine?" she continues, moving to the girl to Mydei's right. "Castorice, and then Cipher?" She shakes each of their hands, and Mydei squeezes the hand she had just touched into a fist. He's embarrassingly clammy.

"I listened to all of your music over the past week, and I'm so happy my team was able to find a band like yours," she starts, stepping back. "My favorite song is *Taxidermy.*"

Mydei can't help the look that comes over his face. "Seriously?" he asks, and he can feel Castorice's excitement, equally palpable, behind him. They wrote *Taxidermy* by themselves, and it was on their first EP, but no one ever spoke about it. Castorice always said it was her favorite song, and Mydei was inclined to agree. Cipher thought it was good, but her favorite song of theirs was *Child's Play.* For reasons Mydei couldn't quite understand.

Hyacine wasn't there when they wrote the first EP, but she loved *Taxidermy* as well. It had their most ambitious guitar solo out of all their songs so far, and it took her over a month to learn.

Robin nods. "I was blown away when I first heard it. And to think you did all that on your own…it's unbelievable. All four of you are so incredibly talented."

"So are you!" Hyacine chimes in. "I've been a fan since I was in middle school," she says earnestly. "Your second album was my favorite. I had tickets to the tour, and everything, I just couldn't go because…something

came up.” Her smile fades slightly at the last part. Mydei wonders what she could be talking about, but realizes now is not the right time to pry.

“I’m so happy to hear that,” Robin says. “Don’t tell anyone I said this, but my second album is probably my favorite, too. I think it’s underappreciated.”

“It *is* underappreciated!” Hyacine exclaims. “The industry can’t handle something a little different nowadays.”

“That’s part of the reason why I’m writing this album,” Robin agrees, nodding. “Actually, why don’t you come in, and we can talk about it?”

She opens the door again, leading the four of them inside. Her house is even more beautiful on the inside, with intricate gold and blue wallpaper and polished marble flooring. She guides them through, all the way to a back corner, where she opens a door into her own personal recording studio. It doesn’t look that different from the ones Mydei is used to—maybe a bit bigger, with half of it turned into a seating area of sorts. A whiteboard hangs over one of the couches, filled with notes, song titles, and a couple artist names Mydei recognizes.

Mechanical Fever is what catches his eye the most—he knew Serval from college, when her band was a side gig and she was fully dedicated to her mechanical engineering degree. He didn’t think they were still playing at all.

“This is where we will be recording,” she says. “I have all the instruments you guys might need, but if you’re more comfortable with your own, feel free to bring them.”

Cipher has already made herself at home on one of the couches, and Mydei moves to sit beside her. Usually, she makes it a point to annoy him as much as possible when they sit next to each other, so he can only hope she wouldn’t pull anything weird in front of Robin.

“So, the album,” Robin continues. She flicks a couple switches to turn on the console. The speakers hanging from the walls make a faint sound as

they turn on. “I wanted to explore themes of mortality and humanity. My brother, Sunday—he studied philosophy in college, and always made it a point to ask me these questions he was studying. One that really stuck with me was ‘why does life slumber?’ That’s one of the biggest themes on the album, and I’m thinking of calling it that.”

Why does life slumber? Mydei doesn’t even know how to begin going about answering that. Philosophy was never his strong suit, always the kind of thing he hated talking about, because ultimately, who cares? He always took the questions too literally and didn’t think outside of the obvious answer.

Now, though, he’s struck with a memory from his childhood. His father was the closest thing to a Kremnoan conservative that existed in this time, even as someone with a very non-traditional career. He encouraged Mydei to exercise and tone his body like their ancestors did, so he would never forget where he came from. He had an old quote in his office that read “even blades must be laid down.” Mydei always thought it was stupid, and that his father was corny for hanging on to traditions that only existed millenia ago.

But he thinks of the quote today. Even though his father probably never thought about it too deeply, he supposes it’s a good enough answer to that question.

“I wanted to play you guys the rest of the album and a couple samples of what I’m thinking for this song,” Robin is saying. “The first song I wrote in collaboration with the country artist Boothill. Have any of you guys heard of him?”

Mydei hasn’t. He looks at Cipher—the only person in this room that he knows at least somewhat enjoys country music. He doesn’t hate it, but it’s never going to be his first choice.

“Don’t look at me,” Cipher says. “Okay, I know of him, but he’s more classic country than modern, so I think his stuff is boring.”

“Like modern country isn’t boring,” Castorice mutters under her breath.

Robin laughs before Cipher can start an argument. “Yeah, I didn’t like country music at all before I worked with him. But that’s the point of this album: stepping out of my comfort zone, and I knew if I *really* wanted to do that, I would have to study a genre I don’t like.”

She plays the first song, and the sounds of what sounds like three overlapping guitars fills the room. It’s not what Mydei was expecting, given that she had prefaced it by saying it was country music, and he’s surprised at how easily he’s able to get behind it.

He looks over at the whiteboard, at the tracklist written in one of the corners. *Birds and Sky,* featuring Boothill. He nearly jumps out of his skin when he looks down and sees *Helektra Phagousa* written beside one of the songs in the middle.

Hysilens. How in the world did she find *Hysilens?*

Robin’s soft voice comes over the speaker, and Mydei turns back around. So far, it doesn’t sound like she did much to alter the way she normally sings for this song. He knows that Robin is a talented singer, so she probably chose not to add an artificial “country twang” to her voice for reasons Mydei doesn’t know, but can appreciate nonetheless. The idea of it almost makes him laugh.

Near the end of the song, though, the instrumentals take over, and both Robin and a man’s voice can be heard yodeling in the background. He can’t help the smile that breaks over his face. *Yodeling.* Something Mydei wouldn’t be caught dead doing.

“He had to teach me how to yodel,” Robin explains. “It requires a lot of vocal control. I hadn’t sung in a long time when we recorded this, so it took longer than I’d like to admit.”

The next song is called *Epsilon,* which Robin says is the name of her hometown. A tiny island north of Penacony that few people have heard of. She sings most of the song in her native tongue, and says that the style of music was inspired by a band she stumbled across when she was visiting. They called themselves The Halovians, and did most of their performances

for free. Even though Mydei can't understand what she's singing about, she describes it as a love letter to her home. He thinks he can understand that, even though he does not know why he still loves Castrum Kremnos. There were few good memories associated with the place, and even fewer things to be proud of.

The third song is *Fate in Dreamland*, followed up with *Night in Dreamland.* Neither of the songs have a feature, being the first songs she wrote for the album. *Fate in Dreamland* is the most upbeat song so far, and sounds like a classic pop song. The kind of thing you would hear on her debut album. She doesn't explain what it's about in depth, but Mydei can tell it was written about her experience in Kasbelina three years ago. Or at least, partially, because it seems to be somewhat satirical in nature.

Night in Dreamland is a ballad, and Mydei thinks they must be connected due to the titles. He finds it odd that when Robin recounts her experience being shot in the neck during a concert, she doesn't bemoan her own trauma. It's something he respects regardless.

Pinion's Aria is the fifth song, which features the Astral Express. Mydei only knows about the jazz troupe tangentially, given that he was sort of friends with Caelus and Stelle in college. Reaching out to them would be weird, he thinks, since they were obviously much closer with Phainon than they ever were with him.

Robin explains how Sunday was the Express' newest member, and she wanted to explore jazz as another genre she knew very little about. Mydei admits that jazz is one of his favorite music genres, always preferring it to classical. He enjoyed the Express' music as their original work put a modern twist to it, and their covers of classics were always incredible. Knowing that Sunday is their pianist, though, makes him like the group slightly less.

The next one is Hysilens' feature, *Moonless Midnight.* From the beginning, Mydei is shocked at how different Robin's voice sounds in this. Throughout the beginning of the album, her voice only rarely strayed from what he was used to hearing from her. The music styles differed, but her voice was

always the same. Now, though, she adopted a rougher tone, and belted the entire chorus with an aggression Mydei wasn't expecting at all.

Hysilens plays throughout it, given a solo violin part after the first chorus. Mydei isn't impressed by her prowess, he's always known how talented she was. Throughout everything Robin has shared about the album so far, he's come to admire her wholly as a person, but it's this song that starts to make him admire her as a musician, too.

Harmony is next, and Mydei feigns indifference when she introduces Ruan Mei as the feature. Castorice and Hyacine both say they know her, which surprises Mydei, because he thought Castorice listened to mainly harder music like shoegaze and grunge rock, and Ruan Mei is far from it.

But he doesn't know her, not well, anyways. He only knows Herta, her friend? Partner? Wife? Mydei is still confused about that. He doesn't share that Ruan Mei shook his hand and said he was talented, but his pride surges when he hears her part in the song. *Multi-instrumentalist,* Robin said she was, and Mydei isn't sure which instruments that encompasses, but he can hear her on the most beautifully placed saxophone part he's ever heard throughout the song. Robin's soft voice floats above the instrumental part, and Mydei feels like he's dreaming as he listens to it.

The next song is called *Had I Not Seen the Sun,* and Robin explains it's a cover of an old Penaconian classic. "I'm not from Penacony, obviously," she says, finger lingering on the play button. "But I've been here for so long. Everyone I love is here. It's just as much a home to me as Epsilon is, and I wanted to give this place some love. Even though it has its problems."

The song starts with just her and a piano—*Sunday,* Mydei thinks bitterly. It's a simple enough piano part that Mydei can't be impressed. It's a very intimate song, and he can feel the love that was put into it. Near the end, a chorus chimes in, which Robin says was recorded by a children's choir in Kasbelina.

The last song is called *The Eighth Day*, the one featuring Mechanical Fever. Mydei explains his relationship to Serval, and Robin says she stumbled

across them in Belobog, but it’s still not much more than a hobby to any of them.

Once again, the song is related to Sunday in some way. Mydei would be irritated if it wasn’t so glaringly obvious how much he means to her. He can hear the rock influences in the instrumental, but it’s still different from their style. He had to admit he was unsure how different their song would be from Mechanical Fever’s if she chose to feature two rock bands.

“The next song is the one I want to write with you guys,” Robin says. “It’s the last song on the album. It has to close it out in a special way, I want it to be loud and grand and a perfect finale.”

Loud and grand. Mydei can do that.

Robin moves over to a computer in the corner, clicking the mouse a few times until she pulls up a folder filled with audio recordings. “I got help from Sunday to start recording the general idea I have,” she starts. “I want there to be a prominent piano part, and the rest will be rock instruments. You guys,” she clarifies, looking over at them.

Mydei feels Castorice’s eyes on him. He looks up, making eye contact for a brief moment. He isn’t sure what Robin means by that. He had just assumed he would be doing backing vocals, or something. He didn’t even want his own verse.

“Actually,” Robin’s mouse lingers over the play button on one of the audio files she had opened, but she doesn’t press it before she turns around. “I totally forgot to ask. Do any of you play piano? There wasn’t much of it in your music, so I figured if none of you knew I could just ask Sunday to do it.”

Now, Mydei can feel all three pairs of eyes on him. Poor Robin didn’t even know the can of worms she had just opened, and he can’t even deny it, with how obvious everyone else is acting. He swallows, and the sound practically echoes in the silent room. “I can,” he says quietly.

“You can!” Robin exclaims. “Oh, that’s so great! This worked out perfectly, then!”

“But I—” he cuts in, suddenly growing increasingly nervous. “I worry that my playing won’t be up to your standards.”

“Oh, bullshit,” Cipher interrupts, rolling her eyes as she leans further into the couch cushions. “You were only the best—”

“Cipher, stop,” Mydei hisses, clamping a hand over her mouth in his desperation. “Piano sounds great, Robin. I’ll get back to you on whether I'm willing to play it or not.”

“Okay! We don’t have to start recording right now, anyways. I was thinking we could just do lyrics today.” She plays the recording next, of a solo piano part obviously recorded on a phone. It’s simple, the kind of thing Mydei could easily sightread in his prime. Probably today, too. And he’s certain he could do it better than Sunday.

“I want it to be darker than my usual sound,” she says, once it finishes. “It’ll open with just the piano and me, and then the whole band will join in together afterwards.”

“I love it,” Hyacine speaks up first. Mydei nods. It does sound like a good idea. He just wishes it didn’t need to have the piano part, even though he knows deep down that scrapping the piano would make it significantly worse.

“It’s a very rough draft right now, of course. I don’t have any lyrics planned right now.”

“I can help with that,” Castorice says. “If you’d like, of course.”

“I did read somewhere that you write most of the lyrics,” Robin says, moving to pull a box of used notebooks out from underneath the coffee table.

“Not just me,” Castorice blushes. “Mydei wrote *Don’t Cry.*”

“Oh, did you?” Robin looks up as she selects one of the notebooks near the end of the box. “I liked that one a lot, too.”

Mydei thanks her. Even though *Don’t Cry* is one of his least favorite songs. It was the first song he wrote by himself and actually took seriously. It being their biggest hit was completely unprecedented.

Robin sits on the floor and writes down their brainstorming ideas into a blank page of the notebook. Since it’s her album, they mostly piggyback off of her original ideas. Escape, freedom, being trapped like a bird in a cage.

“There’s this children’s book I always read when I was younger,” Robin says. “It’s popular in Penacony, so I’m not sure if you have heard of it, but it’s about this artificial dream world anyone was invited to go to. It was actually quite a dark story, for a children’s book,” she laughs. “I was thinking something like that. Trapped in a land of dreams.”

“The last track is about escaping from the dreamscape,” Castorice murmurs.

Hyacine gasps, clapping a hand over her mouth. “Dreamscape! We can call it *Dreamscape!*”

“Oh, that’s perfect!” Robin rushes to write it at the top of the page, underlining it twice. “Oh, I just realized—I’m such a bad host. Do you want anything to drink?”

Mydei can’t just expect everyone to have pomegranate juice on hand, so he asks for a coffee instead. Cipher copies his request, Castorice asks for tea, and Hyacine asks for water.

“I’ll be right back. You can start on the lyrics then, if you want?” She hands the notebook and pen over to Castorice, who takes it and flips to a clean page.

Robin closes the door behind her as she leaves, and Hyacine and Castorice immediately start work on the lyrics. He has a couple ideas himself, but they’re so far in the back of his head right now. Cipher can clearly tell, staring at him strangely in the corner of his eye.

“Excuse me,” he says, nudging Cipher’s feet out of the way as he stands. “Bathroom,” he clarifies, met with their confused stares. Robin had pointed out where the nearest one was on their walk to the studio room, but he had no real intention of going there. He makes his way through her living room and into the kitchen, where she loads coffee beans into the machine with her back to him.

“Oh! Hi, Mydei, did you need something?” she asks, when she turns around. “The bathroom is that way—in case you forgot.”

“No, that’s not it,” he starts. “Robin, I wasn’t entirely honest with you.”

“Oh,” Robin says again, putting the bag of coffee beans down. Her full attention is on him now, and Mydei feels nervous under the weight of it. “What’s wrong?”

“I am a pianist,” he wets his lips, then swallows. “I am a *very* good pianist. Or…I was. I don’t really know if I am anymore,” he laughs as he says it, more out of nerves than anything. But even with his inexperience, he’s sure he’s at least better than Sunday.

“I went to school for it,” he continues. “It’s not a secret to the public, I couldn’t really cover something like that up, especially when there’s so many videos of me performing on the internet. But I’ve made it clear that I don’t do that anymore.”

Robin looks a little surprised, but doesn’t push it. “That’s fine,” she says. “I don’t want to make you do anything you’re uncomfortable with. I can always have my brother record it for us.”

The thought of having Sunday play on his track when he is more than capable sends shivers down his spine. Putting *La Campanella* in front of him would probably kill the man. He looked like his favorite composers were Mozart or Bach.

Mydei gathers himself, putting thoughts of Sunday’s probable incompetence to the back of his head. “I love your idea,” he starts. “I never

thought about including piano in my music before. If I was going to pick it up again, I see no better time than now."

"Okay," Robin says gently, nodding. "If you don't mind me asking, what was the reason you quit piano?"

"A lot of reasons." Mydei looks down at his hands. He doesn't like thinking about that time in his life, even this far removed from it. "The biggest one, though, was that I didn't like it enough. My teacher told me I would never make it as a classical pianist, because my dislike for it was so obvious.

"But this—" he shakes his head. "This is what I want to do. Make music like this. I can't just go through the rest of my life as a musician ignoring the most prominent instrument in the world."

Robin laughs, but she's serious when she stops and looks at him. "You're sure?"

Mydei nods. "Yes. I'm sure."

"Mydei, why do you think life slumbers?"

Mydei looks up at her, but her back is turned to him again as she returns her attention to the coffee machine. "You know, I tried to answer that question when you first asked it, but all I could think about was this old Kremnoan quote. From when we still adopted a warrior culture." Most people who don't know very much about Castrum Kremnos tend to think of it as a land of brutes. Kremnoans rarely leave, and the rest of the world prefers it that way. He wonders if Robin thought that of him, when she first saw him. It's not a rare reaction.

"'Even blades must be laid down,'" he recites. "I'm sure sleep was important too, then. What good is a warrior who doesn't rest?"

Robin presses a button on the coffee machine, and turns to look at him. "That's a beautiful answer," she says, smiling to herself. "Maybe now, when you pick up the piano again, you'll be better than you ever were."

Chapter End Notes

:D

▶ references/yap

Chapter 3: Not Quite My Tempo

Chapter Notes

are you rushing or are you dragging?

cw: parental loss

See the end of the chapter for more notes

HALL OF STRIFE

Ptolemy Savalas, violin
Perdikkas Katsanevas, viola
Peucesta Lytras, viola
Hephaestion Axiotis, cello
Leonnius Goutas, bass
Mydeimos Nikador, piano

Program

Sextet for Piano and Strings in D major, Op. 110……Felix Mendelssohn (2809-2847)
Allegro vivace
Adagio
Menuetto agitato
Allegro vivace

Grand Sextet in E-flat major……Mikhail Glinka (2804-2857)
Allegro maestoso
Andante
Allegro con spirito

Piano Sonata No. 14 in C-sharp minor, *“Moonlight Sonata”*……Ludwig von Beethoven (2770-2827)
Adagio sostenuto

Allegretto
Presto agitato

About the Performers

Mydeimos Nikador is a Kremnoan pianist, who made his Hall of Strife debut when he was just seven years old. Born to virtuosos Gorgo and Eurypon Nikador, he has performed pieces by Liszt, Rachmaninoff, and many more. He currently attends the Gibranipar School of Music and plans to pursue a BA in piano performance at Paperfold University in Penacony. During his time as a pianist, Nikador has been recognized globally for his performance of Brahms' *Piano Concerto No. 1 in D Minor* with the Symphonic Orchestra of Okhema and for his various appearances alongside the Castrum Kremnos Philharmonic Orchestra.

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September 3rd, 3865. Sophomore fall semester.

"You did exceptionally well, Mydeimos."

Madam Herta looks as put together as always, one leg crossed over the other in her seat that looks more like a throne than a desk chair. "And you've impressed me, which is not an easy feat."

"Thank you," Mydei says, fiddling with his hands in his lap from where he sits at the piano. He tries not to come across like those words make him feel giddy, even though he's rarely felt pride so great in his life.

"So now begins the battle where we have to figure out how you're going to impress me again."

Mydei doesn't care what she throws at him. He's never been this determined to keep someone's pride—not even his mother, or Krateros. But
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if he really wants to be a good pianist, if this is really what he's going to do with his life, he needs Madam Herta's approval.

"I want you to play *La Campanella.*"

Mydei's eyes widen. Now *that's* a piece he actually knows—Phainon joked about it enough times for him to pick up on the title. He knows next to nothing about the actual piece. Just that it's notoriously difficult, and Phainon doesn't believe he could ever be capable of playing it, much as he wants to.

Mydei doesn't quite know what he's getting himself into, but he feels pride surge in his gut regardless. Madam Herta *believes* in him. Last semester, he wouldn't have thought that was ever possible.

"Seriously?" he asks.

Madam Herta merely nods. "It would impress me," she starts, leaning even further back into her chair, "if you perfected *La Campanella* in one semester. And you know what I mean by 'perfected'."

There were two things Madam Herta considered perfect. Herself was the first one. The way he had played his piece at the end of last semester was the other.

"Do you think you can do it?"

Mydei swallows all his doubts and nods. "Yes," he says. "I can do it."

Madam Herta smiles. She looks pleased, but there's nothing nice about the look on her face. It's something Mydei has had to get used to. Madam Herta is pretty much as eccentric as they come, but sometimes Mydei thinks she has to be some sort of sadist.

She hands him a small book of sheet music. The first page is the cover, written in some old font as if Madam Herta had time traveled and stolen the original hand-written copy by herself. He opens it, gingerly, and even looking at the first page makes him feel like he's had an aneurysm.

“Scared?” Madam Herta laughs a little, and at this moment Mydei is even more convinced that she’s a sadist. “I performed this piece at thirteen. In fact, maybe it would do you some good to watch my old performance.”

Mydei merely nods, and places the sheet music on the rack in silence.

“Do your best,” Madam Herta kicks her feet up on her desk, leaning back. “You’re good at sightreading, I’ll give you that—but not good enough to play this easily right now. All I ask is that you improve every week.”

Mydei walks out of her office feeling like he’d just gotten run over repeatedly by an eighteen-wheeler. He’s not sure what kind of a psycho would sit down and write a piece like that, but he’s surprised it wasn’t Madam Herta herself. She’s the perfect amount of evil to come up with something like that—and while Mydei had no strong opinions on Liszt before, today he hates him.

It’s already late, around 8:30, and Mydei hasn’t had dinner yet. But that doesn’t stop him from locking himself in a practice room for an extra three hours. He leaves *that* session even more dejected, if it’s even possible, and feeling like he’s finally run into a wall he won’t be able to pass.

He checks his watch, and realizes how late it’s gotten without him even noticing. The dining halls close at ten, and he’s starving. He makes do with a bag of chips from a vending machine and sits on the music building’s balcony while he eats them in silence. He already feels like he’s losing his damn mind.

His phone rings, and the call almost goes to voicemail by the time Mydei digs his phone out from the bottom of his bag. He curses when he sees Phainon’s name on his screen, and scrambles to pick up. “Hello?”

“*Mydei, hey, are you okay? Herta didn’t kill you, did she?”* He laughs, awkwardly, the sound lingering in Mydei’s head.

“No, she didn’t.” Mydei swallows. He’d told Phainon he would text him after his lesson ended, and then forgot. He’s not sure if he even wants to explain himself to Phainon. What would he think, if Mydei told him that Madam Herta deemed him talented enough to play *La Campanella*? Wouldn’t that make Phainon jealous? Were their roles reversed, Mydei would absolutely be upset. “I was practicing.”

Phainon’s end of the line is silent for a few moments. “*...It’s almost midnight.”*

Mydei puts a chip in his mouth. “So?”

“You never practice this late. I thought you valued your sleep.”

“I locked in.”

“Mydeimos.”

“Phainon.”

“*Did she give you a new piece?*”

Mydei swallows the chip, pursing his lips slowly. It was his first lesson of the semester, so of course he would have gotten new repertoire to work on. “Yes,” he says, finding himself unable to lie.

“*Would I know it?*”

That is a stupid question, because Phainon knows every single piece of classical music ever written. Mydei could bring up some obscure composer who’s only written one piece for piano in their entire career and Phainon would still say he might have heard of them before. “No,” he replies anyway. “Really obscure.”

“*What—are you being sarcastic, Mydei?*” Phainon’s voice has a teasing lilt to it, the way it usually gets when he’s about to say something he knows will make Mydei mad. “*Wait, let me guess. Hungarian Rhapsody.*”

Mydei snickers. It’s his worst nightmare to play that piece. Phainon bringing it up now honestly helps him realize that it could always be worse.

“*Anything by Liszt.*”

“I told you it’s obscure.”

“*And you were lying. La Campanella.*”

“You got your guess for the day.”

“*Mydei—*”

“What are you playing?” Mydei continues, effectively cutting him off and changing the subject. Phainon was bound to figure it out sooner or later, anyway.

“*Well, Mozart with the orchestra. And then I’m doing a Chopin waltz solo, and Brahms 1 with Hysilens’ quartet.*”

Mydei exhales sharply. Being a junior and Mydei a sophomore, Phainon was much more involved with the music department than Mydei was. He probably could benefit from involving himself more, honestly—but he’s getting his credits. Phainon is just over-achieving. “I don’t know any of those pieces,” he says.

Phainon sighs loudly on the other end. “*Yeah, we know.*”

“I don’t like Chopin.”

“*Or Mozart.*”

“No, speak for yourself. Mozart is okay.”

“*Ugh. He peaked at Requiem. Maybe if he’d lived a little longer.*”

“He didn’t even write half of *Requiem.*”

Phainon laughs heartily on the other end of the line. It never fails to bring a smile to Mydei's face. "*Look at you and your composer knowledge.*"

"Good point. I clearly need to spend less time with you."

Phainon laughs yet again, making Mydei's grin grow even wider. "*Are you walking back, then?*" He asks, and Mydei's glad that the concern is out of his voice.

"Soon," Mydei says.

"*Will you text me when you get home? I need to shower.*"

"What, worried I'm going to slip and fall?" Mydei asks. He stands, stretching a little before he heads back inside to throw away the empty bag of chips.

"*Something like that. I know you're very fragile.*"

Mydei snorts. Last year, Phainon saying something like that to him would probably have genuinely pissed him off. Being around him so often has desensitized him to his relentless attempts to make Mydei mad. "Bye, then," Mydei responds. "I love you."

"*Aw, I love you too—*" Mydei hangs up, chuckling to himself as he pockets his phone and heads for the fire exit.

The next morning, he leaves his lesson music behind when he goes to class. His practice session that afternoon is spent doing dexterity exercises and etudes.

Phainon walks in on him, as he does many times. He'd always been able to tell when it's Mydei playing, somehow, and has never walked in on someone by accident who isn't Mydei. Though that was his word, and Mydei isn't sure how much he believes that.

“What the fuck,” he says, effectively cutting off Mydei’s playing. The door shuts behind them, and Phainon stares at him like he *has* just walked in on someone else. “Mydeimos, you’re playing *scales.*”

“You don’t play scales?” Mydei asks, feigning innocence. Phainon does play scales. Every session, he warms up with an extensive scale and arpeggio worksheet in the key of the piece he’s working on.

Mydei, however, does not. He sits down at the bench and starts playing, because he doesn’t have time for all of that. Both he and Phainon are very aware of this fact. They had argued about it more times than Mydei could keep track of.

“G-sharp minor,” Phainon says blandly, peering over Mydei’s shoulder.

Mydei swallows. There are hundreds of pieces written in G-sharp minor. It’s not enough of a clue for Phainon to figure out he’s using it as *La Campanella* practice. “Picked a random key,” he replies.

“Why the fuck are you playing scales?”

“Don’t you think my fingers aren’t flexible enough?”

“What?”

“I mean—see?” Mydei stretches out his hand before Phainon, then places it back on the piano. He can hit a tenth comfortably, an eleventh if he *really* strains. He already knows damn well that Phainon can hit a twelfth if he really wants to.

“What exactly are you playing?” Phainon raises an eyebrow.

“I should be able to hit fifteenths, I think.”

Phainon blinks. “Mydei, no one can hit a fucking fifteenth. Not even Rachmaninoff could do that.”

“With jumping,” Mydei explains.

Phainon stares at him for a moment, and Mydei instantly knows he's figured it out. "You're playing *La Campanella.*"

Mydei's hand goes slack, and he looks away with a dejected sigh. "Yeah," he says. He's not a liar, and it wouldn't work on Phainon even if he tried.

"*Holy shit.*" The words leave Phainon's mouth like an exhale, and he steps back a little. "I knew it. Why didn't you tell me when I literally guessed that?"

Mydei bites his lip. "I didn't want you to be upset," he says, unable to look Phainon in the eye.

Phainon frowns. "Why would I be upset? I can't believe I'm going to get to watch you perform *La Campanella.* Oh my god." He runs his hands through his hair, eyes shining when he looks at Mydei.

"Yeah," Mydei sighs. "You think I can do it?"

"I think you can do anything."

Mydei doesn't care all that much about what Madam Herta thinks of his playing at this moment. He finds himself constantly jumping between fighting for Madam Herta's approval and being satisfied with the simple fact that Phainon has always believed in him. He isn't sure which one is more powerful.

That weekend, Mydei is dragged to a party. It's different from the first time last year, when he and Phainon got caught up in a challenge to see who could drink more than the other. It must have been divine intervention that brought him to his senses enough to leave before it got too late. Mydei doesn't remember much about that night, which upsets him. It's why he doesn't like to drink anymore.

Phainon still manages to convince him to come with him sometimes, under the guise that his friends aren't enough to entertain him. Mydei has met Caelus, Stelle, and Hysilens, and he's somewhat close with Cipher and Castorice because of the band, and boring is the last word he would use to describe any of them. So the real reason must be something else entirely.

Sure enough, all four of them are already there when they arrive. Caelus is the host, apparently, this being his apartment. He lives with four other boys from the marching band and Mydei has no desire to be friends with any of them. Band kids were never his crowd.

There's a group of them crowded around the living room table, playing a card game. Mydei knows none of them. Every once in a while, they scream and cheer so loudly that Mydei has to fight the urge to walk out immediately.

Cipher sits on top of a counter looking like she pays rent, and her jaw drops when she meets Mydei's eyes. "No way you got him to come, Phangry?"

Mydei doesn't know where that nickname came from. He asked Phainon about it once, and he said it was what his childhood friend used to call him. How it got into Cipher's hands is anyone's guess.

"I could get him to do anything, really," Phainon laughs that awfully polite laugh of his. Mydei wishes they would hear the way Phainon laughs around him.

Caelus serves Phainon a drink that Mydei wouldn't even trust knowing they're friends. His sister, Stelle, leans against a corner countertop playing some game on her phone. She gives Mydei a quick nod as a greeting and goes back to her game.

"Good thing you're here. I wanted to talk to you, actually," Cipher says, while Phainon and Caelus are deep in conversation. "That song we recorded over the summer? I just sent it out to a few record labels—"

"What?" Mydei starts, eyes wide. "Seriously? That's amazing, Cipher."

Cipher laughs awkwardly. “Yeah…so anyways, I want you to cover the cost in full.”

Mydei’s smile fades. “…You’re serious.”

Cipher nods, like she’s ashamed, but Mydei knows she doesn’t feel an ounce of shame.

“They charged you to send a song in?”

“Penacony’s a fucked up place, man,” Cipher shakes her head. “I swear I’m not trying to scam you.”

Mydei honestly knows better than to trust her, but he gets her Venmo and pays her anyway. She grins, toothy, when she sees the money, and disappears soon after that.

Mydei met both Cipher and Castorice last year, during the spring semester. Cipher was introduced to him by Phainon, and they met each other when they both worked at the library. Cipher was a senior then, and Mydei isn’t entirely sure how she got into this college party (or graduated, for that matter), but most of what Cipher accomplishes shouldn’t be questioned.

Castorice was a junior literature major who worked for the writing center. Mydei met her after getting help on one of his History essays. She already knew Cipher very well, having met each other when they lived in Okhema. Cipher played electric bass, and Castorice played the drums. Mydei foolishly thought that the rhythm section of a band must get along very well, but with the two of them, that wasn’t exactly the case. They bickered a lot when the three of them worked together to write their first song, though most of that was Cipher’s fault. Castorice was hard to make angry, but Cipher tried her best.

All three of them, and Phainon as well, lived in Amphoreus, which was overseas from their college. It made it easier over the summer where they could see each other to record—all Mydei had to do was travel to Okhema, which wasn’t all that difficult.

The first and only song they'd ever written wasn't a masterpiece by any means, but Mydei liked it. Castorice had written the lyrics, Mydei had written the music, and Cipher produced it, which she had no background in beforehand, but they figured it out together. It's hard to create something perfect with limited materials, but it was the most fun Mydei had had in years. He didn't think, at the time of recording, that they had any bigger plans for the little band they'd started for fun. And Cipher might have sent the song out, but that didn't mean they were going to get a record deal.

"Mydei! My man!" Caelus cuts in, slapping him on the shoulder. He has a cup in hand that better not be intended for Mydei. "You drinking tonight?"

Mydei sighs. "I will if you hit the gym with us tomorrow night," he responds, coming to stand beside Phainon.

Caelus looks over his shoulder to Stelle, who is offering him no help. "I'm kinda busy. Gotta do some homework tomorrow, you know how it is…"

"Your business homework?" Phainon asks, feigning innocence. Mydei disguises his laugh as a cough, turning into Phainon's shoulder as he does it. "Did you fail the last color-by-number exam?"

Caelus rolls his eyes. "You guys are such assholes. The gym isn't really my thing, okay?"

"...You're a business major." Phainon reiterates.

"We're pianists," Mydei adds.

"I'm in marching band!" Caelus defends himself, waving his arms around. "I have…that to worry about, and stuff…"

"Hitting the gym could help you hold your trumpet up for longer," Mydei suggests, and Phainon nods furiously beside him.

"I can hold my trumpet up long enough as is, thank you very much," Caelus admonishes. "Stelle—"

“Deserved,” Stelle says, still not looking up from her phone. “You gotta get rid of those noodle arms, bro. No girl’s gonna hit when you look like that.”

“*What?!*”

Mydei snorts. He always liked Stelle—she had a tendency to say things she probably shouldn’t, but she was always funny. Probably his favorite of Phainon’s friends.

With the two of them bickering, Phainon turns to Mydei. “I’m going to have an extra shot just for you tonight,” he says, picking up a random shot glass from nearby. “To *La Campanella*.”

“Oh, fuck off,” Mydei laughs. “You’ll do it too, one day.”

“A man can dream, Mydeimos,” Phainon shakes his head. “Come on. Let’s join Uno.”

“Are you serious?” Mydei asks quietly, his pleas falling upon deaf ears as Phainon pulls him towards the living room. He doesn’t like new people—especially when they’re loud, and especially when he’s sober. But he’s roped into four games of Uno anyway, while Phainon beats everyone each round.

“Good.” Madam Herta cuts him off, and his fingers slide off the keys. “I can tell you’ve been practicing hard. Did you listen to my performance?”

“Yes,” Mydei says, earnestly. It was odd, seeing a much younger version of Madam Herta on that stage, playing with the perfection of a robot and the emotion of a human. He had always respected her, and wanted to be respected by her, but it didn’t sink in just how talented she was until he watched that video. Honestly, he can’t really believe she’s actually wasting her time on him.

“I can tell.” There’s a small smile on her face, but it’s more amused than proud. “Your problem is that you only know how to phrase if there’s something for you to copy. You played that whole beginning section just as I did all those years ago.” She suddenly uncrosses her legs and leans forward in her chair. “But let me ask you something, Mydeimos—who is playing this piece today?”

Mydei swallows. “I am.”

“Very good, Mydeimos!” she exclaims. It’s patronizing, the way she says it—like she’s talking to a child. “Now, are you going to play it, or am I going to?”

Mydei puts his fingers back on the keys, into position for the first measure. “I will.”

“I saw you do it last May,” Madam Herta continues. She’s back to her original position, leaning back in her throne with her legs crossed. “I know you’re capable of feeling a piece in your own way. Just what was it that made you do it?”

“Er—” Mydei clears his throat, blushing a little as he tries to think of a way to tell her about Phainon without embarrassing himself.

“I don’t need to know the intimate details,” she says, waving her hand back and forth. “Just do it again, by any means necessary.”

Mydei nods. He looks up at the sheet music, then down at his hands, then back up at the sheet music, and begins to play.

He’s taking it at a tempo significantly slower than what’s written, but it was enough of an accomplishment to get it presentable at this tempo, so he’s not too worried about that right now. The bigger problem is that unlike the night of his final recital, with Phainon in the audience, he can’t, by any means, imagine that Phainon is here with him.

He tries to pretend that it’s not Madam Herta in that chair and it’s Phainon instead, but it doesn’t work. They’re too different. No matter what he does,

her terrifying presence still lingers in the back of his mind.

Madam Herta cuts him off much earlier than she had the first time. “Again,” she says, voice sharp. “From the top.”

Mydei swallows the lump in his throat, and abides.

He barely makes it two measures before he’s cut off again. “I can already tell you’re trying too hard,” she says. “One more time.”

He gets later this time, but only by a negligible amount. She shakes her head, clicking her tongue. “Alright, scratch the phrasing. Let’s pick it up at measure thirty-one, and work on the technicalities together.”

Mydei can do technicalities. He almost sighs in relief.

He exits her office hot and borderline sweaty, like he’s leaving a hard session at the gym instead of a piano lesson. The practice rooms across the hall are practically screaming at him. He admits defeat, rather begrudgingly, and enters one with an open door.

He vows, as he drops his bag on the floor and sits at the bench, that he won’t be too long. An hour, tops—he just needed a minute to work through it without Madam Herta cutting him off every two seconds like an annoying gnat.

It’s already getting late, and he still has a reading due the next morning that he hasn’t started yet. He leaves the practice room an hour and a half later, much to his own chagrin. If it were really up to him, he would stay there for another three hours. Curse his double major.

The next day, when Phainon weasels his way into Mydei’s practice room in the afternoon, he has the biggest grin on his face.

“Holy shit—I heard you from outside. You’re amazing, Mydei.”

“Don’t you have your own music to practice?” Mydei asks, writing something in the margins of his music.

“My piece can wait,” he says, waving him off. “Play for me?”

Mydei sighs, tucking the pencil back behind his ear. “It’s not good. Madam Herta said—”

“Fuck her,” Phainon cuts him off. “You could sit on the keyboard and it would still sound like a melody.”

Mydei snorts. Sometimes he really believed that he could sit on the keyboard and Phainon would, somehow, find a way to compliment him. It’s ironic, really, considering their attitude toward each other when they first met.

Mydei will never forget that first day, when Phainon sat next to him in Professor Anaxa’s class even though there were plenty of open desks. He had been overly friendly, to the point where Mydei was mildly annoyed, and then proceeded to tell him he played like shit because he didn’t know how to phrase properly. Mydei had, obviously, returned the sentiment and told him that his playing was too messy because of how overly emotional it was. They’d argued throughout the class, only for Phainon to follow him to the dining hall afterwards.

He was like a lost puppy, always by Mydei’s side after that, no matter how resentful Mydei still was about that day in class. He hadn’t insulted Mydei’s playing once since his recital at the end of the spring semester, not even to jest, which is what it had eventually become.

Playing *La Campanella* feels significantly easier with Phainon watching, instead of Madam Herta. There’s something about his presence that comforts him, every nod of his head more encouraging than anything Madam Herta could give him.

He plays until he can’t anymore, until his fingers falter and he has to think about the chords before he can play them. Phainon is completely silent, and when he stops, taking his hands off the keys, Mydei can hear him exhale.

“You’re so beautiful, Mydei, you know that?” Phainon says, barely a whisper, from where he stands beside the bench. “Beautiful and talented,

how’d you get so goddamn lucky?”

Mydei huffs a little laugh, and turns his head to the side to meet his gaze. Phainon leans down and kisses him once. “I got just as lucky as you did,” he murmurs against Phainon’s lips.

Phainon pulls back. “You flatter me, Mydeimos,” he says lightheartedly, resting his elbows on the lid of the piano. “But I can’t play the way you do.”

“If only I heard what you hear,” Mydei mumbled, turning back to his music.

“Mydei, you’ve been working on this piece for a week, and it’s already good—I mean, it *sounds* like *La Campanella.* Isn’t that enough of an accomplishment?”

Mydei purses his lips. Madam Herta hadn’t said anything about his progress being slow either way—and while she hadn’t had much good to say, she didn’t have much bad to say, either. He supposes that *was* enough of an accomplishment.

“Do you want to come to my dorm?” Phainon asks, changing the subject when Mydei doesn’t respond. “I think you need to relax. We can watch one of those old Kremnoan war films you like.”

Mydei sighs. “Okay, fine. But it has to be *Gnaeus*.”

Phainon heaves a deep sigh. Mydei knows he doesn’t like *Gnaeus* very much, for reasons they’ve argued about at length before. “If we watch *Gnaeus*, we’re watching *Flame Reaver of the Deepest Dark* too.”

Mydei doesn’t mind that one, but he pretends to for the sake of the argument. “You sure we have time for that? *Flame Reaver* is like three and a half hours long.”

“And if it wasn’t, you’d say it’s rushed,” Phainon complains, crossing his arms. “Come. We’ll watch *Gnaeus* and then *Flame Reaver* until you fall asleep.”

Mydei laughs a little, but he's already packing up. He tells himself he'll practice extra tomorrow. Or sometime this week, but he'll get it done either way. Phainon always told him it was important that you didn't practice yourself into hating the instrument.

Mydei's feelings on the piano are already mixed at best, but somehow, whenever he sees Phainon's familiar head of white-blond hair poking in through his practice room door, he starts to remember why he's still in this major.

The walk to Phainon's dorm building is fairly short, as he chose it for that reason. Mydei, unfortunately, hadn't been that smart, and was stuck in a tower halfway across campus. He liked the view on the ninth floor well enough to consider it worth it, until the elevator broke down and he was stuck hauling his gym bag up nine flights of stairs right after hitting legs.

Regardless, they walk a little past it so they can stop at the student center and buy a bag of chips. They argue about flavors until that turns into two bags of chips, and Phainon pays even though Mydei tries to.

Phainon only lives on the second floor, so the walk up isn't nearly as atrocious as Mydei's. He lives at the end of the hallway, in the only single in his suite. Mydei's single is bigger, but Phainon's is nicer, because he actually decorated it much more than Mydei did. He has a few band posters, but most of Phainon's walls are covered in sheet music cut outs, antique photos of his favorite composers, and a few posters dedicated to the modern music he likes, too. He has LEDs so he doesn't have to use the big light, because it makes his head hurt. Mydei doesn't quite understand that, but he likes his LEDs anyway.

He hooks his laptop up to his wall projector, which aims at the only blank stretch of wall in the room. They sit on his bed together as he pulls up his favorite movie piracy site and puts in *Gnaeus*, which is already one of his recent searches—probably from the last time they watched it.

Phainon sighs wistfully as the opening scene fades in, snaking a hand around Mydei's shoulder. "I love the score in this movie."

He says that every time. Mydei doesn't respond, leaning into his side until he's comfortable. *Gnaeus* opens with a very violent battle scene, where the audio is silenced and an orchestral piece plays over it.

Mydei likes *Gnaeus* because its depiction of Kremnoan culture isn't glorified at all. He explained this to Phainon at length, before, and he thinks that's what got Phainon to change his opinion on it in the end—because he sure as hell did not regard it as genius when he first watched it.

"You look just like her," Phainon mumbles into his hair when Queen Gorgo I comes on screen for the first time. He says that every time, too.

Queen Gorgo I is an actual historical figure whom his mother is distantly related to, but in this movie, it's just an actress with good makeup and a braid.

"Phainon," Mydei says suddenly, reaching forward to pause the movie from Phainon's computer. "Come home for winter break with me?"

"What?" Phainon startles a little, loosening his hold on Mydei's shoulder to look down at him, wide-eyed. "Are you serious?"

"If you want to, that is…" Mydei murmurs. "I know you have your own family, and—"

"I don't," Phainon says quickly. "Not…not like you do."

Mydei only has his mother, really. But both of Phainon's parents were killed in a house fire, and he talks about it so rarely that Mydei had assumed the family he moved in with afterwards were just as much his family as his parents were, once.

"I would love to," Phainon continues. "Would your mother be okay with that?"

"She loves you," Mydei answers without a second thought. "I'm honestly surprised she didn't suggest it first."

“Then I will,” Phainon’s voice is soft, as he squeezes Mydei into his side. “Of course I will.”

By November, Mydei has made his way through a chunk of *La Campanella* that he would think was impressive were his deadline not in a mere month. The more he thinks about it, the more he’s convinced that Madam Herta is simply out to get him. Surely even the most skilled pianist would take longer than three months to learn a piece like that—part of him wants to ask just how long it took *her* to master it, but he knows that won’t go over well. She doesn’t like when people talk back to her, he’d already learned that the hard way.

Their last lesson had actually gone surprisingly well, all things considered. Madam Herta had seemed to be giving up on him recently, which she had a tendency to do with the students that weren’t performing up to her standards. She only helped those she actually thought had a chance. Mydei would hate her if he didn’t want to impress her so badly.

This time, though, she was in a good mood. Perhaps something happened before their lesson that caused the switch, but she ended the lesson with comments that Mydei could only interpret as optimistic—that she was excited for the recital, and as long as Mydei spent the next few weeks perfecting the sections he was still struggling with, it would be perfect.

But Mydei couldn’t even work on phrasing when he could still barely play some parts. He’d even started to practice less and less because the amount of time it took for him to get irritated was getting shorter and shorter, and he spent his practice sessions playing literally anything else so he wouldn’t have to work on the piece he had grown to resent.

It was his mother who had gotten him as far as he had with the piece so far, anyway—Phainon was also helpful, of course, but his mother *always* knew the exact right thing to say, and Phainon pissed him off more often than not recently. She was able to calm him down enough to get him to practice

more every time he called her, and was the reason behind most of his progress on *La Campanella* as a whole.

Until he got a call from an unknown number with a Castrum Kremnos area code, and the man on the other end of the line told him that she had died.

Car crash. Fatal. The other man was drunk, and survived. Mydei was filled with an anger he hadn't felt in years. He hung up before the other man was even done talking. All he could think about was his fucking alcoholic father, who wasn't even the reason she was dead, but he might as well have been. While he was at it, he could blame his father for the lapse in *La Campanella* progress, too. And for his rough patch with Phainon that Phainon didn't even know about because Mydei liked to simmer in his resentment.

He walked to the gym and fought with a punching bag until closing time, because his mother was always who he called when he was angry, and he comes back to his gym bag with a few missed texts from Phainon, as well as a missed call.

Phainon: mydei??? are you mad at me?????
Phainon: i know you're probably busy, but you've been distant recently. are you okay?
Phainon: i'm sorry herta is putting so much pressure on you. it's not fair, and i'm here to support you. you can talk to me mydei
Phainon: please call me back when you get a chance. i love you

So it seems Mydei wasn't all that good at hiding his resentment after all. Was he really so transparent? He could only hope it was just Phainon able to see through him so well.

He types out a few possible responses as he mindlessly makes his way to the gym exit, and the freezing winter air hits him hard as he steps outside.

He’s still in his gym clothes, a t-shirt and shorts, but he can’t find it in him to care.

The cold air is grounding as he makes the long walk back to his dorm. He forgoes responding to Phainon, pocketing his phone and ignoring the way it continues to buzz against his thigh. He forgot Phainon can see that he’s opened his messages.

He puts on his headphones and turns his music up as high as it will go, uncaring to the potential long term damage it might cause. The last thing he wants to do is think right now. He’s already dreading going to bed. Maybe he’ll stay up all night, finding thing after thing to distract him.

When he gets to his dorm, his whole body is stiff from the cold and his lips are turning blue. He drops his gym bag on the floor, tosses his phone on his desk, and goes to take a shower. He turns the water up as high as it will go and stands under it while his skin turns so red he thinks he can feel it burning off.

The cold air of his dorm is a sharp contrast once he’s done. He throws on some clothes and climbs into bed, shivering. He feels like he’s getting sick, and it’s humiliating. He was always sick as a kid, but hadn’t gotten anything worse than a light cold since.

It’s only then, with nothing but the soft whirring of his dehumidifier to keep him company, that he actually thinks about it for the first time.

Mama is dead.

He almost doesn’t believe it. That wasn’t possible. She was always there for him, always there to pick up his calls and give him advice and console him when he was sad. She wasn’t supposed to go away so easily. She wasn’t supposed to go away like *this.* The strongest person Mydei had ever known, dead to a fucking *car crash.*

He chokes on his first sob, and only lets himself cry because he’s alone. He cries until his whole body hurts, until his throat stings and there are no more

tears coming out of his eyes. He cries until he’s exhausted himself into silence, and somehow finds enough peace in the aftermath to fall asleep.

He wakes up sick. He’s usually not one to spring out of bed in the mornings, but today is even worse than ever. *Mama is dead.* He revels in the brief moments of respite he had when he had just woken up where he did not remember what happened yesterday.

Through the numbness that settles over him as he remembers this, he’s brought back to last night, where he had cried himself to sleep. He’s embarrassed, disgusted, even, that he would allow himself to be so weak—what would his mother say, seriously—and the only solace he has is that no one was there to witness it.

He doesn’t know how long it takes, but eventually, he finds just enough energy to slide out of bed and stumble over to his desk, where his phone is. It’s at fifteen percent, with way too many notifications for him to sift through. He brings it back over to his bed. It’s almost noon, and he’s already missed one class. Thursday is his busiest day, second only to Tuesday, but he can’t find it in himself to care about any of the classes he’s going to miss. If parental loss isn’t a good enough reason for his professors, then sickness surely is.

He curls back up in bed, shivering from what’s probably a high fever, but he doesn’t care to take his temperature right now. The only messages he actually cares to read are Phainon’s.

Yesterday 11:32 PM

Phainon: mydeimos
Phainon: i can see u read that u ass
Phainon: please call me back
Phainon: or at least let me know you’re safe?
Phainon: i’m going to sleep now. respond when you wake up, ok? we’ll

talk about whatevers bothering you tomorrow. ok?
Phainon: good night mydei i love you

Today 7:00 AM

Phainon: good morning mydei
Phainon: i know youre probably asleep
Phainon: im really sorry mydei

Today 8:12 AM

Phainon: they’re serving honeycakes at alfalfa this morning
Phainon: i’m smuggling one out for you since ik ur groggy ass isn’t going to breakfast

Today 9:40 AM

Phainon: i’m in theory rn, are you coming?

Today 11:01 AM

Phainon: mydei, please respond, i’m getting really worried
Phainon: it’s ok if you don’t want to talk to me, i just want to know that you’re safe
Phainon: just tell me you’re ok and i’ll leave you alone, i promise
Phainon: i’m sorry

Mydei feels so guilty reading those messages that he’s almost brought to tears a second time, but he’s pulled back only by the sheer will that last night was the only time that would ever happen.

He didn’t want to lie, not anymore. He’d lied to Phainon enough in the last month, and for whatever reason, Phainon had let him. So now, he tells the truth, no matter how hard it feels.

Today 11:48 AM

My mom died yesterday.

Phainon: wait what
Phainon: oh my god mydei
Phainon: wait, are you serious?
Phainon: mydei
Phainon: oh my god
Phainon: im coming over, ok

I'm sick. You shouldn't come over.

Phainon: i'm coming over mydei.

Mydei only gets out of bed to let Phainon into his dorm, even though he was tempted to stay in bed forever, just to see how long it would take Phainon to give up.

Phainon stands outside the door, eyes wide and glistening with tears. He doesn't say anything, and neither does Mydei, despite the temptation to question why on earth *he* was crying.

When Mydei closes the door behind him, Phainon's arms are around him in a second. It takes longer than it should for Mydei to hug him back. Phainon's shoulders shake with sobs while Mydei refuses to let himself cry.

"I'm sorry, Mydei," Phainon laments, his voice muffled into the fabric of Mydei's t-shirt. "God, I'm so sorry." He pulls back, eyes red and puffy, snot dripping from his nose, and Mydei is once again faced with the temptation to question the validity of his reaction.

"Don't apologize for something you had nothing to do with," Mydei says. His voice is rough from a number of things—disuse, probably, his sickness, and from how hard he had cried just the night before. "What is your problem? You only met her once."

“Mydei, it’s your *mom*,” he answers, incredulous, like Mydei didn’t know that already. “Why aren’t you more upset about this?”

Mydei feels that familiar wave of annoyance pass through him, and he takes a step back. “I don’t think you have any right to tell me how I’m supposed to feel.”

Phainon closes his eyes, and he reaches forward to take Mydei’s hands in his own. “I know, I’m sorry, Mydei, I shouldn’t have said that—I don’t want to fight, okay? I’m sorry.”

Mydei simply nods, equally as unwilling to get caught up in a fight right now, despite his current realization that his feelings of resentment from before were not at all gone. If anything, it was stronger than ever right now. He wanted to be alone, but didn’t have the heart to tell Phainon this.

“I brought soup,” Phainon continues. “Can I make you some?”

Mydei isn’t hungry. He usually has a large appetite and tries to eat a lot of food so he can stay healthy and maintain his build, but just the idea of eating anything right now is making him nauseous. Still, he nods.

Phainon leaves to use the communal microwave, and Mydei sits down at his desk and stares at his closed laptop like it’s far more interesting than it is. He comes back in a few minutes later, placing the hot glass tupperware down in front of him. Mydei is sure that it would taste good. But looking down at it now, it looks greenish-gray, like sludge, more like it came from a witches’ cauldron than a university dining hall. He picks up the spoon and stirs it around as Phainon moves to his window to open the shades, then stands beside him with a hand on his back and somehow convinces him to take a bite.

It does taste good. The warmth soothes his sore throat, too, and Mydei is just now hit with the realization of how hungry he is. He finishes in silence, and Phainon leaves to wash the dishes. With the door cracked open, he can hear the running water from the sink in the communal kitchen. He listens to it mindlessly until it stops, and mourns the loss. Phainon comes back a few

moments later, placing the bowl upside down on the towel Mydei uses to dry his dishes.

“How do you feel?” he asks gently, the sound of his voice louder than it should be in the dead silence of his dorm. “Can I take your temperature?”

“It’s just a cold,” Mydei says. “I walked home in my gym clothes yesterday.”

“Mydeimos,” Phainon crosses his arms, deeply disappointed. “You didn’t have a change of clothes?”

He did, but part of him wanted to freeze. He doesn’t tell this to Phainon, though, because it would only worry him beyond belief. So instead, he shakes his head. He’s lying and he hates the way it feels, but he can’t bring himself to tell the truth.

“Here,” Phainon moves to his bag, rummaging through it until he pulls out a small packet of something Mydei doesn’t recognize. “Cyrene would make me drink this stuff when I got a cold. It helps a little, in my experience.”

Mydei has never met Cyrene before, only in brief video calls, and he thinks they might follow each other on social media. She was Phainon’s childhood friend and later roommate (sister?) after his house burned down. From what he’s heard about her, she was a pretty weird kid—convinced she was a psychic who could hear prophecies. Mydei’s just glad she used this talent to become an author instead of scamming people out of their hard-earned money.

Phainon hands him a plastic cup containing the contents of the packet mixed with water. He leaves again, to wash off the end of the fork he had used to stir it together, and Mydei forces himself to try it. It tastes better than he had expected, like a vitamin drink. In all his attempts to keep himself healthy, he’s had his fair share of vitamin drinks.

When he comes back in, more silence passes. Mydei sips mindlessly on the drink, not many thoughts crossing through his head. Phainon watches him carefully, and Mydei can sense that he wants to say something, but won’t.

“Spit it out,” he finally says, putting the cup down and turning to face him. “It’s not like you to be so quiet.”

Phainon releases his breath, running a hand through his messy hair. He looks like he might be sweating, but Mydei doesn’t think his room is all that hot right now. “Mydei,” he finally breathes, “I just…well, what are you going to do after this?”

“Keep going.” Is Mydei’s answer. “I’ll be fine.”

It’s clear that’s not even close to what Phainon wanted to hear, because his visible distress increases even more. “No, you won’t,” he insists. “You can’t just push everything away, Mydei. It will only backfire.”

“We’re different people, Phainon,” he snaps. “I’ll be fine.” He really believes it. He grieved last night. That was all he needed.

“You *won’t,*” Phainon says again. “Mydei, at least take the semester off. The school will understand. Grief like this isn’t the kind of thing you can get over in a day—”

“Clearly, I managed,” Mydei shoots back. “If we’re just going to argue, I’d rather you leave.”

His words send a shock through Phainon, and he stares at Mydei with wide, pleading eyes. “You made yourself sick, Mydei,” he says softly. “You’re not okay.”

Mydei turns away, his attention back on the drink Phainon had made him. It’s such a kind gesture—all of it, the soup, even coming over in the first place, that it only pisses Mydei off more. Why did he have to make *everything* so difficult?

“You weren’t okay, even before this,” Phainon continues. “I wasn’t going to bring it up, but

you’ve been cold towards me for *weeks now*.”

Mydei closes his eyes. He should have known he couldn’t avoid this forever.

“Did I do something, Mydei?” Phainon pleads. “The last thing I want is to be part of the reason you’re feeling this way.”

“You didn’t do anything,” Mydei responds, because it’s true. Phainon has been nothing but kind and loving to him, and it’s solely his own fault their relationship is starting to fall apart.

“Then *why,*” Phainon starts, voice rising in desperation. “Mydei, I love you, and—”

“Phainon,” Mydei interrupts, ignoring the pain in his heart. “I want to be alone right now.” He says it as gently as he can, but it doesn’t lessen the blow, and he knows it doesn’t. “I’m sorry,” he adds.

Phainon looks conflicted. He bites at his lip, eyes still wide with worry, but after a brief period of deliberation, he zips up his bag and picks it up. “Are we going to be okay?” he asks, hovering in front of the door.

Mydei nods, and that prickling feeling is back. He hates lying more than anything, but he truly doesn’t know, and he doesn’t want Phainon to spiral after this.

It’s a terrible, terrible thing that Phainon trusts him as much as he does, because this nod is enough to bring him some semblance of reassurance as he walks out the door.

Mydei hates the way he feels when Phainon is gone. Even emptier than before, and the silence in his room is suffocating. All he wants to do is go back to sleep. None of his problems seem to exist when he’s asleep.

He goes back to class on Monday. On Sunday, he had actually managed to sit down and get some work done. When he wakes up for class Monday

morning, he feels alright. Like he's not slipping. Like his life is perfectly in order.

He catches Phainon for the first time since their conversation (fight?) on Tuesday in the music building. He's about to leave, presumably after a practice session, and walks past Mydei doing his theory homework in the lounge. They had spoken since, over text, but nothing was ever addressed.

Of course, Phainon approaches him. He sits in the other empty seat at the table but doesn't say anything, like he's waiting for Mydei to speak first.

Mydei puts his pencil down and lifts his head, letting him know he has his full attention.

"I—" Phainon starts, and Mydei already knows what's coming. "I'm sorry."

Mydei sighs. "How many times do I have to tell you not to apologize for things that aren't your fault?"

"But how is it not my fault?" Phainon asks. His hands are clenched into tight fists. His hair is a mess and there are bags under his eyes, like his insomnia is coming back. Mydei steels himself and bites his tongue. "You wouldn't be pushing me away right now if I didn't…do something, right?"

"Phainon," Mydei says, annoyance creeping into his voice. He rubs at his temple, squeezing his eyes shut. "This doesn't have anything to do with you. Please, just…let me deal with this myself."

"But I'm supposed to be there for you," Phainon says softly. It's so reverent that Mydei isn't quite sure how to react. "I *want* to be there for you."

"I understand," Mydei responds. He doesn't feel like saying anything else on the matter. "Can you help me with this, now?"

Phainon looks down at the packet Mydei's working his way through, then back up at him, confusion etched on his face. "Mydei—" he starts, and it already sounds like he's not about to talk about music theory.

Mydei shoots him an obvious look, daring him to continue. He doesn't.

Phainon visibly swallows, then slides the paper over to his side of the table. “You wrote a parallel fifth here,” he starts, taking Mydei’s pencil and beginning to erase part of his work. “You have to stop doing that. It doesn’t sound good.”

“I think it sounds good,” Mydei responds. A bit of peace settles over him as their relationship seems to have taken a tiny step closer to what it was before.

Phainon gives him a look. “It doesn’t sound good,” he reiterates, swiping eraser shavings off the side of the table.

Or maybe they’re just lying to each other.

By Mydei’s lesson on Wednesday, it marks exactly a week since he got the phone call. And exactly a week since the last time he practiced.

Usually, he practices every single day for at least an hour, though he does the bulk of his practicing on the weekend. This weekend he spent rotting away in his dorm room, and he was too busy catching up on the work he missed on Thursday and Friday to have time to practice.

Madam Herta notices instantly. Of course she does. She has the hearing of a bat, and Mydei would even say with confidence that she has something stronger than perfect pitch, if it was possible. She knows when Mydei has improved, which was pretty steadily a weekly occurrence up until this point.

This week, though, it’s like not only has he not improved, but he’s regressed, too. He messes up on phrases he could have sworn he could play perfectly last week. Madam Herta stops him fast, with a hand in the air.

“Mydeimos,” she begins, and Mydei begins to steel himself for the spiel he’s about to get. “Would you like to explain to me why you haven’t been practicing this week?”

Mydei takes a deep breath. He curls his hands into fists, and his palms are sweaty. “I didn’t get a chance,” he answers. He knows he can tell the truth —that it would be a valid excuse to most people, and hopefully that included Madam Herta. But he doesn’t want to succumb to it. Admitting the true reason he’s slipping would be like allowing it to defeat him. He’s stronger than that. He knows he is.

Madam Herta takes a moment before answering, pushing her glasses up so they sit on top of her head. She tosses her clipboard to the side, and it clatters against her desk. “Alright, then,” she says. “In that case, why don’t you get out of my office?”

Mydei opens his mouth, then closes it again, unsure of what to say. He knew he was going to get in trouble, but he didn’t think he was going to get kicked out. Does this mean she’s dropping him as a student? He knew Madam Herta didn’t like teaching students she didn’t see potential in, but dropping them entirely was unheard of for her. As far as he knew, anyway.

“Have you lost your hearing? Is that why you couldn’t practice?” she continues, and Mydei might have laughed at that if she wasn’t dead serious. “My time is precious, and I will not allow it to be wasted on your carelessness.”

Carelessness? Mydei has been called a lot of things, but careless is not one of them. Especially not when it comes to his love of music. Couldn’t she see how much time he had already put into this piece? How could she call it careless?

In what is a very strong contender for the most embarrassing moment of his life, Mydei feels his eyes start to sting. The last thing he would ever want to do is cry in front of Madam Herta because she was *too mean* to him. He stands up so fast the piano bench goes skidding into the wall, and picks his sheet music up haphazardly. The papers are probably not in order, but all he cares about is escaping right now.

“Thank you,” he mutters as he flees out the door. She doesn’t say anything else, and Mydei doesn’t look at her as he leaves.

He makes a beeline to the first practice room that's open. On his first run through, his fingers are stiff and cold and he can't see very well through the tears in his eyes. By midnight, his fingers are stumbling over themselves and all Mydei wants is to throw the piano against the wall. He's still upset for his whole walk home, and even wakes up the next morning angry.

For the rest of the week, he gets up early to practice before his classes and doesn't get back to his dorm until well after midnight. He's averaging four hours of sleep a night. His goal is to double the amount that he would normally practice, and he thinks he's making good work of it. The only thing he's touched is *La Campanella.* He hasn't been this desperate to please someone in his life.

He likes being this busy. It keeps his mind off things. Instead of thinking about his mom, which would just discourage him from practicing, he thinks of how humiliating it was to be kicked out of Madam Herta's office on Wednesday. It's the only thing keeping him going.

Phainon notices. Mydei knows that he does, because he makes it painfully obvious, even though he's been good about not mentioning these things.

They meet for breakfast more often than they had before, because Mydei isn't sleeping in anymore. He doesn't have much of an appetite in the early morning, but Phainon does.

On Sunday morning, Phainon sits down in the booth across from him with a plate of pancakes. There's a comment about eating healthy on the tip of Mydei's tongue, but he stays silent. It was merely a passing thought compared to how often he thinks about *La Campanella* recently. He had even dreamt about it last night. He was on stage, for his final recital, and had sat down to start playing when he looked at the piano rack to see that he had forgotten his sheet music backstage. He had no choice but to play it from memory, and woke up with his heart pounding in his ears. He couldn't fall back asleep after that.

"You know how I hate Mozart?" Phainon is saying, his mouth full of food. Mydei's leg bounces restlessly under the table and he knows Phainon can

feel it, but can’t bring himself to stop. “I still do, but I think he might have *one* good song now. Besides *Requiem.*”

Mydei had heard the concerto—it was just alright, but Phainon had been so upset when he learned they were playing a Mozart piece.

“Mmh,” he says.

“And Herta is actually pretty nice to me. She’s a good conductor, you know. A little mean to the violas, but that’s obviously warranted.”

Mydei doesn’t particularly care for viola jokes on a good day, but the mere mention of Madam Herta shakes him to his core. He hadn’t told Phainon she kicked him out of her office last week. He would only ask why he hadn’t told her the truth, and Mydei was trying to avoid those kinds of conversations right now.

A tiny part of his brain whispers that Madam Herta is only nice to Phainon because she doesn’t see the same potential that she sees in Mydei. He immediately feels disgusted with himself for even thinking such a thing. Phainon is talented. He doesn’t deserve to be the target of Mydei’s insecurity.

He reaches for his cup of orange juice, and his hands shake a little as he raises it to his lips. His hands have been violently shaky recently, whenever he’s not playing.

He notices the exact moment that Phainon recognizes both the shakiness of his hands and the source of it, and can only pray to the god his people used to worship that he chooses not to bring it up.

Of course, he’s not so lucky. Phainon reaches across the table, taking Mydei’s free hand into his own. “Mydei,” he says, looking at him with his wide blue eyes. “Your knuckles are swollen.”

Mydei jerks his hand away, shoving both of them underneath the table. “I took a break,” is his weak argument. “They’re not used to playing this much anymore.”

“You didn’t play for a *week*,” Phainon shoots back. “How much did you practice yesterday?”

A lie is on the tip of Mydei’s tongue, but he bites it down. Phainon won’t believe him anyway, and he doesn’t deserve to be lied to as much as he has been recently. “All day,” he says.

“How much is *all day?*”

“Seven,” Mydei starts. “To, um, one?” He’s ashamed. He can’t seem to meet Phainon’s eyes.

“AM, Mydei?” Phainon demands. He’s leaning over the table more each time he speaks, as if getting closer will make Mydei more open to making eye contact.

Mydei’s face flushes. “I took breaks,” he says weakly. It doesn’t work.

Phainon goes silent, and Mydei sees him lean back into the booth in the corner of his eye. “*Why?*” he finally asks, the question breathless.

“What do you mean *why?*” Mydei asks, sounding more aggressive than he means to. “I need to get better.”

“*Better?!*” Phainon exclaims. “You’re already the most talented musician I’ve ever met, Mydei! You’re playing *La Campanella*, for fuck’s sake! You think any other pianist at this school can do that?!”

“That’s by your standards,” Mydei shoots back. It’s cruel, but he says it without thinking. Even if he had thought, he probably would have said it anyway. His hands hurt, he’s overstimulated, and every new word out of Phainon’s mouth is just annoying him more.

“Are you *serious?*” Phainon gawks, incredulous. “You don’t think all the opportunities you’ve gotten are any proof of your talent, Mydei? Herta *clapped* for you. Anaxa told me I could learn things from you that *he* couldn’t teach me as well as you could. You were invited to play with the *PY Phil* in two years. What is going to be enough for you?!”

“I’m not good enough,” Mydei reiterates.

Phainon groans, frustrated. “To *who?!*”

“*Herta,*” Mydei shoots back.

“*Fuck Herta,*” Phainon is frighteningly close to yelling at this point, and Mydei knows the others eating around them can hear their conversation. “Who are you doing this for, Mydei? *Herta?* Or yourself?”

Mydei can’t bring himself to unpack that question right now, so he doesn’t even try. “I need to be perfect,” he insists.

“Mydei,” Phainon’s voice is softer now, much to Mydei’s relief. “What good is perfection if you lose all the joy it gave you getting there?”

“I can tell you prioritize enjoyment,” Mydei mutters. He can see Phainon’s heart break just in the expression on his face.

“Oh,” he says softly. “I didn’t know you felt that way.”

Mydei immediately regrets it. But instead of apologizing, like he knows he should, he gets up. Slings his bag over his shoulder and walks away, out of the dining hall. For the first time since he’d known him, Phainon doesn’t chase after him.

He sits in the practice room he walked to in silence. His music is still in his bag, unpacked.

His mom would be able to give him good advice right now. Comfort him through all the pain but tell him it doesn’t give him an excuse to treat Phainon the way he had. But she’s gone, and if she wasn’t, Mydei supposes he wouldn’t be going through this in the first place.

Hephaestion is the second person he wants. He’d long gotten over that loss —his first best friend, his first love. It wasn’t easy, but he had his mother back then. But Hephaestion would always set Mydei straight. Tell him he’s being a spoiled asshole and that Phainon doesn’t deserve to be spoken to like that.

He hadn’t spoken to the rest of their friend group since he had gone to university. Nothing was the same after Hephaestion died, anyway. Mydei wouldn’t trust them with his issues anymore.

Everyone else he was friends with at their university was closer friends with Phainon. Truly, Mydei has never felt so alone in his life.

It doesn’t take very long for Mydei to start thinking about dropping out.

When it wasn’t Phainon motivating him to continue his major, it was his mother. And now, both of them are more or less gone. Herta’s blatant disapproval of him motivates him to practice, sure, but he knows that dropping out of college would also mean he wouldn’t have to deal with her ever again.

Maybe she would be more disappointed than ever with his decision to drop out. But that would be a one time thing that she would get over, and Mydei wouldn’t have to deal with the repercussions of her disappointment, since he’d be gone.

He misses when Phainon had given him a reason to improve when he felt like he didn’t know why he was in his major anymore. He misses the reverence in his voice and in his eyes when he watched Mydei play. Realistically, he would get that back with a single apology, if he just faced him and worked on their issues together, but for some reason Mydei enjoys being alone.

The night before Mydei’s next lesson with Madam Herta, Phainon calls him.

Mydei’s hands still on the keyboard when he notices who’s calling. He thinks it over for two rings before he picks up.

“Hello?”

“*Hi, Mydei.*” He sounds a little unsure, like he’s nervous. “*Can we talk?*”

Mydei swallows. He hates that part of him hopes Phainon is breaking up with him right now. That’s what he deserves, anyway—were their roles reversed, Mydei would have been gone by now. Mydei is convinced that the only reason Phainon is still with him is because of his own low self esteem. “Yeah,” he answers. And, then, before he allows himself to think himself out of it, “I’m sorry.”

“*What?*” Phainon sounds surprised. “*For what?*”

“For *what?*” Mydei repeats, a little incredulous. “I’ve been terrible to you, Phainon.”

“*I thought you said not to apologize for things that aren’t your fault.*”

“This is exactly the thing I should be apologizing for,” Mydei says. He moves to rest his elbows on the keys, which is bad for the piano, but he doesn’t really care.

“*It’s not your fault your mom died.*”

“But it is my fault I’ve handled it the way I have.” Phainon doesn’t say anything for a moment, and so Mydei keeps talking. “I know you wanted to help me, and I know you understand what I’m going through, but I…I just thought I could get through it by myself. And I thought it would be weak if I accepted your help.”

“*Mydei…*”

“And I think you were right,” Mydei continues. “I shouldn’t have kept going, because it’s making everything even worse.”

“*I think that’s a great idea,*” Phainon says softly. “*Do you think you’ll take next semester off?*”

“No, Phainon,” Mydei answers. He purses his lips, and his next words are so quiet they might not have been spoken at all. “I’m thinking of dropping out.”

It’s humiliating, to admit that everything has gotten to him to the point of quitting for good. But, realistically, this was bound to happen one day. He never liked piano enough for him to make a career out of it, and whatever he had with Phainon was never going to be enough to fix that.

“*Oh,*” comes Phainon’s reply, after enough time that it’s clear he was thinking about what to say. “*Okay.*” He doesn’t sound happy about it in the slightest, voice shaky and saturated with disappointment.

“It’s not final,” Mydei says, trying to give him at least some consolation. “You told me there was no point in perfection if you lost all the joy you had getting there,” he starts, and hears Phainon take a shaky breath on the other end of the line. “But that’s the problem, Phainon—I never had any joy to begin with. How am I supposed to believe I’m in the right major when I don’t even like it?”

“*Lots of people don’t like their major,*” Phainon tries. His words almost trip over themselves with how quickly he gets them out of his mouth. “*For example, chemistry. No one likes it, but there are still people who study it.*”

“Phainon,” Mydei groans, “no one studies music for money.”

Phainon doesn’t reply for a bit, so Mydei knows his rebuttal worked, even against the debate champion himself. “*I just…*” he starts, taking a deep sigh before continuing. “*I don’t want you to leave.*”

Mydei closes his eyes. Damn his incessant manipulation, even when he doesn’t mean to. Phainon has never been one to make anything easy for Mydei. “I don’t know,” is what he settles on. “I guess I’ll see how my next lesson goes.”

“*Okay,*” Phainon says quietly. Mydei wishes he would just argue with him normally instead of pretending to be okay with it while making his true feelings on the matter so obvious.

“Phainon,” Mydei replies, cautiously. “Do you want to break up?”

“*What?!*” Phainon’s voice is high with alarm. “*No—Mydei, do you—*”

“You can be honest with me,” Mydei whispers. “I haven’t been kind to you, I would understand it if you wouldn’t want to be with me anymore—”

“*Mydei.*” Phainon sounds desperate, borderline crazed, as he cuts Mydei off. “*Mydei. Do you want to break up.*”

Mydei takes a deep breath. “No,” he says. “Of course not.”

He can hear Phainon exhale on the other end of the line, his following laugh saturated with relief. “*Okay…we’re okay, right, Mydei?*”

“Yeah,” Mydei breathes. “We’ll be okay.”

Mydei’s legs shake as he sits down at the bench in Herta’s office the next evening. His hands are clammy, fingernails bitten down to nubs, and he’d torn at his cuticles until they bled with all his nerves. If Herta notices—which she does, as nothing ever gets past her eyes—she doesn’t say anything.

He can’t remember a single time in his life that he’d practiced as often as he had the past week, and he doesn’t know whether to hate or thank Herta for bringing him to this point. Even so, November is almost over, and his concert is only in a few weeks, and *La Campanella* isn’t even close to ready.

Dropping out crosses his mind again. He swallows the lump in his throat as Herta rolls her chair over to the piano, clipboard in hand. “Hello, Mydeimos,” she says. “Are you going to waste my time this week?”

Mydei bites the inside of his cheek. He wants to lash out, to tell her to go fuck herself and rip his sheet music to shreds right in front of her, but he doesn’t. *If only she knew*, he tells himself, even though it’s his fault he doesn’t. Madam Herta is his *advisor*, for god’s sake. Out of anyone at the school he should have told his issues to, it should have been her.

He can’t say no, because he’s not confident in his abilities right now, and that would be a lie. Saying yes might get him thrown out again, and any other answer would probably piss her off just as much. Thankfully, she continues before he has to answer.

“Why don’t we start with a run through today?” she suggests, leaning back in her chair and crossing one leg over the other. “Don’t worry about it being perfect. I just want to see what else we need to get done in the next few weeks, okay?”

There’s a gentleness to her tone that Mydei has never heard before. He wonders if she feels bad, but that’s impossible, so it must be something else.

He nods, placing his hands in position. He had tried a run through just yesterday. He got so annoyed he yearned for a gun to his head, then decided he needed to get some fresh air.

The beginning is fine. Perfect, even—by his standards, anyway. But it’s not the beginning that he’s worried about. The piece starts almost impossible for any sane pianist, and only gets harder as it goes. There’s not a single part of this piece beyond the first phrase that Mydei is completely confident in.

He stumbles through the rest of the piece, to silence on Herta’s end. The tempo is sloppy. He lingers on a note for too long, an amount of time that would be imperceptible to an audience member but is sacrilegious to Herta. He slows down significantly near the end, and it’s obvious that it isn’t a dramatic ritardando, but is instead a result of his own shortcomings.

But he finishes it. Once he’s held out the last chord for long enough, his hands slump down to his lap. He doesn’t even want to look Herta in the eye, and is already bracing himself for her to kick him out again.

“Alright,” is how she starts. Mydei already knows what that means. “Mydeimos, I want you to look at me when I say this.”

Mydei listens, turning his head until they make eye contact. “You’re a talented musician, Mydeimos. I’ve had faith in you ever since the first day I heard you play, but you’ve gotten to a point where I am not entirely sure what more I can do.”

Mydei licks his lips. He’s heard all about harsh music teachers hoping they can scare their students into improving. The worst part about those tactics is that most of the time, they *work.*

“Anyone can practice themselves to perfection, and you are not excluded from that. I can motivate you, I can give you tips, I can help you phrase in a way that can emulate emotion, but I *cannot create passion.*” Despite her words, Mydei finds that for the first time since he started taking lessons with her, he’s not scared of her right now. “Mydeimos, there is not a future in this for you if you don’t even like it.”

When Mydei doesn’t respond, she continues. “If it’s this piece that is putting so much stress on your shoulders, you don’t have to play it. Even as a performance major, you’re not required to play a recital every semester. We can take more time on it, and you can perform it at the end of next semester instead.”

Mydei still doesn’t say anything. Despite how comforting her words are, there’s still something weighing down on him. *The end of next semester.* He hadn’t been thinking that far into the future, and he knows what that means. Deep down, he doesn’t want to be here anymore. He’s already mentally dropped out.

“You’re right,” he starts. “I don’t like it.”

Herta smiles at that, and it seems somewhat genuine even if it’s tiny.

“Madam Herta, I…” he bites his tongue. Forces himself to take a deep breath. He can’t believe he’s saying this to her face right now. He can’t believe he’s already made this decision. “…want to drop out.”

Even in Herta’s genius brain, her reaction confirms that of all possibilities, that was not at all what she was expecting Mydei to say. “You…do?”

Mydei nods, firm. He's already said it. He might as well go through with it now.

"Why?"

Mydei swallows the lump in his throat, taking a moment to gather himself before he answers. It's harder than he thinks, because *where does he even begin?*

He opens his mouth, and starts with the first thing that comes to mind. "My mother passed away," he says. His voice doesn't shake as he says it, nor do his eyes tear up. "Two weeks ago. It's why I didn't practice last week. I…" he trails off. "She was my main motivator. I was doing it to make her happy, because I wanted to follow in her footsteps and she inspired me, but now that she's gone, if I don't like it, why am I still here? She wouldn't…want me to be unhappy…for her sake."

"Mydeimos," Herta says, and her voice is back to stern again. "And you didn't think to tell me this? I'm your advisor. There are ways we go about dealing with loss, but you have to start with letting someone know."

"I know," Mydei says. "I'm sorry. I thought I was—that I would be fine."

"Typically, I would both recommend you for counseling and suggest you take a semester off. Are you certain you want to drop out?"

Mydei thinks about Phainon, and how crushed he would be if he knew Mydei had really gone through with it—and so quickly, too. He pushes that aside. Phainon just wants what's best for him. He would accept Mydei's decision either way. "Yes. I'm certain."

"Did you consider other options?" Herta continues. "Perhaps, you can take a semester off and change your major when you come back."

History, maybe. If Mydei wasn't a musician, he would have studied history. But now, he's sure he wants to go home. Go home, and find something else to do. Maybe he'd get lucky. Maybe the labels Cipher sent that song to would reply. "No," he decides. "I want to drop out."

Herta takes a deep breath. There's something in her eyes akin to sadness, Mydei thinks. After all, she had just admitted to thinking Mydei is a talented musician. That's a compliment he'll carry with him for the rest of his life, he thinks.

"Okay," she says. She rolls her chair back over to her desk and opens her laptop. "We can work this out now, then."

It's a boring process, with even more questioning on Herta's end, but by the time he exits her office, it's final. He will have officially dropped out by tomorrow.

Walking back to his dorm, an odd feeling settles over him. He's relieved, lighter, even, but still not completely sure what his next steps will be. He will fly home, probably tomorrow, if he can get a plane ticket, and bring all his belongings to his mother's house. She wrote in her will that the house and all of her inheritance would be left to him, with no one else to give it to. He's not sure how he feels about that.

As soon as he gets back to his dorm, he texts Phainon and asks him to come over. They hadn't spent much time together in person recently—at the beginning of the semester, Phainon would stay overnight more often than not. Mydei doesn't know how this conversation is going to go, so he doesn't tell him to bring his things.

Mydei takes a quick shower, leaving the door propped slightly open, and Phainon is in the room when he's finished. He's sitting awkwardly at Mydei's desk, scrolling through some social media on his phone. "Hi," he says when Mydei enters, sounding a little breathless.

"Hi," Mydei responds. He can feel Phainon's eyes on him as he changes silently. He knows what he has to say, but isn't sure how to say it. It was just yesterday that he'd promised Phainon everything would be fine. *This*, he knows, is anything but *fine*.

He shakes his hair out a little, trying to pretend he's not stalling, before he finally comes to sit on his bed.

“Mydei—” Phainon starts.

“I dropped out,” Mydei blurts out, effectively cutting him off. Phainon’s mouth drops open, but the look on his face is more of despair than shock. “I’m sorry, Phainon. I just,” he pauses, running a hand through his wet hair, “I can’t do this anymore.”

Phainon stands up, and walks over to Mydei to wrap his arms around his neck. He hugs him with so much force that Mydei is knocked onto his back, Phainon nearly crushing him with his full body weight. “I’m so sorry,” he whispers into Mydei’s neck.

Mydei wriggles beneath him until he can finally breathe, resting one hand on the back of Phainon’s head. “Again—”

“I don’t know how else to express my pity!” Phainon lifts his head, annoyed. “You don’t deserve to be going through any of this right now. I know it’s not my fault, but I’m sorry regardless.”

Mydei takes a deep breath. “...Okay.”

They stay like that for a while. Mydei thinks Phainon might be crying at some point, but he tries to hide it, so Mydei doesn’t comment on it. Finally, he sits up, Mydei following suit, and sure enough, the corners of his eyes are still tinged red.

“What are you going to do now?” Phainon asks.

“I’m flying back to Kremnos tomorrow,” Mydei swallows. “I’ll stay in my mom’s house, maybe find a job in the area. I can wait tables, or something.”

Mydei can see Phainon’s throat bob as he swallows. “So you’re just giving up?” he asks, and Mydei’s heart drops.

“No,” he insists. “I didn’t say that.”

“Mydei, you might not be passionate about piano, but you still love *music*,” he continues, like he wasn’t listening at all. “I can’t let myself just…let you

go, if you're just going to let all your talents, everything you've worked for, go to waste—"

"I'm *not*," Mydei shoots back. "I have the band, we have that song Cipher sent out. It's not over, Phainon, I just have to wait it out—"

"*Wait it out?* Mydei, the label hasn't responded yet. Do you seriously think they're still considering it? If this is really something you want, you have to go out there and start putting music out by yourself. If you're worth investing in, the labels will find you themselves."

Mydei swallows. That had been in the back of his mind already, but he hadn't admitted it to himself yet. He had thought they would at least get some sort of a rejection letter.

"Fine," Mydei mutters. "I'll go to Kremnos and I'll…start making music full time." Phainon smiles a little at that, before he continues. "And I'll never have to touch a piano ever again."

"That's a little far-fetched, I think."

Mydei doesn't think it is. He certainly doesn't *want* to. That would be his ideal life, really—making music full time with his band, no pianos in sight.

Despite the light-hearted lilt to Phainon's voice, he can't help but think it's just a front. Phainon is devastated, he can tell. They both know where this is going. "Phainon," he starts gently, placing a hand over his knee. "What about *us?*"

Phainon flinches, and his hand comes to rest over Mydei's threading their fingers together. "I don't know," he admits. He bites at his lip so hard he could draw blood, and Mydei brushes his thumb over it, forcing him to soothe it out. "We could…do long distance," he tries, but Mydei can tell he doesn't actually believe that would work.

"You don't want that," Mydei says.

“Of course I don’t,” Phainon shoots back. “But I don’t want to *lose* you, either.”

“You could come with me.” Mydei regrets the suggestion as soon as it leaves his mouth, but he can’t take it back, and he can’t erase the look on Phainon’s face, either.

He unlaces their hands, pulling back a little. “What about me, then?” he starts, tone notably more aggressive than it had been just seconds ago. “I know you’re rich, and have everything you could possible want, but piano —*this*—is all I *have*.”

Mydei doesn’t say anything for a moment. “...Seriously?” he finally murmurs, his voice a little strangled. He doesn’t know how to refute Phainon’s comment about his life being easy without coming across like a spoiled rich brat.

“You’re asking me to drop *everything I have* for you,” Phainon shoots back. “That’s a little ridiculous, right, Mydei?” He’s standing now, hovering over where Mydei sits on his bed.

“I don’t have anything left, either.” Is all Mydei says. He doesn’t want to talk about his mother. And he sure as hell doesn’t want to talk about his father.

Phainon takes a step back, running a hand through his hair. He exhales deeply before responding, “I’m sorry,” he drops his hands to his sides helplessly. “I shouldn’t have said that. God, I’m sorry, Mydei.”

Mydei swallows, and gets to his feet, too. He doesn’t want to argue. They’re both hurt, and they’re both wrong. A winner is the last thing that matters right now. “I probably shouldn’t have suggested it in the first place.”

Phainon takes another deep breath. “Maybe,” he starts, chewing on his lip again before continuing. “Maybe we really should…go our separate ways.”

Mydei’s eyes sting at hearing those words out of his mouth. Words he should have heard weeks ago. Words he knew were coming from a mile away, and yet it still hurts. He nods, regardless.

Phainon chokes, and comes forward to wrap his arms around Mydei’s neck. “I don’t want to,” he cries, tears already wetting Mydei’s shirt. “I really don’t want to, Mydei.”

“It’s okay,” Mydei raises his hands, rubbing at his back. “Please don’t cry, Phainon.”

“I love you,” Phainon whispers. “I always will.”

Mydei laughs wetly, trying his best to hide the way he actually feels. “You’re going to have to move on eventually.”

“I won’t,” Phainon insists. “How could anyone move on from you?”

“You’ll find a way,” Mydei kisses the side of his forehead, just once, and Phainon seems to relax at least a little bit.

Finally, Phainon pulls away, eyes still brimming with tears. Mydei nods, and he takes a few steps backwards, wiping at his eyes carefully. “You have to promise,” he says. “You’re going to make this worth it. You have to.”

Mydei nods again. “I promise,” he says earnestly. “You too.”

“I will,” Phainon insists. “I’ll play Rach 2, and you’ll sell out stadiums, and I’ll be there when you do.”

“Rach 2 is a small goal for you.”

“I promise,” Phainon answers, with a hand over his heart. “I’ll do everything I ever dreamed of and more, but only if you do the same.”

“Are you seriously turning this into a competition?” Mydei asks. He can’t stop the fondness from creeping into his voice.

“Do you accept, Mydeimos?”

Mydei snorts, shaking his head. “Yeah,” he replies. “How could I not?”

Chapter End Notes

i wrote this chapter last semester when i, too, started slipping after being the best i'd been mentally in years my freshman year of college. sophomore slump or whatever. but that was for no particular reason, and mydei had more than enough reasons to crash tf out. he underreacted like crazy.

obviously madam herta is not nearly as bad as the whiplash guy, but this type of teacher is extremely common in music circles. the piano teacher i had for nearly ten years from the time i was four years old was like this, to the point where i was crying during lessons because she was so mean but regardless, i was still so, SO good. although i've learned recently that apparently she was much nicer to my brother and he liked her, so i'm not sure what that was about. maybe she saw more potential in me. haha.

anyways thank you so much for reading. see you next week.

▶ references/yap

Chapter 4: Muscle Memory

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

r/Robin

u/hotpinkrobinblue • 12h
Who's playing piano on track 10?
discussion

With some of the credits released online, I was going through them when I noticed that track 10 (unknown feature right now) has piano credits but it's blank (so no Sunday). This probably isn't a mistake because he's credited on other tracks like 4, 5, 7, and 8. Ideas?
492 upvote | downvote **112** comments

boothillfan11111
I heard rumors that it's CALAMITY. Underground band based in Amphoreus.

> **robinwings277**
> That's the probable feature. No one in CALAMITY plays piano.
>
> > **numberonemydeifan**
> > wrong. mydei was classically trained.

numberonemydeifan
it's mydei

> **hotpinkrobinblue** • OP
> Classically trained pianist doing backing work?
>
> > **numberonemydeifan**
> > you don't know that he's doing backing work

sundayluvr27
Just admit your goat is washed

numberonemydeifan
who’s talking?

~~~

September 14th, 3868. Ten months before the release of Dreamscape.

Mydei doesn’t sleep any better on the second night.

Phainon had a tendency to infiltrate his dreams more often than Mydei would like to admit, but it was never like this. Never to the point where he can’t fall asleep, too convinced he’s doing something terribly wrong.

He should have stayed in college. He should have gotten that damn degree, shouldn’t have dropped out the second it got hard. He should have married Phainon, and now it was too late. It had been *three years*. Why did it have to be Mydei who couldn’t move on?

He’d tried dating again, and the worst part was that it almost worked. He could have loved her, could have finally moved on, only for it to fall apart because of *Phainon*, of all people. He’d tried sleeping with other people, too, even though he didn’t like casual sex—only to discover that this opinion hadn’t changed.

He flips his pillow onto the cold side and tries to fall asleep again, but to no avail. His fingers are itching to play something for the first time in years. Maybe to prove to himself that he can still do it. That he might have been apart from it for a while, but that doesn’t mean he forgot. He’s still one of the best pianists in the world. He’s still the same musician who got applause from *the* Herta.
~~~

It’s just muscle memory. He hasn’t forgotten how to read the notes, so surely his fingers won’t forget how to move, right?

Decision made, he gets out of bed and slips on an easy pair of shoes, as well as a shirt. He takes the elevator down to the ground floor, which is empty at this hour. The lights are dim—there’s a receptionist sitting at the front desk, who looks very unhappy to be there. Mydei walks past him into the lounge, which is just as empty. There’s a public piano there. He saw it when they had first checked in, just out of the corner of his eye. He doesn’t remember what he thought at the time, but now he sits at the bench and tentatively presses down on middle C.

He plays a C major scale, and then its arpeggio. He feels a little stiff, so he takes a moment to stretch out his fingers before running through an old exercise Madam Herta used to make him do. It feels weird warming up, because he’d almost never done that in his college days, unless it was the beginning of his lessons. And yet, now he does. Maybe that meant he had matured.

And then, without thinking very much, Mydei starts to play the beginning of *La Campanella.*

It’s just as it always was, like not a day had ever passed since he last touched the piece. The beginning is near perfect, just like Madam Herta’s recording from when she was fourteen years old. The way he had subconsciously trained himself to play.

The longer he plays, the more confident he gets. He closes his eyes, and doesn’t miss a note. He’d poured so many hours of his life into this piece—time he would never get back, although at this moment he has no regrets.

The hotel is silent except for his playing, but he imagines Phainon beside him, watching. He always said he loved watching Mydei play—that it was his playing that he fell in love with first, and Mydei second. Back then, he thought that such a comment was just Phainon being annoying. Now, he wouldn’t want it any other way. Maybe Phainon wasn’t in love with him anymore, but maybe, just maybe, he hadn’t fallen out of love with Mydei’s music just yet.

Maybe he still listens to Mydei's music, streams every single, just hoping to catch a glimpse of his first love in the remnants of what Mydei's career turned into. Maybe he's disappointed every time.

He forgets a note. His finger slips, and he curses quietly as he drops his hands to his lap.

A little cough sounds from beside him, and he scrambles to his feet, as if it wasn't too late to pretend he wasn't just playing the piano again.

It's not, though. Castorice stands in the doorway, in a white t-shirt and butterfly pajama pants, and she stares at Mydei like she just saw a ghost.

Mydei thinks the way he stares back couldn't have been much different. What feels like minutes pass silently between them, until Mydei finally realizes that Castorice was waiting for an explanation from *him.*

He clears his throat. Straightens his back. "Um," he says, which wasn't what he was planning to say, but it's a lot more accurate to what he's thinking. "Morning."

"Good morning," she whispers, eyes flicking back and forth between Mydei and the piano.

Mydei runs a hand through his hair, stressed out. "I couldn't sleep," he attempts.

"Me neither," she says. She still looks at him like he's a completely different person. "What do you normally do when you can't sleep?"

"Not this," Mydei says.

"Mm," she hums. "Well, I was going to get some fresh air, if you want to come."

Mydei nods, and they move towards the front entrance. Mydei holds the door open for her, and she gives him a sideways glance as she walks through.

It’s still warm outside, courtesy of early fall weather in southwest Penacony. Mydei’s hometown is hotter, even in late fall, so he doesn’t mind. They walk a little bit, Castorice at his side though a few feet apart. The city is empty at this hour, nothing accompanying them but the slight rustle of wind and the shuffling of their footsteps.

“I told Robin I would do it,” he blurts out into the silence around them. “I was going to tell you, I just wanted to make sure I still had it before I could disappoint you all, I guess.”

“I think you still have it,” is all she says.

Mydei purses his lips, considering his next words before he speaks. “Do you want to know why I dropped out?” Is what he settles on.

Castorice doesn’t say anything for a moment. They turn right, heading towards the beach—a subconscious decision on both of their parts. “I admit I’ve always wondered about it. It took me by surprise when I first heard.”

Mydei shoves his hands into his pockets, staring off into the ocean as the shore comes closer and closer into view. “I was good,” he admits. “I know that. Any classical musician would look at my best performances and think it’s a waste of my talent for me to move to rock music.”

“We all know you were good,” Castorice answers quietly. “But we appreciate your prowess here nonetheless.”

“I would never go back.”

That seems to surprise Castorice a little bit, as she turns to look at him with wide eyes. “Never?”

Mydei shakes his head. “I love making music with you guys more than I ever loved performing piano.”

“Did…you and Phainon break up because of that?”

“Not really,” Mydei says, staring at the path they walk through. The last thing he wants is for Castorice to figure out, well—what he *wants*. “We

fought, though." He thinks back to that. The things he said. The things *Phainon* said. They had both apologized to each other, kissed and made up, but some part of Mydei can't help but wonder if the reason their break up succeeded at all was intrinsically tied to that.

"I'm sorry," Castorice says quietly. "I know he meant a lot to you. Both of you," she corrects. "Both of you meant so much to each other."

Mydei doesn't give her more of a response than a half-hearted grunt, because what he feels in response to that statement is far more than he can trust himself to say eloquently. Phainon didn't just mean *a lot* to him, he was *everything.* Still is. His heart lurches in his chest.

"I wanted to move on," Mydei says, once he's sufficiently regained his composure. "He was always going to be there, reminding me of the life I was trying to escape. Both of us had different dreams we wanted to pursue, and we weren't meant to be in each other's futures. Rock music and classical music, they're not…they don't mesh."

"Oh," Castorice says. She stares into space like there's something she wants to say, but she doesn't allow herself to say it.

"It's childish," Mydei mutters. "I know." He pulls his hands from his pockets and crosses his arms over his chest instead, still annoyed at the way he chose to behave all those years ago. If only he had an ounce of maturity back then, maybe they would still be happy together.

"It's how you felt," Castorice responds. "People act on emotion all the time. There's nothing wrong with that."

Mydei turns her words over in his head. He's not sure how to respond. "You're still in touch with him," he says instead. "Aren't you?"

They stop walking when the path turns to sand, the sound of rushing waves much louder than it had been just a few feet ago. "I'm sorry," she says, clasping her hands together at her hips.

“No, it’s fine,” Mydei says immediately. “He’s your friend too.” Castorice, Cipher, and Phainon all knew each other in high school, having attended the same school in Okhema. Castorice was closer to Cipher than Phainon was, the two of them making up the rhythm section of their high school jazz band, but they all got closer in college. “How is he?”

“Good, I think,” she says. “He’s back in Paperfold for grad school now. But I think he’s planning on getting an apartment in Okhema when he graduates.”

“That’s good,” Mydei nearly sighs, more wistful than he intended.

“Come on,” Castorice kicks her shoes off and steps into the sand, moving towards the ocean.

Mydei looks back at the street behind him, before sighing and following behind her. He doesn’t shed his shoes, and it proves to be a mistake as he trudges through the sand.

There’s a little log buried halfway into the sand a safe distance from the tide. Mydei sits near the middle, and Castorice next to him. She keeps her distance, though, as always.

“You don’t like water,” she remarks, curiously.

“Huh?” Mydei turns to her, a little bewildered. “Where did you get that idea?”

“We went to the beach in Okhema so many times, and I never once saw you get in,” she shakes her head. “You would just sit on the towel and read.”

“What’s wrong with that? I like to tan.”

She shrugs, and seems to accept that answer easily enough.

“There’s something I want to tell you,” she says suddenly, voice loud around them like she had blurted it out. Mydei gives her his full attention, watching her carefully as she fidgets with her hands in her lap. “I’m—” she starts, then breaks off, taking a deep breath. “I’m sick, Mydei.”

“What?” Mydei asks. He can’t think of anything else to say.

“I was born sick.” She looks down at her hands, and Mydei thinks her voice grows even softer with every word. “I practically grew up in hospitals. Whenever they thought I was free to get discharged, it would flare up again in a month and I’d just be back to a hospital bed.”

“Cas,” Mydei starts, then stops. He reaches out to touch her, to place a comforting hand on her back, but she shifts away from him on the log until he stops and drops his hand back down to the wood between them.

Castorice sighs, clenching her hands into fists. “Sorry,” she whispers, voice catching in her throat. “It’s not the disease that’s contagious, but I have a weak immune system because of it, so I get sick more than most people, and…” she stops, and shakes her head. “I’ve made people sick before, Mydei. I’ve…”

“It’s okay, Cas,” Mydei murmurs. “Don’t apologize.”

“Did you know I used to have a twin sister?” She looks up, regarding Mydei with tears in her eyes. He shakes his head, as gently as possible, and curls his fingers into a fist so he resists the urge to reach out and touch her again. “Polyxia,” she continues, a tiny smile breaking over her face as she says it. “She had the same condition, only worse. She couldn’t walk, was always in a hospital—at least I *got* to go to school sometimes. To see other people except for the doctors.”

Mydei doesn’t pull his eyes away, He hangs on to her every word, listening as intently as he can, even though he can’t bear to hear the rest of her story. He can already tell where it’s going.

“I got her sick, Mydei,” she rasps. She looks at him and her eyes are swimming with tears. “They didn’t say that that was it, but I know it was.” She bites her lip as a tear runs down her cheek. “I killed her.”

“Cas,” Mydei says, before she can continue. She clamps her mouth shut, chin quivering. “That’s enough. It wasn’t your fault.”

Castorice shakes her head, bottom lip caught between her teeth. “It was, Mydei,” she whispers.

Mydei lifts his hand again, bringing it to her shoulder carefully, as if he were trying to soothe a stray cat. She shifts away slightly, but he touches her anyway, and she lets him. “It’s okay,” he murmurs. He reaches slowly around the back of her neck, and pulls her into his shoulder. “It’s okay, Cas.”

She doesn’t say anything, burying her face into his neck even though she keeps her hands clasped tightly in her lap. Mydei snakes his hand to her other shoulder, sighing as he turns his head back to the ocean. He thinks it makes a lot of sense. Why she’s always been so inexplicably averse to touch. Why she writes, like she yearns for some semblance of normalcy in a life that is cruel with its abnormality. Her love of music, and why she picked up the drums, just another outlet for her escapism. She always said she liked how it took her mind off things.

He holds her for what feels like a near eternity, the crashing of waves drowning out the sound of her soft cries. She sniffles quietly, lifting her head and wiping her nose with the back of her hand. Mydei doesn’t let go of her.

“You were right, by the way,” Mydei breaks the silence, overcome with a sudden bitterness at the sight of the ocean. “I don’t like water.”

“I know,” Castorice says softly. “I just wasn’t going to pry.”

“I *do* like to tan,” he continues. “But I can't swim.”

“Oh…” Castorice pulls away, looking at him with wide, red-rimmed eyes.

Mydei bites his lip. The words are at the tip of his tongue, and he still can’t find it in himself to say them. Things he’s only ever admitted to Phainon, and even then, the only thing he hated more than Phainon’s pity was his own vulnerability.

“It’s nothing,” Mydei eventually decides. “I just never learned.”

He can tell Castorice doesn’t believe him. Mercifully, though, she doesn’t push it.

Mydei’s alarm wakes him up far too early the next morning, and he has half a mind to turn around and go back to sleep, uncaring of the deadlines he has to meet. All he knows is that no matter how terrible of a morning he’s having, Cipher’s is probably worse.

It’s that notion that motivates him enough to get out of bed. He was up late last night, talking to Castorice, but it was likely only a fraction of how late Cipher had stayed up playing video games. He didn’t understand her sleep schedule at all.

They meet up in the hotel lobby when the breakfast buffet starts, and him, Castorice, and Hyacine all have their own plates of food by the time Cipher makes an appearance.

She looks miserable, and slides into the seat next to Castorice with an obnoxious yawn that tapers off into a glare when she sees everyone staring at her. “It’s too damn early for this shit,” she starts, expression souring even further when no one says anything. “*What.* I’m up now, aren’t I? I wasn’t even that late, holy shit.”

“Cassie and Mydei have something to share with us,” Hyacine pipes up, scooping a portion of her eggs onto the empty plate set in front of Cipher.

She makes a face at it despite Hyacine’s hospitality, turning to scowl at Mydei now. “Oh, *god.* Are you two dating or something? Jeez, I don’t think I could handle that. I quit, guys, I’m done with this band.”

Castorice has her head in her hands, peeking at Mydei through the gaps in her fingers. “Don’t worry, Cipher, she’s all yours,” he says, delighted at the way that makes Castorice squirm further. Cipher seems to lighten up considerably, though.

“Then what’s your big secret, little prince? I won’t spoil it for Hyacine, you can do the honors.”

“Can you stop calling me that—” he starts, before processing the rest of her words. “Wait, what do you think I’m going to say, exactly?”

“That you’re playing piano on Robin’s track,” Cipher deadpans. Mydei ignores the way Hyacine looks at him in favor of staring at Cipher in disbelief instead. “Oh, come on, that one wasn’t even hard to figure out. I can’t wait to tell Phainon the news.”

Mydei’s heart lurches at the mention of him, but he tries to play it off like it doesn’t. “Yes, I’ll play the damn piece. Better than her brother doing it, anyway,” he mumbles.

“You don’t like her brother?” Castorice asks, in surprise. “He’s playing with the Astral Express now. I thought you liked them.”

“He’s not a good pianist,” Mydei starts, feeling a little more like he’s talking to himself than the others at the table. “And I don’t like his hair.”

“Oh my god,” Cipher groans. “Get over yourself, already. You know if you sent Phainon a text telling him you wanted to fuck, he’d be knocking at your door within the hour.”

“Not everything is about him,” Mydei retorts, unsure where else to start with that comment.

“Sure,” Cipher says simply, leaning back in her chair. Her feet knock against his under the table, and she refuses to move them, so Mydei does instead.

“I mean it,” Mydei says, to the rest of the table. He stabs a pineapple on his plate with so much force that it rings out in the room around them. “I’m my own person, we broke up, I’ve moved on. You might still be friends with him but that doesn’t mean anything for me.”

“You’ve moved on,” Cipher deadpans. Mydei resists the urge to kick her under the table, putting the slice of pineapple he had speared into his mouth.

“Three years, Cipher,” Mydei reminds her. “Three goddamn years. Of course I’ve moved on.”

Silence falls between the four of them, and Mydei is glad that at least Cipher doesn’t have anything else to say. No matter how unconvinced she looks as she stares at him across the table.

Hyacine is the one who breaks it. “Well,” she starts, voice bubbly as ever despite the obvious tension between them right now. “I think it’s exciting.”

Mydei glances over at her.

“All of *this*,” she clarifies. “Robin, piano, everything—you guys aren’t at least a little bit excited?”

Mydei doesn’t answer right away, looking over at Castorice who wordlessly gives him her encouragement. He doesn’t really know what to say—of course some part of him is excited, but the part that wins is more nervous than anything.

“It’s one track,” he says, sounding more like he’s trying to convince himself than anything.

“We know it means more than that,” Castorice says. “It’s okay, Mydei. We all believe in you.”

The reassurance is nice, but all that Mydei can think about is how real all of this is all of a sudden.

The next two days, they meet without Robin. It’s just the four of them and Ratio in a stuffy old recording studio, as Ratio messes with the buttons to get a feel for how it works. He has an mp3 file playing off his phone speaker, the demos Robin had sent him. It’s not the first time Mydei has

heard it, but knowing that the piano part is definitely his now changes things.

“Look at him,” he can hear Cipher whisper in Castorice’s ear. “I bet he’s already rewritten it.”

Not exactly, but his brain is already rapidly filling with improvement ideas. He’s not sure what it was, but his inspiration is back. This track has potential to become an instant hit, even if it wasn’t for Robin’s name already attached to it.

In fact, the sheer potential of it the more he thinks about it is enough to get him so excited he starts to feel a little sick. He jumps to his feet, startling Castorice, and heads over to the piano, pulling up the sheet music Robin had sent them on his phone.

It’s hard to read off his phone, the notes too small with not enough of an excerpt able to be on the screen at a time, but he leans in and squints instead, paying little attention to what his hands are actually doing.

Castorice and Cipher have heard him play before, having been dragged to Phainon’s concerts at Paperfold that Mydei was ultimately playing in as well. He doesn’t even think the base sheet music he was sent was all that difficult, even when sight-reading. It’s the kind of performance that only Phainon would praise, because he used to be too smitten with Mydei to do anything else.

But silence falls over the room as he plays through it for the first time anyway—even Ratio has stopped what he’s doing to watch. He can feel everyone’s eyes on him, but if it does anything, it only makes him play better. He’s his best self in front of an audience.

He abandons the sheet music at some point, making up a melody that he thinks would sound good. It does. He adds a little flair that’s impressive to non-pianists and is not all that crazy to someone who knows what he’s doing.

And then he messes up, leaving the key he was in on accident during his improv moment. He curses a little as he removes his hands from the keyboard, and doesn't even want to look at his bandmates to see how they've reacted.

"Okay," Ratio starts, a little slowly. "This is…a *great* start."

Mydei looks over at Castorice, who is beaming. Cipher and Hyacine don't say anything, but he feels as though he can tell what they're thinking. No one wants this to be a one time thing.

He doesn't address it. He replies to Ratio and they work through it together, figuring out which parts they want to change, which parts they want to add to, and which parts they want to keep. And then all four of them are playing together, changing up each part so they work together best. Mydei records the final thing so that he can write it down later, because he's not skilled enough to change his ideas into sheet music on the spot like this.

Ratio leaves halfway through the session, having to attend an important meeting with Aventurine, and their productivity throughout the whole morning instantly dissipates.

"Play the hardest song you know," Cipher requests.

La Campanella instantly jumps to the forefront of Mydei's mind. He grimaces—yes, he had just revisited it last night, but he still hates that piece.

"You don't have to do that," Hyacine jumps in to defend him, as always. He appreciates her, but his hands are already in position for the beginning of *La Campanella.*

"This is the piece that made me drop out of college," he explains, and then starts playing it. He thinks it's the sort of thing that would sound impressive to anyone, but non-pianists would only understand the full extent of its difficulty by watching someone play it.

As he makes it through the piece nearly mistake-free, though not without the occasional blunder, he can't help but feel oddly empty. It's different from three years ago, when he walked into his first lesson of the semester with Madam Herta and saw the *La Campanella* sheet music on the stand. It's different from the last time he had played it for her, and even the last time he had performed at Paperfold. Even when he hated it, he still felt something. Performance anxiety, frustration at his imperfections, a desire to be the best pianist in the world.

Now, he feels nothing. Playing *La Campanella* brings back none of those feelings, but it doesn't bring him anything good, either. He stops, too distracted to continue, and realizes that he hadn't felt anything particularly strong when he was playing through Robin's song, either.

Part of him had thought that coming back to piano on his own terms, to make the music he loves instead of the music he was forced to make for so many years, would bring back the entire reason he had decided to study it in the first place. Madam Herta had always been right in her assessment of him, that he didn't love it enough to make it in that industry, but that didn't mean he never loved it. Anyone who puts that much work into learning something has to love it at some point.

But instead, it just feels like something he has to do. It's not the big deal to him that it is to Cipher, Hyacine, and Castorice, but it's not something he's against, by any means.

Regardless, he looks over to see Cipher speechless for the first time in his life. Hyacine says something he barely processes about how amazing he is, before stepping forward and requesting her own song.

"Do you know *Piano Man?*"

Mydei just barely restrains his snort, nodding as he reaches for his water bottle. At least he's making *someone* happy, he thinks, as he puts his hands on the keys and begins to play.

Still, after they've killed nearly an hour making Mydei play for them, he can't help but think that this must have been what they thought this whole

time. All the time they spent defending him to interviewers, giving every question regarding Mydei's potential return to piano a hard *no*, was all a guise for how they really felt. They *wanted* him to play this whole time, they just weren't saying it out loud.

They finish up their version of it the next day, with Ratio there the whole time to keep them on track. Mydei listens to Ratio's request that he reel it back in some places.

"It's not about you," he tells Mydei, as blunt as ever. "This song doesn't want you showing off. It wants you as support."

He's right, so Mydei responds with a nod as he takes a moment to scratch out any of the lines that were too complicated for the song. It's a new exercise now, trying to write something where he isn't at the front of it. His whole life, he had performed pieces where he was the center of attention, and now, writing a rock song with one of the biggest pop stars in the world, he has to change this mindset greatly to match these new goals.

When they play the recording of their new version for Robin the next day, Mydei can't help but smile a little to himself at the sound of Robin's high praise. It gets even better when she sings along on the second time, and Mydei realizes just how much better it will be when they record everything together for the first time.

It doesn't disappoint. Mydei's part isn't the easiest thing in the world, but they cut down on a lot of the parts he had written to show off. Still, he can't find himself to be bored by it when the whole song comes together.

They then record each part separately. Robin goes last, and Mydei is immensely impressed by her vocal talent. The tone she uses on this track is glaringly different to the vocals Mydei remembers from her. It's darker, less suited for pop and more for rock. He didn't think she had a sound like that in her, but her voice is incredibly mature this time around.

They add their final touches the next day, making little changes in production and adding strings in the background. And then they spend the rest of the time they have playing it live together. It takes longer than usual to sync every part up with each other, with a few frustrating mistakes on Mydei's part. This is another thing he's going to have to get used to—with every solo he'd played alongside a massive orchestra, the orchestra and conductor changed what they were doing to match *him*. When he took time, they took time. He could do whatever he wanted with it, and they would follow.

But now, he needs to be steady, because Robin wasn't going to change her part on his behalf. All four of them were supporting her, not the other way around.

Regardless, they get through it, and Mydei finds himself so in the zone that he doesn't even realize they're nearing the end of the song until it's already over. It's a far cry from the catharsis he thought he might feel, returning to piano after so long, but it's a step in the right direction. For the first time in years, he's really, *truly* proud of something he's created.

Chapter End Notes

> i thought about posting 4 and 5 together because they could have been one chapter, i only ultimately decided to keep them separate because the time skip between the two is a little too long. but i haven't finished 5 yet (yikes) so i might post 5 and 6 next week but i haven't decided.
>
> anyways i have no notes on this chapter because there aren't enough references for me to nerd out about. thank you for reading :)

Chapter 5: Promise

Chapter Notes

> shorter chapter today before the rest of them start averaging 10k+ words. think of it as a palatte cleanser of sorts. before it all starts going downhill. and then uphill. it will go uphill eventually.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

I'm going to play it one day.
Rach 2. I'm going to play it one day.

Okay.

Promise me you'll be there when I play it.
And I'll be there when you're selling out stadiums and have three charting rock albums.

You think I'm going to be a rockstar?

I think you're a gift to the world.
Whatever it is, then. Whatever music you make. I'll be there.

Okay.

Promise.
Promise me you'll be there.

I promise.

~~~

July 19th, 3869. Two days after the release of Dreamscape.
~~~

Mydei has never felt concert anxiety this brutal in his life. Between all the shoots, interviews, and travel, he had no idea what he was actually getting himself into until this very moment: backstage at the festival Robin is headlining, patiently waiting it out as she goes through the rest of her set. He can hear the audience screaming as if he was in the middle of the crowd. He can hear Robin perfectly, as she hypes up the crowd and her performance goes perfectly.

It feels like it's just been months since CALAMITY was booking gigs at empty bars, singing to three drunk men and a bartender, none of whom knew a single one of their songs. In reality, though, it's already been nearly a year since they first flew out to west Penacony to record with Robin.

It hasn't hit until right now. Even though his social media follower count has skyrocketed, and he's been recognized in the street for the first time, and people seem to know who he is now. It's just been days since the album was released, and CALAMITY's streams have already tripled overnight.

"Do you realize how many people are out there?" Cipher whispers to him, like she'd be heard outside if she spoke too loud.

Mydei covers his face with his hands, taking a deep breath. His hands feel cold against his cheeks, and it makes him feel the tiniest bit better. "I don't know, Cipher. At least a thousand."

"*At least a thousand?!* Mydei. Bro, I think there's more people than there were at Cerydra's inauguration."

"*What?*" Mydei pulls his hands off his face, squinting as he looks at her. "Cerydra is, like, twenty?"

Cipher whacks him across the shoulder, gawking like he's said something offensive. "Dude, that's so rude. Just because she's short doesn't mean she's that young."

"Is she *forty?*"

Cipher frowns, looking away. "Hm. No."

“Then she couldn’t have been inaugurated, dumbass.”

“Oh shit, you’re right. Who the hell am I thinking of, then?”

“Can you leave?”

“Deep in thought, are you? Don’t let it mess you up on stage!” Thankfully, she leaves to bother Castorice instead, but the whole experience has left Mydei so baffled that some of his nerves have begun to dissipate.

He pulls out his phone instead, which is never a very good idea nowadays if he wants to calm his nerves. Robin’s post had already alerted lots of fans to the fact that she’s bringing a guest on stage at her festival performance, leading a lot of people to suspect that it might be them, since they’re the only ones known to be in the general area.

Those that are sure it would be them already know they will be performing *Dreamscape*, leading to speculation about whatever else they might play. Obviously, Mydei knows they’re only playing *Dreamscape*. It’s Robin’s show, and they don’t have any other song good enough to perform, anyway. Still, that won’t stop his phone from being blown up from people convinced they will be playing *Don’t Cry,* too.

Out of all the music they’ve released, *Don’t Cry* remains their most famous song. Before *Dreamscape,* it was so popular and the rest of their music was so unpopular that CALAMITY was believed to be a one-hit-wonder. Mydei had thought that with Robin’s album out now, it would cause people to realize they had made other music, too—but apparently that had been wishful thinking. He’s grateful for the engagement, of course, but would like to be recognized for something else for once.

He turns his phone off, throwing it to the side. *Don’t Cry* always has him thinking of Phainon, and now is no different.

This festival isn’t in a stadium, but the amount of people in the crowd may just as well be able to fill one up. Either way, it’s easily the biggest concert he’s ever played. It’s a milestone. There are musicians who spend their whole careers waiting to play a show of this size.

He had been there, for Rach 2. He still remembers it like it's yesterday. It had been in April, near the end of Phainon's first year at grad school. He saw the posters, happened to be in the area, and remembered their promise immediately. Even through everything—the break up, the distance, the resentment—he still felt like he needed to go.

He had brought Phoebe, the girl he was dating for two months before she inevitably dumped him that very night. He foolishly thought he was far enough removed from Phainon and their relationship to date someone else. He foolishly thought he would be okay to go to that concert—to see Phainon's biggest dream come true right in front of him while he was in the middle of producing an EP he didn't even write.

After everything, it would be ridiculous of him to seriously expect Phainon to attend. Those promises meant nothing, in the end. They had broken up and weren't a part of each other's lives anymore. But he had upheld his end of the deal, and naturally wished Phainon would do the same.

He's pulled from his thoughts by a sudden soreness in his back, and instantly sits up straight, tossing his phone aside.

"*Fuck,*" he mutters under his breath. *Why now?*

It wasn't pain debilitating enough to render him unable to perform, but he would much rather perform without it. Without the constant reminder of all the ways Phainon used to soothe him when it would act up, raking his nails over the spot and pressing light kisses into his vertebrae like it was something to be protected.

"Mydei," Hyacine says, and his eyes fly open to the sight of her standing before him. "We're on in a minute. Are you okay?"

Mydei nods, grimacing a little as he stands up. He stretches his back twice, which is good enough for now, and ignores the way Hyacine looks at him strangely.

"Are you sure you're okay?"

So much for trying to ignore it. “Yes, Hyacine, I’m fine.” It’s enough for her to drop it, and they walk over to where Castorice and Cipher stand near the entrance to the stage.

His back issues have been something he’s dealt with for enough years now for it to be normal to him, but that doesn’t mean an answer wouldn’t be nice. He had never seen an actual doctor about it, but Hyacine, as an ex-med student and his friend, might be able to give him an explanation.

He considers it briefly and then pushes it aside after all. Even if he went through with that, now is not the time.

“Ready?” Aventurine asks, as he sneaks up behind them and claps his hands on both Mydei and Hyacine’s shoulders.

Mydei nearly flinches, taken by surprise, but nods regardless as he turns to look at Aventurine.

“For this last song,” Robin says, voice echoing through the speakers outside, “I’ve invited some friends.”

“You are going to do great,” Aventurine reassures them, pushing both Mydei and Hyacine forward a little bit. “They already love you. See?”

He points forward, to where Mydei can hear the crowd chanting *Mydei, Mydei, Mydei. His* name. He understands CALAMITY is hard to chant given that it’s three syllables rather than the typical two, but he still doesn’t think a single one of their band members deserves full credit for their work. He swallows, suddenly feeling bad for the three girls now getting less credit for achievements that are equally theirs.

“*Go*, Mydei,” Castorice says, stepping aside.

Mydei nods, swallowing his guilt and nerves as he pushes through the curtains and walks out to the center of the stage. It’s nearly deafening, even with his in-ears, how loud they scream. He can’t help but grin as he takes in their cheers. It’s a scene out of his wildest dreams. He would be ridiculous not to soak it in.

Robin gives him a hug as a greeting, whispering *good luck* in his ear with her microphone off to the side. He nods, and moves to take his seat at the piano.

He starts by raking his fingers over the keys, getting a feel for the instrument he's never played before. Sunday was on it earlier, so he knows it should be in tune—assuming, anyway, that Sunday knew what an out of tune piano sounded like.

He takes a breath, as the crowd around him begins to fade. None of them matter. Robin doesn't matter. The only person he wants to hear this is Phainon—whether or not he's in the crowd doesn't matter, either. His imagination is strong enough.

He starts to play. It's not the opening to *Dreamscape*, not yet, because he had arranged a solo piano part, sort of like a cadenza, at Robin's request. It doesn't even start in *Dreamscape*'s key, written with inspiration taken from both his favorite classical pieces with a mix of jazz and rock thrown in. It's the kind of thing Phainon would call him a genius for. The kind of thing that traditionalists like Krateros would grimace at.

The relief he felt when Robin asked him to write something for their festival was almost overwhelming—the opportunity to convince Aventurine that they can do it, too. That just because he dropped out of college and didn't finish his piano degree doesn't mean he didn't know what he was doing. He has less experience writing lyrics than writing arrangements, but with Castorice's literature degree, he knows they're capable of making art.

But more than anything, he still wants to make Phainon proud. Make him see that his talents aren't being wasted on rock music. That their worlds can still coexist.

The change into *Dreamscape*'s key is subtle, and then he shifts to a melody that slightly resembles the opening of *Dreamscape.* He thinks he can faintly hear people start to cheer. Behavior like that would be ridiculed at a classical music concert where you can't even clap between movements. Now, though, Mydei smiles at the sound of it. People clap when there's

something they want to appreciate. Why would he ever stop anyone from doing that?

And then, finally, he transitions into the first piano part of *Dreamscape.* Robin pauses longer than usual before her entrance, and Mydei listens to her as they'd always practiced before coming in again.

Castorice comes in, signifying the faster tempo as Mydei switches to his arpeggios, and then Hyacine and Cipher join together, too.

It's perfect. Mydei doesn't think he's felt bliss like this in years. He doesn't think he felt it when they signed with the IPC, or got the Robin feature, and he certainly never felt it while playing piano in his life.

The crowd knows every word. They scream it like they're the ones performing, like they feel each word like a knife to the chest. Mydei can't help but smile at the pure ecstasy he feels in his gut, so powerful he could choke on it.

This is, without a doubt, where he is meant to be. Making music he loves, performing it for people who love it almost as much. He doesn't think he needs anything else after this.

The song ends, and he is instantly reminded of the pain in his back again. He finds himself wondering, once again, if Phainon is in the crowd—but he can't see individuals. And even if he was, Mydei doesn't think he would be in the front.

"Thank you," he says, caught off guard after Robin offers him her microphone and asks if he has anything to say. "It's an honor to share my music with you."

Robin beams at that, and Mydei stands up to join the rest of the band as they're given a chance to say something, too.

There are very few things Mydei allows himself to truly want. *This*, everything he has right now—the crowd screaming for him, loving him and

his music—is something he only ever wished for quietly. He thought that if he wanted it too much, it wouldn't come true.

Phainon is the second thing he wants, and he feels like there are weights in his heart with this realization. The only thing he can do is hope that somewhere, somehow, Phainon is listening. That would be enough.

None of them have calmed down from the adrenaline and pure disbelief at it all by the time they're in the back of a tour van, pulling out of the cramped parking lot to begin the long drive back to east Penacony. The festival hadn't been far outside of the city, especially considering how Robin had to fly all the way from the west coast, but it was still a few hours.

Mydei's eyes are closed as he leans against the window, willing his heart to relax. If playing for audiences so large is what he's going to have to do for the rest of his life, he hopes he never gets used to it.

He can hear Cipher laugh at something Hyacine says, and it sounds so distant, like in the background of a dream. Even through the simmering adrenaline, he feels like he's started to drift off.

Until the bus comes to a harsh stop, and he jolts awake.

"Oh, good, you're awake. Just in time," Hyacine says.

Mydei doesn't think he was asleep, but now that his eyes are open, he feels like he might have been. Everyone is looking at him now, even Aventurine, who had climbed back from the passenger seat.

"What's going on?" He asks. Looking out the back window, he can spot a long line of cars piled up behind them.

"Traffic," Cipher explains, like that wasn't obvious. "Probably a car accident." She shrugs, then looks back at Aventurine. "Anyways, you were saying?"

“I just got off the phone with Diamond.”

Diamond. What a stupid name. Sometimes Mydei thinks that all of the IPC workers he knows must have code names, because it was just too perfect. But that would make no sense, he just has no better theory right now.

“Reception to the concert is already incredible. Your names have been skyrocketing even before Robin’s album was released, but now it’s finally confirmed that the four of you have serious star quality.” Aventurine begins. Mydei tries not to let himself get excited prematurely, but this is really sounding like good news.

“I’ve been pushing for this since we signed you, but Diamond is the one who actually calls the shots here,” Aventurine continues. “But I digress. Point is, we want an album.”

Mydei genuinely thinks he could cry. He leans back as far as possible in the seat, heart back to racing a thousand beats a minute. Part of him thinks this might not be real, but it *is*, and he’s here, and he can think of very few moments where he’s felt happiness this great.

“Wait, really?” Hyacine asks, the first to speak up out of the four of them. He’s never seen Castorice smile this big, or Cipher this speechless.

Aventurine nods. “We want to arrange for you to start as soon as possible. You will not be assigned any third party writers or producers unless you ask for them. Ratio will help you record and edit studio versions, but you will be in full control of any and all creative decisions.”

Mydei exhales. He doesn’t know what he did to deserve this, but it must have been something good.

“We want the album to be released before next summer, for multiple reasons: one, scheduling tours will be better, and two, we don’t want to allow the hype from Robin’s album to die down for too long before release. When do you think you can realistically finish writing this album?”

“September,” Cipher says immediately.

“No,” Mydei answers, just as quickly. “That’s a month and a half, Cipher, are you crazy?”

“I figured that wouldn’t be realistic,” Aventurine says. “Any other suggestions?”

“End of the year?” Hyacine asks, looking at Mydei for confirmation.

He thinks it over. That’s a little over five months, which doesn’t sound like a lot of time. But then he thinks about all the songs he’s written, that he’s already itching to revisit. All of the songs he *wants* to write. And that’s not even taking into account the lyrics Castorice has, or the ideas Hyacine and Cipher have.

“Yeah,” he says, shrugging. “Why not?”

“I like end of the year,” Castorice chimes in, nodding slightly.

“Then it’s settled.” Aventurine types something quickly on his laptop. “Finally, all of you need to stay active on your social media accounts. I’ll try to book interviews to do here and there to keep people interested, but most of the work will have to be on your end. Promote old music, show people who you are, and most importantly, *hint* at writing an album but don’t confirm anything until we have a release date. Understood?”

Mydei hates posting on social media. Too many strangers. The idea of having several million people following him that he doesn’t even know irks him. But he can talk about music. He can post cryptic photos with no caption. His most recent post, with a long paragraph for his caption, was already too much for him. He would never do that again, even though the reception had been mostly positive.

“Alright. Sounds good.” Aventurine closes his laptop, getting to his feet. “Anyways, I have to return to the front. I have a game of Blackjack going with Francisco.”

“The—the driver?!” Hyacine exclaims, eyes wide.

“Don’t worry, I’m playing for him.” Aventurine winks and climbs back into the passenger seat, officially out of their sight.

Mydei doesn’t even care a little bit about Aventurine’s apparent gambling addiction. He’d always had a hunch, anyways, just no proof. The only thing that matters right now is this album.

“So,” Cipher says, lifting her leg up so she can kick him in the knee lightly.

“What?” Mydei asks, moving out of her reach.

She blinks. There’s a stupid little half-smirk on her face, like he’s supposed to know what she wants to say without her saying it.

“*What?*”

“...Piano?”

Chapter End Notes

> if mydeimos was an element i think he would be tungsten. just fucking heavy as fuck. and dense as fuck. can form a quadruple bond. phainon would be fluorine because he's super unstable but also the most useless and weak hydrohalic acid out of all of them. and i think hysilens would be mercury but idk why. childe genshin impact would be carbon. i have no other ideas on this right now.

▶ yap

Chapter 6: Interlude (farewell, my poor hands)

Chapter Notes

early update bc i have a super busy week ahead of me and need to study tomorrow

cw: mentions of abuse, alcoholism

See the end of the chapter for more notes

***Penacony Times*, "How the 'Astral Express' is reviving jazz"**
29 December 3867
O.W.L. Bert

An introduction to the visionary jazz troupe and their illustrious members.

In 3862, when Himeko Murata and Welt Yang joined forces with one common goal in mind: to study jazz music lost to time, they didn't expect the success they've achieved today. Murata is the troupe's talented vocalist, trained in both operatic and jazz styles throughout college and beyond. She sang for an opera house in Lushaka for ten years before meeting Yang, a decorated saxophone player from Earth.

The troupe didn't take off immediately, though. Murata and Yang spent a good amount of time working one-on-one, fine-tuning their abilities and playing small shows when they could. Now, with the Express harboring many more members than it had upon its genesis, the troupe has been on tour for a year now, with no signs of stopping any time soon. "It's unprecedented," Murata explains, "how many people out there actually love jazz. Young people, too." Both she and Yang agree that they love the opportunity they have been given to inspire future generations to pursue jazz, as well.

Their supporters aren’t the only young people they’ve found who love jazz, though. The other three members are all fairly young, two of them fresh college graduates. Caelus Aron is their trumpet player, who started playing seriously in high school for the social aspect. He continued throughout college for the same reason, as a revered member of Paperfold University’s marching band for all four years. When asked if he saw himself playing trumpet full time at any point in his life, his answer is intentionally ambiguous. “I can’t remember anything before I was, like, sixteen,” he admits. “It’s like my life started then. So I don’t really ever know what I wanted to be.” He loves jazz, though, and says that proudly. The Astral Express has welcomed both him and his sister with open arms.

March 7th is the troupe’s drummer, who grew up in Amphoreus. She admits that she also suffers with minor amnesia issues from her childhood, but found Murata and Yang during the Amphoreus leg of their tour. “I love live music, so I thought it would be fun to go to the concert,” she explains. “I loved it so much I went up to them after the show and begged them to let me join.” Both Murata and Yang confirm this story, saying that at that point in time they would let anyone in if they had talent and asked.

Dan Heng is their final member, and the oldest of the three. He plays the upright bass, though he will occasionally play the electric bass as well. Neither he nor March went to college, choosing to dedicate their lives solely to spreading music instead. Dan Heng joined the Express only a month before March, deciding that jazz was a fitting path to follow as he attempts to find himself.

“It’s all fun,” Murata declares. “All our concerts are free, we don’t make money outside of donations. So we don’t care very much about the music being perfect, as long as everyone is having fun.”

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July 16th, 3869. Eight hours before the release of "Why Does Life Slumber?"

Phainon is running late. The highway was backed up with some of the worst Okhema rush hour traffic he's ever seen in his life, turning a fifteen minute drive into thirty, and what's worse is that he looked at the invite instructions and the venue claims they take absolutely no latecomers under any circumstance.

He supposes that at the end of the day he can always reconvene with his friends after the show, but he isn't *just* going so he can see them. He wants to hear the music, too, especially as someone who isn't very well-versed in jazz music at all.

He speeds into the parking lot and parks crooked, but he's just in the lines, so no one can really complain. He practically scrambles out of his car, hearing it beep to confirm that it's locked when he's already run several yards away. He hopes he isn't sweaty when he barges through the front doors, and takes a moment to gather himself before he heads downstairs, to where the entrance doors are.

It's a small venue, nothing like what he's ever played, but the Astral Express exclusively plays in intimate places like these. The doors are glass, blocked by a man on a stool with a scanner in hand. Phainon pulls his phone out of his pocket so quickly it almost slips out of his hands, his hands shaking as he searches for his email. "Sorry I'm late," he says, pulling up the QR code and turning his phone screen towards him.

The man hums, examining his ticket as he scans it. "Phainon Khaslana?" he asks, raising an eyebrow. Phainon nods. "You can go in. They're just about to start."
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Phainon rushes through a very enthusiastic *thank you*, and pushes through the glass doors as quietly as possible.

He was given a single table, with a white tablecloth and an intricate candelabra on top of it. It's near the back, so he doesn't draw too much attention to himself when he walks in and takes a seat. Sure enough, the troupe begins to play their first note the second Phainon sits down.

Phainon knew Caelus after they were random roommates their freshman year of college and chosen roommates their sophomore year. Junior year, Caelus got an apartment with his friends from the marching band, and Phainon got a single, but they remained friends ever since. He was a business major who somehow managed to finish his degree despite how little he tried and how much he disliked it. He seems much more content playing trumpet full time now.

Being friends with Caelus, he naturally met Stelle as well, though didn't see her as much. Stelle was a communications major, which she always said she picked because she had no idea what she wanted to do. Sure enough, she dropped out of college after their sophomore year and decided to start Twitch streaming instead. Now, she travels with their jazz troupe even though she doesn't play an instrument, and does Twitch streaming full time. Phainon's never been very big into video games, but she's supposedly very successful there.

He's known March for the longest time—the drummer, one of the girls Phainon grew up with for a couple years after the farm burned down. He wasn't as close with her or her twin as he was with Cyrene, of course, but Phainon's obsession with learning piano as a teenager was one of the things that motivated March to learn an instrument, too.

Then there was Dan Heng, who was Caelus's new best friend (which Phainon definitely doesn't mind at all). Dan Heng used to go by Dan Feng, who was the bassist in the High Cloud Quintet, a band Phainon never listened to, but an old friend of his was a huge fan. (He doesn't think about how overjoyed Mydei would be if he knew that Phainon was mutual friends with one of his idols. He never thinks about that.) Now, Dan Heng plays

upright bass for a much less popular jazz troupe, and says he's "finding himself" whenever he's asked about his past.

Phainon knows all about the band's extremely messy break up. How they were once a tight-knit group of best friends, until Baiheng, their pianist and guitarist, died in a freak accident. Dan Feng and Yingxing, the drummer, were so unable to cope with her death that they released a disastrous comeback album not even a year after the incident, which heavily relied on AI generated vocals made to sound like Baiheng. It was terrible and painfully obvious as the amount of recordings of Baiheng singing circulating the internet could have been counted on one hand. The actual lead singer, Jingliu, tried desperately to salvage their public image, but it was short-lived and ultimately resulted in her public arrest when she finally lost it, successfully ending her career. Yingxing fell off the face of the earth following her arrest and was never heard of or seen ever again. Jing Yuan, the lead guitarist, was seemingly the only normal one, who was able to cope with his grief in a healthy way. According to Mydei, he's raising a child now, and has a fairly successful solo career. Phainon loves his solo music much more than he ever loved the High Cloud Quintet's discography, but he thinks Mydei had the opposite experience.

Given that this is all the previous information Phainon had on Dan Feng and his nature, he was surprised to discover that Dan Heng actually comes across as a polite, and well-adjusted man. If Phainon didn't know any better, he would have thought they were two different people.

Himeko is the lead vocalist, who sometimes plays guitar if the piece calls for it. He doesn't know very much about her personal life at all, but the two of them get along fine.

It was a similar situation with Welt, an older man who played the saxophone. Phainon didn't know anything about him except for that, but he was very polite in all their interactions. As a musician, Phainon respects him greatly.

Sunday was their final and newest member, older brother to the famous pop star Robin. He'd worked with her for years, as her pianist, but ended up joining the Astral Express when they stopped in Penacony for the first time.

Phainon doesn’t know the details, but Caelus was, at the very least, wary of him right now, so it must have been a little messy.

Phainon thought he was a very talented pianist. Both he and Mydei were better, of course—*especially* Mydei, Phainon still dreams about his music—but he was good at what he was doing. Phainon never really dabbled in jazz, and he respects Sunday for his improvisational skills.

The song they’re starting with is far too slow for the beginning of a concert, in Phainon’s professional opinion, and he feels like he’s about to fall asleep. Regardless, it’s nice, with barely-there drums and soft acoustic guitar and a beautiful sax solo that sounds perfectly unpredictable, like it was never written down and Welt is merely making it up as he goes. Phainon supposes most of jazz is exactly that.

That’s what Phainon likes about jazz—he might not know much about the technical side of things, but it’s always striked him as a music genre that is impossible to play by musicians lacking passion. He’d trained for six years to get his master’s degree in piano performance, had studied his ass off to grasp music theory to the best of his ability, only for all his knowledge to be thrown out the door the second he speaks to a jazz musician. He’s always regarded it as something out of his reach.

Phainon believes every musician has a genre they can’t touch, no matter how much they might admire it. For Hysilens, it was folk and bluegrass—anything with a fiddle. She would often complain about how she wished she wasn’t classically trained from such a young age. For Phainon, it was jazz, without a doubt.

As for Mydei, well—he might be the only exception.

The first song ends, and Welt thanks the crowd briefly after they applaud for him. Himeko steps up next, giving a short speech about how they’re so grateful to share their music with the world and love nothing more than being in a room full of people able to appreciate their art to the fullest. Her speech brings a smile to Phainon’s face—he’s never had his own thoughts put into words so beautifully.

They play the next three songs back to back—the first one is much more upbeat, a stark contrast to their opener. Caelus plays a bold trumpet solo with a wine glass held to the bell of his trumpet, and his face gets so red that Phainon can barely stifle his laugh. Caelus points right at him in the audience once he's done, shaking his head with mock disapproval. Phainon must have severely underestimated just how well the group can see the audience's faces. This venue is a far cry from a concert hall.

The next one is an old jazz standard Himeko leads that Phainon actually recognizes. The one after that is another instrumental, with a fast tempo that makes Phainon feel weird for sitting still.

Caelus talks next, which surprises Phainon, because knowing Welt and Himeko, they don't seem like the kind of people who would let him touch the microphone with a ten foot pole. He actually manages to get a couple laughs out of the crowd, always one to sneak a few jokes into a speech that does not call for it. Eventually, he gets to announcing the next song, claiming it's one of his favorite standards and he had to beg Himeko to let them play it, because it's typically out of her range.

Phainon is pleasantly surprised by this. He didn't even know Caelus listened to music at all, let alone jazz. He'll have to ask him about that sometime. Maybe his time with the Astral Express really was changing him for the better.

This song starts with a long piano solo that Sunday takes his sweet time with, as if he can feel every single note. It's beautiful, without a doubt. Phainon closes his eyes and if he uses the full extent of his imagination, he can almost pretend it's Mydei on that stage. What he wouldn't give to hear him play the piano just one last time. If he had known the last time he heard Mydei play would truly be the last, he would have bathed in it. He wouldn't ever have let him stop.

He does this often, nowadays. He's not sure how he's regressed so far so fast, but the only way music seems to make him feel things anymore is if he pretends it's Mydei's music. He should have known, from the first day he met Mydei, that that man was going to ruin his life someday.

Himeko’s sultry voice cuts through his thoughts as the second half of the song begins, and Phainon’s eyes shoot open before he allows himself to think of Mydei any further. He’s instantly blown away by this song—not knowing jazz nearly as well as most other genres, he’s not familiar with it. But he falls in love immediately nonetheless. He makes a mental note to ask Caelus for the name of the song later.

They play two more songs after that, and take the last fifteen minutes of their show improvising together. Phainon thoroughly enjoys this segment, because the chemistry between all of them really shines. Caelus tries to do something that doesn’t end up working at all, and Welt laughs into his saxophone in a way you can hear in the audience. Everyone gets a solo at least once, and even though the highlights to Phainon are when he gets to watch his friend embarrass himself, he has to admit that all of them—including Caelus—are really talented musicians.

Phainon makes his way towards their little stage once they’re done. Welt, Himeko, and Sunday are busy talking to other audience members, perhaps people who are bigger fans of jazz than Phainon is. Caelus is already done packing up his trumpet, and he comes to the front to greet him.

“Hey there, sexy,” he says. His face is still flushed, bangs matted to his forehead with sweat. “I thought you’d be too good for us now that you’ve made it big, and all that.”

Phainon snorts, ignoring the nickname. “Made it big, my ass. You did good up there!”

“You think so?” Caelus asks. “Stelle always tells me I suck.”

“Because she’s a dick. Where is she, anyways?”

“Streaming, I think. She usually comes to watch, though.”

March bounds over to them next, drumsticks tucked into her belt. “Phangry!” she says, a big grin plastered on her face. Phainon internally cringes at the nickname. Why she and Cyrene insist on calling him that to this day, he has no idea. “How have you been?”

Phainon sighs, looking over at Caelus to see if he heard that—thankfully, he had stepped aside to talk to Dan Heng, who had just finished packing up his bass. “Good,” he answers. It’s true, for the most part. Ever since he left that terrible troupe with Nanook and his comically evil goons, anyway. Curse postgrad desperation. He didn’t think it could possibly leave him with more mental scars than he already had. “I’m doing solo stuff now. Only taking offers I want.” It’s the first time in his life that he hasn’t *needed* money. He’s not filthy rich by any means, but he has enough money to maintain rent on a nice apartment and pay not only for his own food, but his dog’s, as well. It’s nice to be comfortable for once.

March smiles, and as always Phainon finds himself thinking one of her smiles could make his entire day. “I’m so glad you left that stupid group. Let me know if you ever want me to punch Mr. Nanook in the face, okay?”

Phainon laughs. March might seem too small and friendly to go through with a threat like that, but Phainon knows better. Eve is her twin sister, after all—and Phainon genuinely believes she has killed a man before. You always had to walk on eggshells around that one in Cyrene’s household.

“Anyways, have you heard about the new Robin album?” March continues, and proceeds to shove her phone in his face. “She has a feature with *Calamity!*”

Of course he knows. He’s been following it since the day he found out, all the way back in September. But March is smart enough and knows him well enough to pick up on what that actually means, so he shrugs it off like it doesn’t bother him. “Isn’t Robin a popstar?”

March scrunches up her face, taking her phone back. “Whatever! Rock can totally work with pop!”

Caelus has now made his way back to the front of the stage, Dan Heng trailing behind him this time. He asks Phainon if he’s okay with his eyes. Phainon doesn’t say yes. He hates that Caelus, one of the stupidest people he has ever met, can somehow tell exactly what the true nature of his feelings for Mydei are.

“I’m going to go find the restroom.” Is what he actually says. “Text me where we’re meeting for dinner, okay?”

March nods, and lets him go. He fully intends on finding the restroom and hiding in there for ten, maybe fifteen minutes, but he doesn’t ever make it there.

Someone approaches him, looking like they have something to say, and Phainon isn’t one to be rude.

“You’re Phainon Khaslana, right?” It’s a girl, probably teen-age, with what seems to be her friend next to her.

“Uh…” Phainon stammers. “Yes?” He’s never actually been recognized before. And with Mydei on his mind, too—what a night. He thinks that after this, he’s going to rot in his bed for a week straight.

The girl grins so wide that Phainon feels like he needs to smile too. “Oh my god, I went to your Rach 2 performance like a year ago, I didn’t know who you were—I just liked Rach 2, it’s my favorite piece—and I just fell in love with your playing instantly. You’re such an inspiration to me, I’ve been playing piano since I was five!”

“...Rach 2,” Phainon manages. He stares at her and blinks at least five times. His breath is coming short now, and he can feel his fitness watch vibrate against his wrist to alert him about his heart rate. “That was my favorite piece too.”

He digs his nails into his palms, like that will rid him of the memory of Mydei’s lips against his neck. He’s not sure what he must look like, in front of these girls, but it can’t be good. He can usually handle thinking about Mydei—it happens often enough that he just has to continue to live his life around it. But Rach 2 is completely different. He can’t listen to that piece anymore. There used to be nothing in the world that could compare to it.

“A–are you okay, Mr. Khaslana…?” she asks.

Phainon forces himself to lock in. He thinks of anything else, literally *anything* but Mydeimos, because every thought of him is only bound to end horribly. “I’m sorry,” he says quickly. He takes a deep breath and puts a smile on his face. “I’m a little out of it today. I promise I’m really happy to meet you.” He breathes again, blinks twice. As soon as he gets out of this interaction, he can think about Mydei all he wants. “What’s your name?”

“Annie,” she says. “This is my friend, Maya. I dragged her here—she doesn’t really know anything about music.” Her friend looks at her like this is a deep betrayal.

Phainon laughs, and he silently praises himself for how realistic he’s able to make it sound. “Well, Annie, you have to promise me you will keep playing. Don’t quit like an old friend of mine.”

“Aw, that’s sad,” she replies, frowning a little. “I won’t quit. Not until I’m as good as you.”

Phainon smiles. “Try to be better.”

She grins at this, too. “Is that what your goal was, with your role models?”

Phainon thinks of Mydei again, but he holds it together much better this time. At the end of the day, it was Professor Anaxa who mentored him the most, who helped him become the musician he became. But every day since the very moment he met Mydei, he has wanted to be just like him in every way. Mydei was everything he was, just better. He was the sun Phainon didn’t know he was missing. His world became overcast the day he left.

“Yes,” he tells her, even if it’s a lie. This girl doesn’t need someone like Mydei to come and ruin her life all by making it so much better. “As long as you never give up, you can be better than me one day.”

She beams. They take a few pictures together, say goodbye, and Phainon goes straight to his car instead of the bathroom where he slams his forehead against the steering wheel and forces back tears. He turns the car on, trying to find just one song that doesn’t make him think of Mydei somehow, and a song from the middle of Ruan Mei’s new album immediately picks up right

where it left off when he parked. It’s devastating, in every sense of the word, and he fights the urge to scream just hearing it. He switches to his liked songs, and shuffles it until some stupid song he probably heard at a frat party when he was in college comes on. But then all he thinks about is all the frat parties he dragged Mydei to. He skips past every piano concerto, every shitty pop song that played in his old truck when Mydei was his passenger princess, every rock song that Mydei introduced him to, and *especially* every Calamity song.

Eventually, he turns it off altogether and puts on a podcast he’d been meaning to listen to about the history of antique Belobogian samovars. Caelus texts him the address of the restaurant the troupe is travelling to, right on cue. Phainon takes five minutes to do some breathing exercises before he turns on navigation and starts heading that way.

Phainon gets home a mere thirty minutes before midnight. His apartment is freezing despite the hot summer air, so he takes a shower that leaves his skin red and splotchy and him slightly lightheaded. He tucks himself into bed, plugs in his IEMs, and spends the last ten minutes before this single is supposed to drop looking into all the promotional stuff they’ve done for it.

Phainon doesn’t follow Mydei on social media, because that would be too obvious, but his account is almost always in his recent searches. Regardless of their distance, he *knows* Mydei, and he knows he was never a big fan of social media—at least not when it wasn’t an anonymous account.

So Phainon figures all the posts on his current account were ones he was required to make. He has a solid two million followers at this point, the most out of everyone in his band (even though Phainon thinks it should be Cipher, because of how much more she posts). His recent post was uploaded twelve hours ago. It’s three photos: the first one is the cover of the single, the same one March had shown him earlier. Robin is the only one in the photo, which Phainon assumes is because it’s her album, and Calamity is merely a feature. It’s a shot of her in some sort of pool, stylized so that bubbles and bright blue water obscure most of her body. Her eyes are

closed, and one hand rests on her stomach, barely obscuring a gash that tears through her stomach. Red blood seeps into the water around her waist.

The next photo is a professional photoshoot with all five of them, dressed in black. Robin stands in the middle, in a plain black dress with a fur coat slipping off her shoulders. Mydei is to the right, wearing a button down tucked into black slacks. He looks like he's in concert black, and Phainon feels his throat go dry.

The third photo is a selfie that looks like it was taken in the recording studio, with Robin behind the glass, seemingly in the middle of singing into a microphone. Mydei is in the right corner, smiling slightly at Hyacine, who takes the photo with tears in her eyes.

The caption reads "dreamscape is out everywhere at midnight" and nothing else. Mydei and his cryptic ass captions.

He looks through Robin's account for the next five minutes, who has done a whole lot more promotion than Mydei has. The second his phone's clock hits midnight, he scrambles to open Spotify. It's already on his home page —"Listen to the new release from Robin!" in big letters like that wasn't exactly what he was going to do. He clicks on it, scrolls all the way down to the very last track, and hits play.

Within the first three seconds of the song, Phainon's heart drops.

It opens with a piano solo. Only, not just any piano solo—*Mydei's* piano solo. Phainon doesn't need to look up the instrumental credits for this song, he *knows.* He would recognize Mydei's playing anywhere. If he was blind and deaf he could tell it was Mydei just from the vibrations running through the floor.

Robin starts singing, but he's not listening to her at all. Mydei is still playing behind her, now along with some orchestration. The drums kick in, and his playing picks up a little. It's nothing difficult or overly impressive, far from it—but it suits the song, and that's all that really matters. And that it's *Mydeimos,* whose music could save Phainon's life, playing the piano just as he had all those years ago.

As soon as the song ends, Phainon lays in bed, feeling like he just got the air knocked out of him. He doesn't know how much time passes before he picks up his phone and goes back on social media, refreshing Mydei's page once. Sure enough, a new post pops up. It's a series of pictures he took during the writing and recording practice. The first one is a picture of him taken by someone else. He's sitting at a piano in the studio. One hand is on the keys, and the other is writing something on the score before him. He looks deep in thought, like he doesn't even know someone is taking a picture of him. Phainon's heart aches seeing him like this after so long. The picture could have been taken of him during their college years, if only Mydei wasn't obviously older.

The caption is a long paragraph. Phainon has to take a moment to prepare himself before reading it, because Mydei's captions never get personal.

dreamscape is finally out. i can't put into words how much this song means to me, even though i was skeptical of the pitch at first. it's the first time the band and i were allowed to have a major part in the writing process. it's robin's story, more personal to her than it ever could be to me, but we all helped to write it, which makes me feel like it's actually my creation, and not just something i bought.

now, about the piano. calamity has never used piano in one of our songs, except for a few drone notes played on a keyboard in production. this was my decision, as many of you know. i have said publicly several times that i don't intend to play the piano with this band, despite my background in it.

by the time i dropped out of college, i effectively hated piano and everything attached to it. but i've had the break i needed, so thank you robin for bringing us this beautiful song and giving me back the inspiration i lost. thank you cipher for telling me how ridiculous i was being, and forcing me to get over myself. and, of course, thank you cassie and hyacine for always believing in me.

and thank you, whoever is reading this, for supporting my music even when it wasn't fully authentic, and i'm sorry that i let my resentment deprive you

of this for so long. i hope you like the piano.

Phainon feels like he's going to cry.

He doesn't know why, because realistically this is a ridiculous notion, but some part of him feels like the last paragraph was meant for him. *I do like the piano,* he thinks. *I really, really do.*

He reads the caption three more times. It's the sort of vulnerability Mydei only showed him rarely. He must have seriously matured since they broke up, and Phainon feels stupid, because *he* certainly hasn't.

Phainon likes the post, because he doesn't care if Mydei sees or not anymore. He's merely supporting a fellow musician. It's totally not because Mydei bringing his piano skills to the rest of the world is the only thing Phainon has ever dreamed of.

A quick refresh of his page shows that he's posted something on his story now, which appears to be a repost from something off Robin's account. It's a large graphic filled with performers at a music festival happening this weekend. Robin is listed as a headliner for the first day of the festival, this Friday. Her caption reads "So excited to headline at the Reverie this weekend! Maybe with some special guests? ;)"

Phainon wasn't raised to squander his money, but he has a confirmation email about his festival ticket in the next five minutes. Then, he searches for plane tickets that can fly him out the same day and back the next and a hotel room he can book for one night. It's not easy—flights to Penacony from Amphoreus are long and expensive. He goes to bed and hopes he won't regret that decision in the morning.

Phainon parks his rental car a mile away from the Reverie, because traffic closer to the venue was terrible, and he doesn't mind a little walk. He plugs

in his IEMs and listens to Mydei's music without regrets this time, even if it brings him nothing but pain.

There was never a moment in time where he had to come to terms with the fact that he was still in love with Mydei, because he never successfully convinced himself he had fallen out of love in the first place. Mydei was unforgettable, a spot in the timeline of Phainon's life that would never leave him. It didn't help that he had seen him everywhere over the last couple days—people discovering the band, and thus, discovering him. There was a billboard with his face on it that he passed in the taxi fifteen minutes ago, and a Calamity x Robin advertisement hung in the airport he landed in. Their fan base had grown considerably as well, and Phainon was sick and tired of seeing thirst tweets and fan cam edits of Mydei made by people who didn't even *know* him.

And then, he had to remind himself that *he* didn't know Mydei either, or at least, not anymore. He knew Mydei when they were teenagers in college, when Mydei was immature and spoiled but Phainon loved him anyway, for those parts of him and the parts that only came out when they were alone and vulnerable.

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"Phainon." The voice is familiar as ever, like it hadn't changed one bit in all their years apart. Part of Phainon thinks he's dreaming, that it's fake, and if he turns around he'd only see a crowd of strangers instead of the only person in the world he actually wants to see.

Except that part of him doesn't win. He turns around, and he can feel the exact moment his blood runs cold.

Mydei is there, in all his glory. He's wearing a navy blue dress shirt with the top buttons undone just enough for Phainon to see the red tattoos trailing up his neck. His sleeves are also rolled up slightly, and the shirt is tucked
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into black slacks. He's dyed the ends of his hair red, and it's tied back into a low bun. He looks like all of Phainon's deepest desires, all his hopes and dreams, in one person.

"Mydeimos?" Phainon asks. It's so quiet that Mydei definitely can't hear him, but he reads his lips anyway and nods. There's a little smile on his face. It's sickeningly attractive. Phainon thinks he might be shaking.

He walks closer. He doesn't even process that he's doing it, he just moves on his own, like there's an invisible rope tying him and Mydei together. And then they're eye-to-eye, and Phainon doesn't even know what he's doing, but he hugs him.

Mydei hugs him back. He's warm, like he'd always been, and Phainon thinks he could die happily in his arms. He's probably squeezing Mydei's neck so tightly that his airflow is cut off, but he doesn't care. They can die together

"I'm sorry," Mydei mumbles into his shoulder. Phainon doesn't say anything. He doesn't even remember what he's apologizing for.

"You remembered," he says as they pull apart. The tears in his eyes blur his vision and it irritates Phainon that they thwart his ability to see Mydei clearly.

"Of course I remembered," Mydei responds. He's grinning wider now, and it's a more blinding sight than it would be to stare directly into the sun. "Er —I brought someone I would like you to meet," he says then, and the tone of his voice is a stark contrast to before. Even his body language is different. He shifts his feet a little, like he's uncomfortable.

"Hi," says a woman beside them that Phainon didn't even know was there until now. His eyes are loath to part from Mydei's beautiful face, but he looks her way regardless, only to find a face that would only rival Mydei's beauty were he anyone else. "I'm Phoebe. It's so nice to meet you, Phainon. You're very talented." She outstretches her right hand, and Phainon takes it, trying to match the bright smile on her face even though he knows he's failing miserably.

“Phoebe is my girlfriend,” Mydei says. When Phainon looks back up at him, trying to pretend like his whole body didn’t just flinch, he’s looking at her instead. There’s love in his eyes, and Phainon couldn’t deny it if he tried. He’s starting to feel more sick than giddy.

“Oh,” Phainon responds. He’s trying his absolute hardest to play it off like his heart isn’t actively breaking, and he knows he’s not doing a very good job of it. “Then it’s nice to meet you too, Phoebe. How long have you been dating?”

“A little over two months,” Mydei turns back to him now. His expression is unreadable, and Phainon hates it. He thought he knew everything about Mydei. “What about you? Do you have a partner?”

Now Phainon thinks Mydei is just being mean. He forces out a laugh, scratching at the back of his neck. “Nah, not really. I’ve been too busy lately.” He has, but he wouldn’t be trying to date if he had all the time in the world, either. Not when every suitor would inevitably be placed next to Mydei in his head, and no person in the world could ever come close.

“I will let you two catch up,” Phoebe says. She’s looking at Phainon like she knows exactly what he meant when he said that. It terrifies him to his core. “I’ll be in the bathroom, Mydei.”

Mydei nods. His gaze lingers on her as she walks away, and he sighs a little as he turns back to Phainon. “I…” He doesn’t finish what he wanted to say. He merely shakes his head and looks down at the floor.

“I’m happy for you.” He thinks Mydei is being needlessly cruel, bringing her here, but he doesn’t confront him about it. That would be too obvious, and as far as he knows, Mydei hasn’t the slightest clue how much Phainon still feels for him. “It’s really good to see you again, Mydei. You look good.” It’s not even a morsel of what he really feels, but it’s as much as Mydei will get.

“Thanks,” Mydei says, smiling again, and it feels more casual now. “You do, too.”

Phainon's not sure he believes that. His insomnia is back more than ever, and he absolutely hates where he's ended up. He should feel happy for the opportunity to play a piece like Rach 2, but all he feels is emptiness. He wishes desperately that it were under different circumstances.

The sight of Mydei was initially enough to make him feel better about the whole situation. Now, he still just wishes it were under different circumstances.

"You look happy," Phainon comments, and his voice shakes audibly.

"I am." Mydei shakes his head, and looks a little wistfully in the direction Phoebe had just walked in.

That's all Phainon ever wanted, really. He might not have liked Phoebe before, but if Mydei is happy with her, that's all he could ask for. He starts to feel himself relax, like maybe he's coming to terms with the fact that he's lost this battle.

The rest of their conversation is small talk. Mydei asks what he's been up to, and congratulates him on pursuing his master's degree. They talk about the performance, and even though Mydei doesn't play anymore, he still talks about the piano like he's an expert.

Phoebe comes back shortly, and they leave soon after that. Phainon watches them until they're completely out of sight, as they disappear hand in hand outside the doors of the concert hall.

There's no shortage of people who want to talk to him, and he entertains all of them with his usual smiles. Somehow, he feels like there's a weight lifted off his chest. He still feels like he belongs to Mydei and Mydei alone, and he doesn't think he's ever going to move past that. Yet at the same time, if Mydei is happy and in love, who is he to take him away from the woman he loves just because he thinks it should be him? There is nothing that makes him any more special than Phoebe. He doesn't even know her, but if Mydei thinks highly of her, then so does Phainon.

As he walks through the parking garage to his car, he can feel himself giving up. He's going to live the rest of his life wanting Mydei, but as long as Mydei was happy without him, none of that mattered.

Phainon surrenders.

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The spot he ends up getting is terrible. He's so far away from the stage that he wouldn't be able to see it at all were he a few inches shorter, but he doesn't mind it this way. It's safer that he remains far away from Mydei.

And the crowd grows even bigger during the performance of the artist before him, who is fairly well known but Phainon isn't that big a fan of.

He had almost forgotten this was, first and foremost, a Robin concert, and is surprised when she's the one who walks out first. The sun is just beginning to set behind her, and Phainon can't even hear the music start over the sounds of people screaming until they're a good fifteen seconds through the song.

It's not until the very end of the show that Robin's promised guests make an entrance. Phainon isn't necessarily *not* a fan of Robin—surprisingly, Mydei liked her music more than he ever did. It was too basic for him, not nearly interesting enough. Phainon wasn't the kind of person to hate on pop music, but he knew how to recognize that he wasn't the target audience for something. He'd explained this to Mydei, too, to which he'd responded by laughing and saying he was a snob and that not all music has to be musically interesting for it to be good.

That was where their opinions diverged, most of the time. Phainon loved composers who were experimental and so ahead of their time that they were crucified back in the day for the music they made. He doesn't think he'll ever forget Mydei's face the first time Phainon played him *Rite of Spring.*
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It wasn’t like they only ever disagreed on these things; of course, Phainon always loved the classic piano concertos like Rach 2 and Tchaikovsky 1. But nothing excites Phainon like an artist doing something he had never heard before, like Ruan Mei and Fugue. Robin might have been a visionary when she first started making music, but nowadays every song on the radio sounds like cheap copies of something she revolutionized. *Dreamscape* was by far the most interesting piece of music she’s put out so far.

“For this last song,” Robin is saying to the crowd, which cheers extremely loud at this. So Phainon was clearly not the only person who enjoyed it as much as he did—but he knew that it was successful already, and still doubts that there’s anyone in the world who loves that song more than him. “I’ve invited some friends.”

Phainon doesn’t think he’s ever heard a crowd this loud when she says that, and he’s heard some pretty loud applause. For him, of course.

On stage, what feels like a mile away from where he stands, he thinks he can faintly see Mydei’s silhouette step out through the curtains. On the screen, all his dreams come true.

Mydei looks as dashing as ever, the same sickeningly attractive grin on his face that’s always there when he comes on stage, and had been since their piano days. Despite all his introversion, Mydei loved performing more than anything. And it was always a sight to behold when he did.

He doesn’t have a microphone, but he waves to the crowd as they cheer for him and his smile only gets wider every second, until he’s made it to the center of the stage and sits at the grand piano, and Phainon thinks he might pass out.

Robin is still on stage, but everyone’s eyes are on Mydei and Mydei alone. How could they not be, when the first notes of his piano playing starts to ring out? It’s a far cry from the cheers that shook the ground just seconds ago. Phainon doesn’t even realize he’s holding his breath.

He’s not playing the beginning of *Dreamscape*, and is rather doing his own thing. Phainon can’t tell if it’s improvised or if he wrote it out beforehand,

but it doesn’t matter. It’s a composition wholly unlike anything he had ever heard before. Creative, not quite classical, not quite rock, or jazz, or any genre Phainon can name. He can’t pinpoint the exact moment he starts tearing up, but it doesn’t surprise him. Hearing good enough music does that to him often.

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“I’m Mydei. Nice to meet you.”

Phainon blinks. He doesn’t really look like someone he would get along with. His fault for sleeping in on the first day of classes, having no choice but to sit in the only open seat left as he walked into Professor Anaxa’s class exactly one minute late. No one is ever late to Professor Anaxa’s classes. He’s really lucky Anaxa likes him—but clearly not lucky enough to sit next to someone that he actually likes.

“Phainon,” he responds. Mydei is blond, with golden eyes that are intense like a cat. He seemed to be wearing a leather jacket when he first came into class, but now it’s abandoned and draped over the back of his seat instead. The tank top he wears shows how muscular he is, as well as the red tattoo climbing up his right arm, and Phainon is kind of pissed off that he has the nerve to show off like that.

When he turns around, looking back at the chalkboard to whatever nonsense Anaxa is writing, Phainon lets his gaze linger a little longer. His resting expression is stoic and borderline mean. No wonder no one wanted to sit with him.

He tries not to pout for the rest of class, but it’s difficult. Especially with Hysilens just across the room from them, sitting next to Raiden Mei. The two of them certainly look like they’re having a whole lot better of a time than Phainon is. He doesn’t even know Mei very well, just that Hysilens
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played a violin duet with her last year, and he still bets that she'd be way more fun than this egotistical grouch.

A week later, he walks into Mydei's practice room, falsely assuming it was empty. It takes Mydei a few seconds to realize there's someone watching him, and in those few brief seconds Phainon's ears are filled with the most wonderful music he's ever heard, and that's all it really takes for Phainon's opinion of him to do a full one-eighty.

Mydei stops abruptly, and Phainon mourns the loss. "Um," he says, looking up at Phainon and blinking once, slowly. "Occupied?"

"Right," Phainon says, but he doesn't move. Nor does he say anything. Mydei's wearing glasses, his hair pulled back into a sloppy ponytail. He has a hoodie on today and Phainon doesn't know why that sort of pisses him off. There's a pencil tucked behind his ear, and that just pisses Phainon off more. Put it on the stand like everyone else instead of trying to be performative.

"Do you need something?"

"No," Phainon desperately hopes his face isn't as red as it feels like it is. "Um, sorry, I'm sorry, I'll go."

He stands outside the door and listens to him play for another fifteen minutes before he finally drags himself away.

Phainon wants to marry Mydei one day. It would be on the most beautiful day of the year, in Castrum Kremnos. They would grow old together and adopt a daughter. She would grow up to be the best pianist in the world, he thinks—until it dawns on him just what he's thinking, and he wipes the thought out of his head just as quickly.

Mydei doesn't do anything special when it finally clicks to Phainon just what he's experiencing. They're simply in Phainon's dorm together, watching a movie while Caelus is busy at rehearsal, and Phainon says something that makes Mydei laugh.

It's a stupid joke. But he laughs like it was the funniest thing he'd ever heard, and Phainon realizes that seeing any of his other friends laugh like this doesn't make him feel this way.

The amount of romantic experiences Phainon has had at this point could be counted on one hand, and yet he can't help but think that this must be exactly what it feels like to love someone.

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Phainon gets the same feeling now, watching the camera's close up shot of Mydei's hands on the piano keys. His playing is still as beautiful as ever—fuck whatever Madam Herta had to say on the matter. Phainon still believes that Mydei could lay on the keyboard and it would sing out a melody. Ever since that day that he realized he loved Mydei, every time he saw him play it was like he fell in love with him all over again.

Phainon's so focused on the original melody Mydei performs that he doesn't recognize the key change into D-sharp minor, matching that of *Dreamscape*. He doesn't register that the rest of his band has now walked out on stage, taking their respective places with Robin standing right in front of Mydei's piano, until the crowd starts cheering again.

And then Mydei launches right into the *Dreamscape* piano solo, and Phainon thinks he finally loses it.

Robin starts singing, and then the drums kick in, and Mydei's solo picks up. The guitar and bass are added, and Phainon wants to kill whoever is controlling the screencast for focusing on anyone but Mydei.
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He can barely hear the piano part over the screaming of the crowd now, but he knows that it's happening, and the way the music comes together live is almost overwhelming.

He can't stop himself from crying, uncaring for how dramatic he might seem. Mydei never seemed to mind how weak he was, anyways. Maybe, if they could see each other, Mydei would step off stage and come console him. Hold him in his arms and run his fingers through his hair like he always did when Phainon's insomnia hindered him from sleeping back in college.

And then reality hit him: Mydei couldn't see him, and Phainon was probably the last thing on his mind right now, anyway. If he knew Phainon were here, he probably wouldn't think much of it. He had a beautiful girlfriend at home that, if everything worked out in his favor, would be his wife someday.

To Mydei, Phainon was in the past. And Phainon was okay with accepting that.

The song finishes. Phainon doesn't stay for the rest of the set.

Even once he's waded his way out of the crowd and begins the walk back to where he parked his car, he can hear the low rumble of Mydei's voice speaking to the crowd, even through their earsplitting screams.

It's not nearly as busy on the outside of the festival as it was when Phainon had arrived, so it doesn't take long to walk to where he parked. Just as he's getting into his car, he gets a phone call from an unknown number.

It's from outside Penacony, he can tell by the way the numbers are laid out before he even reads the country it's tracked to.

Castrum Kremnos. He almost drops his phone, then scrambles to accept the call before it goes to voicemail. There's only one person he knows from Castrum Kremnos, and it can't be him mid performance. He's not entirely sure why he picks up—his phone number still has the Aedes Elysiae area code, anyways, so it could very well be Amphoreus spam.

“Hello?”

“Hello. Is this Phainon Khaslana?” It’s a man’s voice. Deep, but not as deep as Mydei’s. He speaks in Kremnoan-accented Okheman. Phainon blinks a couple times, caught off guard as he forces his brain to switch back into Okheman, too.

“Yes?” Phainon says, suddenly extremely confused. “Who is this?”

“I’m calling from Kremnos Pianos. We’re reaching out to you for a sponsorship opportunity. Would you be interested?”

Phainon’s brain short circuits. “What?” The word comes out harsher than he intended, but he’s in no rush to take it back. He swallows as the man keeps talking, yet fails to wash down the bitter taste in his mouth.

“It won’t take much from your end. We would pay you five hundred thousand dollars upfront to use one of our pianos in every performance for the next year, as well as a 50% cut of all revenue made from an advertisement you’re featured in.”

Phainon’s brain is moving at a snail’s pace. First, Kremnos Pianos is calling him—Mydei’s *father’s* company—and they’re willing to pay him *five hundred grand* just to play on one of their pianos for a year.

Phainon isn’t poor like he was after the fire and in college, when all the money he made was from the occasional concert and each minimum wage job he worked, and his college tuition was mostly covered by a scholarship he still doesn’t think he ever deserved.

But he’s not rich enough to think five hundred grand is beneath him. He’s happy with where he’s at, but he can’t even fathom where that sort of money might get him.

He can’t believe it, but he’s actually considering saying yes—until a cold hang drags him back as if forcing him to remember. It had been so long since he’d allowed himself to think about the ugly parts of Mydei. Like his

past—like his father. Things he hated thinking about then, and hates just as much today.

The man on the other end is still talking, but he doesn't know what he's saying. Something about other options and how they're open to negotiation.

Phainon doesn't care how flexible Eurypon Nikador is willing to be. "No," he says, a little too quietly.

"...Sorry?"

"I said no." It's more forceful the second time around. He swallows the lump in his throat. "I won't do it."

He doesn't seem to be willing to take that as an acceptable answer. A few beats of silence pass on his end, and Phainon considers hanging up, but decides against it. He wants them to know just how little he's willing to take this sponsorship. *"Er…we can up the price as much as you want, sir. How about seven hundred?"*

"No," Phainon says again. He's starting to get a rush from denying Mydei's father this. He feels genuinely good about himself for the first time all week. "I don't care how much you'll give me. I have no interest in working with your company."

"Well," Phainon can hear the man swallow thickly on the other end. *"That's…not an acceptable answer, sir."*

"Oh, is it?" Phainon laughs. "I'm the one you're begging to work with. I don't think you're in any position to tell me what is and isn't acceptable."

"Our company is willing to take matters into our own hands if this is your final answer, sir. You will receive a check in the mail for all the money we owe you regardless."

"What the hell are you talking about?" Phainon doesn't think he's talking to Eurypon right now—it would be weird if he was, but this is exactly the kind of manipulation he imagined he used to run his business. Suddenly he's

getting weird images in his head of edited pictures of him smiling next to a Kremnos piano.

“Have a good day, Mr. Khaslana.”

The line clicks off. Phainon stares at his phone screen, immensely confused. Was that *actually* what they were going to do? Make it look like he supported their company, when he didn’t agree to a sponsorship? Did they seriously think they would legally get away with that?

Regardless, he does the first thing he can think of, and posts something to his public Twitter account—a disclaimer about his refusal to collaborate with Kremnos pianos. It comes across a little meaner than he might intend on a different day, but he doesn’t think he’s felt such hatred for a man in years.

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Summer in Okhema was always unbearably hot. Somehow Phainon managed to drag Mydei, Cipher, and Castorice to the beach for a day while Mydei was visiting to record music for the band. Phainon thinks he has the worst heat tolerance out of any of them, but he would never admit that to Mydei, lest he find something else to hold over his head.

At some point, Phainon leaves Castorice and Cipher in the water to talk to Mydei. He lays on his back underneath the burning sun, eyes closed and hair like a bright yellow halo around him. For a brief moment, Phainon thinks he might really be asleep, but he stirs as he feels Phainon approach and sits up onto his elbows.

“Hey,” he says casually, squinting up at him. “Having fun?”

Phainon just shrugs, coming to sit beside him. “It would be more fun if you went out there with us,” he says, smiling at Mydei sideways.
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Mydei's carefree expression falters a little. He looks away, at the ocean, and there's clear pain in his eyes. Phainon instantly feels bad for prodding. "I can't swim," Mydei finally admits.

"What?"

Mydei turns to look at him. He doesn't repeat himself, because they both know Phainon heard. That was just never something he considered before—Mydei was so strong, athletic, and he grew up rich, in a large estate with an outdoor pool. He'd mentioned it in the past. How was it possible that he was never taught how to swim?

"I was seven," Mydei begins, sitting up fully and crossing his legs. There's tension in his shoulders, and without thinking, Phainon reaches up to soothe it. Mydei's flinch is almost unnoticeable, but he relaxes instantly. Phainon doesn't ask.

"My father…" Mydei continues. "He was an asshole to me." He takes a deep breath, and tells the rest of the story without pausing once. "The bigger his company got, the more he drank. The alcohol changed him until he wasn't the same even when he was sober. When I started taking piano lessons, he got this idea in his head that I would overshadow him one day. And that was a big enough problem to him that he wanted me gone. My mother fought with him all the time. She wasn't one to let him speak to her the way he did, and she wasn't one to let him hurt me, either. But one day it went too far. He was the drunkest I'd ever seen him, and he threw me into the pool. I would have drowned if my mother didn't pull me out. We left him that night. But I haven't been able to swim since. So I just…I never learned."

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Phainon turns the car on and tosses his phone aside. He pulls out of his parking spot a little too fast, just as his car connects to the local radio
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station. He practically bruises his knuckle with how hard he mutes it. He does not have the patience to listen to the Fools right now. He’s not sure why such a terrible band ever even got a record deal.

The traffic is moving too slowly in the city for him. Phainon usually praises himself for being a safe driver, but he’s overcome with the urge to crash head on into the car in front of him right now—a feeling he’s completely foreign to.

He’s gripping the steering wheel so hard his knuckles are turning white. He’s never had tunnel vision this bad before, too lazer-focused on what’s directly in front of him, that he doesn’t notice the light turn red before he’s speeding through it, and he doesn’t notice the car hurtling into his driver’s side until it’s too late.

Chapter End Notes

> i feel like the timeline especially with phainon's part is a bit confusing. so basically, he and mydei broke up in his junior year. he graduates undergrad and goes to grad school immediately for 2 more years. in between these years (summer after his first year of grad school) he played rach 2. this was with nanook's orchestra. he played with them once or twice since, before joining them temporarily after he graduated due to desperation. it sucked and he hated them so he left. then, not long after that, this chapter takes place.
>
> ▶ now i will talk about jazz for the rest of this character limit
>
> with this chapter, part 1 is complete. as in part 2 starts next week. uploads will continue on sundays as expected, although im posting this after midnight where i am so i guess technically we're still on schedule

Chapter 7: The Next Best American Record

Chapter Notes

title is from the PEAKEST lana album of all time, NFR. this chapter reminds me of that album very much, i'm not really sure why.

cws: mentions of abuse

also two extra disclaimers before we begin: i am not a med student. i have no desire to go into any medicine-related field. thus, i know nothing about this stuff and discussions of phainon's injury and treatment plan will most likely be very inaccurate. thank you.

second, i hate poetry and i cannot write that shit for the life of me. therefore, any lyrics throughout this fic are taken from the songs they're inspired by. mostly, anyways. there might be a few later on where i tried my hand at it, but it's bad and i imagine mydei's songwriting would be much better.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

albumoftheyear.org

CALAMITY - **Bleed Gold**

Critic score: **66**
Based on 5 reviews

User score: **84**
Based on 1,907 reviews

DETAILS
August 29th, 3866 / release date
EP / format

No Label / label
Hard Rock, Alternative Rock, Art Rock / genre
Mydeimos Nikador, Cifera Mnestia / producer
Mydeimos Nikador, Castorice Thanatos / writer

TRACK LIST
1. Bloodlust **62**
2. Don’t Cry **94**
3. Child’s Play **78**
4. Lionheart **64**
5. Taxidermy **89**

USER REVIEWS

User: *deliverthedawn*
Rating: 90

Wow. I’m not even sure where to begin. This is essentially the best you can get with a debut EP. CALAMITY is criminally underrated, even if this is just the beginning of what will undoubtedly be a long and fruitful career. Mydei, Cipher, and Castorice are all incredibly talented, and it’s impossible to ignore with a record like this. They have the perfect blend of nostalgic rock with visionary creativity, creating an almost otherworldly sound you rarely hear in music nowadays. I only give them a 90 because I know there is room to grow.

Favorite tracks: Taxidermy, Lionheart

Least favorite tracks: Don’t Cry

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July 27th, 3869. Ten months before the release of Oracle.
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The band takes a few days of rest after the festival. Aventurine informed them they weren't required to write their album in an IPC building, but needed to record it in one—which was easy enough. Mydei knows he's supposed to use these days to take a break, but it doesn't feel very well deserved after only playing one show. Robin brought out two different guests for the other two nights of the festival, and besides, it was her album that was out, and not theirs. All Mydei really had to adjust to was his skyrocketing popularity.

And now *Don't Cry* is charting again. Mydei even heard it on the radio once. And speaking of Phainon, one of his posts was trending on social media to the point where Mydei had actually gotten a notification about it. His feed usually doesn't include anything related to pianists or the classical music world as a whole, but what really caught his eye was the mention of Kremnos Pianos specifically.

Phainon released a statement publicly denouncing the brand and stating that he had been *boycotting* them. What Mydei finds especially interesting is that he never elaborates as to why, not even in the replies when people press him for further comment. In fact, he was oddly silent under this post, not answering a single comment. Mydei knows enough about Phainon's social media presence to know how friendly he was with all of his followers, and Mydei has a hard time believing he would be the type of person to stay completely silent online. Especially when talking about an issue that is clearly very important to him.

Mydei, of course, has a guess as to why he's chosen to boycott the company. It's a personal thing, without a doubt—a lingering connection to Mydei, and his father, and Phainon's stubborn hatred of the man. Mydei never understood why Phainon insisted upon hating Eurypon for him.

And there's no evidence out there that Kremnos Pianos is an unethical company. While Mydei has no knowledge of their business practices, disconnected from all of it as he is, he doesn't have any reason to believe Eurypon is an asshole beyond being a drunk old man with a short temper. So he chalks Phainon's silence up to a simple lack of evidence.

That is, until he receives a phone call around noon, a couple days before the band had agreed to start working on the album together. It's from a number he doesn't recognize. He picks it up anyways.

"Hello?"

"*Hi, we're calling from the Feldspar Hospital of Penacony. Is this Mydeimos Nikador?*"

"Yes." Mydei suddenly feels a wave of nausea overcome him, thrown back to that terrible phone call he received in college. Was Castorice sick again? Did Hyacine get in an accident? *Cipher?* It all seems so unlikely, everything was going so *well* recently. But that was also the case the day his mother died.

"*Do you know a Phainon Khaslana?*"

"Oh," Mydei can't help it from coming out of his mouth, the word so small in the air around him. He takes a seat on his couch, accidentally sitting on his cat's tail. She yowls and runs away, but it's hardly at the front of his mind. "I…do. Did. We—is he okay?"

"*He was in a car accident last Wednesday. His condition was stabilized, and he has been recovering. We cannot allow him to fly back to Amphoreus, as he is foreign, and he says you are the only person he has a connection with in the area.*"

Mydei almost doesn't hear the end of her words after processing the first part. A car accident. It must have been *him* on that day, after the festival. What the hell was he doing in Penacony in the first place? All his family and friends still lived in Amphoreus, as far as Mydei knew. Unless he was here for the concert—which is a possibility Mydei doesn't allow himself to ruminate on for too long.

He was safe, at least, and that was all Mydei needed to hear. Only once he's calmed down a little bit does he process the second half. Phainon wants to stay with *him* until he can fly back home.

God, Mydei wants nothing more. He spent the last three years of his life inadvertently chasing him down, anyway—attending every concert in his area, watching videos of his performances late at night, wondering whether or not he's moved on, and not thinking too hard about why he so desperately wants the answer to be *no.*

Regardless, it doesn't matter. They were friends first, were they not? The closest friend Mydei had ever made—he always hates himself for how easily he let him go.

"*Sir? Are you still there?*"

"Yes," Mydei rushes to say. "Are you saying he wants to stay with me?"

"*Of course, something like this cannot be done without your consent, and it is an atypical situation, as the two of you are not family. There are alternatives to this, if you don't have the means or desire to take him in.*"

"No," Mydei says, a little too loud. "I can do it. I will do it."

"*Are you sure?*"

"Yes. You said he's alright now? What are his injuries?"

"*His hands and fingers were crushed, he dislocated a hip, and fractured a collarbone. He is also recovering from mild whiplash.*"

"What?" Mydei practically whispers. "He can't use his hands?"

"*That's right, sir.*"

No matter how hard he tries, Mydei cannot think of a more devastating way Phainon could have injured himself. Something like that, Mydei thinks, might be a fate worse than death. He had always loved piano more than anything else in the world.

His phone call with the nurse ends soon after that. He asks if he needs to pick Phainon up, and they say the hospital will transport him to Mydei's

apartment themselves. He would be discharged by the weekend, which only gives Mydei a couple of days.

He stares at the baby grand piano in front of him. Ever since writing *Dreamscape*, he'd been playing here and there again. Not learning any new pieces, just recalling ones he used to know. It was as frustrating an experience as it was cathartic—now, after being so far removed from all the bad things he had come to associate with it, he realized that he really did like being so good at an instrument few can say they've mastered. But it's not as much muscle memory as he had thought it was. Trying and failing to play pieces he *knew* how to play mere years ago only served to piss him off, not to relax.

He wonders how Phainon would feel, seeing it. Would it make him happy to see that Mydei still had a piano in his apartment after all these years, or would it just sadden him, being so close to an instrument he wants to play, but can't?

Before doing anything else, he texts Phainon. He doesn't expect him to respond, knowing he probably can't, but doesn't think the first time they've spoken in years should be on the day Phainon moves in with him. He makes sure to clarify who he is, just in case Phainon had gotten a new phone or deleted his contact. He wouldn't blame him if that was the case.

Phainon responds a minute later with a message that reads "Hi mighty I'm on like so many drugs right now and I just I love you." Mydei stifles his laugh and types back a few more messages that Phainon doesn't respond to. He doesn't think about it too hard—even initiating voice text must seem impossible when you can't even hold up your phone.

As soon as he puts his phone down, finally able to process the information he was just given, he can't help the giddiness he feels pooling in his gut. Worry is there too, of course—Phainon's message was lighthearted enough for him to believe he was doing fine, but that was most likely just the painkillers speaking. And Mydei knows Phainon. He knows he would rather die than pile his burdens on anyone else, even if they're asking for it.

But he’s going to see him again. They’re going to reconnect. It’s ridiculous that it took something so terrible for that to happen, but Mydei is glad regardless.

The day of Phainon’s arrival comes much quicker than Mydei was anticipating. He had spent the last few days until the weekend doing his best to prepare—he could have the guest room, which up until now Mydei was using as his office, so he moved all the clutter into the living room instead. The band had initially agreed to do their work together in the studio, but after the change of plans Mydei had to ask that they work in his apartment instead. He then spent an entire afternoon moving all the soundproofing boards from the guest room to the living room.

Phainon is brought to Mydei’s apartment at the beginning of the next week. The nurses ensure Mydei knows exactly what he needs to do to make sure Phainon heals properly. He’s more or less off the strong painkillers by now, but the first time he actually addresses Mydei alone is after the nurses are gone.

“Hi,” he says. He sits on the edge of the couch, and Mydei isn’t sure if he looks more uncomfortable about being in Mydei’s apartment, or his injuries. He had been kept in the hospital for a little under two weeks, until he could walk on his own since he wasn’t able to use a crutch. His hands are in splints, his left arm in a sling. Mydei was already given all the information for the physical therapy sessions he had already been attending three times a week.

“Hi,” Mydei replies. He swallows thickly. He had already spent several hours fantasizing about this moment, wondering if they would click back into being best friends like no time had passed, or if too much would have changed for them to even reach that point ever again. Right now, it’s looking like the second option is more plausible. “How do you feel?”

“Fine,” Phainon’s response is immediate. “It’s really not that serious, I just have to keep the brace on because they tell me I have to.”

And all of a sudden, Mydei's already annoyed. He fights the urge to click his tongue at him, or cross his arms, or do anything to reveal how he truly feels. But the last thing Phainon needs right now is to misread his irritation. "Phainon," he says, as gently as he can manage. "You can be honest with me."

"Of course, Mydei." He gives him what Mydei assumes is the biggest smile he can manage right now, but it doesn't look that convincing. Mydei sighs, quietly, and sits down on the coffee table across from him.

"Why were you in Penacony?" He gently places a hand over his knee. "Did you have a concert?" He doesn't admit to the fact that he knows Phainon did not have a concert in the area. He always knows when Phainon is coming near him.

"No," Phainon says. "I was visiting a friend."

Mydei knows he's lying. "A friend?" He questions, in an attempt to get something more out of him. "And yet you chose to stay with me?" He stares at Phainon in a way he knows is intimidating. Phainon can't look away, even though Mydei can tell he wants to.

He worries at his lip, and then exhales. "It was you," he admits quietly. "I went to the festival."

Mydei already knew that was probably it. He just didn't want to admit it to himself in case it was merely wishful thinking. He tries to stop himself from smiling, and fails miserably. "You did," he murmurs. "You were there."

"Of course I was," Phainon says, frowning a little. "I promised."

"Rach 2 wasn't the only performance I went to," Mydei admits. "I saw you play with Aglaea's orchestra when I was in Okhema last."

"Oh my god," Phainon starts to laugh, but it doesn't last very long. "Didn't I play *Hungarian Rhapsody* as an encore?"

Mydei fights back a smile of his own. He hated that piece—it had caused one or two arguments in college, as it was one of Phainon's favorites. Watching him play it live had almost been enough to change his mind. "I was proud of you, because you said you didn't think you'd ever be able to learn it."

Phainon settles for a simple smile this time, though the twinkle in his eye tells Mydei that he wants to laugh. "It wasn't that hard once I finally sat down to do it," he says, and then his smile fades as quickly as it had appeared. "Wait, Mydei, you don't…live alone, do you?"

Mydei can't help but laugh, a little in disbelief. "What?"

"Well, because—"

"Who would I possibly be living with? Cas? *Cipher?* Although, Kephale knows she probably needs help with rent—"

"I meant your girlfriend."

Mydei closes his mouth, caught off guard. "My *girlfriend?*" It takes too long for him to realize that Phainon means *Phoebe,* who he had brought to his Rach 2 performance over a year ago now. He almost forgot about that completely. "Phainon, we broke up. We've been broken up." Since the day Phainon met her. It didn't take Mydei longer than a couple weeks to get over it, but he's still riddled with shame whenever he thinks about that night now.

"Oh," Phainon murmurs, so soft the word is barely even there. "I'm sorry."

Mydei remembers what he used to tell Phainon in college whenever he apologized to him unnecessarily. *Don't apologize for things that aren't your fault.* He almost laughs at the irony of it now, thinking about all of it. It would be a lie to tell Phainon it wasn't his fault. "It was a while ago," he says instead. "We went our separate ways, and I'm past it now."

"That's good, then."

“What about you?” Mydei prods, leaning forwards a little. “How’s your love life going?”

Phainon half-snorts. “Just as bad as you’d expect. You know who I am.”

“Huh.” Mydei thinks he might know what Phainon means by that. Phainon didn’t fall in love easily. Piano always came first in his life, and he might have been in love with Mydei once, if only for the fact that they shared that priority.

But they didn’t anymore. And Mydei supposes that’s okay.

“Huh,” Phainon echoes.

They fall into silence. He had known what Phainon had grown up to look like, of course. The slightly messy way his hair sits on his head, fluffy and sticking up in several stubborn places he can never seem to tame. His bright blue eyes that almost feel overbearing sometimes. The pink undertones of his skin and the rosy blush on his cheeks. It’s all the same. And yet, he looks a thousand times more mature now, and infinitely more handsome, even through the circles under his eyes and fresh scar on his cheek.

Mydei sighs, finally breaking his gaze away. “I’m happy you’re here, though,” he admits. “Even though the circumstances are terrible. I wanted to talk to you again.” He shocks himself with how vulnerable he is so quickly. Leave it to Phainon to bring it out of him.

“Me too,” Phainon agrees. “You know, you could have just called me. I would have picked up without a second thought.”

Mydei snorts, head hanging low. “I could say the same to you, you know.”

“Yeah,” Phainon chuckles softly, and Mydei lifts his head to look at him again, at the way his eyes twinkle with mischief and relief and a thousand positive emotions, without a single negative one in sight, even in such circumstances. “I guess we’re both just fucking stupid.”

“Okay,” Castorice sighs, as Mydei sets down the final case he had dragged out of her car. “That’s the last of it.”

“I didn’t know you *had* a kit this big,” Mydei mutters, staring at the mess they had just turned his living room into. Hyacine and Castorice had been slowly unloading every box Mydei had dragged out of Castorice’s car, setting up her drum kit in the living room. Cipher was supposed to be helping, but she wasn’t.

“I brought everything,” Castorice explains. “For options.”

“Right,” Mydei stands in the archway between his kitchen and living room, hands on his hips. “Options.”

“When can we meet the lovely delivery boy?” Cipher chimes in, and Mydei almost jumps at how easily she was able to sneak up on him.

“*Delivery boy?*” Mydei snickers.

Cipher comes to stand before him, smiling like she was trying to feign innocence. “Yeah, he used to deliver pizzas in high school. You didn’t know that?”

Mydei pinches the bridge of his nose and walks past her, exasperated. “He’s in his room,” he answers. “He’ll be out soon. He did say he wanted to meet you all.”

“Meet?!” Cipher scoffs, turning away. “Bastard gets a little lick of fame and pretends he doesn’t know us anymore.” She huffs, exasperated, before stalking off to perch herself on Mydei’s couch and watch Castorice and Hyacine do actual work.

Mydei shakes his head, moving to the kitchen to retrieve the plates of food he had prepared last night. He sets them down on the coffee table, choosing not to comment on the very obvious bite that had been taken out of one of

the dishes. Cipher, no doubt—Castorice and Hyacine wouldn’t do such a thing, and Phainon wasn’t even able to feed himself with both his hands in a cast.

He knocks on Phainon’s door, hoping to retrieve the whiteboard he forgot was still in the spare room. It was the best thing he could think of to start brainstorming with.

“Come in?” Phainon's voice comes on the other end, laced with uncertainty.

Mydei pushes the door open, and Phainon audibly sighs in relief when he sees it’s him. “I need the whiteboard,” he explains, closing the door behind them. “You okay?”

Phainon is shirtless, and the room is a mess. Eve had sent over a suitcase full of his clothes, and he wasn’t able to empty it out very neatly. There’s a t-shirt halfway on one of his arms, and he stares at Mydei helplessly. “I’m useless,” he shakes his head, slumping as he sits on the side of the bed.

“Here,” Mydei walks over to him, lifting the shirt and opening it so Phainon can stick his head through. It’s more of a hassle to get his other arm through, but they manage. “You can ask for my help, you know,” he says. “It’s nothing to be ashamed of.”

“I know,” Phainon mutters, but he still sounds bitter.

“It’s temporary,” Mydei says. “You’ll heal.”

Phainon chews at his lip, but doesn’t say anything.

“Come,” Mydei sits up, offering him a hand. “They want to meet you.”

Phainon doesn’t accept his hand, looking up at him despairingly. “Mydei, I…look like shit.”

Mydei takes him in—his hair is a mess, unable to tame his bedhead, and there are even worse bags under his eyes than yesterday, but there’s still something almost devastatingly attractive about him. Mydei shakes it away.

It’s the outfit, it *has* to be—jeans and a solid-colored t-shirt, much more mature than the horrendous things he would throw together in college. He doesn’t look like shit at all.

“You just got in a car crash, Phainon, no one is expecting you to be model ready,” Mydei shakes his head, gripping his arm and pulling him up to his feet. “Come on. You look fine.” *Fine* is an understatement, but he can’t say any more than that.

Mydei grabs the whiteboard by the wall, and by the time they both enter the living room, Castorice’s drum kit is almost entirely set up.

They all look up as the two of them enter. “Hi guys,” Phainon says from Mydei’s right, a little sheepish. “It’s been a while…”

Cipher gives a low whistle from her seat atop the couch cushions, with Kokopo III on her lap. “Shit, Mydei, you weren’t lying.”

“About what?!” Mydei demands, alarmed. He’s horrified, for a second, that he said something he shouldn’t have, until Cipher continues.

“He really did get fucked up. I thought you just wanted an excuse to live with him.”

“Why would I lie about that?”

Cipher doesn’t respond, and Mydei turns his attention back to Phainon, who is currently trying to figure out a way to shake Hyacine’s hand.

“Do you remember me?” Phainon asks, when they part. “From chemistry?”

“You asked more questions than any other student, of course I remember you,” she answers. “And, I graded your final. It was…disappointing, to say the least.”

Phainon’s whole face flushes, and he looks away. “I only failed it because I didn’t study!” he jumps to defend himself, like that’s an acceptable excuse. “He said the finals would only count if they helped, and I had a ninety!

Pretty good for chemistry, if you ask me.” Sometimes, Mydei thinks Phainon must be a genius.

Hyacine giggles. “Yes. It’s not for everyone.”

They move to sit around the coffee table, making idle conversation as Mydei sets up the whiteboard. Now, it was clearer than ever that although Cipher, Castorice, and Phainon had kept in touch, they hadn’t seen each other since he and Mydei broke up. Mydei thinks that is probably his fault. He never said anything about allowing them to meet Phainon despite them not being on speaking terms, and would feel terrible if he was the sole reason they hadn’t seen one of their closest friends in years.

“How’s Agy doing?” Mydei catches Cipher asking while he’s in the kitchen, rummaging through one of the drawers for a dry erase marker.

“Aglaea?” Phainon asks. “Last I saw her, her vision was getting a lot worse,” he says. “She’s handling it just fine, though. But I think she would appreciate a call from you.”

Mydei doesn’t hear her response, and by the time he’s back in the living room, the conversation has moved on. Cipher doesn’t talk about Aglaea often. He thinks they must have been close, given how Aglaea was Cipher’s legal guardian, but their relationship is somewhat strained nowadays. He has no idea why that is.

“Are you still living with Cyrene, Phainon?” Castorice asks next. Mydei sits on the couch beside Phainon and unlocks his tablet. He has all his old music on here somewhere, he just has to find it.

“No,” Phainon answers. “I have my own apartment in Okhema. She’s abroad right now though, doing her book tour.”

“She published it?” Castorice’s eyes light up, hands clasped together. Phainon nods, beaming.

Mydei had heard about the book Cyrene was writing in passing; when he and Phainon were still close, she had already been working on writing it for

years. From his understanding, it was a long retelling of ancient Amphorean epics titled *As I've Written*. She studied history and anthropology in Janusopolis for years in preparation for this novel.

"It's gone really well so far. I'm sure she'd ship you a free copy if you wanted, Cas. All of you, actually." Phainon looks at Mydei specifically, and he's not entirely sure why.

"Nah, I don't read." Cipher stretches out from her spot atop the couch cushions, hitting Phainon's shoulder with her foot. Kokopo III jumps off her lap. "Can we clock in now?"

"I didn't think making music was such a chore for you, Cipher," Hyacine admonishes. She scratches the top of Kokopo III's head like she's a dog.

"I'll leave you guys to it, then," Phainon says. He carefully stands from the couch, giving Mydei a light nod as they make eye contact. "I'll be in the guest room if you need my help with any theory stuff, Mydeimos."

"Very funny. Get out."

Phainon goes, soft laughter trailing behind him as he disappears around the corner.

"You two seem close," Hyacine says once they can hear his door shut. She wears a pleasant smile on her face when Mydei whirls his head around to look at her.

"Seriously?" He demands.

"Yeah, what exactly did *reconnecting* entail with you two?" Cipher chimes in. She's rolled off the top of the cushion now, legs thrown casually over Castorice's lap. "He might not be as spry as he once was, but surely *you* can put some work in now and then."

"What does that even me—"

"The album," Castorice chimes in, as if trying to remind everyone why they are here in the first place.

Mydei shoots to his feet, uncapping the marker in his hand. “Yes, Cas. The *album.*”

“The album,” Hyacine agrees, shifting the way she’s sitting until she faces the whiteboard Mydei had hung on the wall. The only open space was over one of his windows due to all the soundproofing equipment he had installed. He writes the word *album* on the top of it in all caps.

The one thing they all remember very quickly is that none of them have ever written an album before. Individual songs are different—they can be anything, but an album must be at least somewhat cohesive. In theme, or sound.

They mess around on their instruments until they find a general sound they like, before deciding they don’t want to be confined to one sound. Cipher turns one of their old basslines into funk, and Mydei plays an improvised jazz lick on the piano. Hyacine points out that they’re technically still a rock band, after which they all unanimously decide that while they don’t want to lose this origin, they don’t want to be tied down by it, either.

They brainstorm themes next, Mydei writing each one on the whiteboard. Hyacine’s first suggestion is that they write a social commentary, right before spitballing “romance” while looking very pointedly at Mydei. He shakes his head but writes it down anyway. Cipher follows that up with “heartbreak” and a wink. Mydei writes that down, too, because he has a lot of songs about heartbreak he already knows he wants to workshop.

Castorice suggests a concept album, where they wrote a story along with characters and based the songs after their experiences. She claims she already has a couple ideas, paging through her notebook at vague sketches and half-written stories.

“I like the idea, but I still want this album to be more personal,” Mydei confesses, thinking about the promises he had already made to himself.

“What the hell happened to you?” Cipher demands. “You never tell us anything.”

“Well, neither do you,” he responds. “I couldn’t waterboard details about your relationship with Lady Aglaea out of you.”

“Okay, you could definitely *waterboard* it out of me—”

“I find that hard to believe considering—”

“That’s enough,” Hyacine juts in, getting up from her seat. “We’re never going to finish a whole album by the end of the year if you’re going to keep starting all these petty arguments.”

Hyacine rarely scolds them, but when she does, Mydei can’t help but feel ashamed each time, without fail. He didn’t think his banter with Cipher was ever that serious, even if he always said how he felt.

“It’s true,” Castorice chimes in. “Neither of you ever tell us anything.”

“I tell you things,” Cipher crosses her arms, closing herself off as she looks at Castorice with an expression akin to a pout.

“You’re bad at telling the full truth,” Castorice answers softly.

“If you want an honest album, Mydei, you have to be honest with us,” Hyacine says. “At least a little bit.”

Mydei sighs. He knows that’s true. Even if he doesn’t want to talk to them about it, giving them the music would be enough to let them know. And it’s the *knowing* that he’s scared of, not the conversation. The potential of them looking into his past, his deepest feelings, and thinking of him as weak because of it.

“Fine,” he concedes. “I’ll be right back.”

He goes to his bedroom, lugging out the case filled with his old music from under his bed. He brings it back to the living room, dropping it onto the carpet and sitting before it, legs crossed. “All my old music,” he explains, gesturing to it like it’s some sort of treasure chest. “Help yourselves.”

Cipher pounces on it almost instantly, digging through the case for whatever scores she thinks speak to her. Castorice crawls beside her, equally curious but much more toned down.

“Are you serious?” Hyacine asks. She hasn’t gotten up, but Mydei can tell she wants to. “You’re really trusting us with all of this?”

“Isn’t that what you wanted from me?” Mydei crosses his arms. “I can’t guarantee all of it is worth workshopping. But it’s a start. Right?”

“Mydei, is this a song about golden honeycakes?” Cipher asks, holding up a single sheet of paper. It’s crumpled, tossed to the bottom of the case, but Mydei knows exactly what she’s talking about regardless.

“Yeah,” he closes his eyes. The regret is starting to kick in. “I think I was high.”

“Dude, just get some honeycakes delivered,” Cipher tosses the draft to the side. “You don’t need to write a whole song about it.”

Mydei pulls his knees up to his chest and watches them as they sift through the papers, trying not to let his nerves get the best of him. The honeycakes song was one lighthearted example in an ocean of songs he never intended to see the light of day. The amount of songs in that case about Phainon *alone* is enough to make him hold his breath, knowing the man in question was just down the hall. Even his most generic romance songs, not written with any muse in mind, always circled back to him in the end.

“This one looks interesting,” Hyacine holds up two pieces of paper stapled together. “You rarely write songs this stripped back.”

“Oh, god,” Mydei reaches over to snatch the paper out of her hands, panic ringing in his ears. “Did you look at the lyrics?” He demands, eyes wide.

“Oh, uh, no?” Hyacine shrugs. “I’ve just been looking at the instrumentals to see if anything catches my eye.”

Mydei nods, squeezing his eyes shut. “Good, good,” he breathes. “You weren’t supposed to see that one.”

“Give it to me,” Cipher puts down whichever song she was looking at and reaches one hand out, trying to grab the papers from him.

“*Cipher*—I would actually rather die than let you read this,” Mydei’s voice shakes a little with alarm. “It’s not *personal*, it’s just…”

“Then what’s the problem?” Cipher cocks her head to the side, feigning innocence. She knows damn well what the song is about, and Mydei hates it. “C’mon, we’re all adults here—”

“Sit down,” Castorice urges, tugging at Cipher’s wrist. “There are so many other songs to look at. You don’t have to torment him over one.”

Cipher huffs in annoyance, but gives up for now anyways. Mydei makes a mental note to shred it later, just in case she decides to go through his garbage in her desperation. Because a song like that was not sticking around now that Cipher knew it existed.

Mydei crumbles the draft up, and stuffs it deep into his back pocket. Cipher wasn’t above attempting to pickpocket him, but now she would have to touch his ass to do it. He doesn’t think she wants it that badly, and if she did, that’s just sad.

“How about this?” Hyacine asks, having analyzed another selection during Mydei and Cipher’s bickering. “It’s in the early stages of development, but I think it looks promising.”

Mydei moves over to her, looking over her shoulder at the song she had picked. He vaguely remembers starting this one, and recently, too. It was just a couple days after he had watched Phainon’s performance of Rach 2—he was inspired by the orchestra and decided to try composing a rock song that included an orchestra.

He only got to writing a somewhat simple string part to play before the chorus, and had a little bit of an acoustic guitar part planned, as well. At the

bottom of the second page, he had written “trumpet solo?” as some sort of reminder, even though he never continued it after that.

There were no lyrics, and the base was just simple enough to give them a starting point. It was the perfect selection.

“Yeah,” he says. “Yeah, let’s start with this.”

By the time the sun starts to set, they have almost the entire instrumental part worked out and in the beginning stages of being transferred to the online site Mydei uses for demos. The trumpet solo, which Mydei still thought was a good idea, took some convincing on Cipher’s part, but she acquiesced eventually. Now, all he needs to do is find someone to record it for them, because fake trumpets added in production never sounded good.

They play what they have together before parting ways, Castorice left with the task of starting to add lyrics to it. There’s no specific direction they want to take the song. All they know is that, right now, it sounds good, which, based on their past experiences, was all the IPC really cared about.

Phainon comes out to say goodbye to them, eyeing the mess in the living room as he does. “What’s all this?” he asks, gesturing to the papers strewn across the floor. “I didn’t think your writing process was this horrific, Mydeimos.”

Mydei scoffs at how he speaks about the mess like it’s closer to a murder scene than what it actually is. “Most of that wasn’t my fault,” he answers. “I let them go through my old music. *That* was actually horrifying.”

“You did?” Phainon turns to him, eyes wide. “Can I?”

Mydei holds his gaze for much longer than necessary as the memories of what he’s written about come back to him in an instant. The songs about his grief and trauma were one thing, Phainon probably knew to expect those. The countless songs he had written about Phainon, both when they were

dating and when they weren't, were a whole different beast he wasn't quite ready to tackle. Not even by himself.

"No."

"Aw, I really thought you were going to say yes for a second," Phainon pouts, but it's not enough for Mydei to relent. Nothing would be. "I heard you guys playing," he adds, as Mydei turns his back to him.

"I thought you said you were going to put your headphones on?" Mydei moves to the kitchen, surveying the contents of his fridge as he debates what to make for dinner.

"Couldn't," Phainon says, from behind him. "My hands."

"Oh." Mydei pulls out a few vegetables and closes the fridge. "Next time, I'll help you."

"No need," Phainon takes a seat at one of the barstools before the island, watching Mydei pull out a cutting board. "I liked listening to you. It sounds great so far."

"You know I don't like people listening to my works in progress," Mydei huffs.

"Well, I doubt my headphones would drown out much of anything to begin with." Mydei can feel Phainon's eyes on his back as he washes the vegetables, one by one, in the sink. He tries not to think much of it, but can't help the slight shiver that runs down his spine.

He continues the conversation before he can think for too long. "Are you still in touch with Caelus?"

"Yeah, of course. Why?"

"Could you get him to record something for me? I want an actual trumpet part, so it doesn't sound fake."

“You’re putting *trumpet* in your song?” Phainon sounds like he’s on the verge of laughing, but pulls himself back. “Sorry. Didn’t you say that was your least favorite instrument?”

Mydei shrugs. He might have said something like that in the past, but how Phainon remembers all these years later is beyond him. “It fits the song.”

“I can’t wait for this album,” Phainon says wistfully. Mydei dumps his handful of washed vegetables onto the island, right beside his cutting board. He unsheathes his best knife, one he had gotten shipped directly from Edo Star. “Your last EP—”

“I don’t want to talk about it,” Mydei cuts him off, chopping the stem off an heirloom tomato. “We didn’t write that record, we didn’t even produce it. I want to prove myself with this one.”

“I know you didn’t write it,” Phainon says. “I’m on album of the year. I gave your EP a sixty-eight.”

“A sixty-eight,” Mydei almost laughs, taking a break from cutting up his tomato to look at him. “That’s gotta be one of the highest user reviews it has.”

“The top one was the first to give the IPC that stupid nickname,” Phainon says matter-of-factly. “They didn’t like it. But you’re lucky they took it out on your label, and not you.”

“I guess that’s true.” Mydei resumes his chopping.

“It’s okay, Mydei. Only the best of us write bad albums.”

“I don’t think it’s bad,” Mydei shoves his chopped up tomato to the side, reaching for the next one. “And judging by your score, you didn’t think it was bad, either.”

“No,” Phainon admits. “It just wasn’t *Bleed Gold.*”

“What did you give *Bleed Gold*, then?”

“A ninety,” he responds immediately.

“Hm.” Mydei will accept that, he supposes—*Bleed Gold* wasn’t perfect in his eyes by any means, but he would have liked to think Phainon found it so. “What’s your favorite song?”

“Of yours?”

Mydei nods.

Phainon hangs his head, presumably in thought. Mydei knows it was probably a selfish question to ask, but he couldn’t help his curiosity. He doesn’t know what he expects—perhaps *Don’t Cry*, the only song that’s explicitly about him, but Phainon is too niche to consider Mydei’s most famous song his favorite.

“One you haven’t written yet, I guess,” Phainon murmurs. It took him long enough that Mydei finished chopping up all his vegetables, turning around to dump them in a pan.

“Huh,” Mydei turns up the heat, leaning against the stove to survey him properly. “So you don’t like any of my music, then?”

“You really have to stop twisting my words, Mydeimos,” Phainon scolds, shaking his head. “I didn’t say that. I simply mean that I think your music will only ever get better.”

“Right,” Mydei shakes his head. Phainon’s manipulation truly held no bounds. “I’m sure that’s exactly what you meant.”

“I would never lie to you, Mydei.”

“Oh, you wouldn’t? That’s a new one.” Mydei turns back to the pan, pouring in some vegetable stock he had retrieved from the fridge before covering the pan to let it simmer. “If you don’t have a favorite, do you have a least favorite?”

Phainon makes a noise close to choking. “I do,” he says quietly, once he’s recovered.

“Would you share?”

There’s undeniable pain present in Phainon’s eyes as he looks at Mydei, but he covers it up better than he did when they were students. “*Don’t Cry,*” he finally admits.

Mydei swallows. A whole conversation could pass between them as they just look at each other. But Mydei doesn’t ask the questions on the tip of his tongue, and Phainon doesn’t answer them, even though his feelings are so obvious.

Mydei turns, retrieving a pot from one of his cabinets and moving to the sink to fill it with water. “Understandable,” he finally says, breaking the silence with as lighthearted a tone as he could manage. “It’s too overplayed. I don’t like it anymore.”

“Yeah,” Phainon agrees. “It’s overplayed.”

Mydei knows that’s not why he dislikes it. He might not know what the real reason is, but it’s obviously much deeper than he’s letting on, so Mydei doesn’t pry.

He finishes filling his pot up with water, and carries it to the stove to boil. There’s leftover pesto cream sauce in his fridge, so he microwaves it and sets it aside as he waits for the water to boil.

“Tell me,” he says, when the silence starts to grow too awkward for him. “What have you been up to? Besides playing Rach 2 and accomplishing all your dreams.”

Phainon laughs, but it’s still a little strained. “Not all my dreams,” he says sheepishly. “I graduated, obviously, and then went back to Paperfold the next year for my master’s.”

Mydei knows this. He saw the post he made after he got his master’s: a shot of him walking across the stage, robes weighed down with all his cords. Mydei never thought all the extracurriculars he was in were going to pay off in the end, until he saw that photo.

“Hysilens and I did a lot in between those years. She was still playing with her quartet, but we booked a lot of venues and small gigs playing for more intimate crowds. My Rach 2 performance started getting me followers on social media, so I started posting on there, too.”

Mydei knows this, as well. His following wasn’t something to laugh at—he had enough for brand deals, even though his videos were mostly educational—teaching his audience the most fascinating parts of music theory, as he put it, or little minute long videos of the pieces he was working on. Sometimes he would take requests and cover popular songs. Most of the time he played obscure classical music no one had ever heard of before.

“When I graduated, I was desperate for opportunity, because even though I was making a lot more than I could ever have expected, my income was not enough to maintain rent at my apartment in Okhema. I ended up signing with the orchestra I played Rach 2 with as an official member.”

This, Mydei didn’t know. He had never heard of the orchestra when he watched the performance, but he had seen little of Phainon’s performances over the last couple months.

“I never liked them, or the conductor, very much,” Phainon admits. “But they promised opportunity, and even though I was with them for a short time, they did bring me it. We performed a lot in Adlivun, and the pay was good enough for me to stick with it, even though there was no one I clicked with—seriously, Mydei, they were *all* insufferable. And then I found out how much they got funded in Adlivun, and how underpaid I was compared to literally *everyone* else, so I left. I think they replaced me in a week with some guy named Zephyro. Weird names they have over there.”

“How recently did you leave?” Mydei asks. He sprinkles some salt into the steaming water.

“Just last month,” Phainon answers. “I didn’t know if I wanted to leave, at first. They gave me enough money to live on, and I was fine with that, until Cyrene told me I didn’t deserve to be treated like that. I listened to her because of how much I didn’t like them.”

“How bad were they?” Mydei knows it takes a lot for Phainon to truly dislike someone. Once he does, there’s almost no changing his mind, but this hatred does not come easily to him.

“Cartoonishly evil,” Phainon says. “It was a weird group, Mydei. I can’t even believe they actually liked any of the music they played in the first place. But I’m free now, and I can’t even play to begin with, so it doesn’t matter anymore.”

Mydei dumps in the remnants of a box of pasta without measuring, hoping it’s enough for both him and Phainon’s big appetites. As he covers the pot, he can’t quite pull his thoughts away from the obvious: Phainon can’t play anymore. And even if the way he mentions it is casual, he knows this can’t be anything less than heartbreaking for him.

“You will heal,” Mydei turns around, making sure Phainon is looking at him as he says it. “And you *will* play again.”

Mydei can see Phainon’s jaw tense as he bites down on his tongue. He and Mydei were similar in few ways, but they were always one and the same when it came to the way they handled their grief. Phainon always pushed it to the side and pretended it didn’t exist. Not that the events didn’t happen, but that they didn’t hurt him as deeply as they did. It infuriated Mydei to no end, and he wonders only now if this is how Phainon felt about him, too.

“Thank you,” Phainon looks away. “But I know that, Mydei.”

He’s lying. Normally, Mydei might call him out on it. Today, he cuts him some slack.

Mydei takes the top off his pot as it starts to boil over, stirring through the noodles until the water calms down. He tastes one, and deciding they’re ready, pours them into a strainer over the sink.

Phainon doesn’t say anything as he finishes preparing the dinner. He carefully drains the broth from the vegetables, too, then adds the noodles to the pan and mixes in the sauce he had just heated up.

Mydei halves it, preparing two plates. He's not used to cooking for two people, and even though it looks like too much food, he thinks the portions are more likely to be too little than too much.

He gives Phainon his with a spoon, before sliding his own across the island to the seat next to Phainon's. "This looks incredible, Mydei," Phainon says, carefully balancing his spoon between his thumb and pointer finger.

"Really? I think it looks like shit," Mydei grumbles, retrieving two glasses from one of his cabinets. "I haven't gone grocery shopping in a bit. This probably won't even taste good."

"Stop being modest. Everything you make tastes good."

"You knew my cooking in *college*, Phainon." He fills them up with filter water, then gets a straw to place into Phainon's cup.

"Exactly. So you can only have improved, then."

"Believe what you will," Mydei says, passing Phainon his water, and then finally taking his seat beside him.

"Mmh," Phainon mumbles, trying to talk with his mouth full. "I was right." He swallows his food, then leans over to drink some water.

Mydei shakes his head, trying the food himself. It's nothing special, but it's far from his best work. "I wanted to ask," he starts, swallowing. "How much do you know about Cipher and Aglaea's relationship?"

Phainon sighs. "Not very much," he admits. "Neither of them like to talk about it. All I know is that Cipher doesn't really talk to her anymore, not for no reason, but the reason they haven't spoken for so long is because both of them are too stubborn to reach out first."

"I see," Mydei looks down at his food, swirling it around with his fork. For the brief two weeks he had known Aglaea, he always felt like she disdained him, somehow. Cipher reassured him that that was just the way she was, but he couldn't shake the feeling that she disapproved of the music they were

making to her very core. “Cipher doesn’t really talk to us about anything. I thought maybe things would be different with you.”

“If anyone actually knows her thoughts on the matter, it’s Cas,” Phainon says. “They’re best friends. Of course, that doesn’t guarantee anything. Cipher’s like a slimy fish.”

“I think she’d kill you if she heard you say that.”

“Good thing you’re not going to snitch on me. Right?”

“Don’t push your luck,” Mydei says. He turns back to his food.

“Your life, then,” Phainon presses. “I want to know what happened when you went back to Castrum Kremnos. You did, right? Go home?”

Mydei nods. He feels as though he’s lost his appetite for a moment, and puts his fork down. He doesn’t like talking about this. His mother. His grief. The way he had spiraled. He’s brought back to Hephaestion’s words time and time again, about how crying doesn’t suit a man like him. Grief doesn’t, either.

“It was hard,” he admits. Saying it without looking at Phainon makes it easier. Like he doesn’t have to face his pity. “I had the house to myself and too much money than I knew what to do with. I spent a month doing nothing. I didn’t leave. I ordered food to be delivered whenever I got hungry, which wasn’t often. I lost so much weight, it was humiliating.”

Mydei’s breath hitches when he feels Phainon’s injured hand press lightly against his back. He settles right over the middle of his spine, over the vertebrae that always aches under his touch. “Eventually, Krateros came by. He told me I needed to get off my ass and do something, so I got a job at a bakery. Slowly, I started going to the gym again. I reconnected with my old Kremnoan friends, and they knew my mother, so they had heard. But comfort was the last thing they offered, and honestly, the last thing I wanted.”

Phainon's hand stays still on his back, grounding him. Mydei knows it must hurt him to lift his arm in such a way. Selfishly, though, he wants him to stay. "When Cipher and Castorice graduated, they reached out to me and I traveled to Okhema for two weeks, staying at Aglaea's place with both of them. We recorded our first EP together, and released it without much thought. I went back home, and we had our record deal by the end of the summer. Moving to Penacony, and working with the two of them, and eventually Hyacine…" Mydei trails off, shaking his head. He doesn't know how to articulate the sheer magnitude of his gratitude. Even if he didn't like the music they were making then, it healed him anyway. He's not sure how he would ever be able to repay them for something like that.

Phainon exhales sharply through his nose. Neither of them eat, letting the silence settle between them instead. "I'm really happy for you, Mydei," Phainon finally says. "I'm happy you're happy now."

Mydei can't think of a better word to describe the way he feels about how his life has ended up in this moment, but something else still lingers under the surface. A hole in his heart that he had never quite been able to fill. It had been there since he left Phainon, but even now, with Phainon right by his side, the emptiness stays.

Phainon is already awake when Mydei gets up the next morning. He sits in the living room, staring at the TV like he's not actually watching whatever random channel he had turned it to. It's set to a low enough volume that Mydei couldn't hear it in his room, captions flying across the bottom of the screen instead.

"Good morning," Mydei says from the doorway. Phainon flinches out of his thoughts, eyes wide as he turns to look at Mydei. His gaze lingers on Mydei's torso for a beat too long, before flicking back up to his face. "How did you sleep?"

"Fine," he says.

He’s lying. Mydei sighs and heads into the kitchen. “Do you want coffee?”

“Yes, please,” Phainon replies. Mydei can hear him struggle to get to his feet, then limp back over to the kitchen. “I tried to make some myself, but couldn’t figure out how your coffee machine worked.”

“It was out of coffee, dumbass,” Mydei laughs, pouring more beans into the top compartment. “Black?”

“Yes. Thank you.”

Mydei resists the urge to roll his eyes, and makes his coffee for him.

“You have more tattoos,” Phainon blurts, when Mydei hands him a mug of steaming black coffee. “When did you get them done?”

“A little over two years ago,” Mydei answers. He busies himself with his own coffee, trying to hide his growing embarrassment with his careless decision to not put a shirt on before he left his room.

Phainon hums. Mydei can feel his staring as he pours coffee creamer into his mug, and puts it back in the fridge. As soon as he turns around, Phainon’s eyes dart away, and he hides behind his coffee cup.

“You want breakfast?”

Phainon shakes his head. “I’m not hungry.”

Mydei knows that’s a lie, so he makes enough breakfast for two people, and pretends not to act surprised when Phainon inevitably steals his share.

He has to drive him to physical therapy at noon, so Phainon goes to take a shower first. Mydei helps him out of his splints and sling. His hands are red and swollen underneath and he tries not to wince when he sees it.

Phainon goes impossibly stiff underneath the shower water, as Mydei forces shampoo through his hair because his hands are too weak to do it himself. They don’t say a word. Phainon tries to get out of it multiple times, and insists he can do the rest alone, effectively kicking Mydei out.

Mydei stands outside the bathroom door for a couple seconds, listening to the running water. He knows why Phainon refuses his help, but that doesn't mean he likes that he does.

He shakes his head, and leaves to get ready himself.

Ten minutes later, he's knocking on the bathroom door. Phainon lets him in, though not without an obvious amount of frustration. Mydei helps him get dressed as Phainon once again grows stiff and eerily silent beneath his touch.

"You don't have to—" Phainon tries, once he's fully clothed and Mydei starts working on putting his splints back on again. "You don't—"

"Yes, I do," Mydei interrupts, fastening his left splint and putting his arm back through the sling. "There's no one else here, is there?"

"I'm sorry," Phainon whispers. "I was high off my ass when I mentioned you. If I was thinking even a little bit straight I wouldn't have—"

"I'm glad you did," Mydei says, finishing fastening the straps on his right splint. "Let's go now. Alright?"

Phainon nods, and doesn't push it. Mydei helps him into his shoes, then puts his own on, grabs his keys, and they head out of the apartment. Phainon is still limping a little, but won't let Mydei touch him when he tries.

The drive there is silent, until they arrive and Phainon tells Mydei he can do the rest himself. So he drops him off, and Mydei drives to the grocery store instead.

His usual grocery store of choice is an organic private-label one which he's found he is very rarely approached in, but it's too much of a drive from the physical therapy office, so he settles for one closer.

The fame he had gotten after the Robin collab was not enough to stop him from being able to live his life, but getting recognized in public was much

more common now than it had ever been for him. Still, he does his grocery shopping mostly in peace, turning up the volume on his headphones and ignoring the obvious stares of other patrons.

Mydei arrives at the physical therapist five minutes early, and gets out of his car as he sees Phainon approach the front door. He opens the car door for him, and Phainon gets in wordlessly.

“How was it?” Mydei asks, after he climbs back into the driver’s side and shifts the gear out of park. “Any progress?”

Phainon shakes his head. He leans his head against the window, face gaunt as he stares at the road as they pull out of the parking lot. “It was fine,” he mumbles, a stark contrast from what his expression implies.

“Alright,” Mydei answers. He lets them sit in silence for the rest of the ride back.

Mydei carries the groceries up to his apartment, even after Phainon offers to help. He retreats into his room as soon as they get back, so Mydei is left putting his groceries away in silence.

The band comes over shortly after, though not for as long as they had the day before. Hyacine asks how physical therapy went, likely just as invested in Phainon’s health as Mydei was due to her medical background. Mydei doesn’t let her see him when she asks, thinking the last thing he probably wanted right now was to talk about something that was very obviously bothering him—and to someone he barely knew, no less.

Hyacine doesn’t seem to mind this decision, so they gather in the living room and get straight to work. Castorice presents the lyrics she had written the night before, and they start rehearsing it with lyrics this time. They spend much longer than Mydei would have expected working on backing vocals. Mydei had layered his vocals in the past to create a harmonizing effect, but decides this time that he wants the others to do them instead, so there are different voices present.

What he finds is that none of them are terrible singers by any means, and they all have very unique voices. Cipher has the deepest range, probably an alto or even a tenor if she tried. Her voice is the roughest, the most stereotypically “built” for rock besides Mydei. Castorice’s is similar to Jingliu’s, which doesn’t surprise him much in retrospect given how much of a High Cloud Quintet fan she was as a teenager. She has the most versatile range and the richest tone. Hyacine’s is the highest and breathiest. It’s clear she has the least practice with singing in the past, and Mydei thinks her voice could be a very interesting touch if she worked on her chest voice instead.

After he spends too much time giving singing lessons, Cipher brings forward a song she and Castorice wrote together a couple months ago. Mydei’s not sure what he’s expecting, but it’s not this: a song they called *Cat Food* about the Amphorean economy (or, at least, that’s how Mydei interprets it) coated in a heavy layer of sarcasm.

“It was mostly a joke,” Cipher explains. Mostly. Mydei, as he’s grown so used to, doesn’t press. “We thought the instrumentals could be a joke, too.”

“You want to write a bad song,” Mydei deadpans.

“No, we want to write a funny song.”

And that’s where they leave him, four pages of extremely messy sheet music in Mydei’s hands with the singular mission of writing some sort of piano part that Cipher would deem “funny”.

It’s not until he checks his phone after they’re gone, fully intending to find a recipe for dinner tonight, that he sees it: pictures of him from earlier in the day, going viral on social media.

He’s been spotted by paparazzi in public without his knowledge before, only to come across the candid photos later on, but they’re never quite this talked about online. Because if it were just him grocery shopping, there wouldn’t be much to say. But instead they got pictures of him outside of his car, holding the passenger side open while Phainon climbs in, of both him

and Phainon inside the car. He can feel the tension he felt earlier return tenfold through his screen.

He swallows as he scrolls through his feed, holding his breath for anything too bad. It's not like Phainon wasn't known in the public eye, either—there are people who know him, who approach him in public. He's not the kind of celebrity that needs to worry about paparazzi, but he exists online. He's not a secret.

While Mydei has talked about their past relationship before, but never in depth. As far as their respective fan bases are aware, they have very little knowledge about the other besides the fact that they exist. It's not exactly bad that they were seen together, it just leaves Mydei with more questions to answer than he wants to.

He gets caught off guard when he sees his first post by a fan and not a paparazzi account: "i'm starting a rumor", it reads, though Mydei isn't entirely sure what that means. He thinks it reads like the account knew of both of them somehow, which he thinks is a rare crossover. He opens the comments to try to get some sort of an explanation, and doesn't find anything helpful.

The post underneath that is a fan of Phainon's, writing a heartfelt message about how they were happy to see Phainon was okay. The crash had become public knowledge in the last couple of weeks, though any confirmation about injuries or how he was doing hadn't been released. Mydei smiles at the sight of someone who clearly cares a lot about Phainon, and scrolls past it. The next post is one which very obviously implies that they believe he and Phainon would make an attractive couple.

He exits social media immediately after this revelation, vowing not to open it again until this mess finally subsided as he returns to his recipes.

Phainon doesn't say he minded being spotted together, and having the whole world know that they reconnected—whatever the nature of that may

be—but the next time Mydei picks him up from physical therapy, he gives the parking lot a thorough scan before getting into Mydei's car.

August flies by, between band rehearsal and being Phainon's personal chauffeur. He rarely asks to leave outside of doctor visits, but they catch an orchestra performance of Dvorak's ninth symphony when Mydei sees a flyer about it. It's one of the most famous symphonies in the world, as far as Mydei is aware, and he finds himself dragging Phainon with him when he refuses to go. He desperately needs to get out more.

Phainon ultimately ends up enjoying it more than Mydei did, but seeing him happy for the first time since he'd arrived was enough to put a smile on his face, too.

The band focuses on the two songs they have for a while. Mydei, with Phainon's help, gets Caelus to send a recording of him playing the trumpet part Mydei had written, and they finish their first song of the new album, titled *City of Thieves.*

Cat Food takes slightly longer, even after all the hours Mydei pours into writing a suitable piano part for it. Phainon ended up being a lot of help in the end, once Mydei worked up the courage to ask him. Together, they wrote a part that was inspired by jazz, though it was much more random and much less relaxed than the jazz Mydei listened to. He added an acoustic guitar part as well, and they decided the rest of it could be done in the studio.

Their first meeting after finishing *Cat Food*, Castorice explains to Hyacine what she had told Mydei almost a year ago now.

"I'm telling you this because I wrote a song about it," she finishes. The room had been silent the whole time. Even Cipher listened intently, and didn't interrupt to say anything stupid. "I don't just want you to make up ideas for what you think I wrote it about. I want you to know the truth."

"Cassie," Hyacine starts. She reaches out to grab one of her hands, and Castorice doesn't pull back. Through Cipher's help or not, she had gotten

better at accepting touch from other people recently. “You didn’t kill your sister, Cassie.”

“How can you say that?” Castorice whispers. “It was me. I got her sick, I know I did, because I realized I was sick afterwards. It must have been me.”

“Hospitals are careful about these things,” Hyacine explains gently. “If your sister was extremely immunocompromised, they wouldn’t have let a child attending school visit her without taking all the necessary precautions beforehand. Do you realize how many germs and sick children you’re exposed to every day in an elementary school?”

“That’s what…my mother tried to tell me, too.”

“I think you should have listened to her,” Hyacine shakes her head, moving closer to her on the couch. “Instead of carrying all this guilt with you for so many years.”

“Sorry,” Castorice mumbles. “I know you’re right.”

“Come here,” Hyacine says, pulling Castorice close to her chest. “This better be a good song, if you had to suffer for it for so many years.”

Castorice giggles, turning her face into Hyacine’s neck. “Thank you, Hyacine.”

Mydei glances at Cipher, who is staring at them with the most serious expression Mydei has ever seen on her face. She catches him staring, and it’s gone in an instant.

Mydei’s first read of the song she had titled *Fever* has him thinking about Hephaestion for the first time in years. Castorice has a way of writing in which her words tend to be very flowery, roundabout ways of getting her point across instead of saying her feelings outright. This, however, is the most honest song Mydei has ever seen her write.

Hephaestion died of an illness he never told Mydei about, one he never found out about until Hephaestion was breathing his last. He pleaded for

forgiveness and then asked Mydei not to cry for him, an impossible request.

Castorice knew exactly what Polyxia was going through. Mydei never did. Castorice spent years finding reasons to pin Polyxia's death on, before eventually deciding that it must have been her. Mydei spent years in a state of confusion as to how he never realized something was wrong.

"This is beautiful, Cas," he says, turning back to the first page and handing it off to Hyacine.

"You think so?" Castorice asks. "You like the music I wrote, too? It was my first time doing something like that, I didn't really know what I was doing…"

"It's good," he nods. "We'll look at it together. I don't think we'd have to change much, though." It was already clear that Castorice had spent years alone on this song, ever since they wrote their first EP and Mydei taught them basic music theory and how to read treble clef.

After *Fever* is finished, they spend the first few weeks of September going through Mydei's old music again. They experiment with some songs that never really go anywhere, before Cipher pulls one out that he had almost forgotten about. It's not the oldest one in the box, but it's far from the newest—he had likely written it in college, when he had first come to Penacony.

"It's about Kremnos," he explains, when Cipher asks. "Kind of, anyway."

The song was his first attempt at satire, something he eventually realized he wasn't very good at, which led to him ultimately scrapping it. People in Penacony had a fixed view of Kremnoans, one that wasn't very educated outside of ancient Amphorean myths no one really followed anymore. Their view of Okhemans was already misguided, but they still thought of Kremnoans as war-mongering brutes, even though Kremnos hadn't been at war in centuries, and Penacony had.

He thought it was amusing, if not overwhelmingly frustrating, that people overseas still thought of them in this way. That was why he started the song.

He explains this to them now, and Cipher nods like she knows exactly what he's talking about. This reaction is, somehow, a little relieving when she reminds him that sarcasm is one of her strong suits. She gets her hands on the lyrics and somehow manages to rewrite them exactly how Mydei wanted when he first started this song.

So they finish it together, titled *Berserker*. It takes a little over a week. The night they call it done, Mydei forces Phainon into a celebratory movie night after finishing four whole songs. He had to do a lot of forcing on him recently. Phainon spent most of his time in his room, coming out only for meals. Seeing him in such a state is the last thing Mydei wants, and he's starting to wonder how long he can keep pretending to buy his excuses.

Just like old times, they argue over *Gnaeus* and *Flame Reaver of the Deepest Dark,* and eventually decide on both. This time, though, they start with *Flame Reaver,* and Phainon has fallen asleep on Mydei's shoulder halfway through *Gnaeus.*

He mutes it as soon as he notices, turning the captions on so he can keep watching. Phainon hasn't been getting very much sleep lately—that much is as glaringly obvious as the rest of the problems he pretends doesn't exist, but just as with those, Mydei doesn't bring it up. He's not sure if this development is a result of his pain or insomnia, or both, but having him soundly asleep is not an opportunity Mydei is going to pass up on.

It's here, with Phainon asleep on his shoulder, trying his hardest to remain as still as possible, that he gets an idea. A drill sergeant is yelling at his soldiers, barking questions that they respond to with a repetitive and deeply annoying holler of "aye, sir". Mydei can practically hear them clear as day from how many times he's watched this movie, even though the screen is muted, and he can imagine those lines perfectly as if they were included in *Berserker.*

He reaches for his phone as carefully as possible, and immediately texts the idea to the band's group chat. Cipher is the only one still awake, and she gives him some stupid response about how she "doesn't know anything about that nerd movie". Mydei shakes his head, turns his phone off, and makes a mental note to include the excerpts during production anyway.

The band takes a short break from meeting every weekday near the end of September, forcing Phainon to spend more time with Mydei than he might have liked. Mydei sits down at the piano Friday morning, recovering an old piece he used to love in an attempt to lure Phainon out of his room. He clearly harbors some disdain for the instrument, but would still never pass up an opportunity to watch him play.

Sure enough, he can hear his footsteps coming down the hallway until he reaches the living room and makes himself comfortable on the couch. His hip is almost completely healed, no longer needing to limp. He doesn't need the sling anymore, even though his collarbone still faces some issues. His hands were by far the worst injury, though today they are in lighter splints than they were a month ago.

Mydei plays through the rest of the song, pretending that Phainon's presence wasn't the whole reason he started to play it in the first place. Phainon pats his thigh lightly with one of his hands, in lieu of applause as he finishes. "*Fantaisie Impromptu*," Phainon comments. "Good job. Show off." He smiles as he says it, but some bitterness is there anyway.

Mydei spins in his seat until he's facing Phainon directly. "You finally decide to keep me company," he tries to keep it equally lighthearted, but much like Phainon, is unable to keep the bitterness out of his voice. "I finally have a roommate, and then I never see you. I'm getting lonely, Phainon."

"*Lonely,*" Phainon scoffs. "His Highness Mydeimos Nikador of Castrum Kremnos, *lonely.* Whatever is he going to do?"

"Just as I kept my promise and never called you Deliverer, you vowed never to call me *that.*"

“That,” Phainon rolls his eyes, “is your real title, Mydeimos. The Deliverer is just some stupid roleplay.”

“My real title. So I’m a prince now.”

“Cipher calls you prince.”

“Cipher is an asshole,” Mydei stands up, getting even closer to him until he sits on the edge of the coffee table, and Phainon can’t run away. “Tell me why you’re avoiding me.”

Expectedly, Phainon doesn’t look at him as he answers. “I’m not avoiding you.”

Mydei bites down his debilitating irritation, taking a moment before he responds so he has time to calm himself. “When will you finally stop lying to me?”

This time, Phainon looks at him. “I’m not lying to you.”

“Stop it, Phainon,” Mydei snaps. “You know I can see right through you.”

Phainon’s jaw tenses. He exhales, frustrated, and turns away, attention stolen by Kokopo III as she runs down the hall and leaps into his lap. She had grown fond of him during his stay. Probably because he was less likely to get up than Mydei was. He places one of his scarred, broken hands on top of her back and Mydei’s own frustration almost dissipates as he sees the beginnings of tears in Phainon’s eyes.

“I have tried to be so attentive to you, Phainon,” Mydei continues. “I gave you time. I guess I thought that one day you’d finally be honest with me on your own, but I’m losing my patience. It’s a miracle I’ve kept it for this long.”

“I can’t—” Phainon starts, then shakes his head. “I can’t just—I’m not like you, Mydei. I don’t want you to think I’m weak.”

“Are you serious?” Mydei leans forward. “*Weak?* Phainon.”

“I know,” Phainon hangs his head. “I know, Mydei. Please don’t start.”

Mydei isn’t sure what he’s talking about, so he continues anyway. “You’re a lot of things, Phainon. Most of them infuriating, but I have…” he shakes his head in disbelief. “I would…never in my *life* consider you *weak.*”

Phainon doesn’t say anything to that. Mydei can see his chin quiver, his hand on Kokopo III’s back tense a little bit.

“Do you think I would judge you for reacting to an injury like this?” Mydei continues. “Phainon. Do you think I would like it if I had my tongue cut out, and I couldn’t sing anymore?”

“I don’t know!”

“You *don’t know?*”

“*Obviously,* yes,” Phainon bursts, distressed. “But that would never happen to you, would it? And *this* happened to *me*.”

“And I am trying to tell you that you have every right to react to that how you have been. But I don’t like being useless, Phainon. I’m supposed to be here to help you.”

“Do you really want me to be honest, Mydei?” Phainon finally turns his head to look at him, eyes alight with determination, or something else.

“Of course,” Mydei says, leaning back a little bit. He doesn’t show the raw excitement he feels. How that was everything he ever really wanted from Phainon.

“I think I’ve been enough of a burden on you,” Phainon’s voice is harsh, despite his words. “I live here, I don’t pay rent, I don’t pull my weight in housework. I don’t leave. I make you drive me to PT, to the doctor. I don’t think you need all my emotional baggage on top of everything I’m already making you deal with.”

“*Phainon,*” Mydei exhales, exasperated. “I’m happy you’re here,” he admits. “Even if you avoid me, and don’t come out for dinner until you

think I’m asleep. Even if you don’t tell me anything, and think pretending everything is fine is enough to fool me. I’m just happy I get to be your friend again.”

Phainon blinks rapidly, then lowers his steely gaze to set on Kokopo III. “My friend,” he mutters. “You want to be my *friend*.”

“Why wouldn’t I?” Mydei asks. “You might think yourself a bad roommate, but I don’t mind all those things, because it’s you, Phainon.”

“Mydei,” Phainon murmurs. “Please.”

“No,” Mydei continues. If Phainon isn’t going to burden Mydei with his emotional baggage by himself, then Mydei will just have to force it out of him. “I know that you spoke to my father.”

Surprisingly, Phainon doesn’t jump away from this accusation. “Not your father,” He says, voice growing even more bitter at the mention of him. “One of his sales representatives.”

“And what did they want from you?”

“A sponsorship.” The tears are gone from Phainon’s eyes. He glares daggers into Kokopo III’s head, gaze near murderous. “An advertisement. Five hundred grand.”

“*Five hundred grand.*”

“And half the revenue made from the ad.”

“Are you—”

“And then he offered to up it to seven hundred.”

Mydei feels like his head is about to explode. “Are you fucking serious?”

“I didn’t take it, Mydei.”

“*Why not?!*” Kokopo III scatters, claws scratching at the floor as she runs out the room. Phainon doesn’t seem to mind, though, meeting Mydei in kind.

“Because I *hate* your father, Mydei!” He bursts. “I fucking *abhor* that man like nothing else—”

“And yet you have *no reason* to!” Mydei shoots back. “A deal like that could have gotten you—”

“Yeah,” Phainon spits. “I know what it would have gotten me. And you know what the best part of all of this is?” He sits up in his seat, glaring not quite at Mydei but at the space between them. “I wouldn’t have crashed that *goddamn* car if I hadn’t been so *goddamn* angry.”

He gets up, storming down the hall and back into his room before Mydei can so much as call out for him, blinded by shock.

One thing Mydei knows for sure is that he doesn’t hate his father. Perhaps in the past, he had. When he was a child, maybe—when hatred was an easier emotion to feel towards someone than something this complicated. But the older he got, the more he understood just how complicated it actually was.

Phainon still finds hatred easier than facing his true emotions. Perhaps his hatred for Mydei’s father was a guise for something much deeper than he was ready to face. Whatever that might be, Mydei wouldn’t know.

But he does know one thing: if it was Eurypon who led to Phainon crashing his car, however indirect his involvement might have been, for that, Mydei *hates* him.

He’s pulled from his daze by his phone ringing. He stands, fishing it out from his back pocket, met with Aventurine’s contact name. Without thinking about why he might be calling, he picks up.

“Hello?”

“*Hi, Mydei, how are you? Are you busy right now?*”

Mydei’s brain lingers on how he should go about answering the first question before he processes the second, and realizes that he can ignore it altogether. “No,” he says, even though he feels like he’s lying.

“*That’s great! Is the album going well?*”

“Very, thank you. Is there anything you need?”

There’s a bit of commotion on Aventurine’s end of the line, before he answers. “*How soon can you be at the office? I’m sorry this is so last minute.*”

“Um—about ten minutes, probably. Why?” He doesn’t feel like he should leave right now, not after an argument, not after learning what he’s just learned. He would say he was busy were it any man other than the one who gave him his career.

“*We have a company representative here to talk about future sponsorship opportunities,*” Aventurine says. “*It’s a piano manufacturer. I think it would be a great deal, after you recently came out playing piano for the Robin collab.*”

“Aventurine,” Mydei says, voice rising in panic. “What company?”

“*Kremnos Pianos. I’m sure you’re familiar, given your background.*”

“Aventurine,” Mydei’s voice is the closest to pleading he’d even let it get without embarrassing himself. “Please deny it.”

“*Deny it?*” Mydei can hear the disbelief through the line. “*This would be a fantastic opportunity, Mydei. I can’t do that so easily.*”

Mydei’s grip on his phone is so tight he can feel it shaking, unsure of how to respond in a way that maintains professionalism. What are the odds that this happens *now?*

“*Will you come then, Mydei? We can talk about this in person.*”

Mydei moves the phone away from his ear to take a deep breath. “Okay,” he says back into the receiver, though his voice still shakes a little bit. “I’ll be there soon.”

Mydei does not crash his car on the drive to the IPC office, though it’s a near thing. He parks in his usual spot, which is surprisingly empty this late into the day, scans his badge to enter through the back door, and makes his way to the elevator. Aventurine’s office is on the seventh floor, and by the time Mydei stands outside his door his heart is throbbing so hard he can feel it through his whole body.

He knocks. Aventurine calls for him to enter, and when he does, he can practically feel his heart fall through the floor.

“Mydeimos!” The man standing in front of Aventurine’s desk lights up at the sight of him, and Mydei recoils like he’s been shot. “My boy.”

It’s Eurypon Nikador, in the flesh. To think he actually flew all the way to Penacony for this makes Mydei’s stomach twist.

Age has done him no favors. When Mydei was a kid, his looks and all the ways they differed from his mother’s led him to believe that he must have simply looked a lot more like his father. He knows that’s not entirely true now, but can only hope he doesn’t age the way Eurypon has.

“Father,” Mydei glowers. Eurypon tries to pat him on the shoulder, and he steps away, forcing him to drop his hand awkwardly.

“Ah,” Aventurine says from his desk, just as awkwardly. “It seems he needs no introduction. I did think there was a little bit of a resemblance.”

Mydei wants to throw up. That’s the worst thing he’s ever heard.

“Long time no see, Mydeimos. I’m glad to see you’ve grown into a real man. You look a far cry from the frail little kid you used to be.”

Mydei swallows. He doesn't pull his eyes away from him, ensuring Eurypon knows the depth of his distaste.

Aventurine clears his throat. "Let's talk business, shall we, gentlemen?"

"I want nothing from him." Mydei says this more to Aventurine, though his eyes stay glued on Eurypon. "I don't care how much it is. I doubt he even has the money upfront, given that he's here now."

Mydei expects anger from Eurypon at this, and is even prepared to dodge whatever punches he might throw at him. To his surprise, though, he gets none of that. "You are not incorrect, Mydeimos. Sales have been dropping recently. A famous piano maestro publicly denounced my company a few months back…Strife knows why."

"Praying to Strife won't give you a more peaceful death than you deserve," Mydei sneers. "Why don't you go back to stealing money like you did ten years ago?"

"Didn't Gorgo ever teach you not to speak to your elders that way?" Eurypon answers. "Now that I'm your legal guardian, maybe it's time we revisit some basic manners."

Mydei steps closer to him so they're eye-to-eye. He takes some pride in the fact that today, he has grown to be a couple inches taller than him. "How dare you talk about her?" he starts. "The last thing she ever would have wanted is for anything of hers to fall into *your* hands. She hated you until the day she died."

"You know that's not true, Mydeimos."

Aventurine clears his throat again, and Mydei bites the inside of his cheek before he chooses to ignore Aventurine and respond to Eurypon anyway. "*Business*, gentlemen," he reminds them. "Mydei, Mr. Nikador requested that you feature in an advertisement and play only Kremnos pianos until your partnership ends. As a result, you would receive a 15% cut of all revenue Kremnos Pianos receives for the rest of the partnership, and a 50%

cut of all revenue made directly from the advertisement you are featured in.”

Mydei clenches his jaw. He’s hardly listening to Aventurine as he speaks, just barely processing the amount of money he would probably make by accepting this. He knows it’s a lot. Of course it is—Eurypon needs it to be convincing.

“We think this would be extremely beneficial in promoting your new album to a wider audience. Fans of classical music would be introduced to you and invested because of your background in it. And your endorsement of Eurypon’s company would help Kremnos Pianos sales increase greatly, which only means you would be making even more money from the deal.”

Mydei stares at him. “I can’t accept this, Aventurine,” he says. “I don’t care about the benefits. I just can’t.”

To his surprise, Aventurine actually nods. He moves to say something else, too, but Eurypon beats him to it.

“Refusing this deal, Mydeimos…” he starts, shaking his head. “Would be… *unwise*.”

“Are you threatening me, Father?” Mydei demands. “Is that what you did to Phainon, too? Because I know he would never have said yes.”

Eurypon raises an eyebrow. “So you know him.”

“Phainon *hates* you,” Mydei continues. “You might not remember that night, but *I* do. *All of us* do.”

“I was trying to protect you.”

“You were trying to protect *yourself!*” Mydei bursts, incredulous. That was the best explanation Gorgo could ever come up with as to how her husband, who she had once loved deeply, had lost himself so greatly. *He was a prideful man. Your talent challenged that, Mydeimos.* He liked to remember those words before every performance. Let it challenge him.

Eurypon takes a deep breath, before turning all the way to face Mydei. Aventurine tries to cut in again, but neither of them are listening to him anymore.

“Is that why you keep Mr. Khaslana around? To protect you?”

“I don’t need anyone to protect me,” Mydei sneers. Even the idea of it is enough to make him squirm. “Least of all you.”

“You think just because you’re tall and fit, you’re any more of a man than you were fifteen years ago?” Eurypon demands. “I still remember the way you cried when I took you hunting, Mydeimos. Your heart is soft, no matter how hard you try to hide it.”

Mydei bites his tongue so hard he tastes blood. He clenches his hands into tight fists, resisting the urge to lash out. The ringing in his ears is so loud he can barely hear his surroundings anymore.

“You want to hit me.” Eurypon urges, leaning in even closer. Mydei can smell cigarettes and alcohol on him. He didn’t even have the decency to show up here sober. “Do it, Mydeimos. Hurt me, I dare you. Prove me wrong.”

Mydei swallows. He digs his nails into his palms and calms his breathing, until he’s at a place where he no longer thinks he would genuinely give in to Eurypon’s relentless instigation.

Mydei doesn’t notice that Aventurine has stood up until he’s between them. “I have to ask you to leave, Mr. Nikador,” he’s saying. “I can escort you out, if you would like.”

“This isn’t over,” Eurypon shouts at Mydei, over Aventurine’s shoulder. Mydei doesn’t say anything. He watches Aventurine lead him to the door, and then he’s alone.

Mydei takes a deep breath, running a hand through his hair. He sits down in one of the chairs before Aventurine’s desk, trying to calm down. He needs

to apologize. He hadn’t been that close to losing his cool since he was a hormonal teenager who hated the world.

Aventurine comes back in soon, sitting at his desk. He doesn’t say anything for a bit, until Mydei lifts his head to look at him. “I’m sorry,” Mydei starts. “You shouldn’t have seen that.”

“No, I’m sorry,” Aventurine smiles apologetically. “I shouldn’t have made you speak to him when you clearly didn’t want to.”

“I didn’t think it would be *him*,” Mydei explains. “He’s too lazy to actually do things himself.”

“Regardless, some of the things he said were horrible,” Aventurine offers. “I couldn’t stand for that. He has no place here.”

“No,” Mydei says. “Thank you.”

“If you want to talk about it—”

“I don’t,” Mydei says immediately. “I’ll be fine.”

Aventurine nods. “Well, then, there was one more quick thing I wanted to mention.” He opens his laptop, navigating somewhere before turning the screen around to show the paparazzi photos of him and Phainon. “Phainon Khaslana,” he starts. “These photos were taken a while ago, but when you mentioned him, I remembered.”

“Yes,” Mydei says. “He was in the area and got in a car crash a few months ago. He’s staying at my place now, and I’m helping him recover from his injuries.”

Aventurine nods again, turning the screen back towards him. “That’s all fine, I just thought I’d let you know that these images have caused some dating rumors to circulate online.”

Mydei swallows. “I know,” he starts. “I don’t really care. They can think what they want.”

“Very well,” Aventurine says. “Then you’re free to go, Mydei.”

Mydei nods. “Thank you.” He gets up from his seat, making his way over to the door before Aventurine stops him abruptly.

“Just to clarify,” he says, and Mydei turns to face him. “Your father. If he really does try something like this again—”

“I don’t want to see him ever again.”

“Then you won’t.”

Mydei thanks him again, and leaves. He drives back to his apartment in silence. There’s already a new bass riff at the back of his mind that he can’t wait to get his hands on.

He sits in his living room, spare bass in hand, and attempts to play exactly what he had heard earlier. It would undoubtedly sound better if Cipher were playing it, but she’s not here. He pulls out his electric guitar next, much more accustomed to six strings than four. Attempting to play the riff on guitar goes much smoother than on bass, and even though it doesn’t sound perfect to what he’s envisioned, it’s enough to allow his imagination to thrive.

Phainon pads into the living room at the sound of him working on something. “Where did you go?” he asks. “I’m sorry I yelled at you, Mydei. I was upset and wasn’t thinking, and I don’t want to fight anymore.”

Mydei puts his guitar down. Some things about him were drastically different from college, but this had remained constant—Phainon always seemed to apologize first, mere hours after they would fight. He never seemed to want to argue until Mydei forced it out of him. “Me too,” he says. “I just…” he takes a deep breath, pressing the heel of his palm into his forehead. “I went to the office,” he starts. “My father tried to get me on a sponsorship after what you said had sales dropping.”

Phainon’s eyes widen. He looks horrified. “What…?” he closes his mouth, then opens it again. “Was he there?”

Mydei nods.

“Oh my god.” Phainon moves forward, slowly lowering himself to sit on the floor, facing the spot Mydei sits with his legs crossed. “You just spoke to your father.”

Mydei nods.

“And?” Phainon whispers. “How did it go?”

Mydei swallows, looks down, and shakes his head. “I almost lashed out,” he admits. “It’s been a while since anyone has made me that angry.”

“You should’ve,” Phainon’s eyes flash as he says it. “Bastard deserves to get the shit kicked out of him.”

“No, he doesn’t,” Mydei insists. “It wouldn’t have made me any better than him. Would it?”

Phainon doesn’t say anything to that. Mydei picks his guitar back up, strumming a quiet cord that plays through the nearby amplifier. “I’m never going to see him again,” he continues. “Aventurine. My manager. He promised me I wouldn’t have to.”

“So you didn’t take the deal.”

“Of course not,” Mydei breathes. “I couldn’t. I would never accept something like that.”

Phainon’s jaw hardens. “Then you should be able to understand why I rejected it, too.”

“No, Phainon, I don’t,” Mydei says. “You have no ties to him. That deal could have changed your life.”

“No ties to him?!” Phainon demands, incredulous. “I have *you*, Mydei.”

“I don’t need you to hate him for me,” Mydei shoots back. “*I* don’t even hate him.”

“Just—” Phainon sighs, his head falling back onto the couch cushion. “I don’t want to argue, Mydei. I really don’t.”

“Fine,” Mydei says. He looks down at his guitar, positioning his fingers to match the riff he had just been working on. “Make yourself useful and help me with this arrangement, then.”

They call the song *Wrath of Man,* and Mydei writes the lyrics last, once he’s calmed down enough. He thinks they still come across as angry, even though the emotion he was trying to emulate wasn’t anger, but something more complex than that.

Phainon is helpless with rock music, but he sits on the couch making little comments here and there when he has something to say, and Mydei is glad that he’s at least not hiding in his room anymore.

After the break, Mydei gives each member a copy of their part and they play through it together. It’s almost perfect on the first playthrough, and they add it to the working list of songs on the whiteboard. Cipher especially likes it, but Mydei thinks that’s just because her part is so prominent.

Hyacine reads them a poem she had written during their break on the same day. Inspired by everyone pitching their own songs, she asked Castorice for help writing poetry, since she wasn’t the best at it.

Mydei wasn’t expecting her poem to sound so bleak.

Throw it all away
Let’s lose ourselves
There’s no one left to take the blame
And it’s a shame we’re all dying
Do you think you deserve our freedom?

How could you send us so far away from home?
When you know that this is wrong
I would still lay down my life for you

Do you think you deserve your freedom?
No, I don't think you do

There's no justice in the world
And there never was.

"It's about a couple things," she explains. "My ancestors were warriors like yours, Mydei. The nation of Skyfolk was just as destructive as Castrum Kremnos in its prime."

Mydei swallows. He had interpreted her poem in the same way. Thoughts of his father plague him recently like they rarely had in the past. What would he think if he heard Mydei singing an anti-war song? The thought just makes him want to include it on the album even more.

"Just like you, Mydei, I hate war," she says. "I went to med school because I wanted to bring people the happiness everyone deserves. Maybe it would have been different in Okhema, but the industry in Penacony was so… *unfair*," she admits. "I had a summer internship at a hospital in a low income area, and the amount of patients we were forced to turn away because they couldn't afford their medical bills, and didn't have insurance, I just…I couldn't do it."

Mydei looks down at his hands. He's never been poor. He doesn't know what it's like to be denied something you need. He doesn't even know that much about how Penacony differs politically from Okhema, but he thinks it's much more unjust, based on what he's heard.

"It made me lose all the hope in humanity that I used to have," Hyacine continues. "But music changed that. Guitar had been a hobby of mine since I was very young, but it wasn't until the IPC scouted me that I realized I could actually do something with it. And seeing people come together because of the music that we made is better than anything I could have asked for."

Turning Hyacine's poem into a song—now titled *Bleeding Out*—becomes more of an exercise on singing and harmonies. Mydei is the main voice, but they layer everyone behind him, like a choir. The instrumentals are fairly stripped back, just guitar and a little bit of drums. Cipher says she could add upright bass in the final version, but for now they use her electric bass.

The song turns out to only be a little over a minute long, so they decide to keep it as an interlude somewhere in the middle of the album.

With that, they've written six songs, which is about half of the length they're intending the album to be. Cipher says thirteen, Castorice says twelve. Mydei thinks they should just write until they have nothing more to say. But if that were the case, they might have nothing to write about in the future, and just one album that's forty songs long, so he's more on Cipher's side.

Even though Phainon had been improving ever since their conversation last week, he's still silent as Mydei drives him to physical therapy on Wednesday. With his hands getting better, their appointments have gone down from three times a week to twice a week. Phainon has been able to do more, and needs Mydei's help with simple tasks less. The pain has gone down too, Mydei thinks, but his insomnia remains. Mydei doesn't know what he could possibly do to remedy that.

"Hey," Mydei says, as Phainon climbs into the passenger seat. He doesn't look at Mydei as he enters, dropping his bag into the space between his legs and beginning to fumble with his seatbelt. "How was it?" Mydei continues, reaching over the console to help him buckle himself in.

Phainon presses the back of his head firmly to the headrest, clearly frustrated as he allows Mydei to help him. "It was fine," he finally says. His voice is hollow, betraying none of what he truly feels.

"Yeah?" Mydei clicks his seatbelt into place and unpauses his music. It blares through the speakers, alarming them both, and Mydei rushes to turn it down almost all the way. "Sorry," he mutters, as he shifts the gear into reverse.

The quiet music does little to ease the awkward silence between them as he pulls out of the parking lot. Mydei taps the beat of the drums against his steering wheel and it's louder than the actual music. He stops at a red light, and looks over at Phainon beside him. He stares into space, unaware Mydei is even looking at him. His lips are pressed into a tight, thin line. He looks like he's being driven to his own funeral.

"Phainon," Mydei starts, and he flinches out of his trance. "What did she say?"

Phainon swallows hard. Mydei observes it in the bob of his throat. "Nothing," he answers. Just as expected.

The light turns green. Mydei presses on the gas, making a left turn down the road his apartment is on. "Didn't we decide you were going to start being honest—"

"It was *fine*, Mydei," Phainon doesn't snap, but it's a near thing. "Okay? I said I was fine."

"Alright." Mydei pulls into the parking garage. They're silent as he searches for a spot, finally finding one on the third floor. They remain silent as they both step out, and he locks the car, and they walk to the elevator. Phainon trails behind him like a storm cloud all the way to his apartment building, and all the way to his door.

He helps Phainon out of his coat, and bends to untie his shoes. Phainon gives a frustrated sigh above him as he does. Mydei understands. He doesn't say anything.

When Mydei rises to his feet, Phainon's shoes set neatly under the rack, he meets Phainon's eyes and sees that his are wet with unshed tears. "Phainon," he murmurs, concern softening his voice. He lifts one of his hands to set it on Phainon's shoulder before he can run away. "Evidently, you're not fine." Phainon doesn't cry often, and Mydei hates it every time he does.

He hangs his head, messy bangs obscuring his face, as if that would make Mydei forget he had just seen the tears in his eyes. “I wish I had just died in that crash,” he mumbles.

“What?” Mydei whispers, setting his other hand on his free shoulder, too. “*Phainon—*”

“I don’t have anything to live for anymore, Mydei,” Phainon laments, lifting his face and bringing their eyes to meet. “*Nothing.*”

“Phainon.” Mydei moves his right palm to press against Phainon’s sun tattoo, his fingers light as they brush against the back of his neck. “What are you talking about?”

“She said—” Phainon starts, then stops, sniffling, before trying again. “I finally told her I played piano.”

“Oh,” Mydei murmurs. Dread settles deep in his gut. He waits for Phainon to elaborate, and finds he doesn’t want to know what she said in response.

Phainon presses his forehead into Mydei’s shoulder. His voice is muffled as he continues. “She said it’s unlikely I will ever be at the level I was at. Ever again.”

Mydei doesn’t say anything. Comfort has never been something he was all too good at offering. He thinks it must be a Kremnoan thing, because his mother was the same. She would always hold him wordlessly when he was upset, and that was enough.

He does the same now, wrapping his arms around Phainon’s back and holding him upright as he puts all his weight onto Mydei’s shoulder. He cries silently, even as sobs wrack his body violently. “I’m sorry,” he finally whispers, voice nasally and wet. “I shouldn’t have put all this on you.”

“Do you think I would have agreed if I didn’t want to?” Mydei asks, into the crown of his head. “This isn’t a burden on me, Phainon. I’m glad I was here for you.”

Phainon sniffs, and lifts his head. His eyes are bloodshot, cheeks stained with tear tracks. “Mydei, this is…” he shakes his head, and wipes his nose with his sleeve. “This is almost the biggest loss of my life.”

Mydei swallows. He resumes his rubbing at Phainon’s upper back, wiping away the tears with his other hand that Phainon couldn’t get himself. There are lots of things Phainon has lost. His parents. His hometown. His childhood dog. He carried no small amount of grief on his shoulders everyday, taking each loss honorably. And still, today he cries. “Almost?” The word catches as it leaves Mydei’s throat. He doesn’t know why he asks. It’s a question he can safely answer by himself, and yet he still wants to hear Phainon’s answer.

Phainon doesn’t say anything, looking at him through the silence that falls between them. His chin quivers. And then he falls forward again, resting all of his weight atop Mydei’s shoulder.

He never elaborates. Mydei holds him anyway.

Chapter End Notes

ngl i was so close to posting this tomorrow because i can't even begin to explain how shitty my week just was like there was literally nothing good about it. actually i lied i had my requiem performance and it was the most alive i've felt all semester. music will do that to you wont it

but we made it and we are here. two more weeks yall im so close.

▶ anyways

thank you for reading i love you

Chapter 8: Adagio Sostenuto

Chapter Notes

the chopin/rach 2 chapter

cw: non-explicit sex

See the end of the chapter for more notes

EXCERPT FROM: *Contemporary,* Issue 33 — Spring Edition, 3870

Mydeimos Nikador, virtuoso-turned-rockstar: "How I learned to love music again" [TRANSCRIPT]

Interviewer: After starting work on this new album, your performances have taken a stark turn from how they used to be perceived by the classical music community. Do you have anything particular to say about this?

Mydei: Um. Well, I think I've been very obsessed with making my music perfect for my whole life, really. I never understood the appeal of allowing the music to take control, because if I ever lost control, I feared it would lose its accuracy, and I thought that making perfect music was playing it exactly as written. It took a lot of work to lose that habit.

Interviewer: Was there any moment in particular where something changed in your perception?

Mydei: Oh, definitely. I could name the exact day.

Interviewer: Really?

Mydei: (nods) May fourth, 3865.

Interviewer: Wow. And what happened?

Mydei: (pause) Something just clicked. I guess. It was right before I walked on stage, actually, and now that particular performance of mine is one of the most cited interpretations of the piece.

Interviewer: What piece was it?

Mydei: Chopin's étude no. 3 in E Major…very misunderstood piece, at least that's what the classical music fanatics say. I wouldn't know.

Interviewer: Would you say you understood it, then?

Mydei: (laughs) I guess.

Interviewer: Anything in particular that caused this understanding to come about?

Mydei: It definitely wasn't always there. I hated that piece up until the moment I finished my performance and realized that I had just done something people were going to love. But obviously it wasn't, like, hatred that was coming through during my performance, but rather, well. I don't know. I guess it just clicked in my brain for the first time who I was playing for.

Interviewer: Someone specific?

Mydei: (pause) Yeah.

Interviewer: Did this realization change your approach long term, or was it just the one piece?

Mydei: That night was the first time I think I made real music. I've been trying to chase that feeling ever since.

Interviewer: Do you think you have?

Mydei: (nods) I love the music I've made in this album more than anything. Honestly [expletive] Chopin, that performance wasn't even that good when I look back on it.

Interviewer: (laughs) When you're performing today, do you still do it for that same person?

Mydei: (sighs) Yeah.

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May 3rd, 3865. Freshman spring.

Mydei finishes the piece with a flourish. His hands lift off the keys, and his foot off the pedal so he doesn't hold the last note out for longer than necessary.

He looks back at Madam Herta nervously. *He* certainly thinks he's ready for the concert tomorrow night, but if he knows one thing for sure it's that Madam Herta is always impossible to impress. All Mydei wants is for her to clap for him, to finally see that he's talented, that he *can* do this. But that dream is seeming increasingly unlikely.

"Do you know who said the quote, 'to play a wrong note is insignificant, but to play without passion is inexcusable'?"

Mydei wets his lips. He'd heard that quote a thousand times before—it's the kind of thing he might have cared to listen to five years ago, but now it just goes in one ear and out the other. He names the first composer he can think of. "Beethoven?"

"Wrong. Me."

Mydei grimaces.

"Why do you think I am mentioning this quote, Mydeimos?"

"Because I played the notes right, but played without passion."
~~~

“And you are going to improve this by tomorrow night.”

Mydei nods. He means it. He always focuses too much on the notes, playing exactly what’s written, and in this haze forgets that he’s supposed to be making music.

Madam Herta uncrosses her legs, and rests her glasses on the top of her head. “Well then. I suppose playing the notes perfectly is something to be proud of.”

She doesn’t mean it as a compliment. Mydei doesn’t take it as one.

He leaves her office after that, their lesson time over, and isn’t sure what to think. Madam Herta hadn’t been *mean* to him, but he’d heard from her older students that she was only ever mean to her students when they let her down. He’s faced with the undeniable fact that he hadn’t let her down, but only because she didn’t particularly believe in him in the first place.

He sits at the piano bench in one of the only empty practice rooms at this hour, but isn’t sure where to start. He can play the piece over and over again, but he won’t be able to tell if his playing is up to Madam Herta’s standards unless she’s right in front of him.

After an hour of workshopping, playing random passages over and over and trying to emulate the phrasing of random performance videos he found online, he settles on his last resort and calls Phainon.

Mydei has to wait four rings before he picks up, which is unusual.

“*Mydei?*” His voice is a little bit muffled, and a little rough, like he hadn’t spoken for a bit. “*Is everything okay?*”

“Yes,” Mydei says. “I’m okay. Did I wake you?” Phainon, asleep before ten PM is a foreign concept to Mydei. Sometimes, he thinks the man must be an insomniac or something.

“*No, not at all, I…I wasn’t asleep.*” Mydei can vaguely hear the sound of someone else laughing in the background, before Phainon shushes him.

“*Shut it, Caelus, you’ll understand when you—*” the rest of his sentence is cut off by a loud sound as Phainon presumably covers the microphone. “*What is it, Mydei?*” he asks afterwards, voice clearer now.

“Can I ask you a question?”

“*Of course you can. Are you sure you’re okay?*”

Mydei ignores the last part. “Phainon, when you’re playing…” he starts, thinking for a moment before continuing. “How do you do it? How are you able to immerse yourself so well?” Mydei has seen Phainon perform several times, and he’s seen him practice many more times. Each time, it’s like he loses himself in the music entirely. Like he opens his eyes when he’s done and has forgotten where he even was. It’s the one thing Mydei can’t do.

“*Well…I don’t really know, Mydei,*” he starts. “*I don’t exactly do it by choice, I guess. I just love the music so much, and I love performing. I guess it kind of just happens.*”

Mydei hums in response, not sure what else to say to that.

“*Which étude are you playing again?*” Phainon asks, in response to Mydei’s silence.

“E major,” Mydei responds. The music school decided to give each of the piano performance majors a Chopin étude to perform this semester, so that there was a cohesive theme to the concert and no one performance dragged out for too long. There were twenty-seven Madam Herta had to choose from, and there were about twenty Mydei would have preferred. It took him three weeks to realize she wasn’t playing an elaborate prank on him.

“*Oh.*”

“Oh.”

“*Yeah. Not your style.*”

“No.”

If only Professor Anaxa and Madam Herta switched their assignments around. Phainon was given a fast piece Mydei could have mastered in two weeks, tops. Mydei was given one of the slowest, most emotional pieces, out of all their options.

"*Herta wasn't happy?*"

"No." Mydei bites his tongue, suddenly getting annoyed all over again. "It's hard to play it with any amount of passion when I don't even like the piece."

"*You can't find* anything *to like about it?*"

"No. It sucks."

"*Well, sorry. It is what it is, Mydei.*"

Mydei sighs, loudly, into his phone.

"*Don't sigh. You're not always going to get what you want.*"

"Are you calling me spoiled?"

"*No,*" Phainon says immediately. Then, "*okay. Maybe. Yes.*" After another beat of silence on Mydei's end, he continues further. "*I like your piece.*"

"Is there any piece you don't like?"

"*I don't really like Rite of Spring.*"

"I know that's a lie. You clearly just picked the obvious choice because you couldn't think of a piece you actually don't like."

"*Not true. I'm not a huge fan of Segerstam's 81st Symphony.*"

"Who the hell is that?"

"*Weird guy. You could do without listening to it.*"

Mydei sighs again. “Good night, Phainon. Maybe I’ll check it out.”

“*Seriously, Mydei. There are much better composers you need to listen to before you get into the weird shit.*”

“Good night, Phainon,” he says again, firmer this time. “I’ll see you tomorrow.”

Phainon yawns at the other end of the line. Mydei *knew* he had been asleep before he picked up. “*Good night, Mydei.*”

Mydei hangs up, slipping his phone into his jacket pocket. He sits at the bench, silent, for a few moments before making his decision. He grabs his sheet music off the stand and leaves, shoving it into his bag haphazardly as he does. What did Madam Herta’s approval matter, really? Phainon was always going to cheer for him.

“Mydei, look!” Phainon finds him as soon as he steps into the green room, shoving a stolen program in his face. “We’re next to each other!”

“What?” Mydei takes the program from him, analyzing the page it’s opened to. Sure enough, the piano section is arranged in alphabetical order by their last name, and he is right after Phainon. “Oh. I see.”

“I’ll stay backstage,” Phainon’s eyes are shining, with something akin to wonder as he looks at Mydei. “I’ll watch you. I promise.”

“I’d really rather you not,” Mydei mutters. “I’m going to embarrass myself in front of Madam Herta.” He’d seen her briefly as he made his way to the green room, exiting her office. She had given him a tiny nod, nothing more than that. Now, Mydei cares more about impressing Phainon than anything, but he doesn’t want to admit that.

“No, you’re not,” Phainon presses a hand to Mydei’s shoulder blade. “Just remember what we talked about yesterday. Did you find a reason to like

your piece?”

Mydei turns his head, looking at him for a few long moments. “Yeah,” he finally says, softly.

“Well, that’s great!” The edges of Phainon’s eyes crinkle as he grins. Mydei looks away.

“Phainon, can you help me with something?”

They both turn, met with someone Mydei doesn’t know. Before he can get a good look at him, Phainon is whisked away, apologizing quickly over his shoulder as they move to the empty piano in the corner.

Mydei’s heart starts to calm once he’s alone. He spots Hysilens unpacking her violin in the corner. He doesn’t know her very well, and usually wouldn’t spend his time speaking to people he’s not friends with, but he needs something to do with himself to offset his nerves.

Hysilens turns slightly as he approaches, in the middle of rosining her bow. “Finally lost him, did you?”

“Huh?” Mydei sits at one of the chairs beside her. “Who?”

“Phainon.” She puts her bow down, capping her rosin. “His clinginess is obvious to anyone with an ounce of perceptive ability. He talks about you all the time, you know. I’m surprised you’re ever afforded a moment alone when you’re in the same room.”

“Um, okay,” Mydei says, a little uncertain about how he’s supposed to take that. She sits back on her heels and plucks lightly at each of her violin strings. “If it’s that frustrating to everyone else, I can tell him to stop.”

“No, that’s okay.” She presses her ear closer to the strings, before reaching up to adjust her tuning pegs. “Does this sound right to you?” She plucks her A string, louder this time.

“I think so,” Mydei says. “You should ask Phainon if you want someone with perfect pitch to help you.”

“You should know what an A sounds like,” she answers, before moving to one of her other strings.

“So should you,” Mydei crosses his arms. “I’ve never tuned a piano in my life.”

“I’m tone-deaf,” Hysilens says blandly. She expertly continues to tune the rest of her strings by herself, so Mydei doesn’t comment on how he doesn’t think that’s true. “Anyways, I’m happy for you two. Without your generous services, Phainon would surely end up dying alone one day.”

Mydei’s unsure what that’s supposed to mean, but Hysilens has a tendency to say odd things, so he doesn’t question it too much. “I didn’t realize you and Phainon were so close,” he says, as she retrieves a thin rag from one of the compartments in her case and begins wiping down her strings.

“We met last year. I need an accompanist for a lot of the pieces I have to play, so it’s nice to have a pianist I’m friends with.”

“That’s good. I’m sure he’d be happy to play with you any time.”

She looks up at him, eyebrows scrunched together, and shakes her head. “Uh huh,” she starts. “We’re just friends, though.”

“I didn’t…” Mydei shifts his weight from side to side. He’s growing more uncomfortable with this conversation every second. “I didn’t say you weren’t?”

“I have a girlfriend. And I wouldn’t touch a man with a ten foot pole.”

“Okay?”

“So you and Phainon can keep each other to yourselves.”

Mydei swallows. Suddenly, he thinks he might know where this is going, and he doesn’t like the implications of any part of this conversation one bit. “Hysilens, are we…talking about the same thing?”

“Oh my god,” Hysilens mutters, setting her violin down carefully in her case. “You two aren’t dating?”

Mydei’s mouth falls open. Inexplicably, he feels his face heat up. “What—why would we be—?”

“Because he’s in love with you?” Hysilens supplies, like it’s obvious. “Do you have no intelligence outside of music?”

Mydei is suddenly overcome with a need to defend Phainon, because a statement such as that is so obviously defamation. “Phainon isn’t in love with me. We’re friends? Just like you two?”

“*Just like us?*” Hysilens laughs. “Phainon doesn’t talk about me 24/7. He doesn’t follow me around like a lost puppy and isn’t inconsolable when I’m more than a five minute walk away. He doesn’t look at me like…well, like that. And honestly, I would be disgusted if he did.” She stands, brushing dust off her black skirt, ignoring Mydei’s obvious bewilderment. “Now, get out of my way. I have to use the bathroom.”

Mydei steps aside, watching her leave. His heart is racing in his throat. He thinks his vision might black out, because he doesn’t notice Phainon until he’s right in front of him, waving a hand in his face.

“Hello-o-o, Mydei. Shit, what did she *tell* you? You look like your whole life philosophy was just turned upside down.”

“Not quite,” Mydei manages, throat dry. His voice is weak, but not as weak as he feels. Like he’d collapse like a newborn foal if he tried to walk.

Phainon laughs, collapsing into the chair Hysilens was just sitting in with as much comfort as if he were in his own house. “Don’t listen to her. She can be kind of intimidating.”

“Intimidating,” Mydei breathes. “Sure.” He refuses to look Phainon in the eye. He doesn’t want to know what he’d find.

“Want to go find a seat? They start in ten minutes.”

String solos open the concert, so pianists aren't until the end. Mydei nods, and follows Phainon out of the green room.

Dating Phainon. That sounds…well, Mydei's not quite sure. He's never really thought about it before. Except in his dreams, perhaps, the details of which always seem to dissipate as soon as he wakes.

He wipes his sweaty palms on his dress pants. He needs to calm down.

Phainon leads him all the way down the hall until they reach one of the side entrances no one ever really goes through. He waves at the worker outside the door, and Mydei accepts a program of his own.

They climb all the way to the top, before settling in two seats off to the side that are part of a balcony. Mydei can't see the stage very clearly unless he leans completely on the bannister, but it's the least disruptive place to sit given that they have to leave halfway through.

"Oh! Look!" Phainon is shoving his program into Mydei's face again, pointing at the first performer. "Hysilens is first." He frowns. "Weird. I thought there were more violinists than just her and Kafka."

He continues to ramble, something about Raiden Mei and her girlfriend, a bunch of people Mydei barely knows. He can't find it in himself to pay attention. Not when Phainon's knee brushes his and their elbows keep bumping like it's casual. It would have been casual ten minutes ago. Now, Mydei has no idea what to believe.

Mydei tugs at the collar of his shirt, uncomfortable. He's not even under the scorching hot stage lights, and he's already sweating.

"Did you know a member of Hysilens' string quartet is a high schooler?" Phainon finishes, propping his legs up on the bannister.

"Fascinating," Mydei mutters. He wishes Phainon would just stop looking at him.

“I know, right? Talk about prodigy. Honestly, I’m surprised *you* didn’t start college when you were, like, fourteen.”

“Worked out for you, didn’t it?”

“Ha,” Phainon huffs, then goes eerily silent. Mydei can still feel his gaze on him. He leans back in his seat, closing his eyes. “Yeah. I guess it did.”

Mydei gulps. He can tell the house lights start dimming, so he opens his eyes and sits up. Thankfully, Phainon’s attention is on the stage now.

The head of the music department—Mydei has no idea what her name is, as he hasn’t spoken to her once—starts the concert by saying a few words, before exiting. Hysilens walks out moments later, violin in hand. There’s a moment of polite applause as she bows and adjusts her music stand that Mydei takes to look at the program.

He’s not familiar with violin repertoire at all, especially not when it comes to solo pieces. “Do you know this piece?” he whispers, turning to Phainon.

“You don’t know *Erlkönig?*” Phainon looks bewildered. Mydei shrugs. “Oh my god, prepare yourself. This piece changed my opinion on violin music entirely.”

Mydei shoots him a confused glance and settles back into his seat. He can hear Hysilens lightly pluck at her strings, ensuring they’re in tune. She starts playing shortly after that.

The piece is weird. Mydei is useless when it comes to string players and their technique, so he doesn’t expect to be overly impressed by her performance given that he doesn’t know what is difficult and what isn’t. In this case, it’s pretty easy to tell how incredibly talented she is, though.

There’s too much going on. With piano, you have ten fingers and seven octaves of notes at your disposal. It’s only natural that the hardest piano pieces would sound incredibly complicated. A violinist, though, has four fingers and four strings. There is no reason why Mydei should be hearing what sounds like three different instruments right now.

“*What the fuck,*” he breathes. Phainon snorts into his hand, before leaning in and resting his head on Mydei’s shoulder.

Mydei freezes. Hysilens’ performance, confusing as it was, had sufficiently wiped his brain of their earlier conversation, and with something as simple as Phainon leaning on him, it’s like the music is a thousand miles away.

It’s not out of the ordinary. Phainon is a very affectionate person, and Mydei, being his best friend, was no stranger to his physical affection. Now, though, he can’t help but wonder if it’s for an entirely different reason. What is Phainon like with his other friends? Touchier than Mydei, sure, but would he do this? Mydei doesn’t think so.

He swallows and tries not to appear as stiff as he feels. Phainon lifts one of his hands, settling it atop Mydei’s. “Are you alright?” he whispers, lifting his head so his chin rests on Mydei’s shoulder.

Mydei nods. Phainon’s gaze is so intense it feels like it’s burning holes through Mydei’s skull.

“Am I making you uncomfortable?”

“No,” Mydei says. Phainon accepts it, laying his head back down. *Yes*, Mydei thinks. He’s never been so unsure of himself before. He doesn’t know what he wants.

I’m happy for you two. Hysilens had thought they were dating. She thought Mydei reciprocated Phainon’s feelings, and it was obvious.

Mydei closes his eyes. He tries to pay attention to Hysilens’ performance, but it doesn’t work, no matter how starstruck he’s sure he would be. He can’t get her words out of his head. There’s a nauseous feeling in his gut, one he’s unfamiliar with, as he allows himself to think it over. *Am I?* He wants to throw up. *Am I in love with Phainon?*

The concert hall erupts into applause, and Mydei startles as he realizes that her piece has ended. He drops his program into his lap and joins them in

their applause. Phainon lifts his head from his shoulder to cup his hands over his mouth and whoop.

She bows, deep and graceful, and Mydei thinks he can see her shoot a grin at someone in the audience as she rises. He can count the number of times he's seen her smile on one hand.

She walks off. The applause continues for a couple seconds before it finally subsides. Mydei feels bad for not listening as intently as he should've, given how impressive he had found her piece before Phainon ruined it all for him.

There are a few moments of silence. Mydei can't quite see what's going on onstage, until the doors open up and he can hear footsteps on the stage as light applause starts up again.

Mydei swallows. His hands are so sweaty, and he thinks that if they weren't already curled into fists his fingers would be shaking.

Phainon is looking at the program, nodding slightly to himself as he undoubtedly recognizes the next piece and settles back into his seat.

He clears his throat. "Phainon—"

Perfectly on cue, the first few notes of the next piece ring out around them. He snaps his mouth shut, but it's too late. Phainon is already looking at him, eyes wide with his unadulterated attention.

Mydei wets his lips. "Never mind," he whispers.

Phainon's eyebrows furrow together. "Are you sure you're okay? You're being weird."

Mydei turns back around. "Watch the concert, Phainon."

"We can leave," Phainon suggests. "We can go back to the green room, if you want. I don't really care about Kafka, and her piece is boring anyways —"

“*Phainon.*”

He closes his mouth. Mydei glares, for a moment, before they both turn back around.

They sit through the rest of the performances in silence. Kafka finishes her Bach piece. There’s one viola performance Mydei isn’t overly impressed by, and three cellists. If Mydei had to pick a favorite string instrument, it would be cello without a doubt, but he can’t even focus on the performances with Phainon next to him, practically simmering in their shared silence.

After the last cellist, they slip through the nearest exit as silently as possible after exchanging nothing more than a little nod.

Phainon is fourth, so they have some time before he has to be on stage. He immediately goes to speak with Hysilens, who is in the corner talking with Kafka and a tall, purple-haired cellist Mydei had just watched perform.

The last person Mydei wants to talk to is Hysilens right now, no matter how impressed he was by her performance. So he decides to sit at the piano instead, quietly going over a few rougher parts of his piece.

The first pianist comes back into the room. When Mydei looks up, Hysilens has moved away from the rest of the group, talking to Phainon in private. She glances his way. Mydei feels bile rise up his throat. He looks back down at the keys.

Some time during the third pianist’s performance, he can feel Phainon approach him before he sees him. He takes his hands off the keys and braces himself for whatever he’s about to hear.

“Mydei,” he starts, leaning over the lid. “Hysilens said—”

“Phainon.”

They both look up at the sound of Professor Anaxa’s voice, coming from where he stands in the doorway.

“Sorry, prof, two seconds, I promise—”

“Whatever you are talking about can wait. You’re needed now.” The third performer walks in behind him, and Phainon scrambles to grab his sheet music.

“Later, Mydei, I promise.” And then he’s gone, bolting out the door after Professor Anaxa.

Mydei sighs, and gathers his sheet music from the shelf before him. He looks over at Hysilens, but her back is turned to him, and she’s returned to her earlier conversation.

By the time he makes it to the backstage area, Phainon is already outside. Professor Anaxa leans against the door, watching the mini screen showing the main stage. There’s a tiny speaker that plays the outside audio, currently playing applause and the slight rustling as Phainon gets situated.

He takes a short moment of dramatic pause before he starts playing, and even outside the concert hall, through the shitty audio and vague background noises of him playing in the hall, Mydei is blown away by his prowess.

He’d only listened to Phainon’s étude once before, a recording of it after Phainon told him which one he was learning, but they’d never played them for each other before.

Beside him, Professor Anaxa is nodding along, tapping one of his fingers along with the tempo. Mydei’s eyes are glued to the tiny screen, trying to see as much of it as he can. He knows he needs to watch it back later. A thousand times, maybe. Until he can’t get it out of his eyes, or his ears.

He stares at Phainon’s hands, one flying across the keys as the other jumps around, playing tiny little chords. He doesn’t miss a single note, and doesn't stumble once. He stares at his black button down, sleeves rolled up just a little after his elbows, at the way the top button of his shirt is undone. His hair is messy, the little whorl on the top of his head bouncing back and forth as he moves his entire body with the music. He’s barely even sitting on the

bench anymore as he nears the end of the piece. He looks almost crazed as he plays the last chords, hands practically slamming against the keys.

Mydei's throat feels dry. This, at least, finally isn't a feeling he's unfamiliar with. He finds people attractive all the time, and he's believed Phainon to be stupidly handsome since the day that they met. But it was never like this. This wasn't just attraction anymore—he wants to be by Phainon's side forever.

He swallows regardless, heart hammering in his chest with a thousand emotions he can't name as the concert hall erupts into applause.

"Thank you, Mydei," Professor Anaxa says, from beside him.

Mydei still can't take his eyes away from the screen, at the way Phainon tries to catch his breath as he stands. "For what?"

Phainon smiles from ear to ear as he bows, deep and long. Mydei has to bite his tongue to calm himself down. "He wouldn't have been able to do this without you." Is Professor Anaxa's answer, one that Mydei cannot find a suitable reply to in the time it takes Phainon to walk from the center of the stage to the door.

He emerges, one hand pushing his sweaty hair out of his face. He's still grinning, and it doesn't even falter as he looks at Mydei.

"Good job, Phainon," Professor Anaxa says. "That was, well. Perfect."

"Thanks, Anaxa," Phainon says easily. He looks at Mydei again, and something flickers across his face like there's something else he wants to say.

He wouldn't have been able to do this without you.

Mydei thinks he might know what Phainon wants to say. He can only hope it's the same thing that he's thinking, now—that Phainon is all he ever needed. That he's the only person Mydei would ever have to play for that actually mattered.

Anaxa's hand on his upper back drags him back to reality. "Good luck, Mydei," he says. Phainon, still staring with something close to reverence on his face, nods.

The door opens. Mydei tightens his grip on his sheet music, and walks out.

The applause that sounds as he makes his way over to the piano sounds like it's a thousand miles away. Mydei wants to look back, to catch just one more glimpse of Phainon on the other side of the door before it closes, but he pulls himself back to reality, stops before the piano, and bows. He doesn't look at the audience as he rises. He doesn't care anymore.

He sets up his sheet music on the rack, and sits down. He pulls up both his sleeves a little bit, and takes a deep breath as he sets his hands on the keys.

Mydei's heart is pounding in his throat. He looks at the notes on the page, and it all seems like gibberish to him.

Something like a confession lingers longer in his brain than every other passing thought. *You are in love with him.* And then, *fuck.*

He can feel the audience's tension. He doesn't know how long he's been sitting here, playing nothing. The stage lights beat down on him to an almost suffocating degree.

Phainon. Fuck.

He swallows. Closes his eyes. All he can see is Phainon's white-blond hair and bright blue eyes, his dimples when he smiles, the sun tattoo on his neck.

He starts playing. It starts quiet, so quiet he can barely hear it. The audience is so silent it feels like he's the only one here. Him, and Phainon. Behind that door. He's watching, Mydei knows he is—he promised, and Phainon would never break his promise.

Mydei follows the notes on the page with perfect precision. He can't remember the last time he made a mistake during a performance, but his

head is anywhere but where it needs to be right now. All he can think about is Phainon. He keeps playing.

He shuts his eyes, because he doesn't need the notes anyway. *He is so obviously in love with you.* How couldn't he tell? How did he need Hysilens to spell it out for him? Phainon always seemed to love him as easily as breathing. Ever since that first day he heard Mydei play, since the first time they got together outside of class. Things were always easy between them. Phainon befriended him in seconds and loved him quicker than that. He didn't care about Mydei's family. He didn't care where he came from, or who he was. He gave Mydei a reason to keep playing, one he actually cared about. For the first time in his life, Mydei could see his future with perfect clarity. He would get this degree and become a pianist, and it didn't seem so terrible anymore. All because Phainon would be right there with him, the whole time. Mydei is going to make sure of it.

The piece ends with a ritardando. He slows it down longer than he'd ever practiced, doesn't count the perfect amount of time to hold out the last note. He does what he feels, what he thinks the piece needs. And when he finally lifts his hands, and opens his eyes, the lights are blinding. The sheet music before him is blurry. He relaxes, and the applause starts.

He sniffs. Wipes his nose, blinks tiny tears out of his eyes. He stands, facing the audience, really looking at them for the first time that night. He carefully gathers his sheet music off the rack, and bows. As he lifts his head, he spots Madam Herta off to the side. Mydei thinks his heart stops as they make eye contact for the briefest moment.

She gives him a tiny nod and lifts her hands in his direction. She's clapping.

Mydei can't help the ridiculous smile that breaks over his face. He practically bounces on the balls of his feet as he walks off stage, pushing the doors open.

They're just barely closed when Phainon rushes towards him, nearly toppling him over with the force at which he hugs him. "Mydeimos," he whispers, directly into his ear. "Kephale, you're amazing."

Mydei laughs wetly, and hugs him back.

“Good job, Mydei,” Professor Anaxa says. “I’m sure Herta is proud.”

“I think she approved,” Mydei answers, over Phainon’s shoulder. “Applause is a good sign, right?”

Phainon hugs him tighter, and then pulls away. “Of course she did,” he gushes, hands on Mydei’s shoulders.

“Cruel, that woman,” Professor Anaxa tuts, shaking his head. Phainon and Mydei move out of the way as he ushers the next student out the doors.

“Good job, Mydei,” she says, as she passes. “You too, Phainon.”

Mydei wishes her good luck as she exits, and the two of them head back down the hallway. “Do you want to watch the rest of the show?” Phainon asks. “Or—”

“No,” Mydei says immediately. “Balcony?”

“Balcony,” Phainon agrees instantly, grabbing Mydei’s hand and pulling him towards the elevator. Mydei’s palm is sweaty. He only hopes Phainon can’t notice it because his is sweaty, too.

The balcony is on the fifth floor of the music building, attached to the lounge near all the practice rooms. Mydei liked to spend his time there, doing homework outside when the weather was nice. It was probably his favorite place on campus, and was somehow almost always empty.

It is now, too, and so are most of the practice rooms, given that most people were either yet to perform tonight or had already. Thus, most had gone home or were inside watching.

Phainon finally lets go of his hand once they’re outside, both of them sitting on the bench overlooking the best view. It’s dark out, and the light from inside only barely illuminates Phainon’s face. Mydei faces him, one leg propped up on the bench, and the other hanging off the side. Phainon has his legs crossed, leaning back against the concrete wall.

“Are you ready for our theory exam tomorrow?”

Mydei has barely studied so far, and he knows that Phainon hasn’t either, even though he’d probably ace it anyway. That’s only one of the reasons why Mydei has no desire to talk about this right now. “Stop stalling.”

“Stalling what?” Phainon cocks his head to the side in mock innocence. Mydei nearly rolls his eyes. He can tell that under his light-heartedness is a touch of fear.

“Hysilens told me—”

“Mydei.” Phainon’s voice is firm. “Seriously, I can’t…I don’t want you to get the wrong idea.”

“Wrong idea?” Mydei raises an eyebrow. “I don’t think I am.”

Phainon forces a hand through his hair. “Look, Mydei, she didn’t know what she was talking about. She shouldn’t have told you that.”

“Told me what?” Mydei suddenly feels much less sure about this. “Say it, Phainon.”

“That I…I’m…” Phainon wets his lips. For the first time that night, he can’t seem to bring himself to look Mydei in the eye. “Mydei…don’t do this to me. Please.”

Mydei sits up. “Phainon,” he says, voice firm. “Tell me. Now.”

“Okay! Okay, I’m sorry…” Phainon fiddles with the hair at the back of his neck, the kind of gesture he usually does when he’s nervous. Mydei doesn’t take his eyes off him. “It’s just, I’ve never…I’ve never really, um, felt like this before.”

“Felt like what?” Mydei prompts, as gently as he can possibly muster. His voice is fighting to keep steady, and he can barely hear himself over the intense beating of his heart.

“Like…” Phainon’s free hand shakes as he lifts it to rest on his knee. Mydei reaches over and

places one of his hands on top of it, a gesture he hopes is soothing. “I,” he starts again, eyes wide and unblinking when he finally looks at Mydei, and isn’t too scared to look away. “I really like you,” he admits quietly. “More than I should.”

“How much do you think you should?” Mydei prods.

“As much as I like my friends,” Phainon swallows, so thickly that Mydei can hear it. “I don’t want to be your friend, Mydei. I never wanted that.”

Mydei bites his tongue. To think this had been going on for so long with Phainon, only for Mydei to realize it fifteen minutes ago. “And I…I don’t care if you feel the same or not, I really don’t. I just want you, by my side, and—and we can be friends if that’s all you want. I can be okay with that. Even though I don’t think I’ll ever really be able to move on.”

“Why wouldn’t I feel the same?” Mydei asks, dropping his leg off the side of the bench.

“You—” Phainon starts, then stops. Mydei lifts both his hands up to cup Phainon’s chin.

“I’m saying that I like you too, Phainon,” Mydei murmurs. “And I’ll go out with you, if that’s what you were trying to ask.”

“I—” Phainon starts. “I—*yes*, Mydei.”

Mydei presses closer. He wants to kiss him more than he’s ever wanted anything in his life, but Phainon’s obvious inexperience holds him back. “Can I—” he starts.

Phainon doesn’t let him finish. He leans all the way in, pressing his lips to Mydei’s with all the fervor and confidence of someone who knows exactly what they’re doing.

Mydei sinks into him, relishing in the feeling of Phainon's lips on his. He's warm, almost achingly so, even in the chilly evening air. His hands are the worst, burning his skin even through the fabric of his shirt, but Mydei can't find it in himself to pull away, and he doesn't think Phainon would let him if he tried. He kisses Mydei like he doesn't need air.

Mydei almost can't believe it's his first kiss, but he knows it is. He gasps as they finally separate, Phainon's lips bright red and slicked with spit, his eyes shining brighter than every star in the sky. "*Mydei*," he breathes, voice ragged. He stares at Mydei like he's starstruck. "God, I wanted you for so long."

"How long?" Mydei asks. He wipes his lips dry on the sleeve of his shirt.

"You first?" Phainon prods, leaning back into him. His hands haven't left Mydei's waist, so hot Mydei vaguely thinks he might burn him.

"Ah…" Mydei bites his bottom lip. "About ten minutes, maybe."

Phainon gapes. "You—*what?* When was that?"

"I was on stage."

"Oh my god, Mydei," Phainon laughs, forehead falling on Mydei's shoulder. "I was wondering why you were taking so long to start."

"Your fault for distracting me."

"A good distraction, right?" He lifts his head, staring up at Mydei. "I would assume so, if your performance is anything to go off…"

"Yes," Mydei assures him. "I thought of you, and then played what I felt."

"Mydei," Phainon whispers, then kisses him again. It's shorter the second time, but the feeling lingers on Mydei's lips for just as long. He wishes they had more time, that they weren't technically in public right now. He wants Phainon to himself, now.

“They should be ending soon,” Mydei says, checking the time on his phone. “Do you want to go back downstairs?”

“No,” Phainon mutters, pouting. “I want to stay here with you.”

“You would still be with me downstairs,” Mydei stands up, forcing Phainon to pull his hands away. “Come on. Let’s go talk to people, and then you will come to my room.”

“Your room?” Phainon gets to his feet, perking up instantly. “Really?”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “Come on,” he says, pulling Phainon towards the door. He follows him all the way back to the elevator. “My roommate is gone, by the way,” he continues, a bit amused by the way Phainon instantly flushes bright red. “He went home this morning.”

Phainon presses close to Mydei’s side, his head burrowing in Mydei’s neck. “Stop it,” he murmurs. “You’re going to drive me crazy.”

Mydei doesn’t say anything, smiling to himself silently.

The elevator dings, and the doors open. The lobby is packed with people, enough to put a lump in Mydei’s throat. Part of him just wants to leave, but he needs to see Madam Herta one last time before the semester ends.

“Phainon!” Caelus bounds up to them almost immediately, his sister right behind him. There are a couple other people he came with—people from the marching band, which Mydei has done a good job avoiding up until this point. “And Mydei!” He looks down at their joined hands, and his eyes light up. “Fucking *finally.* Took you long enough, man,” he says, clapping a hand on Phainon’s shoulder.

Mydei tunes out the rest of their conversation, scanning the crowd around them. He spots Professor Anaxa talking to a couple of his other students, Hysilens with her violin case strapped over her shoulder walking out the door with a short girl at her side. He sees so many of his classmates, both in his music classes or history classes, that it makes him feel a little sick.

And then, finally, he notices Madam Herta, standing outside one of the stage doors talking to another woman. Mydei thinks he vaguely recognizes her as the one sitting next to her in the concert hall, but he wasn't paying very close attention to anyone else.

"Be right back," he says, mostly just to Phainon, letting go of his hand. He slips through the crowd, suddenly growing very nervous, as he approaches Madam Herta.

"Mydeimos!" she says, once she sees him. She smiles at him, for the first time in Mydei's life, and a surge of pride runs through him. "Incredible job," she says. "I was very impressed."

"As was I," the woman beside her adds. Mydei turns to look at her, wondering how he's never seen her before. "Ruan Mei," she explains, extending a hand to him.

Mydei takes it. "Mydei," he says. "Thank you. It means a lot." He has no idea who Ruan Mei is, but he's sure she knows enough about music for Mydei to take it as a compliment if she's hanging out with Madam Herta.

"Will I be seeing you in lessons next semester?" Madam Herta asks. It's a pretty roundabout way of asking if he's going to drop out, or switch professors. While that might be something he would have considered a few days ago, it's not even a question in his mind now.

"Of course," he answers. "I look forward to it."

"As do I," Madam Herta smiles again. "I do have high hopes for you, Mydeimos. You have real talent, we just have to figure out what it is that will unlock this talent."

"Thank you," Mydei says, flushing. "But I think I finally figured out what it is."

"Perfect. Enjoy your summer, Mydeimos."

“You too,” Mydei smiles again before he walks off, nearly bumping into Phainon in the middle of the crowd. Just setting eyes on him again is enough to send butterflies to his stomach—he can’t wait to get to his dorm. “Let’s go,” he says, grabbing Phainon’s hand and pulling him towards the door, ignoring all his protests.

“You’re way too eager, Mydeimos,” Phainon laughs, as they get outside. “Herta approved, then?”

“She’s never been so friendly in her life.”

“You don’t know that,” Phainon retorts. “Surely there are people out there that she loves.”

“Hm.” Mydei is skeptical, but then remembers the first time he noticed the ring on Madam Herta’s finger. Marriage, to someone like her, seems impossible. He had always just believed it was a stylistic choice. But then, the woman at her side—who else would you bring to a concert like this? Your friend? It wasn’t terribly unlikely. “Maybe,” he finally says.

“So,” Phainon changes the subject, as they walk down the path towards the dorms. “Am I allowed to stop at my dorm first?”

Mydei sighs, frustrated. He wants Phainon to himself *now.*

“I need to change!” Phainon protests. Mydei turns to look at him, in his concert black, and the idea of him changing out of it just frustrates him further. “And grab some stuff. Please, Mydei? I need my toothbrush.”

“Do you?” Mydei raises an eyebrow. “Your breath seemed just fine to me.”

Phainon flushes, going silent as Mydei swipes his ID at the door to his building. He pulls Phainon through the door as it unlocks, swiftly heading for the stairs. “Come on.”

“I’m *coming,* Mydeimos, you can relax!”

He drags Phainon all the way up two flights of stairs, and down the hall until he finally reaches his dorm room. His card takes what feels like

forever to read, and as soon as it beeps he nearly pushes the door down with the force he uses to open it.

The lights are off. He doesn't care to turn them on and pushes Phainon against the closed door, claiming his lips once more.

Phainon makes a surprised noise, immediately trying to match Mydei's energy as he kisses him back. "Mydei—" he manages, between kisses. Mydei doesn't care. He licks into Phainon's mouth, muffling any words he might have wanted to say, as he fumbles with Phainon's dress shirt and pulls it out from where it's tucked into his pants. He runs his hands underneath, feeling the soft outline of his abs. He might have only just figured out he was in love with him, but the attraction had been there ever since their first session together at the gym.

Mydei pulls away so he can vaguely make out where the buttons start on his shirt, reaching for the first one. "Mydei, wait—" Phainon tries again. Mydei kisses him again, before finally drawing back.

"Stop talking," he mutters, undoing the first button, then lowering his hands to the second.

"I—I'm not—" Phainon starts.

The realization washes over Mydei like a bucket of cold water. He drops his hands. Takes a tiny step back. "Oh," he says, softer this time. In his haze, he had forgotten all about Phainon's lack of experience. It was just so difficult to believe. "I'm sorry. I got ahead of myself."

"No," Phainon nearly whines, stepping forward. "I *want* to, of course, I just —you're so…and I'm…"

"Use your words."

Phainon sighs, frustrated. "I just feel like I won't be able to give you what you want?"

"What?" Mydei crosses his arms. "I don't care, Phainon. I just want *you*."

“Oh…” Phainon whispers.

Mydei presses a hand to his cheek. “Phainon,” he says firmly. “Do you want to do this? Yes or no.”

“Yes,” Phainon’s response is instantaneous. “Yes, of course.”

“Okay,” Mydei says. “Then come on.” He pulls Phainon towards his bed, flicking the desk light on as they go. He pushes Phainon down, before climbing on top of him and resuming his work on his shirt buttons until he finally frees him completely. Then, he moves to fumble with his belt buckle, while Phainon attempts to undo Mydei’s own shirt.

Phainon’s fingers are shaking so violently that he can’t even loosen a single button. Mydei laughs as he swats his hands away, electing to do it himself while he watches. “Sorry,” Phainon murmurs.

Mydei ignores him, tugging his shirt off over his head once he loses his patience. He tosses it aside, and it lands somewhere on the floor.

Mydei settles over Phainon’s lap, rolling his hips gently as he leans down to nip at Phainon’s neck tattoo. “*Mydei—*” Phainon gasps, breath hot as it puffs against Mydei’s ear. He shivers, kissing along the junction of Phainon’s throat and over the thin line decorating his chest.

“Why did you get this?” Mydei whispers, running his finger across it. Phainon’s whole body trembles beneath him.

“The sun,” Phainon breathes. “Praise the sun,” he shudders.

“Praise the sun,” Mydei repeats. “Is that a reference to ancient Okhema?” He leans back, sitting over Phainon’s hips. His nails dig into his thighs, and he ignores the dull pain.

Phainon nods. “The Deliverer,” he whispers. “Cyrene always told me I reminded her of him.”

Mydei smiles a little, amused. “Really? That’s rather presumptuous of you.”

“*Ha*—” Phainon huffs, halfway to a laugh. “Blame Cyrene, then.”

“Well then, Deliverer,” Mydei says, splaying his hands over Phainon’s chest. “Are you just going to sit there, or are you going to do something?”

“Don’t call me that,” Phainon says. He blushes all the way to his shoulders. Despite both his inexperience and embarrassment, he braces one hand on the back of Mydei’s neck and flips their positions in one smooth motion.

Mydei gasps softly as his head hits the pillow, heat instantly pooling in his gut at the sight of Phainon hovering above him. He bites his tongue as he wills his racing heart to calm down.

“Wait,” Phainon says suddenly, and sits back on his heels. He rummages through his pockets, pants still halfway undone, and pulls out his phone. “Do you have a playlist?”

Mydei freezes. “What?”

“A…a playlist,” Phainon repeats. His blush creeps even further down his chest.

“A playlist,” Mydei deadpans.

“Yeah.”

“What the hell are you talking about?” A little bit of Mydei’s arousal is starting to fade. “A sex playlist?”

“Yeah,” Phainon says, unashamed. “That.” Okay—maybe a little bit ashamed.

Mydei blinks. “No. Phainon. I don’t have a sex playlist.”

“Huh,” Phainon wonders aloud, still navigating somewhere on his phone. “Weird. I totally thought you would, given that you’ve done this before.”

“Most people don’t have a sex playlist.”

“Untrue,” Phainon says, turning up the volume on his phone. An ad starts to play at full volume.

Mydei covers his face with his hands. “Why you?” He laments, voice muffled.

“Hey,” Phainon says, as he skips the ad. “It’s not my fault you’re in love with me.”

Mydei starts to say something, but it’s muffled by Phainon pressing their lips together after tossing his phone off to the side. He can’t hear the song yet. He’s not sure he wants to know what he chose.

“Oh my god,” he manages, as Phainon lowers himself to kiss slowly along Mydei’s jaw, and Mydei starts to recognize the first few notes of an orchestral piece. “Phainon,” he says, through his breathy laughter partially due to the sensation of Phainon kissing his neck. “You are…the *corniest* person I have ever met.”

“Again,” Phainon murmurs, against his skin. “You’re the one in love with me.”

“Rach 2?” Mydei nearly wheezes. “You seriously want to—”

“I love you,” Phainon answers, voice so earnest that Mydei can’t find it in himself to make fun of him anymore. “And I love this piece. And so do you, you admitted it yourself last time I played it for you—”

“Because *you* love it,” Mydei says. “Because it reminds me of you.”

“*Mydei…*” Phainon whines, shoving his face into Mydei’s neck. “You can’t just say something like that.”

“Come on.” Mydei shoves a leg between Phainon’s thighs, and he thinks the noise Phainon makes in response would play on repeat in his brain for days. “I already lost my patience five minutes ago.”

It doesn’t last very long. Phainon lays curled into Mydei’s side, both of them naked as they catch their breaths while the climax of the song plays

around them. “I love you,” Phainon whispers into Mydei’s neck. “You don’t even understand what I would do for you.”

Mydei pulls him in closer, and kisses the top of his head. “Actually, I think I do,” he murmurs. He would do the same, without a second thought.

Mydei has almost drifted off when Phainon speaks again, voice reverberating against his chest. The playlist has moved on, halfway through a different symphony completely unlike Rach 2. He thinks it sounds a little like Shostakovich.

“I’m going to play it one day,” Phainon says, decidedly.

“I don’t think this piece has a piano part,” Mydei mumbles into his hair. His eyes are still closed. He feels Phainon’s answering laugh more than he hears it.

“Not Shostakovich, Mydeimos,” he answers, and Mydei internally congratulates himself for being able to recognize composers better now. “Rach 2. I’m going to play it one day.”

“Okay,” Mydei says.

“Promise me you’ll be there when I play it.” He can feel Phainon reach one of his hands up Mydei’s chest, before settling against his chin. He threads his fingertips through Mydei’s hair, pushing it behind his ear. “And I’ll be there when you’re selling out stadiums and have three charting rock albums.”

Mydei thinks about his own realization earlier that day, on stage. How he thought, for the first time in his life, that he could actually build a life for himself around piano. And then Madam Herta’s words. *You have real talent.* If she thought so, how could he waste it on rock music? Even if he loved it more than he would ever love piano music, whether or not Phainon was there. Someone he loved could only do so much, Mydei thinks.

His dream life would be one where he could have rock, and Phainon could have classical, and they were able to live together. But that would never

happen.

“You think I’m going to be a rockstar?” he asks.

“I think you’re a gift to the world,” Phainon says immediately. “Whatever it is, then. Whatever music you make. I’ll be there.”

“Okay,” Mydei hums, lifting his own hand to curl his fingers through Phainon’s soft locks of hair.

“Promise,” Phainon says again. “Promise me you’ll be there.”

Mydei opens his eyes. He lifts his head a little, met with Phainon’s pleading gaze, and finds that he can’t deny him anything. Not that he would ever consider any other future. Not that he would ever be faced with Phainon’s dreams and tell him *no*. He rests his head back against the pillow.

“I promise.”

Chapter End Notes

phainon baby youre on thin fucking ice.

▶ !!!!!!!!!!

Chapter 9: The Greatest

Chapter Notes

dont let the amount of fun i had with this chapter fool you

cw: alcohol, weed, implied sexual content, dubious consent

See the end of the chapter for more notes

PIANO CHANNEL OF AMPHOREUS
National Classical News Platform
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BREAKING: Pianist Phainon Khaslana Injured in Near-Fatal Car Accident / *3 mo. ago*

Castrum Kremnos Hall of Strife to Host 33rd Annual Concerto Competition

Okheman Organist Caenis Elda Has Died, Aged 98

Phainon Khaslana Spotted With Mydeimos Nikador After Injury

Styxian Violinist Helektra Phagousa To Become Marmoreal Orchestra's New Concertmaster

Maestra Aglaea Mnestia Refuses To Step Down Following Illness Diagnosis

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October 3869. Eight months before the release of Oracle.
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With their deadline growing closer and Phainon growing healthy enough to live relatively independently, the band takes a couple weeks off from writing to start recording with Ratio. Mydei was unsure of how it would work originally, but was pleasantly surprised by how much Ratio seemed to trust them. And even though Cipher has production knowledge and capabilities, he wouldn't trust her to touch the production software with a ten foot pole.

City of Thieves is the first song they finish, and hearing Caelus' trumpet solo altogether with the rest of it for the first time is enough to put a stupid grin on his face. Cipher snaps a photo of him that he sees later on her social media, in a slideshow with several other photos from the recording process. Her caption remains artfully cryptic, but the comments speculate nonetheless. One that sticks out to him reads "wow i've literally never seen mydei smile. this album is about to EAT". Unnecessary comment about the frequency of his smiles aside, Mydei is inclined to agree. This is, without a doubt, the best collection of music he's ever written.

Ratio agrees. The more songs they finish, the more praises he has to give. Mydei gets the sense that he doesn't have enough of those to go around, so he's more than happy to be the one to accept them.

Even with the break, though, Mydei can't stop himself from writing. He doesn't want to leave any idea untouched, and the one person in his closest circle that he's never written a song about was his mother.

He could never bring himself to do it. He couldn't even bring himself to write music in the months after her death, and by the time he was recording with Castorice and Cipher he didn't know them well enough to tell them about something like that.

Now, though, he's made peace with her death. He no longer spends his nights agonizing over what he could have done differently. He no longer feels guilty quitting piano, because he knows she would be equally proud of the success he's gotten himself now.

He spends weeks on this song alone, changing lyrics here and there and scratching out parts of the score until it's finally perfect. It's not a sad song,

not really—he's glad, if anything, that he wrote it now rather than when he was mourning her.

He calls it *Conqueror of Lions* and when he finally performs it to the band, on a stripped back version just on piano, he gets tears out of both Hyacine and Castorice. Cipher is close, he thinks, with the way she's made herself tiny in the corner of the couch and doesn't say much when he's done.

"Your mother sounds like an amazing woman," Hyacine says, stepping back when she's finished hugging him. "I'm sad I never got to meet her."

"You would have loved her," Mydei says. He's near tears, too, and the unsteadiness of his voice is hiding nothing. "All of you would've. Actually, I don't know how anyone couldn't."

Hyacine laughs, then moves to the whiteboard and uncaps a pink marker. Their list of songs is in a disorganized jumble to the left of the board, while on the right they have a working tracklist. Cipher's pitch of thirteen songs is the highest anyone had thought, so it goes to thirteen, even though none of the songs have a spot on it yet.

Hyacine writes *Conqueror of Lions* in the thirteenth slot, at the very end.

"The last song?" Mydei asks, standing from the piano to linger behind her. "Really?"

"Does anyone object?" Hyacine turns, pointing the marker at Castorice, and then Cipher.

Castorice shakes her head. "No. I think it's perfect."

Cipher doesn't object either, so it stays.

He's just dropped Phainon off at physical therapy the next week when he gets a text from Cipher alone out of nowhere. She's his friend, of course, but far from his closest friend in the band, so she rarely texts him alone.

Cipher
Today 11:58

hello little prince
r u busy rn

i have an hour of freedom.

ok
Attachment: 1 Location

?

ur dumb as bricks
go there

ok

The location in question turned out to be a cafe in the middle of the city, no more than five minutes from Phainon's physical therapist. He parks his car on the side of the road and enters the cafe, greeted instantly by the smell of coffee and bells jingling as the door shuts behind him.

There are a couple of people sitting down inside, and one barista who smiles at him as he enters. He musters a smile back—which probably doesn't look as friendly as he imagines it does—and scans the cafe for any sign of Cipher.

Nothing. He's about to pull out his phone to check he got the location right when someone taps him on the shoulder and appears in front of him, like magic.

"What the hell?" he sputters. "Where did you come from?"

Cipher flashes him a toothy grin. "Jumped through the roof," she shrugs. "Come on, little prince. We got a lot to talk about."

"Do we?" he asks faintly, following her as she approaches the barista at the counter.

“One triple shot espresso and one of your massive brownies, please,” she asks, pulling out her wallet. Mydei eyes the disaster that’s inside of it and shudders.

“Alright,” the barista says, tapping at his screen. “Are you two together?”

“Oh, no, no,” Cipher cackles, patting Mydei on the shoulder so hard he fears it might leave a mark. “He can pay for himself. Can’t you?” She coos, turning to Mydei.

“Cipher,” Mydei groans, rubbing at his forehead. To think he’s about to spend an hour alone with her is already driving him crazy.

The barista smiles awkwardly at that, and Cipher pays with a crumpled ten dollar bill. She makes a show of telling him to keep the change that Mydei knows is just because she’s too lazy to carry around coins, and Mydei steps up to order next as she finds a table.

“Sorry about her,” he murmurs, apologetic. “Do you have pomegranate juice?”

He ends up ordering a seasonal latte and approaches Cipher’s table as the barista works on their orders. “What kind of a cafe is this?” he complains, shedding his coat on the spare chair and sitting down across from her. “They don’t even have pomegranate juice.”

“No cafe outside of Kremnos would serve you pomegranate juice, you freak,” Cipher scoffs. “Barista was cute, wasn’t he?”

“What?” Mydei turns, eyeing him as discreetly as possible. His back is turned, messing with the espresso machine, so Mydei isn’t sure. He looks like he has some muscle underneath his apron, though, so he shrugs. “I mean, I guess.”

“Oh my god,” Cipher groans. “You’re not even checking people out without my help? Hopeless, you are.”

“Why the hell did you bring me here?” Mydei hisses, leaning over the table. “To talk about my love life? Seriously?”

“Geez, someone’s peeved,” Cipher holds up her hands in surrender. “I just thought I’d try to help a guy out, y’know?”

“I’m not *peeved*,” Mydei leans back, crossing his arms. “And I don’t need help in that area.”

“Clearly,” Cipher rolls her eyes. “I mean, look at you.”

“Triple shot espresso,” the barista says, sliding Cipher’s order across the table at her. “And your brownie,” He slides over a brownie that takes up the entire plate, and Mydei wonders how often Cipher frequents this cafe to know about their “massive brownie”. She seems more like the type of person to be a regular at a strip club than a cafe.

“And a pumpkin latte, for you,” he says to Mydei, giving him his coffee.

“Thank you,” Mydei says. The barista smiles and walks away.

“He’s totally into you,” Cipher says, the second he’s out of earshot.

“You think he’s into me because he *smiled at me*,” Mydei hisses. “Do you even hear how ridiculous you sound?” He picks up the spoon placed on the plate underneath his latte mug, and begins to stir it around.

“You only think that because you can’t understand social cues,” Cipher rolls her eyes. “Again, dude, *look at you.*”

Mydei closes his eyes, leaning further back into his seat. “I don’t know what you mean by that, and I’m not sure I want to,” he says, chewing at his lower lip.

“Dude,” Cipher says. “You’re, like, *hot.*”

An itching feeling climbs up the back of Mydei’s neck. He grimaces. “What?”

“Oh my god,” Cipher mutters, rolling her eyes. “Modest son of a bitch. You’re smoking, dude. I mean it.”

“Cipher,” Mydei groans, covering his face with his hands. Their sexualities had not exactly been a common point of conversation, but he was certain Cipher didn’t swing that way. “I thought you were a lesbian?” He whispers, leaning forward a little bit. He can only hope Cipher picks up the hint and lowers her voice.

“Uh, yeah?” she says, like that was obvious even with this conversation. “And I’m telling you you’re hot as fuck. So you should take it as a double compliment.”

“Please stop calling me that—”

“There’s something feminine about you,” Cipher continues. “I think that might be it. I haven’t quite been able to place my finger on what it is, though—”

“Stop.”

“—given that you’re six feet tall and pure muscle—”

“Cipher, please,” he begs, and she finally closes her mouth. “You can stop. I know my assets.”

“Oh my god, are you serious?” She’s getting dangerously close at this point, leaning more over the table with every word that she says. One of her sweatshirt strings is hanging into her coffee, but Mydei isn’t going to tell her about it as punishment for putting him through this conversation. “Your *assets?* Are you even a real person?”

“All I’m saying,” Mydei groans, “is that I know they like it when I take my shirt off.”

“Oh, you think your *abs* are the moneymaker? No, pretty boy, your torso would mean nothing if it wasn’t attached to that gorgeous face.”

“You have to stop.”

“*Pretty boy.* That’s so fitting. I bet, when you were bullied in high school, they loved to call you that.”

“I wasn’t bullied in high school.”

“*HA!* You were a classical pianist, and you want me to believe that?”

“I went to a music school. Can we move on now?”

“Fine, you win,” Cipher acquiesces, leaning back in her seat. She watches her hoodie string fall out of the cup and puts it in her mouth. “All I’m saying is you could have anyone you want, and you’re choosing… *celibacy?*” She shakes her head. “That wasn’t even in the list of options.”

“I never said I was celibate,” Mydei mutters.

“...Okay, ew…”

“Just that I don’t want a relationship right now. Is that so hard to believe?”

“No,” Cipher starts, and Mydei foolishly thinks for a second that he might have gotten through to her. “Because I *know* there’s someone you want.”

Mydei sighs, bracing himself.

“But I bet you’d want a relationship with *them*, though. Or should I say *him?*”

“*Cifera—*”

“You know I’m right,” Cipher’s voice is infuriatingly smug. “You weren’t even over that boy for a day. You can tell yourself all you want that you’re only happy for the chance to reconnect with an old friend, but you know the truth deep down. You know you want him back, that you’re in love with him, and have been for years.”

Mydei hangs his head. He doesn’t know why he can’t even tell her she’s wrong.

“Do you need me to clarify who I’m talking about?”

Mydei still doesn’t answer. Of course he doesn’t. But admitting that would only prove her point, and it’s too late to act confused.

“Phainon, Mydei. You’re in love with that pianist.”

“Why don’t we ever talk about *your* love life?” Mydei retorts, lifting his head. His hair hangs into his face, and he shakes it out of his eyes.

Cipher rolls her eyes. “Going great, pretty boy. Out of the two of us, I’m not the emotionally constipated one.”

“Oh, wow. *You* calling *me* emotionally constipated. That’s a first.”

“In these matters, yes. When I like someone I tell them.”

“You’re a terrible liar.”

“I’m an incredible liar,” Cipher scoffs. “See, just now, when you accused me of lying, you were right. Except you think I’m lying about the wrong thing.”

“Okay,” Mydei says, reaching for his drink as he attempts to decipher what she was *actually* lying about. He finds it’s too difficult, met with her elusive blue eyes. “Who’s the last person you liked, then?”

Cipher takes a very long sip of her drink through the straw. “No one you’d know,” she mumbles, when she’s done.

“How am I meant to trust a single thing you say?” Mydei throws his hands in the air, a little frustrated. He hates liars, which is why he had so much trouble getting along with Cipher when they first met. “Who is it? Who do you know that I wouldn’t, at least tangentially?”

“You don’t know my life,” Cipher answers.

“Cas?”

“No.”

“Hyacine.”

“No.”

“Fuck. Okay. Hysilens.”

“Hysi—no.”

“Hysilens’ little girlfriend.”

“Don’t call Cerydra *little*. No.”

“Robin.”

“What the fuck? No.”

“I’m out of girls. Phainon.”

“Phainon,” she deadpans. “*Believe me*, Mydei, he’s all yours.”

“Either you really do know other people, or you’re lying to me.”

“Wonder which one it is.”

“Stelle. Do you even know her?”

“Of course I know that little freak. No.”

“Cyrene.”

“Stop, Mydei.”

“March. Or her twin, the evil one.”

“You’re just pulling random people out of your ass, at this point,” Cipher closes her eyes, pressing her palms together like she’s praying. “If I tell you, will you stop?”

“Obviously?”

“It’s someone you already mentioned.” Cipher stares down at the wooden table between them, like the flimsy plastic menu is suddenly a lot more interesting.

“I knew it,” Mydei says, then thinks back to everyone he mentioned. “It’s Cas, isn’t it?”

“You totally believed me when I said no, though.”

“Holy shit,” Mydei breathes. He *had* believed her. In fact, he was so certain it must have been Castorice, that he was surprised when her “no” sounded true. “How long?”

“Enough about me,” Cipher says, waving her hand side to side. Mydei can sense the tiniest bit of fear in her voice. “*Phainon.* The real important part of this conversation.”

“I think you being in love with one of our bandmates is much more important.”

“Did I say in love?” Cipher feigns innocence, looking anywhere but at Mydei. “I don’t think I did. But you, Mydei, are in *love*.”

“I’m not, and I’m serious,” Mydei says, placing his elbows on the table and leaning over at her. “Seriously, Cipher. I’ve been over Phainon for years.”

“Hm,” Cipher pouts a little, lifts her cup to her mouth, and takes a tiny sip. She savors it in her mouth for a while before responding. “Yeah, okay. I believe you.”

Mydei sighs. “Now I can tell you’re lying.”

Cipher gasps. “Wow, good job, Mydei! You’re learning!”

Mydei can’t stand sarcasm on most days, but he always finds himself less irritated by Cipher’s because he can always, at least, tell that she’s being

sarcastic. He would say she makes her sarcasm more obvious around him on purpose, but he thinks that might be giving her too much credit.

“You can deny it all you want, but you should think about it,” she says, ripping a corner off her brownie and stuffing it in her mouth. She continues to talk around it. “It would do great things for our song tally if you could finally write some damn love songs.”

“Or you could,” Mydei suggests. “About Cas.”

“I will do no such thing,” Cipher says, swallowing her brownie. “But I am here to talk music.”

“Ah,” Mydei nods. “So all the bullshit about me being in love with my best friend was just, what, to throw me off?”

“Stop calling him your best friend before you really piss me off,” Cipher scoffs. “I’m getting serious now.”

“Oh,” Mydei raises an eyebrow, “okay.”

“I want a song,” she confesses. “Like,” she swallows, lacing her fingers together on the table in front of her. “I want to sing one.”

“Wait, seriously?” Mydei pushes his latte aside. He doesn’t have a problem with any of his bandmates being the main vocalist on a track instead of him, he just always assumed they didn’t want to. To think it would be Cipher, of all people, to volunteer herself first, throws him off.

She nods. “There’s this song that I think I need to write,” she says. “I thought we could write it together, and then both of us could sing it.”

“You can sing and play bass at the same time?” Mydei asks.

Cipher sighs. “Not…currently.”

“Okay,” Mydei says. “I see no problem if you think you could learn. What are you going to write about?”

“My, um…mother,” she admits, then sighs, leaning back in her seat in frustration. “You inspired me, okay? I’ve been such an asshole to Aglaea, when it could be so much worse. She could be dead.”

“Yeah?” Mydei starts, a little uncomfortable. “I guess she could?”

“You want to know,” Cipher says. Her tone isn’t accusatory, but Mydei feels like it might as well be. She sighs, sitting up straight in her chair. “Aglaea adopted me when I was thirteen,” she begins. “I was a shit kid, and an even worse teenager. I don’t know how she handled it, and one day, all my bullshit caught up to me, I guess.”

“She kicked you out?!” Mydei demands, incredulous.

“Not really,” Cipher says. “We had a huge argument, I was probably screaming at her. Aglaea never showed many emotions—cold as ice, as always—and it’s infuriating to be faced with nothing when you’re so pissed off you feel like you’re losing it. So I left, and didn’t go back for years.”

Mydei knows they must have reconciled at some point, since he and Castorice were allowed to stay there while they recorded their first EP.

“You know, I was just never the kind of kid a woman like her should’ve had,” Cipher continues. “I was a piece of shit. Had been my whole life. By the time she adopted me, she wasn’t going to be able to just…discipline that away. I felt like I belonged on a sidewalk, not in a mansion. We never really saw eye to eye on most things. She had her tailor shop, modeling agency, orchestra—nothing I was any fit for. I started the double with her guidance. She never said it out loud, but I know she hated when that switched to electric. When I started playing rock music.”

That must have been the reason Aglaea seemed so disdainful while they were there. Maybe she wanted them to start a string quartet, instead. Mydei almost laughs at the thought.

“I guess today, we’re kind of on good terms,” she says. “I just don’t talk to her or visit very often, because I don’t want to ruin the truce we have. She doesn’t push anything because she thinks that’s what I want. I know she

doesn’t approve of the life I’m living, but today, it’s more okay than it was when I was a teenager.”

“God,” Mydei breathes. “That is complicated.”

“Not really,” Cipher says, back to chewing on her hoodie string. “I know I’m wrong for how I’ve handled all of this.”

“Well, you’re a lot more self aware about all this than I was expecting.”

“So now you’re just calling me an ass. Thanks, Mydei.”

Mydei shrugs, because he sort of was, and isn’t going to deny it. “Anyways, your song. What do you have planned so far?”

As it turns out, she doesn’t have anything past the idea. Mydei is beginning to wonder how much of *Cat Food* was her contribution and how much of it was Castorice’s, at this point.

They don’t get that much done before Mydei has to leave, but it’s enough of a starting point for Mydei to work on instrumentals on his own time.

When he picks Phainon up after this meeting, he feels like he’s looking at him differently. There’s something about him as he climbs into the passenger seat and closes the door behind him that forces Mydei to pull his gaze away.

He’s been getting better. It’s slow, but he has more movement in his hands today than he did three weeks ago. He doesn’t shut down after physical therapy anymore, but Mydei can still see the presence of a deep sadness in his eyes.

Mydei thinks Cipher’s interrogation was pointless, because Mydei knows that he loves Phainon. He always has. Only now, he’s not really sure what that means for him.

They finish recording all the songs they have written on Halloween. It's a much bigger holiday in Penacony than anywhere else, as far as he knows, so he doesn't think much of it when he heads to the studio in the morning. Ratio walks into the room with some sort of wizard's hat on, grumbling something about company policy before immediately taking it off.

All they have left to do is touch ups, re-recording some backing vocals, and adding finishing touches to any parts that feel like they're missing something. It's still somewhat early in the afternoon when they leave, and Mydei can't wait to go to the gym and take a hot bath afterwards.

Unfortunately, though, all of his plans crumble the moment they make their way out of the studio.

"Excuse me, where do you think you're going?" Cipher asks in the parking lot, when he breaks away from the group to go to his car.

"What?" Mydei unlocks the doors, hearing it click. "Home?"

"No you are not. You're coming with us to the Halloween store."

"The Halloween store," Mydei deadpans. "Very funny, Cipher. Bye."

"It's a real thing," Hyacine supplies, looking at least a little more apologetic than Cipher. "Aren't you coming to the party tonight?"

"The party," Mydei looks between the three of them, sensing no sarcasm. He's never been more confused in his life. Maybe ignoring Halloween was just a Kremnoan thing?

"When was the last time you checked your DMs?" Castorice asks. Her voice sounds a little faint.

Mydei wracks his brain. Really, he has been almost completely offline ever since the photos of him and Phainon first started circulating. He'd open it here and then, but actually checking his messages was a completely different thing. "A long time ago," he answers. "Are you seriously telling

me you guys have been planning a party and haven't mentioned a thing to me in person?"

"It's not our party," Hyacine says. "We were just invited."

Mydei blinks. "*I* was invited."

"Why would we be invited and you wouldn't be?"

Mydei sighs, leaning back against his car door. "Do I have to go? Who's party is it?"

"The Astral Express," Cipher says. "They're in the area this month. It's in Sunday Oak's east coast mansion."

Any inkling of desire Mydei might have had to attend this party instantly dissipates. "Do I have to go?" Mydei asks again, voice near whining. He really doesn't want to do anything less.

"Yes," Cipher says, grabbing his wrist. She starts dragging him over to her car, and Mydei starts to wonder what excuses he could possibly make to get out of this. "It's good for meeting people in the industry."

"How many people are going to be there?"

"Phainon can come," is Cipher's idea of a suitable response, as she opens the passenger door and shoves him inside.

"Cipher. *How many people?*"

"It'll be small!"

They go back to his apartment after the "Halloween store", which was very much real, to get ready together. Mydei had bought Phainon a costume too, set on at least having him there so they could suffer through it together.

Cipher and Castorice both have similar costumes. They're both zombies, with similar makeup styles, except Cipher is in a suit, Castorice in a white dress. It looks a lot like a couples costume, and while neither of them say anything about it being such, Mydei can't help but remember what Cipher had said a couple weeks back when they first met up to work on the new song.

Hyacine is a witch, though not of the evil sort. She wears a short black dress with pink accents, ties her hair into pigtails, and puts on a pointy hat. She even has a little wand to go with it that she attaches to the belt of her dress.

Mydei's costume is a vampire—not his decision, but rather theirs. Hyacine slicks his hair back with a disturbing amount of gel, Castorice paints his face several shades paler, gives him dark circles, and blood-red lips. He hates the way the fake fangs feel in his mouth but is eventually convinced to leave them in at least for the beginning of the party.

Phainon is getting dressed while Mydei gets his make up done, and he nearly drops his phone as he walks into the living room area when it's his turn. "Oh," he says eloquently. "You look…good, Mydei." His eyes are wide open, blushing furiously. Mydei swallows down the undeniable realization that Phainon seemingly reciprocates his lingering feelings of attraction.

But attraction doesn't mean anything. It doesn't mean Phainon is in love with him, and it doesn't mean Mydei is in love with Phainon.

Besides, Mydei doesn't think he hides it any better, with the way he gawks at Phainon's waist in the pirate costume he had picked out. Maybe he picked it on purpose, maybe not. That was his secret to keep.

They end up arriving an hour late, around ten, and the party has very much started by then. It is by no means small. Mydei instantly feels out of his depth, and can only hope Castorice and Hyacine have done a good enough job making him unrecognizable.

They can see the flashing lights and hear the DJ from almost a mile away, but it's somehow a thousand times louder the second they enter.

Caelus greets them immediately, dressed as a superhero from a comic Mydei only vaguely recognizes—he was never very interested in superheroes.

“You made it!” he says, grinning ear to ear. Mydei thinks he’s mainly talking to Phainon, but they were all invited, so it’s not like he’s too out of place. “Phainon, how have you been? Getting better?”

“Slowly,” Phainon says sheepishly. “My hands are really ugly, though. Hence the gloves.” He lifts both his hands up to show him. The gloves only look a little out of place with his costume, but Mydei still thinks it would have been better without it. It was Phainon who insisted on wearing them.

“Ah, you’re still sexy, though,” Caelus says, with a wink. Mydei shoots Cipher a confused glance and leaves that conversation there, disappearing into the crowd.

Cipher follows close behind him, cackling. “You don’t think they were flirting, do you?”

“Of course not,” Mydei snaps. “Caelus is straight as a board. I need a drink.”

“Pfft, I wouldn’t be too sure about that, little prince,” Cipher finally catches up, falling into step beside him as he tries to find the food. “He’s had his fair share of homoerotic relationships.”

“How the hell would *you* know?”

“I know everything about everything.” Cipher steps in front of him, then, pulling him by his jacket sleeve directly over to the drinks table. “Use your eyes, dude. Not that hard.”

Mydei takes a long, deep breath, and begins to pour himself some punch. He doesn’t know if it’s spiked, but he hopes it is.

“I’m going to make shit happen with Cassie tonight,” Cipher confesses out of the blue.

Mydei immediately misses his cup and pours punch all over his hand. He curses, grabbing a nearby napkin and patting himself down. “What?” he asks. “Seriously?”

“Yeah,” Cipher says, overconfidently. “Watch and learn, heart eyes.”

“Heart eyes,” he looks at her, unimpressed. “That might be the worst one yet.”

“They’re your eyes, not mine,” she shrugs. “Seriously, though. You don’t think she, like, doesn’t like me, right?”

“I don’t know,” Mydei tells her. “According to you, I can’t even recognize my own feelings, so I’m not sure I’m the best person to ask something like that.”

“*Shit,* you’re so right…” she chews on her lip, staring off into the crowd.

“You two are practically wearing a couple’s costume, though. That’s a pretty good start.”

Cipher smirks, patting him on the shoulder. “Should’ve been your tactic,” she says. “But then you would’ve been stealing my genius idea.”

“Unlike someone, I’m not here to get laid,” Mydei rolls his eyes.

“Oh yeah? Why are you here, then?”

Mydei stares at her, unable to mask his obvious irritation. “I don’t know,” he says between his teeth. “Were this evening going my way, I would be asleep right now.”

Cipher cackles, patting his shoulder one more time. “Just keep drinking that nasty shit,” she says. “Who knows, maybe you’ll get lucky and wake up in his bed.”

“Yeah, right. Go away.”

Cipher actually listens, leaving Mydei by himself as he downs his first cup and immediately pours himself another. With each new day that passes, he's starting to feel less sure about the nature of his relationship with Phainon.

"Are you Kremnoan?"

Mydei nearly jumps out of his skin, having not seen the person who snuck up on him at all. She's tiny, barely up to his chest, with a mask obscuring most of her face and long brown pigtails. Mydei has never seen her in his life, though that's probably the case with most of the people here. "Um," he swallows, holding his cup closer to his chest. "Yes?"

"Hm," the girl fumbles through her skirts, before procuring a gun prop that looks suspiciously real. "Will you play a game of Belobogian Roulette?"

Mydei takes a tiny step back, hoping his discomfort isn't as obvious as he feels like it is. "What?" he asks, voice a little unsteady. "Is that real?"

"All you have to do is point this gun at my head and pull the trigger," she sing-songs, pointing the handle towards him. "And then we both hope it doesn't fire!"

"I know what Belobogian Roulette is," he murmurs. "No thank you."

"Hm," she says again, thankfully putting the gun down. "Shame." And then she skips away, whistling.

"*What the fuck,*" Mydei breathes, finishing off the rest of his punch before going in for a third serving.

"Who was that?" It's Phainon's voice, coming up from behind him. "What did she want?"

"For me to shoot her," Mydei says, voice tired.

"*What—*"

"Sparkle," Caelus says, still following Phainon around, apparently. "She's weird. I don't know why I invited her."

“Some people are really into their costumes, I guess,” Phainon shrugs.

“I don’t think it was an act,” Mydei says, at the same time Caelus says it “probably wasn’t an act.” Phainon looks between both of them, confused, then moves between them to serve himself some punch.

“Is this spiked?” he asks, ladle hovering beside his cup.

“Oh, yeah,” Caelus snorts. “Very. Be careful with that shit.”

Mydei is halfway through swallowing down the remnants of his third serving, and slowly lowers the cup down from his mouth. “Fuck,” he mutters, then tosses the cup into a nearby trash can.

“Dude, already? How much did you have?”

“Like three full cups,” Mydei admits. “How bad do you think that is?”

Caelus laughs heartily while Phainon shoots him an extremely concerned glance. “I suggest you start dancing now before you can’t walk anymore,” he says, clapping him on the shoulder. “Unless you’ve built up your tolerance from our college days.”

Mydei hasn’t, not even a little bit. He usually hates getting drunk. He doesn’t know why he’s so eager to tonight. He turns towards the crowd, which starts cheering as a new song comes on. Mydei doesn’t recognize it —he doesn’t exactly spend his time listening to party music.

“Who’s your DJ?” he asks, crossing his arms.

“Forgot her name,” Caelus says, shrugging. “I found her online. She’s popular in Natlan.”

“Huh,” Mydei stares at the crowd, where the rest of the band is dancing together. Cipher looks like she’s having the time of her life, Hyacine is jumping up and down, and Castorice looks extremely uncomfortable.

“Why? Should I request a CALAMITY song?”

“Do that and I’ll kill you,” Mydei says.

“Empty threat,” Phainon chimes in. “Do it. *Child’s Play.*”

“Why *Child’s Play?*” Mydei turns to him, frowning. “That song’s not even that good.”

“It’s the only song of yours you can dance to,” Phainon says. “Come on, Mydei.” He throws out his empty cup as Caelus walks away, hopefully not to the DJ booth, and lightly touches Mydei’s arm.

“Should you be dancing?” Mydei asks.

Phainon rolls his eyes. “I can dance, Mydei. Come on.” That makes enough sense to Mydei. He’d been showing off his progress occasionally, how he could bend his fingers enough to pick up a glass or cup now, but he couldn’t quite make a full fist yet. And his finger dexterity had a long way to go. A return to piano was, at the moment, a hope and a dream.

They group up with Cipher and the rest of the band, Hyacine pulling on his hand and yanking his arm up and down as she jumps.

“Come on, pretty boy,” Cipher yells over the loud music. “Kephale didn’t give you that ass for no reason!”

“*What?*” Mydei yells, looking at her in disbelief. “Don’t say that shit to me ever again!”

“You heard her, Mydei,” Phainon says. His voice isn’t much louder than a murmur, as he speaks right against his ear from behind him.

Mydei whirls around, placing his free hand that Hyacine isn’t holding against the side of his neck. “You’d like to see that, wouldn’t you?”

Phainon’s grin is blinding, and it makes Mydei feel a little lightheaded. Or maybe the overabundance of alcohol he had just had is finally starting to catch up with him. “I think anyone would,” he teases back. There’s a pit in his stomach. He doesn’t know where it came from, or how long it’s been there.

The first chord of *Child's Play* rings out around them, and it's a miracle Mydei doesn't throw up on Phainon's shoes right there.

The crowd cheers as the song continues, so loud that Mydei feels frozen in place, unsure what to do with this information. As his voice rings out around them, he can hear what feels like the whole room singing along with him.

"You hear that?" Phainon says, leaning in close as he says it. "You're famous, Mydeimos."

"Famous," Mydei scoffs. "Yeah, right."

"Little prince!" Cipher yells. "Hold this, would you?" Before he has a chance to process her words, he's hit in the face with her suit jacket. He lifts his hands, catching it, and glares in her direction, unimpressed. "Be a gentleman," she adds, with a wink.

"Asshole," Mydei mutters, folding the jacket over his arm. "Hey, where's Cas?"

"Getting a drink," Cipher says. She doesn't stop moving for a second.

Phainon is distracted by Hyacine, so Mydei uses the opportunity to slip away. He's never been a very big fan of dancing, anyway.

Castorice, as Cipher said, is pouring herself a cup of punch at the drinks table.

"Careful," Mydei says, coming up behind her. "Caelus said it's strong. I had three cups already."

"How strong?" She asks, dropping the ladle back into the bowl with her cup half full.

"Very? I don't know." Mydei rubs at his temples. "I already have a headache."

“I don’t usually drink, but…” she trails off, cup halfway to her mouth as she stares into the distance. “I’m nervous.”

“Nervous?” Mydei follows her gaze, met with the sight of Cipher, Hyacine, and Phainon dancing together. “Ah.”

Castorice takes a sip, makes a face, and puts her cup down. “You’ve dated many people before, right, Mydei?”

Mydei almost laughs. Were it anyone else, he would think she was calling him a whore. “Three,” he says. “Is that many?”

“By my standards,” she says. “I’m helpless when it comes to these things.”

“That’s okay,” he reassures her. “I’m sure she doesn’t mind.”

“Huh?” Castorice looks at him, flushing through her make up. “Do you know who I’m talking about?”

“Cipher?” He asks. His fingers are starting to feel hot. He tugs at his collar.

“Oh, Kephale,” she mutters. “Am I really so obvious?”

Mydei bites at his bottom lip. “No,” he says, leaning back against the table. “I guessed. I think.”

“I’ve tried so hard to deny it,” Castorice admits. “I don’t want to ruin things. She’s the best friend I’ve ever had. Wouldn’t she think it’s…well, inappropriate of me to harbor such feelings for her?”

“I really don’t think she’d think that,” Mydei says. Despite Cipher’s horrendous attempts at matchmaking between him and Phainon, he doesn’t think it’s his place to comment on Cipher’s feelings for Castorice. She could tell her that herself.

Speaking of Phainon, he can still see him in the crowd. He’s taller than nearly everyone around him. Mydei turns around and starts pouring himself another cup.

“You don’t?” Castorice looks at him, hope flickering in her round eyes.

“No, Cas,” Mydei says. He feels like he’s losing his grip on himself. He tries to blink the weariness out of his eyes, but it doesn’t work. In his haze, he spills the punch all over his hand. “Fuck. *Fuck.*”

Castorice grabs the ladle out of his hand, putting it back in the bowl. “Are you okay?”

“I am wonderful,” Mydei says, standing awkwardly as he waits for the liquid in his cup to stop spilling over the edge. “Shoot your shot, Cassie. Anyone would be lucky to have you.”

“Oh,” Castorice says softly. She’s a little flushed. “Well. Um, thank you.”

Mydei nods. He presses a hand to his forehead, and feels like the room is spinning as he does. “Fuck,” he mutters.

“Um, are you sure you’re okay?” Castorice asks, carefully placing a hand on his shoulder. Her touch is freezing, and he thinks he flinches.

“Yeah,” he murmurs. “I need to pee.”

He picks a direction and wanders in it, downing his cup as he goes. He tosses it in the closest trash can he can find, and out of the corner of his eye, he can vaguely see Phainon’s unmistakable head of white hair.

He stops walking, uncaring of how he might look as he stares without shame. Phainon is laughing, talking animatedly as he dances with a woman Mydei doesn’t know who has her arm around his neck. He laughs at something she says so loudly that Mydei thinks he can hear it, all the way from where he stands.

He feels sick. He turns, continuing his search for the bathroom. He pushes open a door he thinks must be it, only to find a small sitting room that nearly knocks him out with the smell of marijuana.

“What the *fuck*,” he hisses, bringing a hand up to his nose.

“Holy shit. No fucking way!” Some girl shouts, jumping up from where she’s seated and running up to him. “*Mydei?*”

Mydei blinks his eyes open. The woman in front of him *is* someone he recognizes, though it takes him a second to remember who. Her blonde hair is much longer than it was last time he saw her, but with the same purple streaks running through it. She’s dressed as a rockstar, which is an even bigger giveaway than the purple hair. “Hi, Serval,” he says, flashing her the best grin he can manage.

“Guys, wake up. This is *the* Mydeimos I’m talking about here,” she says, turning to the rest of the people in the room.

“Can you *shut it?* I’m locked in right now,” says another girl, sitting on the coffee table with her legs crossed. Mydei isn’t sure what her costume is supposed to be, but she looks like some sort of video game character. She’s holding a video game controller, eyes glued to the TV screen. Mydei has no idea what she’s playing, but it looks like some kind of first person shooter.

There’s another girl with a long white wig knocked out in the corner. Mydei doesn’t know her, but he thinks she’s also supposed to be a vampire.

“What’s up, Dei,” Stelle sits sprawled out across the couch cushions wearing what seems to be a felt trash can, with a smile on her face that never seems to fade. Her eyes are so bloodshot that Mydei has no choice but to assume most of the weed smell in the room is her doing.

“Don’t call me that,” he says, collapsing back against the door. “Did you smoke all of that shit?”

“Are you asking for some?” Serval says, going back to her seat on the other empty couch.

Mydei rubs at his temples. He knows it’s a bad idea, and he hates how long he considers it. He’s not quite past the point of no return just yet, but he knows that’s where he’s headed. “No,” he decides, as the last part of his good judgment fades. “Do you have any alcohol?”

“Sure,” Serval says, pulling a bottle and two shot glasses out of a plastic bag. It looks like incredibly cheap alcohol. Mydei doesn’t want to know who in this room bought it, or where they bought it from. That’s not information he needs right now. “That’s Acheron, by the way.” Serval says, as she uncaps the bottle and fills both glasses. “You should check out her music. She’s also a classical musician turned rockstar.”

“Acheron? Like the river?”

“Um…maybe?”

“*FUCK*,” the girl on the table yells, loudly enough to burst Mydei’s eardrums. She continues to yell at the TV, currently displaying a “deceased” screen, using more creative profanities than Mydei has ever heard in his life. Clearly he hasn’t been cursing to his full potential.

“Dude, chill the fuck out,” Stelle groans, grabbing a throw pillow and tossing it over her eyes.

“Why don’t you introduce yourself to our guest,” Serval suggests, handing him his shot glass. He takes it, clinks it against Serval’s own, and tries not to wince as they take them together. It’s been a long time since he’s taken a shot. It’s so much worse than he remembers.

“Silver Wolf,” the girl says, watching him over her shoulder.

Mydei blinks, unable to focus very hard on anything other than the taste in his mouth. “…Huh?”

She rolls her eyes. “My *name*, obviously.”

Mydei’s head is pounding. He puts the shot glass down on the table and puts all his energy into deciphering what this girl is trying to tell him. “…What?”

“Oh my god,” she mutters, turning back to her video game and selecting the respawn option.

“Her name is Silver Wolf,” Serval explains.

Mydei crashes against the cough cushions behind him. “Your name is Silver Wolf,” he confirms, to which she seems to nod very slowly. “What the fuck kind of parents did you have?”

Stelle giggles at that, vaguely reminding Mydei of her existence, as he begins to cough his lungs out at another fruitless attempt to get the alcohol taste out of his mouth.

Serval tosses him a plastic water bottle, which lands in his lap when he’s unable to process it fast enough. “Water,” she says, like that wasn’t obvious.

Mydei nods, taking a big swig of water. It’s cold going down his throat, and brings him more relief than he’d like to admit.

He can’t get the image of Phainon out of his head. He wants another shot.

“How drunk are you?” Serval asks, following his request.

Mydei shrugs. “Not enough.”

Serval sighs, reaching for the bottle to pour him another one. “I get it, man,” she murmurs. “The world is going to shit, y’know?”

The second one doesn’t go down any easier, but he has some water this time, which helps. “Cipher was right,” he admits, closing his eyes and falling onto his side. “I’m in love with him.”

Stelle giggles again, the sound muffled by the pillow over her face. “Yay,” she says, dragging out the word. “Young love.”

Mydei groans, rolling onto his stomach. Half his body is off the couch, the rest of him slowly sliding down until he falls onto the floor in a heap. “Ow,” he complains, rubbing his head.

“Mydei,” Serval says, and Mydei can faintly hear her stand up before she comes to kneel in front of him. “Are you okay?”

“No, no…” Mydei drawls, words slurring together. “No…”

“You’re *wasted*,” Serval decides. She tries to pull him to a sitting position, but it’s fruitless. “Seriously, Mydei, how much did you drink before this?”

“Not much,” Mydei presses his forehead into the carpet.

“Mydei, can you sit up? You need to drink some more water.”

Mydei pulls himself upright with much effort, reaching above him for the water bottle she had just given him. He can’t find it, until Serval gets up and hands it to him. “I need to pee,” he decides, stumbling a little as he gets to his feet instead.

“Okay,” Serval says, nodding. She guides him to the door, opening it and pointing across the room. “Over there. Make sure you drink the water, yeah?”

“Yeah, yeah,” Mydei says, waving her off. “Thanks, Serval…I love you.”

“Love you too, man. Come back here when you’re done, alright?”

Mydei can’t hear her that well, distracted by the earsplitting music once again. He doesn’t think the song they’re playing now is as bad as it was before, so he heads back towards the dance floor, Serval’s words and his original goal of going to the bathroom quickly forgotten.

Phainon is nowhere to be seen. Mydei moves through the crowd, knocked around by bodies hitting him as he stands in place, mesmerized by the flashing lights with nothing in his head but the sound of the music.

“Mydei!” He’s tugged in one direction, some girl’s hand on his wrist. He blinks, trying to make out who it is, and sees Cipher’s unmistakable gray hair and suit. She’s missing her jacket. Mydei vaguely remembers her giving it to him, but has no idea where he put it. “Having fun?” she asks, winking.

Mydei can’t form words. He doesn’t know if she’s twirling him around, or if the room is spinning on its own. He thinks it might be the latter.

“Where’s Phainon?” he asks. He squeezes his eyes shut like it might stop the room from collapsing around him.

“Over there,” Cipher says, pointing in another direction. “Last I saw him, anyway. Better hurry up, he’s a hot commodity tonight!”

Mydei tugs his arm away with as much force as he can muster, moving through the crowd to where she said Phainon was. He thinks he can hear someone call his name, but ignores it with one clear goal in mind.

Finally, he spots him—that head of white hair, bouncing up and down in the crowd. He’s taller than most people around him, even a little taller than Mydei himself.

“Phainon,” he murmurs, making his way toward him. “There you are.” He practically throws himself in the man’s arms, who doesn’t stop dancing for a second.

“Woah, hey there,” Phainon says, placing both his hands on Mydei’s shoulders. “How’d I get so lucky tonight?”

“Lucky?” Mydei asks, frowning. “You’re not lucky. I only want you.”

“Yeah?” Phainon whispers against Mydei’s ear. “How bad?”

Mydei pulls away. His eyes are so bright, almost blinding, so he looks down at his lips instead. They’re slightly parted, the most beautiful shade of red, even through the flashing lights. Mydei wants to kiss him so badly it hurts.

So he does, leaning in until there’s no room left. The feeling of Phainon’s lips on his sends tingles through his entire body. He feels like he could be floating as he presses his hips flush into Phainon’s body, like they can’t get close enough.

Phainon is greedy, licking into Mydei’s mouth with the same sort of urgency. One of his hands trails down Mydei’s back, pawing at his ass through the fabric of his pants.

Mydei pulls away, panting. “Bathroom,” he manages, then grabs his wrist and pulls him away.

He bumps into no less than ten people, on his way out of the crowd, and his hip slams against the drink table. Phainon catches him, one hand on his back. “You okay?”

“Yeah,” Mydei whispers. “Never better.”

He pushes Phainon against the bathroom door the second they’re inside. He thinks it’s empty, and his fingers trip over each other as he locks it. He can’t see straight. He can’t feel his tongue. He thinks he’s started to see the world in 8-bit.

There are no more clear thoughts in his head as he sinks to his knees. He fumbles with the belt buckle before him for so long, he’s not sure how it actually comes loose.

The last clear thing he can remember is the feeling of strong hands grabbing fistfuls of his hair.

Chapter End Notes

> if you caught where this is going, im sorry that i do this shit to you all the time. like i really am. it's unfortunately a lot of fun for me. LOL
>
> ▶ more
>
> thank you :)

Chapter 10: True Blue

Chapter Notes

i love this chapter so much, for many reasons. please excuse its length it was not intentional <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

youtube.com
CALAMITY: Christmas Special
@ipcmusic 7.2M views 12/25/69

Comments 3.8K

@number1mydeifan • 1h ago (edited)
The new song is INSANE. Whoever he's singing about seriously needs to wake up and realize just what they're missing. I've never seen him quite so angry.

@user211212121 • 30m ago
200 credits on Phainon Khaslana

@number1mydeifan • 27m ago
@user211212121 Stop.

@user211212121 • 26m ago
@number1mydeifan Dude this is like thinking the stripper likes you

@chrysanthemum • 16m ago
@user211212121 How about we leave them both alone and stop being parasocial? Whether or not Mydei is dating Phainon Khaslana has nothing to do with any of us. He can date whoever he wants.

@number1mydeifan • 10m ago
@chrysanthemum Exactly.

@lukewarm123 • 46m ago
God, real music is back.

@bronaaideen62 • 12m ago
Wow, I wasn’t a fan before I watched this video because I don’t really like rock music. He’s so versatile. And I didn’t know the girls could sing, too. Safe to say I've been wasting my life away by not listening to them.

@eeeeeeeejjjj • 1m ago
Who’s Phainon Khaslana?

~~~

November 3869. Seven months before the release of Oracle.

Mydei wakes up with a sore throat and a splitting headache. He opens his eyes to the unbearable sunlight filtering in through his windows, squinting as he sits up.

He’s in his room. At home. He has no memory of getting here, or what happened last night. All he remembers is all of the drinks he had—and Phainon. He was dancing with someone else. Which is fine. He’s perfectly welcome to dance with whomever he likes.

Mydei feels sick. He doesn’t know what, exactly, causes this nausea for him, but he stumbles out of bed and runs to the bathroom to empty his guts out into the toilet.

He doesn’t know how long he’s throwing up, but he feels warm hands on his neck, pushing his hair out of his face to the best of his ability. His hands are too stiff, and a few strands of hair still fall out of his grasp. But Mydei’s stomach flutters at the gesture alone. “Good morning, Mydei,” Phainon says. “Are you feeling okay?”
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Mydei groans, resting his hands on his thighs. He's not confident he's done. "No," he grumbles.

Phainon laughs lightly. "Yeah, you had a rough night," he says, pressing the palm of one of his hands to Mydei's forehead. Mydei can feel his scars, rough against his sweating skin. He needs to shower.

"What happened?" Mydei reaches for the toilet paper, rolling out a few sheets of it and using it to wipe his mouth clean.

"Um," Phainon sounds sheepish, letting go of Mydei's hair completely and sitting down fully beside him. "We found you in the bathroom," he explains. "Hyacine told us to put you on your side and give you water. Serval came in, saying she was looking for you, and that you had done some shots together. Do you know how much you drank?"

Mydei closes his eyes, flushing the toilet. He thinks he feels a little bit better now. "I think so," he says. "It wasn't that much."

Phainon sighs. "You know you're a lightweight."

"Yes."

"I've never seen Hyacine so upset. Didn't think she had it in her. She thought Serval was pressuring you, or something."

"No. I'm sorry."

"Tell that to Hyacine," Phainon huffs. "I think she lost years off her life ensuring you got home safe."

"Fuck," Mydei groans. He closes the toilet seat so he can lean on it, elbows crossed in front of him. He knows it's gross. He'll shower later. "This is why I don't drink."

"Yes, maybe you should take a break for a little while." Phainon puts a hand on his back. Mydei's throat tightens at the comfort it still seems to give him. Comfort Phainon *knew* he was offering. "By the way, how has your spine been recently?"

“My spine?” Mydei squints as he turns to him, resting his cheek on his arms. “Oh, yeah.” It had been so long since the last time he’d felt the pain in his vertebrae, that he had forgotten all about it. “Good,” he says. “It hasn’t hurt since, like…July. I think.” He swallows, as the irony of that statement is not lost on him. But if Phainon doesn’t notice the correlation, he has no reason to bring it up.

“Does your throat hurt?” Phainon asks next, tilting his head to the side. “Your voice sounds rougher than usual.”

“Yeah,” Mydei says. “I need water.”

Phainon nods, getting to his feet in an instant. Mydei watches him leave, staring at his back as he heads down the hallway and disappears into the kitchen.

Whatever he felt for him wasn’t platonic, he knew that now. But he also knew that on Phainon’s end, it was. That much was clear as day.

He puts his head back down. He’s starting to feel sick again.

Phainon comes back moments later, before Mydei has managed to calm his stomach back down. There’s a big glass of water he’s holding with both his hands, carefully handing it to Mydei before sitting beside him again. “Try to finish it, yeah?”

Mydei nods, taking it from him. He downs half of it in one gulp. It makes his throat feel slightly better, but he still feels like he could throw up any second. There’s a strong possibility that it’s Phainon’s presence alone causing him to feel this way.

“Do you think you could eat something?”

Mydei’s stomach rumbles. “Yeah, but if you make me a salad, I’ll kill you,” he says, before drinking the rest of the glass.

Phainon is as good-natured as always, and laughs. “Of course not, Mydei. And I won’t burn down your kitchen, either.”

“You better not,” Mydei growls, pulling himself up to his feet. “I need to shower.”

Phainon nods, closing the bathroom door behind him as he leaves. Mydei drinks another half glass of tap water as he waits for the shower to heat up, staring at himself in the mirror. He looks rough. Most of the makeup on his face has been washed off, though some of it remains in the form of dark, running eyeliner under his eyes. His hair is a mess, but thankfully someone —probably Phainon—had changed him out of his costume.

He’s shirtless, and at the sight of faint hickeys on his neck, he feels his blood run cold.

He has no memory of receiving those. No memory of whoever it was who gave them to him, but he knows it can’t possibly be Phainon, or he would have mentioned something by now. If he had gotten to that point with Phainon, he would have confessed his feelings under the influence. Things would have been different this morning. Mydei knows how his own body reacts to alcohol well enough by now.

He doesn’t know what he said to whoever gave him these. He doesn’t know what else they did, but he hopes it’s not what he thinks it is, given the ache in his throat.

His thoughts continue into the shower. Phainon hadn’t said anyone was with him when they found him, which implies he hadn’t seen. But the hickeys on his neck were so obvious, with him shirtless like this, that he had to have known by now.

The worst part is that he doesn’t seem upset. If Mydei had hooked up with someone else, and Phainon reciprocated his feelings, he wouldn’t have acted like this. He would have distanced himself, moped around and flashed fake smiles when Mydei asked. He wouldn’t have been this caring and gentle, even if he knew he had to take care of Mydei as per Hyacine’s instructions.

Mydei’s eyes burn, and he can’t tell if he’s crying or got shampoo in his eye. He hopes it’s the latter. He can’t deal with something like this right

now, on top of everything else he's supposed to do.

Or, he can. He freezes as the realization comes to him that something like rejection this intense would be the perfect thing to write a song about. Or multiple. Or a thousand. However many it takes until he's finally over him, and for good this time. He's *determined* for it to be "for good" this time.

He leaves the bathroom in a towel, having forgotten clothes in his bedroom. He picks out jeans and a t-shirt, before searching for his phone. It's plugged in on the floor, and Mydei turns it on to find that it's almost two in the afternoon.

He has missed text messages from nearly everyone he had seen at that party: Castorice, Serval, Cipher, Caelus, and most notably, Hyacine. Despite Phainon's warnings, her messages are the ones that sound the least concerned. She has written a couple paragraphs to him that are almost clinical in how they read, with detailed instructions of what to do to feel better, before finally reprimanding him and telling him he was very stupid. She then requests that he text her when he wakes up, so he does. Then he takes some time replying to everyone else as well, before leaving his phone where it is and returning to the bathroom.

When he emerges, Phainon has cooked him breakfast, despite the time of day—two eggs, sausage links, and oatmeal with bananas and honey. He has another large glass of water set out, as well as a smaller one filled with pomegranate juice.

Mydei stares at the meal before him. Phainon rarely cooked for him in college, given that neither of them had access to a kitchen, but Phainon always called his own cooking "mediocre". Either he was lying about his skill level, or he had greatly improved in their years apart.

Regardless, it's such a loving gesture. Mydei would give anything for that to be the intent behind it, too.

"Do you have to go anywhere today?" Phainon asks. He's wearing Mydei's apron that often hangs in his kitchen, unused.

Mydei feels near to tears. “No,” he says, softly. “Thank you for breakfast, Phainon. It looks amazing.”

Phainon beams at that, hands reaching behind him to gingerly untie the apron. He hangs it back up on its peg near the fridge and turns to the sink, beginning to do the dishes.

“Phainon, was I…” he swallows, halfway through cutting up his eggs. “*With* anyone…last night?”

The pan makes a loud clanging noise as Phainon drops it into the sink, pulling his hands away so as not to injure them further. He curses, grabbing a nearby kitchen towel to dry the counter. Mydei would offer to clean the kitchen for him, but that would only upset him. He’s found that Phainon is much more amicable when Mydei mentions his injury as rarely as possible.

“Sorry,” he mumbles, and Mydei can just barely see him blushing, unable to look at him directly.

Well, that was as good an answer as any. Mydei bites his lip, willing his heartrate to slow. It wasn’t productive to dwell on someone who didn’t like him back—but *dwelling* seemed to be all he was able to do when it came to Phainon.

“Briefly,” he admits. “I don’t know who he was. I don’t know what you two did, um, but you were fully clothed when we found you.”

Mydei looks back down at his plate. “Right.” He supposes it’s enough reassurance to know that his dignity remains somewhat intact. He resumes cutting up his eggs, then takes a bite of one along with some sausage. He bets it would taste incredible if he was in the right headspace.

“How do you feel?” Phainon asks. He clears his throat before he continues. “About him.”

“Indifferent, I suppose,” Mydei says breezily, though indifference is the last thing he feels right now. “I don’t know the guy.”

“He took advantage of you.” Phainon says firmly, nearly cutting Mydei off. He says it like he had wanted to say it all day. “He’s a dick.”

“Hm,” Mydei looks down at his food. So the only reservation Phainon had about the whole thing was about consent. Right.

“I’m serious, Mydei,” Phainon says, turning around to look at him. “You could barely stand when we found you.”

“So?”

“*So?!*”

“You don’t know what happened.” Mydei stabs one of the sausages so hard that his fork clangs against the plate. All the food tastes like rubber now. Mydei doesn’t know if he’s more annoyed about that, or Phainon’s bullshit this morning.

“I know enough,” Phainon says. His voice is tight. He’s been scrubbing at one spot in the frying pan for what feels like minutes now.

“No, you don’t. You weren’t there.” Mydei puts his fork down. Now he’s lost his appetite altogether.

Phainon drops the pan into the sink, uncaring as the sound of it rings out around them. He shuts the water off with more aggression than was ever necessary, turning around to look at Mydei. “So, what, you wanted it, then?”

Mydei huffs under his breath. “Of course I did. So what?”

His gaze hardens, and Mydei can see it from all the way across the kitchen. That upsets Phainon. Mydei can’t possibly fathom *why.*

“It was a one night stand, Phainon,” Mydei continues. “You seem awfully preoccupied with a stranger for someone who has no reason to care.” He regrets saying it immediately.

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?” Phainon’s brow is furrowed now. Mydei hates that he always seems to be most attracted to Phainon when he’s angry. Damn him—to think he’s feeling this *now*, of all times.

“Nothing.” Mydei looks away. Back down at his plate, where he picks up his fork again so he can pretend to pick at the food.

“Don’t *lie* to me, Mydei,” Phainon’s tone might be near pleading if it wasn’t already so rough with anger. “You’re acting weird. It’s not *nothing*.”

“You’re the one acting weird.”

“Because I’m upset!” Phainon bursts. His movements are jerky, like he doesn’t know where to put his hands. “Some asshole drags you into a bathroom to go fuck when you’re blackout drunk, of *course* I’m going to be upset!”

Mydei’s stomach twists. He doesn’t think they fucked, but then again, neither does Phainon. It’s only the intent that he cares so much about. “Right,” he mutters bitterly.

“*Mydei*.” Phainon tries. He’s sounding more distressed by the second. “Can you—”

“If I wasn’t drunk,” Mydei starts, quietly. It’s enough to cut Phainon off completely. “You wouldn’t care.”

Phainon inhales sharply. “That’s bullshit.”

“Is it?” Mydei looks up at him. “You’re not upset about the fact that I was with someone last night. So drop it. I wanted it, it doesn’t matter.”

Phainon goes still. He’s staring at Mydei in disbelief, and then something in his gaze softens ever so slightly. When he speaks, his voice is careful, like he’s choosing each word as it comes. “Would you want me to be upset about that?”

Mydei knows where this is going. He can’t allow it to pass. He can’t stand to embarrass himself more than he already has. “No,” he says. His throat is

tight. “I’m just saying you’re making this too big of a deal.”

Phainon laughs, but it’s completely devoid of any humor. “You—” he closes his eyes, running both of his injured hands down his face. “You are unbelievable.”

“*I’m* unbelievable—?”

“*Yes*, Mydei!” Phainon shouts. “Think about it. If it were me last night, you can’t tell me you wouldn’t be pissed off.”

“I wouldn’t care,” Mydei responds, as calmly as he can manage right now. “If you want my *permission* to go get laid, you have it. Do whatever you want.”

Silence blares between them. Phainon’s eyes are still wild, but he doesn’t move. He’s angrier than Mydei has ever seen him.

“Oh my god,” he mutters, disbelieving. “Whatever. You win.”

Phainon walks off without another word, and Mydei hears the guest bedroom door slam seconds later. The dirty dishes are still in the sink. At least now Mydei can do them without feeling guilty.

He swallows thickly. It doesn’t feel like a good win. If anything, now he feels even worse.

“Cipher, you have to tell me,” he groans, when they meet up at the cafe the next day. “Who did I hook up with at that party?”

Cipher nearly pisses herself laughing, and she’s still recovering by the time the barista has delivered their orders to them. “You *forgot?*” she cackles, completely disregarding the barista. “You forgot about Big Phainon?”

“*Big Phainon?*” he demands, leaning over the table and lowering his voice. “What the hell are you talking about?”

“You made out with him—in front of everyone, mind you—and then dragged him into the bathroom. It was quite the spectacle, actually.”

“Oh my god,” Mydei thinks this is the closest he’s ever gotten to becoming suicidal. “What’s with that nickname? Phainon is already big.”

Cipher feigns gagging. “Not what I wanted to hear in front of my brownie.”

“I’m not talking about his—” Mydei picks up the specials menu on the table and smacks her over the head. “He’s *tall*, Cipher,” he hisses, leaning forward and hoping no one around them has heard their conversation.

“Yeah, well, this guy was even bigger,” Cipher states. “And he had the hair. Light blond, you know? And a little charming. And—wait, you didn’t *actually* hook up, did you?”

Mydei closes his eyes. He’s not about to explain to her how far he suspects they went, and he thinks she wouldn’t appreciate it if he did, anyway. “Fuck,” he groans.

“Mydei—did you fuck that guy?”

“*No,* Cipher. Enough.”

“Oh, thank Kephale,” she whispers. “You were *gone* when we found you, dude. Like, scary shit. Hyacine was in full doctor mode.”

“Fuck,” Mydei mutters. “I probably thought he was Phainon.”

“Wouldn’t put it past you, in that state. I thought he might have been Phainon, too, when I saw you with him, until I saw Real Phainon watching.”

“So he saw.”

“Yup,” Cipher says. She picks the cherry off the piece of cake Mydei had ordered and pops it into her mouth. “Didn’t look like he was enjoying the show.”

Mydei furrows his eyebrows. He didn't think Phainon would have *enjoyed* it, necessarily, but the way Cipher puts it makes it seem like it was glaringly obvious. "He didn't?"

"Of course he didn't, dumbass," Cipher gives him a look like she can't believe she has to say it. "Phainon was pissed. He was about to kick the shit out of that guy when we found you."

Mydei rests his head in his hands. That much was, unfortunately, clear. Phainon just wasn't upset about the right thing.

"I mean, you were really out of it, Mydei," Cipher continues, face dropping a little. "He thought—well, you know. You know what he thought."

"I didn't—say anything, right? When you found me later?"

"Nothing that made any sense," Cipher reassures him. "I don't even know if you recognized us."

"That's probably for the best," Mydei mutters. He's been stirring his coffee up mindlessly for a couple minutes now, and finally sets the spoon down on the side of his plate.

"So you finally came to terms with it, then?"

Mydei knows exactly what she's talking about. He feigns ignorance anyway. "Came to terms with what?"

"Your love for Phainon, obviously?"

"I…" Mydei runs a hand through his hair. "...don't know what you're talking about."

"Oh my god."

"Anyways, you and Cas—?"

Cipher rolls her eyes, collapsing forwards until her forehead hits the table. "No," she mumbles, voice muffled. "She got drunk, too. I didn't want it to

happen like that."

"Makes sense," Mydei says, shrugging. "Well, I think you should have a pretty big chance if you just talked to her."

"Hm," Cipher muses, before snapping her head back up. "Do you know something?"

Mydei smiles, shrugging.

"Mydeimos. *Do you know something.*"

"*Talk to her,* Cipher. I'm not going to wingman for you."

"Stupid, boring Kremnoan," Cipher mutters. "Fine. Choose the least helpful option."

"Whatever, man," Mydei answers. "Are we going to finish this damn song, or not?"

The song, called *Lies Will Always Be Lies,* is not finished by the end of their session, though it's ready to present to the rest of the band. They do so at the start of the next week, and Cipher elects not to tell the story behind it. Despite her experience being at the forefront, helping her to write it caused Mydei to develop his own connection to it, as well. He's not sure what it's about to him, but it still feels like it's his song, too.

They've started meeting at the IPC building again. All their equipment has finally moved out of his living room, so he's back to his own space. Castorice, who lives closest to his apartment, drives him to work every morning so that Phainon can use Mydei's car while he's gone. They decided that he would stay in Mydei's place until physical therapy ended, which would run until the end of the year. Mydei doesn't know which he feels more: dread for that day to come, or excitement.

Now that they're writing and recording in the same space, the two things have started to happen at once. Mydei coaches Cipher throughout her recording session of *Lies Will Always Be Lies*, and—as Madam Herta once

said—he cannot emulate emotion, but she finds it without him during her solo bridge. A year ago, he would never have expected to say that he witnessed some of the most touching singing out of anyone in the band from none other than Cipher herself. Maybe she wasn't lying about being emotionally intelligent after all.

"That's great, Cipher," Ratio says, when she finishes her first recording session. "Mydei, I think you'd make an excellent professor one day."

Mydei snorts laughing, and finds that he rarely feels as happy as he is in moments like these. "I think I'd have to go back to school for that, doc."

Ratio shrugs. "Maybe if you studied production, you'd be motivated to get a PhD."

"Yeah right," Mydei says. Why would he do anything else, when he could do this for the rest of his life?

They listen to Cipher's every instruction as they continue to record. Allowing himself to get bossed around by Cipher while he records the acoustic guitar is not something he ever thought he would do. And then she proceeds to tell him that the tone of his voice isn't right. She doesn't know what he needs to change to get it right, but she knows what she wants. Mydei appreciates that.

Hyacine and Castorice get significantly less shit from her during their turns—she merely tells Hyacine that the electric guitar needs to be "bloodier", which neither Mydei nor Ratio understand. But eventually, she gets it. Castorice plays her part perfectly, and Cipher only interrupts to ask if they can add a tambourine. Ratio obliges in production.

It takes about a week for them to finish it, but listening to *Lies Will Always Be Lies* in full at the end of production has Mydei thinking it might end up being one of his favorites on the album. It's good. It wouldn't be nearly as good if it weren't for Cipher and everything she had added to the track. Her voice alone is one thing, but her vision for the song is strong.

As Castorice is driving him home, he gets a group email from Aventurine. He notifies her, and she turns her music down so he can read it aloud.

Promotional Christmas Concert
Aventurine Kakavasha
To: Cifera Mnestia; Mydeimos Nikador; Hyacinthia Seliose; Castorice Thanatos
Cc: Jade Evelyn; Topaz Jelena; Veritas Ratio; **+3 others**

Greetings and good afternoon,

I hope this email finds all of you well. Dr. Ratio informs me the album is coming together splendidly, and I am writing to inform you of an incredible opportunity I have just secured. In order to promote the album, I would like to do a small concert around Christmastime. It will be recorded in the studio, in an intimate setting, and all videos will be posted online.

As for the songs you choose to perform, it is completely up to you. You could do old songs, or mostly covers, which might be more beneficial if they are popular songs. As for new songs, one should be sufficient. Make sure you choose this one wisely. I will ensure Dr. Ratio agrees with your choice before we move forward with the preparations.

More information will come soon regarding costuming and set design. Please inform me or Dr. Ratio as soon as you have your final setlist picked out, and accommodations will be made to fit. All additional backing instrumentals and vocals will be recorded by you beforehand.

Best,
Aventurine Kakavasha
Band Manager | Tour & Operations Manager
CALAMITY

“Oh my god,” Castorice says, the closest to a squeal Mydei has ever heard from her. “This is so exciting. I love shows like these.”

“Do you have any ideas?” Mydei asks, turning his phone off.

“*Crucifixion*,” Castorice says instantly. Mydei laughs, as it’s the song currently playing from her car radio—the title track of High Cloud Quintet’s most famous album.

She turns the volume back up, and Mydei listens to it—it’s far from the first time he’s heard the song, but he somehow feels like he’s using a fresh pair of ears. They could actually do this song. He’s not the biggest fan of the High Cloud Quintet anymore, and neither is Castorice—both of them are much more casual listeners than they were when they were teenagers, when they were actually the band’s target audience. But a lot of their audience *is* High Cloud Quintet fans. Even though they don’t make music anymore, it’s like a rite of passage for all teenagers to become superfans of that band at some point.

Regardless, it’s a tribute that wouldn’t go unappreciated. It’s not a bad idea at all.

Castorice drops him off soon after that. Riding high off another day of success, he’s in a fantastic mood as he unlocks the apartment door.

He nearly jumps as he’s met with music the second the door cracks open. Phainon had an infuriating tendency to keep to himself in Mydei’s apartment, a habit Mydei was hoping he would have broken by now.

He’s overjoyed to discover that Phainon isn’t just playing music, he’s making it. He toes his shoes off and sheds his jacket as quietly as possible, coming to stand in the doorframe as he watches Phainon play in the living room.

It’s a simple piece, one most beginners can play after being acquainted with the instrument for no more than a year. Phainon plays slowly, careful not to strain his fingers too much. It’s clear he’s trying to get used to it again with

his new skin, but Mydei can't stop himself from grinning ear to ear nonetheless.

Mydei claps when he finishes, and Phainon jumps when he looks over his shoulder. "*Shit,* Mydei—warn a guy next time, will you?"

"I didn't want you to stop," Mydei explains. "You sound good. It's been so long since I've heard you play."

Phainon sighs. He looks dejected when he turns back to the keys, chewing at his bottom lip. "I guess it's a start."

"Even without the injury, you wouldn't be at the level you were at before if you didn't play for four months," Mydei says.

"And I never will be," Phainon mumbles under his breath.

"Keep practicing," Mydei drops his bag on the coffee table and takes a seat on the couch. "You never know what might happen." Mydei knows Phainon will never stop practicing. Even if he's never at the level he once was at, being able to hold onto some part of it will still be enough for him. Even if he can't make money off his performances anymore, that doesn't matter, because it was never about that for him. As long as his fingers can still move, even if it's only a little bit, Phainon will keep playing.

Phainon doesn't look very happy, but he turns back to the keys anyway. Mydei pulls out his laptop and listens to him continue his practice as he starts his search for songs to cover.

There's no sheet music in the apartment at the level Phainon is playing at, so Mydei knows he's going through these songs from memory. Both of their childhood piano coaches insisted on having them memorize their pieces, and yet Mydei does not think he could do what Phainon does now.

"What are you doing?" Phainon eventually asks, spinning around on the bench.

“Picking out songs for a mini show we’re doing soon,” Mydei explains. “We’re doing covers.”

“That’s so cool,” Phainon says. “Can I come?”

Mydei looks up, studying him for a moment. He doesn’t know why, but it’s not what he expected him to say. “I don’t know,” he says finally. He doesn’t. He always assumed these sorts of things just had crew members in the audience, rather than being an actual live concert. “I’ll get back to you on that.”

“Okay,” Phainon says. He spins around once. Mydei gets the sense that he wants to ask something, so he stops what he’s doing and looks up.

“What?”

“Huh?”

“You want to ask something. So ask.”

“Okay,” Phainon says, laughing nervously. “I was just wondering if, um, you needed your car tonight…?”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “Are you going somewhere?” There’s a pit forming in his stomach. He tries to swallow down his rising dread.

“I,” Phainon starts. “Well. I. I have a, um, a date.”

“A date,” Mydei deadpans. He forgets to feign excitement.

“Yes,” Phainon says. “Is that…okay?” His eyes are wide, hopeful.

Mydei gives him what he wants. “Yes,” he says. “I’m not going anywhere.”

“Right,” Phainon stands. “Okay.” He clears his throat. “I’ll go get ready, then.”

Mydei stares at the spot where he just was. He’s overcome with an unbearable desire to rip something apart. It’s admirable, how he’s

maintained his composure so well thus far.

He can’t even go to the gym, because Phainon is taking the car. He’ll just have to go tomorrow morning, and hope he restrains himself well enough until then.

He looks back down at his computer, at the working list of cover songs he was typing into a new document. Now, it’s the least of his worries. There’s a new song he has to write—excerpts of it have already been floating around his head for nearly two weeks now. Since the Halloween party, really. He has working lyrics in his head and one piano riff he wrote into Sibelius so he wouldn’t forget it.

He plugs in his headphones and works on expanding the piano part, barely noticing Phainon come out of his room half an hour later with his hair slicked back and a suit on. The sight of him puts a lump in his throat. It’s unfair, the way he looks.

“Bye, Mydei,” Phainon says, voice faint through Mydei’s earbuds. He sounds a little apologetic, but Mydei can’t fathom why that might be.

“Have fun,” Mydei responds. He doesn’t look up from his computer. The less he sees of him in that suit, the better.

The door closes, and Mydei finds himself engulfed in impossibly lonely silence. There can’t possibly be anything worse than this, he thinks. His apartment empty, darkened by Phainon’s absence, every wall closing in on Mydei along with the devastating realization that any hope he might have had left has officially dissipated entirely.

Just the thought of Phainon at some fancy restaurant, sitting across from another man or woman, charming them past the point of no return with that killing smile of his. It makes Mydei feel sick. The first person Phainon expresses interest in should marry him if they know what’s best for them. Mydei just happened to be too late to do it first.

He turns back to his computer, giving the silence around him nothing more than an annoyed sigh. Phainon was perfectly welcome to date whoever he

wanted. It was Mydei's own fault for being a coward and refusing to at least try to get him back first.

Lyrics come quickly. He writes like his hands are on fire, uncaring for rhyme schemes or making it sound pretty. He just needs to say what he needs to say first—he can make it good later.

Halfway through the bridge, he calls Castorice. Not because he needs inspiration from her, but because he needs to calm down. He's worried that he's making it too aggressive, to the point where Phainon would drop dead on the spot if he heard it.

She picks up on the fourth ring. Mydei can hear faint rock music playing in the background, as well as what sounds like an oven fan. "*Hi, Mydei,*" she says, a little breathless. "*I'm cooking dinner. What's up?*"

"What are you making?" Mydei asks. The mention of cooking makes him temporarily forget his grievances in the first place. He hasn't had dinner yet, either, but he'll probably just have leftovers at this point.

"*It's soup day!*"

"Soup day?"

Castorice makes a noise of affirmation. "*The day before I get groceries, I make a soup with all my leftover ingredients. I'm roasting broccoli but I think it's gonna burn—hold on, Mydei, let me put you on speaker—*"

She cuts out for a minute, and then Mydei can hear her surroundings in much more perfect clarity than before. "Broccoli cheddar?" he asks.

"*Not quite.*" She laughs, then continues, "*That's what I'm trying to do, but I'm adding a bunch of other stuff to it too. It might be bad.*"

"It sounds good. I haven't had soup in months."

"*Mydei, you're missing out!*"

He’s not that much of a soup guy. He tries to eat meat with every dinner, and he much prefers it in its original form, where he can tear through it like a wild animal. It brings him a great deal of joy. “Anyways, Cas, I’ll let you go if you’re busy—”

“*No, stay!*” She sounds far away from the microphone, and stressed out. Mydei understands the feeling. Cooking always stressed him out when he was just beginning, and he knows that Castorice doesn’t have as much experience with it as she does baking. “*Why did you call me?*”

Mydei groans, as the previous events of his night come back to him. “Phainon,” he admits.

“*Oh!*” Something loud clangs in the background, and Castorice coughs. “*Sorry, I’m trying not to burn my kitchen down. What did he do this time?*”

“He’s on a date.”

“*...Oh.*” Mydei can hear a faint beep, and then the sound of the oven fan disappears. The resulting silence on her end is devastating. “*Shit, Mydei.*”

Hearing Castorice curse is almost funny enough to make him laugh. He hopes that he can laugh about it later, once he’s calmed down. But nothing is very funny right now. “I want to kill him. I’m serious.”

“*Okay, well, maybe that’s not—exactly—the move—?*” There’s rustling on her end, now, followed by a little shriek that cuts out on Mydei’s end. “*Sorry, Mydei, I really do feel bad for you but I’m getting broccoli everywhere.*”

Mydei laughs at that, a little bit. Really, if he wanted to calm down, he’s already got that.

“*I do get it, though,*” Castorice continues. “*I want to kill Cipher sometimes.*”

“Well, me too,” Mydei answers. “Not sure if it’s for the same reason, though.”

“*She has a penchant for being annoying.*”

Mydei snorts. “And yet you still like her.”

“*Doesn’t Phainon ever annoy you?*”

“Like you wouldn’t believe,” Mydei says, rolling his eyes. He tosses his laptop aside and lays against his couch cushions entirely. “He is the most infuriating man I have ever met, and yet—”

“*You’re in love with him.*”

“Did I say that?” Mydei says faintly, struck with intense deja vu from a very similar conversation with Cipher.

“*Maybe not, but I can see it.*”

And Mydei knows it. He knows in himself that he’s in love with Phainon, but admitting it to anyone else would allow a level of vulnerability that he isn’t ready to face. Even if they can all see it—even if they knew before he did.

“Do you think you’re in love with Cipher?”

There’s a few beats of silence on Castorice’s end before she replies. “*I don’t really know what it would feel like if I was.*”

“But you know you like her.”

“*I know that I don’t feel the same way about her that I do about you, or Hyacine.*”

“Could be…a strong friendship?” Mydei knows he’s grasping at straws. He just wants to make sure that they both feel the same way about each other.

“*But you’re my best friend, Mydei.*”

“Oh.” Mydei doesn’t know why, but he almost thinks that Castorice saying that makes him feel the same way reciprocation from Phainon would. It

alone makes him want to give up on Phainon altogether. Why was he wasting so much time lamenting on romantic reciprocation from Phainon when he had the best friends he'd ever had, surrounding him all the time? "I —thank you. You've already made me feel so much better," he admits.

"*I, um,*" she starts, then sighs deeply as she cuts herself off. "*I don't know about Cipher.*"

"What?"

"*A lot of things,*" she murmurs. "*Whether or not she likes me back is one thing. But I feel like, even if she did, I won't be what she actually wants in someone. You know?*"

"No," Mydei says earnestly. He's never felt that way, personally. Up until now, with all Phainon's signals that he's obviously moved on, he's never doubted his relationships before. "But keep going."

"*I don't think I'd be able to make her happy. I know love can be…blind, I guess. If she likes me, she might not see who I really am.*"

"I really don't think you need to be worried about that," Mydei says. "Cipher has been your friend for, what, a decade now? I think she knows who you are."

"*...Maybe, yeah.*"

"Cipher has a million reasons to like you for you," Mydei continues. "You're so kind, and so strong to manage everything you've been through with so much grace. You have every reason in the world to lose it, and yet you don't. Kephale knows I would've broken down years ago if I was you."

"*Mydei…*"

"I mean it. You're one of the strongest people I know, by a long shot."

"*Well, I don't know about that—*"

"I'm serious, Cas."

“*Okay, Mydei.*” Castorice finally acquiesces, voice quiet. “*People don’t give you enough credit for your kindness.*”

“Wow, okay.” Mydei might actually be getting a bit teary-eyed, now. Phainon feels so far away. He can only hope that, for Castorice, Cipher does, too. Even though he knows in his heart that the two of them are going to work out. No matter how much work they might have to put in to get there.

“*You’re a lot like Cipher, in that way. The things she does for others often go unnoticed.*”

“Mm. I can’t believe you just compared us. I’m going to go throw up now.” Mydei knows that Castorice is right, as she always is. But he says it anyway.

Castorice laughs, and the sound brings him great relief. “*She really likes you, you know.*”

“...Ah.”

“*I’m serious! She loves spending time with you. And she thinks you’re the funniest person ever.*”

“I’m not sure if that’s a good thing.”

“*It is a good thing. Cipher doesn’t make fun of people who can’t handle it.*”

Mydei laughs for a bit, staring at the window as the sun begins to set over the city skyline. Nothing really seems to matter that much anymore. “I’m rooting for you two, you know.”

“*Well, I guess we’ll see. I’ve already written her a terrible love song.*”

“Actually?” Mydei can feel his whole face light up at that admission. “Like an actual love song?”

“*Erm…maybe not.*”

Mydei laughs again. One thing about CALAMITY was that a true, genuine love song seemed to be something they could not accomplish. Mydei would, given that he has the perfect muse, but Phainon pissed him off far too often for him to finish anything he started. It was unfortunate that it seemed Castorice was in a similar situation.

"*I'll send it to you when I finish it, and you can look over it, okay?*"

"What are you going to tell Cipher if we put it on the album?"

"*That I wrote it about someone else.*"

"Oh." Mydei thinks about Phainon and his date again. There's a tinge of bitterness in his mouth, but it doesn't stick around for as long as it did before.

"*Not in that way. I mean I would tell her it was a story I wrote.*"

"Or you can tell Cipher how you feel, and then you wouldn't have to lie."

"*Very funny. I'll tell her the moment you tell Phainon.*"

"Suffer, then."

They sit in a few moments of silence, before Castorice continues. "*I think my soup is getting cold. Do you feel better now, Mydei?*"

"A lot better," Mydei says earnestly. He still has the song to finish. But writing a song with a clear head was always going to be better than writing it drenched in emotion, even if the song itself was inherently emotional. "Thank you, Cas."

"*I feel better, too,*" she confesses. "*I'm…*" her next exhale is a little shaky. "*I'm really happy you're my friend, Mydei.*"

"Me too," Mydei says quietly.

Castorice hangs up, leaving him engulfed in silence once more. Only this time, it doesn't feel so lonely.

The song is nearly finished when Phainon gets home. It's still one of the most emotionally charged songs he's ever written—besides maybe *Conqueror of Lions*. If anything, he's glad this is happening to him since it means that such an amazing song would come from it.

"You're still awake," Phainon says from the doorway, matter-of-factly.

"As you see," Mydei answers. He drops his hands from the piano keys to his lap—he had just played it in full, but the ending was just instrumental. Thankfully, Phainon hadn't heard any of the lyrics.

"Did you write something?"

"I did," Mydei swallows, belatedly realizing how suspicious it might sound if he suddenly was struck with inspiration while Phainon was out on his date. "An old song I've been meaning to revisit," he adds, hoping that's enough for damage control.

"Ah," Phainon pauses, staring at him like there's more he wants to say. "Can I hear it?"

Mydei stands, closing his computer that had the notes open. "No," he says. "I'm going to bed."

"Oh…okay," Phainon murmurs. Mydei leaves him where he is, walking past him and into his bedroom.

He doesn't fall asleep quickly. He thinks of Phainon, in the room across the hall, and wonders if sleep comes easily to him tonight. He hopes it doesn't, even though he knows how horrible that sounds.

Phainon isn't awake before Mydei leaves the next morning. He puts leftovers from breakfast in the fridge and leaves a sticky note on the island, telling him that they exist. He swallows down all the lingering bitterness. Despite how it might seem, he does think he's beginning to head towards acceptance.

“I wrote a new song last night,” he says, once they’re in the studio. Ratio isn’t there yet, busy with another group he’s producing for.

“Me too,” Castorice says instantly, eyes lighting up as she turns towards him. “I’m not sure about it, though, so I was going to send it to you first.”

“That’s, what, ten songs, now?” Hyacine says, looking at the white board they had brought in from Mydei’s living room. “We have to hurry up with the last two if we want to reach our deadline.”

“The last three,” Cipher corrects.

“Does the deadline matter?” Castorice asks. “I don’t think anyone wants to rush us.”

“The song isn’t final,” Mydei cuts in, sitting at the keyboard. “I mean, I think you guys are going to like it, but I don’t know if I want to include it just yet.”

“Then maybe you shouldn’t play it for us until you’ve made your decision,” Cipher answers. She leans over as Castorice sits on the couch next to her, and rests her head in her lap. It’s such a casual action, one Castorice hardly flinches at. Mydei can’t fight the little smile that breaks over his face when he sees it.

Mydei rummages through his bag until he pulls out his laptop. Truthfully, he does want to put the song on the album. He knows it’s an experience many people can relate to. But he doesn’t want Phainon to see. Even if he didn’t realize it was about him, its hopelessness is so palpable that Phainon would have no choice but to see him as weak for writing it. It even feels too vulnerable for his band. Phainon was one thing, but they had already seen the worst parts of him.

The working title is *Become the Dawn*, which he already knows is too obvious. But it’s the best he has, and part of him doesn’t care if Phainon connects the dots. By the time they debuted it, Phainon would already be going back to Okhema in five days. Mydei could handle living in shame for those days if it meant Phainon would eventually leave and they would never

have to see each other ever again. Even though just the idea of that alone hurts.

And then there's just the fact that he loves this song. He thinks it's beautiful. He thinks it's some of his best writing. It has single potential. "I want you to convince me," he tells them.

So he starts playing it for them. The whole song isn't written to have a piano part, but he plays the root chords along with the guitar part instead. He'd written it for piano first anyways, and just transposed it to other instruments afterwards. Honestly, he doesn't know what it sounds like as written yet—he needs the whole band for that, which is why he doesn't consider a song done until they've looked at it together and tweaked what was necessary.

The keyboard in their studio isn't very good. It lacks the quality and emotion of a grand, its sound muted and fake. It doesn't play very loud, no matter how hard Mydei tries, but it's the best he has, and he hopes it's good enough to get the point across.

The second chorus leading into the bridge is his least favorite part, because the vulnerability in it is palpable. He almost wants to stop right here and tell them never mind, he can't. He's come so far already, with them, with everything. He keeps going.

I love you still, that's my sentence
No appeal, no way to repentance
Banish me to the pits of hell
I'll fight my way out, even if I always lose
I don't know why I always choose you
It's not my fault you're so easy to love

I know you'll light up another's life one day
Their sun, their stars, their moon in the sky
You'll become a dawn that isn't mine

But why, why?
Why can’t it be?

Why can’t you be mine?

The rest of the song is mostly piano. Mydei finishes it, almost two minutes of instrumental that eventually fades out, opening his eyes only to double check the sheet music. He does not look at them. He can’t bring himself to see their faces met with his raw vulnerability, the feelings he had denied for so long.

He stops when he sees his written-in notation to fade out. That’s something they can add in production, but he can’t emulate. He can hear his heart racing when he finally lifts his fingers from the keys, lifting his head to look at the rest of them.

They’re still in the same positions they were in when he had started—Hyacine cross-legged on one end of the couch, Castorice sitting politely in the middle, Cipher sprawled out with her head in her lap. None of them look particularly happy with him. They don’t even applaud, and Mydei thinks, for one awful moment, that they didn’t like it at all.

“Mydei,” Hyacine starts gently. “Who is this song about?”

Mydei looks at her, wordlessly begging her to understand. Because who else would it be, really? There’s no one else for him. He thought, based on Cipher’s incessant comments and Castorice’s knowing looks, that it had been quite obvious.

“It’s Phainon, Cinny,” Cipher answers. Her voice doesn’t match Hyacine’s care, but it lacks her usual tease. “Who else?”

Mydei looks at his hands. *Who else?* He had been so blind to his own feelings for so long. He thought he knew himself better than that.

“Well,” he says, snapping his computer shut so he can see them more clearly. “What did you think of the song?”

“It’s beautiful, Mydei,” Castorice says. They share a knowing look. Hers is filled with pity, and even though Mydei hates being pitied like nothing else, he can’t bring himself to feel upset with her at this moment.

“Are you sure?” Hyacine says. “That Phainon doesn’t feel the same?”

Mydei swallows. He knew a conversation like this was unavoidable, but he would still like to try to avoid it. “Do you like the song, or not?”

“It’s good,” Cipher says, yawning. She sits up, and comes over to steal Mydei’s computer so she can look at it herself. “But you knew that already.”

“You don’t have to tell us anything,” Hyacine continues, moving closer to Castorice on the couch so she, too, can look over Cipher’s shoulder at the score.

“Uh, don’t say that, I think he should,” Cipher argues. “What the hell happened to Phainon giving you heart eyes all the time? Where did this ‘*woe is me*’ of a song come from?”

“He was never giving me heart eyes,” Mydei closes his eyes, leaning back in his seat until his head hits the wall. “He didn’t care about the guy I—” he clears his throat. “Whatever. It doesn’t matter. He went on a date last night.”

“No he didn’t.” Cipher’s eyes are wide, the look on her face somewhere between utter disbelief and anger.

Mydei merely nods in response.

“Oh, I am going to kill him,” she growls. “That flakey, inconsiderate son of a bitch—”

“Stop, Cipher.” Mydei shakes his head. “It’s not his fault he doesn’t feel the same.”

“So it’s yours, then?”

“It’s no one’s fault. You don’t control who you fall in love with, do you?”

“We must be missing something,” Castorice replies. “Phainon isn’t like… that.”

“It’s fine, guys,” Mydei sighs. “He doesn’t like me. It’s okay.”

“Well…” Hyacine starts. “I don’t know. Phainon saw Mydei with someone else at the Halloween party, despite Mydei liking him. Should we really be taking Phainon’s going on a date with someone else as absolute proof he doesn’t feel the same? First dates are generally pretty casual, aren’t they?”

Mydei swallows. Of course, he hadn’t thought of that. But he knows Phainon better than most, and he knows how he is when something upsets him. Perhaps he’d been a little awkward recently, but not upset. It would be painfully obvious, were he upset.

He’s not able to respond before the door swings open, and Ratio walks in. “Good morning,” he says, shedding his jacket and throwing it over his chair. “Are we alright? You all look like someone died.”

“We’re fine,” Mydei says.

“We have a new song to record,” Cipher pipes in, sitting up straight. “Don’t we, little prince?”

Mydei sighs into his palm. With Ratio’s intrigued hum as he strides over to the couch and he, too, takes a look at the score, he has no choice but to acquiesce. He’ll do it. He can deal with the consequences later.

The consequences, it seems, come as early as the end of the week. He manages to get through the full recording process without many questions —or comments, for that matter, from anyone he doesn’t particularly want to explain himself to. Ratio cares about the music, not the lyrics. Mydei wouldn’t be surprised if he hadn’t even listened to an actual word this

whole time. And even if he did, it’s unlikely that he would have much to say on the matter. Ratio was the most cerebral man Mydei had ever met.

It might be this ignorance of sensitive subjects that leads him to suggest they perform this song at their upcoming concert. He gives a long speech about why he believes it’s best suited for something like this—it being one of the best songs on the album, but not significantly better than the rest of its songs. He also says it would be a great opportunity for Mydei to showcase his skills as a pianist and writer, as the song with Robin was not an original from him.

His arguments are too good. It’s a massive difference from how secretive he wanted to keep it when he had first pitched the song to the rest of the band. Were it to be released with the album, he was hoping they could stick it in the middle and hope it flew over most people’s heads. If a song was given extra promotion before album release, it didn’t matter where you put it. People were going to remember it anyway.

And now, it would likely be the main song used to promote their album. It would go viral, were their performances successful. It could easily become the lead single.

“Okay,” Mydei says, his face betraying none of the nauseating cocktail of emotions he feels. “If everyone else agrees, I’m okay with that. We can start preparing to play it live, then.”

Ratio nods. “The rest of the songs, too. We’re due to start rehearsals for that soon, so I suggest you focus on finalizing your setlist sooner rather than later.”

“Mydei,” Hyacine says quietly from where she sits beside him. “You’re really okay with this?”

“I am,” Mydei’s voice doesn’t shake as he says it, like he fears it would. He can’t wait until he’s home and can freak out about this in solitude.

“Then, I’m okay with it,” Hyacine offers, smiling.

The others agree soon after that, and it’s decided. Ratio stays with them for a bit, helping suggest other cover ideas that he thinks would work well for them. They end the day with a long list to look over for homework—mainly Mydei, to see if any of the songs would be out of range for him. There are a couple songs on the list by female singers, one of which he’d really like to do, even though he’s not looking forward to transposing it into a key more comfortable for him. He prides himself on his ability to hit higher notes, despite where he sings comfortably—but with a whole song in a higher register, it was a lost cause.

“Also, if there are any additional instruments required, we can hire people to cover it, or just add it to the backing track. It’s up to you,” Ratio adds. Mydei thinks there might be a song with accordion on the list. Where they were going to find an actual accordion player, he has no idea.

Mydei takes a picture of the list once they’re dismissed, and they decide to go to a restaurant together to celebrate the weekend. Castorice plays through the first couple of songs on the list as she drives them there. The first one is too slow for him, and Castorice doesn’t like how boring her part would be, so they eliminate it. The next few remain possible contenders, though Mydei has no strong winners just yet.

The majority decision once they’re shown to their booth in the restaurant is that they are not allowed to leave until they’ve narrowed down the list to its final stage. Mydei thinks that could mean they’re here for hours, and hopes they’re all more or less in agreement.

They get to work as soon as they’ve ordered. Castorice pulls out one of her notebooks, copying down all of the songs from the photo Mydei took.

They have only crossed out four options before they start adding more.

“*Apotheosis* - Argenti Idrila,” Hyacine blurts out.

All three of them snap their heads up to look at her. “*Idrila?!*” Cipher demands, incredulous.

“You’re not serious,” Mydei says.

“Come *on!*” Hyacine grabs the notebook and writes it in herself. “He has such a beautiful voice. Yours would be perfect for that style of music, Mydei.”

“You’re out of your damn mind,” Mydei retorts. “Our music styles aren’t even in the same universe. He went through a completely different kind of training than me, Hyacine.”

“I agree with her, Mydei,” Castorice says. “I think it would be a perfect opportunity to showcase your range.”

“Oh my god,” Mydei mutters. “Fine.”

“And we’re not changing the genre of the backing track,” Hyacine adds. “Maybe we can translate the strings into acoustic guitar.”

“I’ll work on it,” Mydei decides. “*If we choose it.* Don’t get your hopes up.”

They keep making their way through the decided list, arguing over this and that. Hyacine seems set on showing off their range, which Mydei only agrees with to an extent. It’s a good way to prepare listeners for what will come their way with the new album, as it introduces a new sound many old listeners probably won’t be used to. But Idrila is a bit too far, which is where they start to disagree.

Castorice wants to do tribute music, to other artists they take their inspirations from. She’s set on *Crucifixion*, no longer much of a joke, but Mydei worries his voice won’t be a good fit for it. He’s already of the impression that songs written for female singers are much worse when a man covers it, even though songs written for male singers are often better when a female singer covers it. He can’t explain it. Some songs he thinks he can cover, but *Crucifixion* just isn’t one of them. His voice just doesn’t have the right color, and color is so necessary for a High Cloud Quintet track.

That said, a voice built for rock isn’t going to have a very easy time covering Idrila, either.

“I want to do this one,” Mydei says, pointing to the one he had already liked when Ratio mentioned it. It’s by an artist named Acheron, which is a name he vaguely recognizes, though he’s not sure from where. It’s called *Self-Annihilationism* and Mydei doesn’t know how he’s never heard it before, because it’s incredible.

“Oh, yeah? Does self-annihilationism speak to you, Mydei?” Cipher asks. He kicks her under the table because the waitress has arrived with their tray of food, and what he really wants to say to her would be inappropriate.

Not to mention he doesn’t even know what that means. It sounds philosophical. He’s always been terrible at philosophy.

“I like that,” Castorice says, once the waitress is gone. “Any objections?”

When there are none, she circles it, and they’ve finally agreed on one whole song.

Mydei has almost finished half his plate of chicken by the time Hyacine has successfully convinced them of another song that wasn’t on the list, *Transcendence* by a folk band she likes called The Beauty. None of them except her have heard of it. Mydei pulls it up and plays it on his phone at a low volume, and it’s a far cry from the other stretch she suggested, so they eventually agree.

“I’m serious about *Crucifixion*,” Castorice says, not for the first time, after they’ve finally circled their second song. “Mydei, you really don’t think your voice would work?”

“No,” he says, mouth full of food. He swallows. “But yours would.”

Castorice frowns. “You’re serious?”

“It’s the closest match to Jingliu’s,” he answers. “I can do a lot of styles, but I can’t do gothic rock. Me covering it would just sound tacky—talk about a lame tribute.”

Castorice is chewing at her lip. Mydei catches Cipher's eye, who's looking at him almost like she's attempting to thank him.

"I guess I could sing it," she ultimately decides, though quietly. "But who would play the drums?"

All three of them look at him.

"Stop," he says. "I have no talent for that instrument. It would be a disgrace."

"*How?*" Cipher scoffs. "You're good at hitting things?"

Castorice makes a choking noise from beside Mydei. He laughs, patting her on the back. "My rhythm is shit," he says.

"Oh, good *lord*," Cipher shakes her head. "You're such a fucking liar, you know that, Mydei?"

"Can you stop arguing," Hyacine pleads, for what might be the sixth time that night. "I'm sure we could get a drummer for that song."

"You're right," Mydei had, admittedly, forgotten all about that. "The song has two guitar parts, anyways. I'll join you then, Hyacine."

So they circle their third song, with two to go. Ratio said six songs total would be perfect, as he had previously agreed upon with Aventurine.

They argue over *Apotheosis* until everyone has finished their meal and the waitress has cleared the table. They order an ice cream dessert to share, and by the time that arrives, Hyacine has successfully convinced Castorice and Mydei.

Cipher doesn't take long, once she's in the minority. She agrees very begrudgingly, as she still thinks the song is boring, but they end up circling it anyway.

That leaves them with four selections, and the rest of the songs on the list crossed out. They throw suggestions at each other until the ice cream is

gone, before Hyacine finally suggests one of Jing Yuan's solo works, *Suns Subdued.* Mydei still remembers when his solo album first came out—he had been so excited for any High Cloud Quintet crumbs, only to find himself disappointed by the style of music he had chosen to pursue. It wasn't bad by any means, in fact he was wildly successful and loved by many, but it wasn't the kind of thing Mydei liked. Too slow. Not instrumentally heavy enough, while the lyrics were devastatingly emotional. The irony of Mydei's own switch up is not lost on him.

They agree on *Suns Subdued* relatively quickly, with Mydei's main concern being the sheer amount of love songs they had chosen. It's not something that bothers him enough to vocalize it, but it bothers him still.

When Castorice drops him off at the apartment, late that night, she leaves him with a printed out version of the song she had mentioned over their call. "Please look at it," she tells him. "Don't rush it. I just want to know what you think."

"I will, Cas," he reassures her. "Have a good night, yeah?"

She nods, and drives away.

Phainon is asleep when he gets back, lights throughout the apartment turned off. He flicks them on in the kitchen, sitting at his island as he pages through Castorice's music. He thinks it might be her first attempt at writing the instrumentals, and not just the lyrics, and it's impressive.

Funnily enough, she had included an "accordion" part. Her vision certainly seems interesting, and although Mydei can't hear it very well in his head, he thinks her creativity deserves its praise.

The lyrics are stunning as always, enough to leave Mydei with a pit in his stomach.

And if you don't love me, let me go
And if you don't love me, let me go

I am a writer, writer of fictions
I am the heart that you call home
And I've written pages upon pages
Trying to rid you from my bones

Mydei, much to his chagrin, thinks of Phainon. How she had managed to articulate his own feelings so beautifully is beyond him. For so many years, he had convinced himself he wasn't in love with Phainon anymore. That they had both successfully gone their separate ways.

He had never been able to rid himself of the traces of him. It was foolish of him to think he ever would.

He turns the pages over, until the first one is at the front again. To think this was written on her own experience with Cipher, as well. Perhaps he had abstained from being wingman for too long.

He sighs, and texts Cipher. She responds in an instant.

Cipher
Today 11:44 PM

you're a fucking idiot you know that

ok big boy riddle me this
whats 6 x 7
hahahahahaha not so talkative now r u
but like fr
wtf did i do

you need to fix whatever bullshit you have going on with cas

what
did she tell you something

she’s not going to reject you, cipher.
i don’t even know why you’re scared of that

im not
scared

sure

did she tell you something??????

just talk to her.

dude.
Did she tell you something
Mydei
MYDEI

Mydei turns his phone on do not disturb for the night, plugging it in before heading to the bathroom to shower. He can handle a couple spam texts from Cipher by simply ignoring them once she’s tired herself out. All he can hope for is that when he wakes up tomorrow, they’re not tiptoeing around each other anymore.

As it turns out, he does not have any updates the next morning. It’s Saturday, so they’re not meeting for the next two days, and he can only wait it out or expect a text from either of them—most likely Castorice—when it finally happens.

He starts by emailing Aventurine their final setlist, along with finally asking if they were allowed to bring outsiders in to watch. He doesn’t think Aventurine checks his email during the weekends, but he’s proven wrong after getting a response a mere two hours later.

The consensus is that he likes the setlist, and Phainon can come if he wants and promises to be quiet. Mydei doesn't think that would be a problem, so he tells him when he's finally awake and stumbling out of his bedroom.

"Good news," Mydei calls, from the kitchen where he's washing the dishes he had used with his breakfast. "You're allowed to come to our concert."

"Really?" Phainon asks, head popping in. He's still in the clothes he slept in, hair a mess. Mydei's throat goes dry as it always does, seeing him when he's just woken up. "When is it?"

"We're recording on the twentieth of December," Mydei answers. "The videos will be uploaded on the twenty-fifth."

"Oh my god, this is so exciting," Phainon's voice is the closest to squealing Mydei has ever heard. "Which songs are you playing?"

"Wouldn't that ruin the surprise?" Mydei says, head cocking to the side.

"Fine," Phainon pouts. "Keep your secrets." He opens the fridge, yawning as he surveys its contents. "We need more milk," he says lazily, as he pulls out the near-empty carton and moves to get himself a glass.

"I was going to get groceries later," Mydei turns off the sink and dries his hands on the towel hanging from the oven. "Do you want to come with?"

"I'd love to," Phainon says. He takes his glass, filled only a quarter with milk, and grabs a banana from the fruit bowl. Mydei bites his tongue and tries not to dwell on why he wishes such a simple statement meant more than it did.

He goes to the living room while Phainon finishes starting his day, propping up Castorice's score on the piano rack. It doesn't have a piano part, so he plays the melody of the lyrics with his right hand and the root chords, guitar riffs, and accordion with his left.

It's difficult to play something like this without the song translated to a solo piano part in front of him, so it's far from his best work. He pauses and

stumbles through it, but he's getting a feel for how it's supposed to sound. He never had perfect pitch like Phainon, and couldn't hear songs in his head without at least being given the first note.

It's a very cute song. The way it sounds, not necessarily what it's about. It's not something Mydei would write on his own, but that doesn't mean he likes it any less. The lyrics speak to him too deeply for him to turn it down for any reason.

He plays through it a couple more times, changing a few things here and there, before eventually texting Castorice his approval. She sends him a smiley face in return, but no news about Cipher. He sighs, turning his phone off.

He and Phainon drive to the grocery store an hour later, with Phainon's phone connected to the speaker from the last time he took the car. Mydei almost jumps when he sees *Suns Subdued* by Jing Yuan displayed on the screen, before he can even hear the first chord. He swallows, turning back to the road.

The drive is silent as the beginning of the song begins to play. Phainon doesn't skip it, and Mydei can see his eyes glued to the windshield in his peripheral vision. His face looks gaunt, the least amount of a smile Mydei has ever seen on his face.

The car stops at a red light, just as the music begins to build. He sings about his lost lover, begging her to return to him, all the things he would give just to catch a glimpse of her once again.

Mydei wonders who Phainon could possibly be thinking about for him to have such a visceral reaction to this song, yet refusing to skip it. Surely it couldn't have been the person he went on one date with.

The light turns green. Mydei presses his foot to the gas, turning into the plaza that contains his favorite organic grocery store. What he wouldn't give for Phainon to think of him.

“Come on,” Mydei says, parking the car in a spot just as the song ends. “You have the list I sent you?”

Phainon nods, pulling it up on his phone. Mydei grabs his grocery bags from the trunk, and they head inside.

Mydei hasn’t been getting recognized as much lately, thankfully. Most of the people at Caelus’ Halloween party were celebrities, so it was more likely for them to know him than random people. As much as he wants the album to be successful, he hopes it’s not so successful that he wouldn’t be able to leave his apartment in peace anymore.

The store is playing old Christmas music. Phainon hums along to it as they browse the aisles, which Mydei doesn’t understand. Castrum Kremnos wasn’t big on holidays like Penacony was, but he wasn’t very familiar with traditions in other parts of Amphoreus. Phainon’s family did seem like one that was big on holidays like this, though.

“You’ve been playing piano recently?” Mydei opens a carton of eggs and surveys the inside, then puts it in their cart.

“I have,” Phainon says. “Nothing you’d want to hear, I’m sure.”

Mydei frowns, turning over his shoulder to look at him. He’s trailing his fingers over packages of meat as he follows behind Mydei. “Don’t say that.”

“Why not?” Phainon asks. “It’s true. I’m not very good.”

“That doesn’t mean I don’t want to hear you play.” He selects two packages of chicken and three of ground beef. “What have you been working on?”

“Chopin,” Phainon groans, pulling his hands over his face. “Who else?”

Mydei snorts, remembering the awful étude he had to play his freshman year. He’s still pissed off about all the good options he missed out on. “Which one?”

“10/9,” he says. “F minor.”

“Right,” Mydei mutters. “That means nothing to me.”

“I figured,” Phainon sighs. They’re at the dairy aisle now, and Phainon picks up a gallon of milk and puts it in the cart while Mydei looks at the cheese. “Mydei,” he says, coming up behind him. “Do you think I’m…” he trails off, as Mydei picks up the best aged cheddar he could find.

“You’re what?” Mydei tosses it into the cart, then tries to find the brie.

“Well,” Phainon starts again. “I haven’t been able to go to the gym recently, so…” Mydei looks at him, bewildered, as he deliberately avoids eye contact. Two aborted starts later, he seems to give up.

“You’re worried about gaining weight,” Mydei mutters, disbelieving.

Phainon denies it. “Not that,” he says. “I’m just…not fit anymore. I guess.”

“Yes you are,” Mydei has long since forgotten what he was even looking for. “Seventy percent diet, thirty percent exercise, Phainon. I feed you plenty of protein.”

He’s still plenty attracted to him. Were he scrawny now, Mydei thinks that surely would have changed. But of course, he leaves that part unsaid.

When Phainon doesn’t answer right away, Mydei turns back to the cheese. “Come to the gym with me, then. If you can play Chopin, you can lift a weight.”

Phainon hums, though it sounds more like begrudging acceptance than anything. “That’s not even true, you know,” he says, as Mydei finally finds a brie cheese worth getting. “Those statistics.”

“Yes they are,” Mydei argues. “Do you want me to send you an article?”

Phainon groans, slumping over the cart as he pushes it into the next aisle. “No, thank you. I only need one Cyrene in my life.”

“Good to know you at least have someone else worried about your poor lifestyle choices,” Mydei muses. “How is she, by the way?”

“Good,” Phainon responds, standing up straight. “She and Eve have been watching Snowy, and they both moved all my stuff out of my old apartment, since I cut the lease.”

“Snowy?”

“My dog.”

“Huh.” For the first time ever, Mydei is a tiny bit happy that Phainon doesn’t return his feelings. He doesn’t think he could handle having a dog in the house, and he shudders to think what Kokopo III would think of a beast like that.

“I’ll stay with them when I go back,” Phainon says. His voice is a little more mellow as he says it, and Mydei wonders if he’s just as upset to go as Mydei is to see him go.

He could have gone months ago, anyway. Mydei kept making excuses for him to stay longer and Phainon, for reasons Mydei can’t fathom, played along every time.

“Hopefully not for too long. I’ll get a job to pay for a new place, or something.”

“Where are you thinking?”

Mydei watches his throat bob as he swallows, then turns away, back to the cereals they were deciding between.

“It might be back to delivering pizzas, Mydei.”

Mydei shakes his head. “Don’t say that. Hire a coach, and you will be performing again in no time.”

“You don’t know that.”

“Yes, I do. Your injury is public knowledge now, and people would love to watch someone rebound from something like that.”

“You don’t know that places will still take me, Mydei.”

Mydei sighs, throwing a box of cereal into their cart. “Aglaea always will. Start there.”

Phainon clicks his tongue as they move on, towards the produce aisle. He doesn’t say anything for a while, picking up a random ball of cabbage and looking at it thoughtfully.

“We don’t need that,” Mydei says, taking it from him and putting it back. “Speak your mind.”

Phainon looks down at his hands. “Her condition is worsening,” he explains. “Who knows how long she’ll be conducting?”

“Oh come on, Phainon,” Mydei shakes his head. He selects a bundle of asparagus and begins unrolling a plastic bag for it. “You know her better than me. She doesn’t seem like the kind of person who would let something like that stop her so easily.”

Phainon sniffs a little. “I guess,” he murmurs. “But I can’t just mooch off of her for the rest of my life. Just because I’m too stubborn to give up on my dream.”

Mydei swallows. “If it’s really your dream, there’s no such thing as *too stubborn* to give up.” If Mydei had given up after their first non-independent EP wasn’t what he was expecting, Phainon would be just as annoyed with him as Mydei is with Phainon now.

“But what if I want to?” Mydei picks out a bag of kale, and just barely restrains himself from hitting Phainon over the head with it. “It just seems so stupid. I can’t do what I could just four months ago, Mydei. It was like everything was for nothing.”

“Then I must have severely misjudged your character, Phainon,” Mydei mutters. “It’s not like you to give up so easily.”

“My PT told me I couldn’t.”

“She said it’s *unlikely,* Phainon,” Mydei is close to raising his voice, kale forgotten in his hands. “Not that it was impossible.”

“It was implied.” Phainon is clearly getting angrier too, refusing to look Mydei in the eyes.

Mydei sighs, shoving away his frustrations. Arguing with Phainon is always a losing battle, so he gives up. The ridiculously cheery Christmas music still plays in the background, as they move through the produce section in simmering silence.

They have both calmed down enough by the time they’re back at the apartment, eating the lunch they picked up on the way home together. Phainon goes to the piano, and Mydei listens to him in the background as he searches for sheet music online for the songs they were going to be performing.

A lot of it is going to have to be edited. He uploads the versions he finds into Sibelius and adjusts what he can for most of the afternoon, until the sun begins to set and he starts dinner.

Phainon plays throughout all of it. He likes to listen to music as he cooks, but Phainon’s playing is more than sufficient. How he could ever assume Mydei wouldn’t want to hear it is beyond him.

He drags Phainon out of bed early the next morning, handing him a protein shake and taking him to the gym. It’s nearly always empty on Sundays, and he’s so used to going alone that having someone with him is a nice change of pace, even though Phainon is far from where he was when they used to go together in college.

He’s pouting about it when they leave, and Mydei has to remind him that of course his body won’t be used to going after he neglected it for so long.

Phainon clearly doesn’t want to accept that. Mydei shakes his head, disbelieving, as they climb into his car. “Do you feel better?”

“A little,” Phainon admits. Mydei knows that means he feels great.

“Will you join me from now on?”

Phainon sighs. “Fine.”

Mydei turns away, starting the car. “It wouldn’t kill you to admit I’m right every once in a while.”

“Drive the damn car, Mydei.”

They spend the next few weeks preparing for the upcoming show. Mydei and Castorice play the new song for the band when they break for lunch, their schedule too booked nowadays to have any other time for it. It goes well, and even though Mydei says he helped write it (Castorice’s idea of a cover up), he thinks Cipher connects the dots, if how giddy she is for the rest of the day is anything to go off. He’s still pretty pissed off she hadn’t just listened to him, though.

The next day, she walks into the studio they’d been practicing in with the biggest grin on her face. “Guess who has a date this Friday,” she nearly yells.

Castorice, who is busy tuning her drum kit, chokes on nothing. When Mydei turns to look at her, she flushes, shooting him the meanest glare someone like her could muster.

“Oh! That’s great!” Hyacine exclaims. She arrived before the rest of them and stands off to the side, guitar already tuned. “With who?”

Mydei sighs. “It’s not painfully obvious to you?”

“Huh?”

Mydei points at Castorice. “Stop it, Mydei,” she begs, flushing even further.

“Wait, *what?*” Hyacine stares at Cipher, who nods, clearly proud of herself. “You two—*what?*”

“Uh huh,” Cipher grins, all teeth. “Don’t worry, Cinny. You’ll find someone one day.”

“Oh, I’m really not worried about that,” Hyacine reassures them, waving Cipher off. “Maybe you’ll be next though, Mydei?”

Mydei sighs, turning back to his mobile tuning app so he can resume tuning the acoustic guitar around his neck. “Let’s hurry up and get started, yeah?”

With Ratio and a few other IPC staff member’s help, they’re pretty much ready for the concert after no more than a week and a half. December arrives in the meantime, bringing with it a foot of snow. Having lived on the east coast of Penacony for as long as he has, Mydei barely blinks at the sight of snow nowadays, but Phainon drags him out of the city to sled down the biggest hills they could find on a garbage bag.

The sick feeling in his stomach never seems to go away. Mydei can act normal, like they’re nothing more than good friends, but he can’t ever shake the part of him that wants. The sight of his shining eyes and the way the snow in his hair is barely visible against its near-white shade of blond makes Mydei’s stomach churn. He wants to kiss him, to tackle him to the ground and take him right here in the snow. He wants him to stay in Penacony forever, to do concerts while Mydei goes on tours. He wants Phainon to join him on stage, to play the piano part while Mydei sings. He wants CALAMITY fans to be Phainon fans, too. He wants the world to see him just as Mydei does.

Phainon throws a handful of snow in his face, laughing heartily as Mydei scowls at him. He wipes it from his eyes—he can’t stay mad. Not for long. Even though Phainon irritates him to no end.

So he teaches Phainon how to roll a proper snowball. Snow hardly ever falls in Amphoreus, and they never got very much in the more southern region Paperfold was located in, but Mydei at least knows better than

Phainon how snow works. Once he's finished his lecture and crafted a perfectly compact snowball, he hits Phainon square in the face.

Phainon boasts that he won their ensuing snowball fight, but Mydei would claim otherwise. Phainon was new to this sport, after all. His snowballs were falling apart in the air.

But he's hopelessly, helplessly in love with him. So he tells him he did okay, even though he would never give him the win.

And then they lie in the aftermath, fresh snow thoroughly uprooted by the mess they'd made. There's something about the peace of it all that prompts Mydei to ask, even though he doesn't know why. "You never went on a second date."

Phainon sighs. It sends shivers down Mydei's spine, but he convinces himself it's because of the cold. "No," he starts. "I, um, I met her at physical therapy…she was also in a car crash, even though her injuries were much worse than mine. We got along. I don't know. I thought we'd have a lot in common."

"And you didn't?"

"Apart from the trauma, no." Phainon is staring at the sky when Mydei looks over at him. "She works for an insurance agency in the city. She told me my injuries might have been a blessing in disguise, because now I could find a more stable job. When I asked her what her dreams were, she said she'd always wanted to get married and have kids."

"Oh."

Phainon sighs again, and it sounds even more dejected than the first time. "She was nice, and that's a fine life to want, but…I don't even know why I'm explaining this to you. You get it."

"Yeah. I do." *That's why we're perfect for each other,* goes unsaid. They want the same things. They always have. And even though Mydei is ultimately glad they broke up, it was why he and Phoebe worked well, too.

She was an artist. Didn’t have much of an ear for music, but ultimately, she understood.

“Sometimes I think I’ll be alone for the rest of my life.”

“What makes you say that?” Mydei turns his head to look at him, though the hood of his winter coat still obstructs his view.

“Because no one is as important to me as this is.”

Mydei swallows. His throat is uncomfortably dry. Really, though, he thinks he knows exactly what Phainon means. He would happily live out the rest of his life single if it meant he was doing what he loved. Again, it isn’t lost on him how perfectly he and Phainon’s dream lives would fit together. The realization doesn’t sting any less the second time.

The day of the concert is a Wednesday, the week before the studio shuts down until the new year. They spend most of the morning getting ready for it—the whole thing is styled to no end. They all need to go through hair and makeup as if they were being prepared for a real concert. Thankfully, they keep everyone’s looks relatively natural, going for a cozier vibe than what they’re usually put into for a show.

They tie Mydei’s hair back into a low ponytail, including his braid. He doesn’t think that was part of the plan, but he always wears it and for some reason they don’t take it out. Makeup is simple, just slight touch ups, but they do get rid of the red eyeliner underneath his right eye.

He’s handed a loose pair of dark blue jeans, and a maroon sweater with white patterns on it. It’s a little ridiculous how this is treated like a costume when it’s things he could find in his everyday closet—well, not really, since it’s a far cry from his usual style, but still. Thankfully, they let him keep his boots, but replace his necklace and earrings with plain gold ones. Apparently, the blue gems didn’t fit the color scheme, even though he thinks it looked fine.

Being separated from the girls' dressing room, he only sees them afterwards. Hyacine's hair is down, the first he's ever seen it in that state, with a red headband in it. She has on a red plaid dress with a white lace collar, white tights, and fluffy white boots. There are little bells hanging from her ears that jingle when she walks, and out of the three of them, she's dressed the most similar to her regular style.

Castorice and Cipher were both given green outfits, to contrast Mydei and Hyacine's red. Castorice is in a long sweater and long plaid skirt, hair tied back into a braided bun. Cipher is in jeans a couple shades lighter than Mydei's, with another sweater that matches Castorice's, except it has patterns on it, too. Her short gray hair is in two tiny braids, and Mydei resists the urge to laugh at it.

The room they're recording in is set up with chairs for a mini audience before a makeshift stage. It's a cozy setting, with minimal Christmas decorations. There's a tiny piece of holly tied to Mydei's microphone stand, a fake fireplace in the backdrop, red curtains just lining the outsides. Cipher was given a red bass instead of her usual blue one, Hyacine a green electric guitar. Castorice has a brown drum kit lined with tiny golden Christmas lights. The piano is wooden and upright—Mydei would prefer a grand or a half grand, of course, but he knows that would barely fit on the stage, so he'll take what he's given. There's also a regular acoustic guitar and a white electric guitar behind his mic stand.

The audience is mostly crew members, though Aventurine had allowed each of them a plus one of sorts, so Mydei is glad that Phainon wouldn't be totally out of place.

Aventurine directs them to their places on the stage, and they're instructed on everything that's going to happen: they would talk a little bit between songs, given pointers by interviewers in the audience. They would start the show and end it by promoting the album. The audience would applaud between each number to make it feel like they're real audience members, and it isn't all staged.

Before the cameras start rolling, they each tune and do a brief sound check, and then it starts.

“Good?” Mydei asks, a little nervous. Aventurine smiles at him from his seat at the very front and nods. “Okay,” he says, quietly, and starts playing the opening to *Self-Annihilationism.*

The drums kick in shortly afterwards, followed by Cipher sliding into the start of her bassline. Hyacine, on the more distorted electric guitar part, has the same line as Cipher in the beginning. Mydei’s electric guitar part is more melodic, which he prefers.

The song is the closest to a typical rock song that they chose for this performance, so they figured it would be a good place to start given that they’re known for making music like this.

Mydei knows very little about Acheron, where she comes from, or what her real name might be. He doesn’t know what this song means to her, as she sings about a country destroyed by war and the meaninglessness of fighting back. *None of it ever matters,* she sings. *I drown in a sea of souls and stand up unscathed.* Mydei wishes he could have known her. He doesn’t think she’s from Amphoreus, but she references ancient myths he was already so well acquainted with.

The song finishes after a short guitar solo Mydei plays with Hyacine’s distorted part behind him, and finishes with Castorice and Cipher alone together. They cut out at exactly the same time, silence falling into the room around them.

The crowd applauds—no one cheers, as it’s supposed to sound intimate. It doesn’t go on for very long, and Mydei thanks them because he feels awkward standing there doing nothing.

He sets his guitar down, picking up a plastic bottle of water and drinking it as Hyacine talks for him.

“Hi,” she says, and a couple audience members laugh lightly at her awkward tone. “Um—we’re CALAMITY, if you didn’t know that, and we are currently working on our debut album.”

“That song was not ours,” Cipher clarifies.

“Yes,” Hyacine answers. “That was *Self-Annihilationism* by Acheron. We’re going to play a couple covers for you today, and end the show with one of the new songs off our album.”

At the mention of it, Mydei’s heart starts to race all over again. He makes direct eye contact with Phainon in the back corner of the audience as he caps his water. “Yes,” he says, leaning a little too close to his microphone. He pauses for a moment, then continues, “I don’t have anything else to say. Cas?”

He looks back at her, and she stands, coming up to share his microphone. “I forgot I’m singing this one,” she says shyly. “Okay. This is, um, *Crucifixion.* By the High Cloud Quintet.”

Mydei picks his guitar back up, slinging it over his shoulder as the second drummer walks out. She’s an IPC employee Mydei had never met before, but they ended up getting along very well.

Crucifixion’s studio version starts with ambient noises and a little bit of keyboard, and their modified version of it plays through speakers before the full band joins in for the beginning. The instruments fade back out as Castorice starts singing, beautiful voice ringing out perfectly through the room.

He knows this is probably wildly unexpected for whoever would eventually watch this video when it’s posted, but he’s not the only one singing on the album. He might be the leader of the band on paper, but they all work together to make this music. It isn’t just Mydei and his backing track.

Castorice is a talented singer. He’s known this for months, now, and is overjoyed at the prospect of the rest of the world realizing this, too.

The song finishes, and Castorice is smiling brighter than he’s ever seen her. He doesn’t think he’s ever been more proud.

“Thank you,” she says, breathless. “And thank you to our drummer for filling in,” she gestures behind her, and Mydei steps out of the way so the backup drummer can wave at the camera before moving offstage.

“Spoiler alert,” Mydei says into the mic, after Castorice goes back to her kit. “I’m not the only one singing on the new album.”

A couple laughs. Cipher cheers, a muted whoop as she doesn’t have a microphone in front of her.

“Okay, our next song is a little different,” Mydei warns them, pulling the stool up and lowering the mic stand so he can sit on it. “We have Cipher on upright bass, Hyacine on acoustic guitar, and Cas on drums. Surprise.”

He gives them a couple seconds to get situated. “Okay,” he starts. “We are going to play *Apotheosis* by Argenti Idrila.” He looks straight at Phainon as he says it, and thinks the mic might pick up a little bit of his laugh when he sees the shock on his face.

The original song starts with drums, bass, and harp, which he had translated to work for acoustic guitar. Hyacine plucks the notes, and it doesn’t sound like a CALAMITY song, but it sounds more like one than it originally did.

Mydei takes a deep breath before his cue, and starts singing. His voice is deep enough to hit it without having to transpose the key, thankfully, but the style of the original vocals was hard to achieve with training like his. They spent the most time preparing for the live version of this song by far because Mydei could never quite get it right. He wanted to scrap it several times, but Ratio kept reassuring him he could get it, so they kept trying.

He thinks it sounds good now, and hopes he’s right about that.

The original song builds to horns and strings near the end, but they keep it more subdued to match the intimate setting. Hyacine plays most of the melody on her guitar again, demonstrating a difficult picking technique she hadn’t shown off before. Though Mydei doesn’t think the average person would be paying much attention to that, no matter how much he wishes they would.

He holds out the last note alone, until he feels it’s sufficient. The applause when he finishes goes on for a little longer than it had previously, and he thinks they might have found it genuinely impressive.

“Thank you,” he says, because he feels like he has to. He looks at Phainon, who looks back, eyes shining with remarkable pride. Mydei feels a swell in his chest at the confirmation. “That one was definitely a stretch.”

He pauses for a drink of water as Hyacine talks for a minute, answering a question that Mydei didn’t quite catch. They transition into *Transcendence* next, where Mydei finally takes his seat at the piano.

Hyacine starts this one on acoustic guitar again, and continues to be the only one playing throughout half of the first verse, until Cipher joins on bass. Castorice kicks in leading into the pre-chorus, along with Mydei.

The piano part for this song is relatively simple, mainly chords. As he leads into the chorus, Hyacine joins him singing with that beautiful bright voice of hers.

Transcendence is one of the most ethereal love songs Mydei has ever heard, more similar to Castorice’s style than her own. The lyrics are artfully crafted, and the instruments all come together to create a nostalgic, pleading melody. The singer tells a story that is not his own, of two people acting out a marriage in their final moments as they drown together in a wrathful river.

These hazards of love, he sings, as both Hyacine and Cipher join in on backing vocals, *never more will trouble us.*

Mydei wishes he had the right to think of Phainon as he sings it, but he does not. He hopes, in spite, that Phainon is left to wonder who Mydei might possibly be dedicating such a love song to. He hopes he sits in the audience and is moved by the beauty of Mydei’s pseudo-relationship. He hopes it makes him jealous. Not that it couldn’t be him in Mydei’s pretend lover’s shoes, because such an outcome would never be possible. But simply that it couldn’t be him in Mydei’s shoes.

He finishes with his hands off his keys, Hyacine playing the final chord on her guitar.

They only pause briefly between songs this time, Mydei taking his space back in front of the upright microphone, Hyacine handing him the acoustic guitar. She starts *Suns Subdued* with an electric guitar version of the harmonium intro to the original track, before fading out so Mydei takes over on acoustic, joined immediately by both Castorice and Cipher.

He starts singing with his voice soft. He has his eyes closed, so he can avoid making direct eye contact with Phainon. He knows if he were to open them, he would have nowhere else to look.

He doesn't know who Phainon thinks of when he hears this song, but it must be someone. Part of him hopes that this performance has ruined *Suns Subdued* irreversibly for him. He hopes that every time it comes on the radio, on his playlist, he is forced to skip it lest he allow his brain to wander so cruelly to thoughts of his very first love.

Mydei knows that songs are best received by an audience when an emotional impact on the performers is evident. This has been clear since his college days—Herta constantly trying to get him to play with feeling. To be asked that back then was akin to being asked to torture himself, only now it comes almost too easily to him. Had he admitted that in college, he would have thought it made him weak. Now, he's not so sure what it makes him.

He thinks the audience must be able to feel it. This isn't just a song he sings out of love and appreciation for the music, it's a song he sings out of passion. This is personal, and he thinks anyone in the room who might attempt to deny it must be a fool.

He can vaguely hear his bandmates harmonizing behind him as he heads into the final verse, but that's hardly his focus. How he's keeping up with his part on the guitar, he has no idea—his fingers and hands move on his own. He thinks he might forget the next lyric, and then sings it perfectly anyway. There is nothing clear in his head but thoughts of Phainon, and even those are not entirely clear.

Finally, he gets to the final lyric, and allows his voice to fade out. He plays the last couple of chords, Hyacine plays hers, and the music ends.

There’s a torturous few moments of silence after they stop, and finally the crowd gives them their applause.

Mydei dares a glance at Phainon. He thinks, even in the dim lighting of the room, that he looks near to tears. Mydei hopes they're angry tears. Bitter tears. He hopes he’s ruined the song for him forever.

He puts down his guitar, sitting down as he takes another couple sips of water.

“That was *Suns Subdued*,” Hyacine says. “By none other than Jing Yuan.”

“Ex High Cloud Quintet member,” Castorice supplies quietly, and a couple people in the audience chuckle. Mydei thinks they must have been paid to laugh at their jokes. Then he mentally kicks himself for being internally mean to Castorice, as his bad mood was no excuse.

“Our final song will be one from our upcoming album,” Hyacine continues. “Mydei, would you like to introduce it?”

“It would be my pleasure,” Mydei says, standing so he can reach his microphone. His voice is a little unsteady. He swallows, placing his water back down, before he continues. “I don’t have very much to say about this song. I think you will like it very much.”

He moves to the piano, and pushes the microphone back a little bit as it was uncomfortably close to his face. “This song is called *Deliver the Dawn.*” He thanks his awkward angle at the piano, because he could not look at Phainon even if he wanted to. Which, if he ever did, it would have been an accident.

The song starts with an electric guitar solo from Hyacine. He has vocals behind it, though they’re quiet, and her part is the focus.

The rest of them come in together after her solo is done, though the melody from it continues into the main part of the song. His piano is in the background starting at the pre-chorus, and he plays the main theme as they launch into the chorus.

He makes it through the first half of the song without giving so much of a thought to its muse. Right at the start of the second chorus, though, he fails. He grows bitter, just as the lyrics do. He hates himself for writing such a song. He hates Phainon more for forcing his hand.

He knows he's slamming too hard on the keys. He doesn't think he's ever played so angrily, and he opens his eyes and can't help but glare directly into the camera pointed at his face as they reach the bridge. *You'll become a dawn that isn't mine, but why can't it be?*

He's not speaking to Phainon. He pretends he isn't, because admitting that he is would only make him angrier. Luckily, the instrumentals as he exits the bridge only get louder and more convoluted, so he can disguise his vocals in the background as an artistic choice and not a genuine reflection of the bitterness he feels just as strongly as he had that first day he sat down to write it.

He doesn't think he's ever been so happy for a performance to end. He takes his hands off the keys, they clap, he thanks them one last time. Hyacine promotes their album again, and they wish the cameras a merry Christmas together before they finally cut out, and more clapping fills the room. This time, Mydei thinks it's genuine.

He can't find Phainon in the crowd. He was already in the back, and now people are standing, discussing various things, preparing to review footage, dismantling equipment. He's nowhere to be seen, and Mydei soon gives up on trying to catch his reaction. He will leave, and Mydei can deal with the inevitable fallout when he gets home.

Aventurine steps onto the stage, shaking Mydei's hand. "That was great," he says, before giving Mydei the first smile he's ever seen from him that he actually believed. "All of you were truly incredible. Castorice, your singing —"

Mydei is interrupted by Ratio, who he hadn't seen in the crowd earlier. "Was your muse here?" he asks, calculating as ever.

Mydei chokes on his spit. "What are you talking about—"

“No one sings like that unless they’re singing to someone,” Ratio says. “Well, I hope whoever it is knows how lucky they are to be loved so deeply by someone as talented as you.”

Mydei feels his face go hot, and can’t imagine how flushed he might be. He can handle compliments well, he thinks, but a compliment to his talent by someone equally talented will always mean more to him than the general, shallow ones. Not to mention it was from Ratio, who Mydei had previously thought had the emotional capacity of a rock.

He’s brought back to the dressing room once they’ve reviewed the footage and audio and declared the band good to go. Mydei is forced to stumble his way through no less than ten thank yous as several audience members pull him aside to congratulate him, or his talent. It’s refreshing, to be in a room full of people who all care for music as much as he does.

“Why do you seem so glum?” His stylist says, as she sits him down and starts wiping at his face and undoing his hair. “You did great!”

“I know,” Mydei says. “I mean—I don’t mean to be conceited, but I like to think I know what good music sounds like.”

“I’d say you do, too,” she laughs, putting down her wipe before moving to take off his jewelry. “Well, then? Spit it out.”

“It’s nothing,” Mydei chews on his lip. He wasn’t going to tell her, but now he wonders who she is to him that he has to worry about her knowing. “I just worry I’ve ruined my relationship with a close friend of mine.”

“Ah,” she shakes her head. Mydei hopes he doesn’t have to explain himself further than that, but it seems she understands. “I wonder how solid the friendship was on their end if such a thing as you loving them differently than they love you is enough to ruin it for them.”

Mydei looks down. “I guess,” he mumbles. He isn’t entirely convinced of her words. He doesn’t even know if he’s fully processed them yet.

“Well then. Go change, and then go home. But don’t let such a small adversity ruin your successful night.”

“I won’t,” Mydei promises, and he finds that he means it. What he had done tonight was something to be proud of, and he knows it. If Phainon wanted to ruin it by rejecting him, then that was on him.

Chapter End Notes

thank you for reading <3

- yap

Chapter 11: Here's to the Ones Who Dream

Chapter Notes

city of stars, are you shining just for me?

cw: implied sex

See the end of the chapter for more notes

December 20th, 3869.

Mydei's apartment is silent when he arrives. It's almost eerie, like the calm before the storm. He doesn't know where Phainon is, but his shoes sit by the door and Mydei's car keys are hung up on the coat rack. His heart is pounding as he sheds his coat and begins to untie his boots, resisting the urge to throw up what little food he had eaten after the show.

Part of him hopes Phainon did not understand. Deep down, though, he knows that he will. Now, it was all up to whether or not Phainon reciprocated Mydei's feelings, which Mydei already knew was a no. He's already accepted the ensuing rejection, and braces himself for it as he walks into the living room.

Phainon sits on the couch. He's hunched over, head hanging in his hands. For a moment, Mydei reads this as despair—though he can't imagine why—and then he lifts his head, and that's unmistakable anger in his eyes.

Mydei sighs, turning towards the kitchen. "Can you let me eat something before you start yelling at me?"

"*What?!*" Phainon bursts, and Mydei can hear him stand up and start to follow him across the hall. "Mydei, you—*Deliver the Dawn?* Really?"

Mydei scowls as he opens the fridge. There's one yogurt left. He was saving it for Phainon. Now, he tears the lid off so he can eat it in front of him out of spite.

“Are you serious right now?”

Mydei doesn’t entertain him with much of a response. “Yes. I’m hungry.”

“You wrote that whole fucking song about being in love with someone else and you have the *audacity* to name it after me?!”

Mydei pauses, spoonful of yogurt hovering just before his mouth. “What?”

Phainon looks like a mess—hair sticking up in every direction, eyes glassy and bloodshot, lips flushed and bloody from chewing at them relentlessly. “What do you mean, *what?* What the hell was I supposed to think?”

Mydei blinks. He’s not quite sure what Phainon’s conclusion is just yet, so he doesn’t know where to begin with a response.

“Did you think I was going to enjoy that?” Phainon continues. “This… *confirmation* that you’re always going to be out of reach for me? That *you’ve* moved on, leaving me to lament in your absence knowing that I’m never going to get to? Do you even know how much that *hurts*?”

“Phainon,” Mydei starts carefully. The magnitude of his stupidity is almost enough to offset the beginnings of giddiness in his chest, if Phainon means what he thinks he might. “You think *Deliver the Dawn* is about me moving on from you?”

“Don’t do that,” Phainon sneers, brows furrowed as he glares at Mydei. “Don't act confused like you’re not the one who wrote the fucking song!”

Mydei sets the yogurt down on the counter. “I did write the song,” he starts, “so I think I know what it’s about.”

“Look, Mydei,” Phainon continues, like he’s not listening to a single thing Mydei says. “I know that…that *we* are—”

“I don’t think you know anything,” Mydei interrupts, crossing his arms.

“Oh, I don’t?” Phainon argues, eyes wild. “Look, I’m sorry that taking me in was such torture to you, Mydei. If I had known how you really felt this whole time I would’ve been out of your place months ago.”

“*What—*”

“You know I’m in love with you,” Phainon confesses, voice barely above a whisper. “Don’t you?”

Mydei’s lips part. He thinks the amount of conflicting emotions he feels in this moment must be enough to send him into shock.

“I’m sorry,” Phainon breathes. “I’m sorry, I know I’m too late, I know, but I just…*fuck, I’m sorry.*”

The giddiness in Mydei’s chest slowly starts to subside into anger. How *dare* Phainon misinterpret his song so badly? How could the smartest man Mydei had ever met possibly be so *stupid?* It’s so baffling, that Mydei isn’t quite sure how he’s stayed in love with Phainon for so long.

“Look, I know this is awkward for you, but I’d really appreciate it if you would say something—”

“Are you serious?” Mydei starts, and Phainon reels back like he’s been struck. “*You* went on that date a month ago. *You’re* the one who hates every song I’ve written about you. *You’re* the one who said you’re incapable of loving anyone more than you love music. Aren’t you?”

“God forbid I try to move on,” Phainon shoots back. “Like you clearly already have, with Phoebe, and with that guy at the party—”

“I thought that guy was you.”

Phainon blinks. “What?”

“I wanted *you*, Phainon,” Mydei confesses. “It’s always been about you.”

“You…” Phainon exhales, face softening. He looks more hopeful than Mydei has seen him in a long time, and it’s this quickly that all of Mydei’s

ire dissipates. “You do?”

“Yes,” Mydei confesses, quietly. “I do, I…I have.” For how long, Mydei doesn’t know. He thinks, now, that he never stopped.

“Can you say it?” Phainon requests. His eyes are wide, like he’s hands Mydei his heart of glass and prays that he doesn’t break it. “I need to hear you say it.”

Mydei swallows. “I love you,” he murmurs. “I wrote every song for you, because even if they’re not about you, I want you to like them,” he admits, and this confession is somehow worse than the first one. “You’re really the only critic who matters.”

“And *Deliver the Dawn?*” Phainon prods.

“I thought you were moving on,” Mydei explains. “It’s about you. Not me.”

“*Fuck*,” Phainon groans. “I would ask you how you thought that, but I guess I did a good job pretending to—”

Mydei steps forward, and Phainon stops. He can see the bob of his throat as he swallows, then lifts his eyes to meet Mydei’s. He looks a little scared. Mydei licks his lips. “Are we done?”

“With—” Phainon wets his lips, too. “With what…?”

“Discussing asinine topics.”

Phainon slowly starts to nod, like he’s hypnotized. “Yes.”

Mydei doesn’t waste a second longer. He steps forward, determined, and kisses him.

Phainon meets him halfway, hands gripping Mydei’s hips so tightly it almost hurts. Their bodies slot together, just as perfectly as they did all those years ago. It feels familiar and different and everything in between, Phainon licking into his mouth with an urgency that was never quite present

back then. Like he didn’t know, the last time they’d kissed, that it would truly be their last.

His hands are everywhere, hot against Mydei’s face, neck, slipping under his leather jacket as he forces it off his shoulders and to the floor. And then they’re underneath his shirt, and Mydei nearly hisses with such immense heat against his stomach. He nips at Phainon’s lips, trying to get him to stop, but he doesn’t, not until Mydei grips his shoulders and shoves him off.

“What’s gotten into you?” Mydei asks, laughing a little at how red Phainon has gotten. “Has it really been that long?”

“Stop it, Mydei.” Phainon steps forward and grabs Mydei’s wrist, before promptly dragging him down the hall.

“Oh my god,” Mydei laughs in disbelief. “Phainon. You haven’t slept with *anyone* else?”

“*You* have?” Phainon demands, pausing for a moment in between both of their bedroom doors.

“Sorry to disappoint,” Mydei says, still amused. “I wasn’t going to go celibate just because we broke up, Phainon.”

“And?”

Mydei snorts. “I know what you want to hear.”

“So? Say it.”

“No, Phainon. It wasn’t as good.”

Phainon pulls Mydei close, squeezing his back tightly in a near-possessive embrace. “You’re going to kill me, Mydei,” he groans, voice muffled into Mydei’s shoulder. “And…for the record, I haven’t been entirely celibate either.”

Mydei shakes his head in disbelief. “And?” he asks, partially as a joke, partially serious.

“It wasn’t as good either.”

Mydei laughs, shaking him free and pulling him into his bedroom. He flicks the light on, kicking the door shut behind them. “You’re clean, then?”

Phainon wastes no time in pushing Mydei onto the bed, immediately pinning his hands down to the sides of his head. “Yes,” he murmurs, kissing him lightly. “You’re that eager to go raw?”

“Ew, what is wrong with you?”

Phainon doesn’t seem remotely deterred by such a comment, simply pulling Mydei’s shirt up over his chest. It’s a bit of a struggle, but he manages to get it over his head and tosses it to the floor. All of the fear from earlier is thoroughly gone. “Then who is going to make love to you so—”

“*Phainon.*” Mydei grabs the hair against the nape of his neck and pulls him down, silencing him with his lips instead.

“Yes, *yes,* Mydei—” Phainon manages between kisses. “How dare I forget how impatient you are.”

Mydei laughs softly against his lips, a little breathless as Phainon’s hands wander lower and lower, unzipping his fly and then sliding back up to his waist to rub little circles into the sides of his hips. When they finally part, there’s hardly any space between them, foreheads pressed together.

Mydei’s head spins with giddiness. There’s unwritten melodies clouding his brain, and he can hardly wait to sit at the piano and write about him how he had always wanted.

“You’re so beautiful, Mydeimos,” Phainon whispers, hands trailing up over his chest. Mydei’s whole body tingles with it, the feeling of his rough scars against his skin.

Mydei exhales, the sound somewhere between a scoff and a laugh. He pulls Phainon’s hand from his neck and laces their fingers together. “Stop talking,” he requests, and Phainon leans back in.

Mydei wakes up when the sunlight filtering in through his curtains hits his face. He squints, shifting a little, only to be trapped in place by a pair of warm arms.

He can hardly contain his joy as the memories from last night fly back to him. Phainon was *his* again. It was as he had always wanted.

He lifts his head up as much as he can, searching for his phone, only to find an empty nightstand and his charger disconnected. He sighs, unable to find it in himself to be annoyed—he must have fallen asleep too quickly last night. But he needs to know what time it is, so he carefully ejects himself from Phainon's hold and moves to his dresser to put some clothes on.

His phone sits on the kitchen island, and he turns it on to find that it's not dead, but is getting to that point. He has an unread email from Aventurine congratulating them on a great performance, and a couple missed texts from the CALAMITY group chat.

calamity minus ipc
Yesterday 10:23 PM

Hyacine: I think that went well!! I can't wait to see the final video :))))

Cas: I think it went well too. But I'm ready to get back to recording now.

Cipher: we need to lock in if were gonna hit 13 songs

Cas: **12 songs

Cipher: 13

Cas: 12.

Cipher: mydei bro back me up here
Cipher: fine. dont then. 13 songs

Hyacine: However many songs we get to writing.

Cipher: booooooooringggggg

Today 8:47 AM

good morning guys. sorry for not responding, was busy last night once again. i don’t have any strong opinion on the song count argument. when are we going to the studio today?

Cipher: what is wrong with you

Hyacine: Morning Mydei! How about 10? Ratio has another group until then.

Cipher: what were you doing last night

why are you even awake

Cipher: mydei.
Cipher: what were you doing last night.

can you get off my ass

Cipher: tell that to phainon

Mydei sighs, unsure how she was able to figure that out so quickly. He goes back into his bedroom, plugging his phone in and sitting down at the edge of the bed.

Phainon has never looked more at peace, face perfectly relaxed. His mouth is slightly open, hair mussed, snoring quietly. Watching Phainon sleep has always made Mydei happy, with how rarely it seemed to come to him.

He pushes Phainon's bangs out of the way so he can press a soft kiss to his forehead. He stirs slightly, mouth closing, but he doesn't wake.

Mydei wants to spend the rest of his life like this. Phainon in his apartment, in his bed—he wants to wake up every morning with Phainon's body heat warming his bedsheets. He wants Phainon to attend all of his shows, and he wants to attend all of Phainon's. Just him, really, was all he ever wanted. The album doesn't matter. Fame and money don't matter. Nothing else matters.

He leaves to shower, and can hear faint music playing from the kitchen when he steps out of the bathroom.

"I made breakfast," Phainon says, when he hears Mydei come around the corner. "How do you feel?"

Mydei takes in the two plates of food laid out on the island. It's a similar feeling to the one he got when he had first cooked for him, when he was recovering from that awful hangover. He thinks he could be with Phainon for the rest of his life.

"I love you," he says, coming up behind him and planting a kiss to the back of his neck.

Phainon flushes a little, but grins at Mydei as he turns over his shoulder. "I love you too, Mydei," he says softly. "Can you imagine if we had just told each other this five months ago?"

Mydei laughs, pulling Phainon away from the sink to sit at the island together. He takes his first couple bites of the egg, potato, and sausage hash he had made in silence. Phainon had already seasoned it perfectly, with extra hot sauce on Mydei's portion. Such a feeling never quite fails to send butterflies through his stomach.

"Am I going to have to meet your dog now?" Mydei finally speaks up. It's a much less vulnerable question than what he really wants to ask.

Phainon stops chewing, staring at his plate for a few moments. “Really?” he asks, voice deadpan.

Obviously, he wasn’t fully serious. He wasn’t about to let something like a stupid mutt ruin this for him. “Yes,” he says, just to make Phainon sweat a little.

“Mydei, I’m not getting rid of my dog.”

“Fine,” Mydei starts. “But if I recall correctly, you implied that you hate my music last night.”

“Mydei, *what?*”

Mydei frowns, taking another bite of his food. When Phainon looks at him, mouth open in shock, he merely shrugs.

“Oh my god.” Phainon laughs, disbelieving. “I’m sorry. I obviously don’t actually think that.”

“Maybe so.” Mydei shovels the rest of his food into his mouth, washing it down with the pomegranate juice-and-milk concoction set out for him.

“*Mydei.*” Phainon’s voice is more serious now, as he watches Mydei move to the sink. “I’m serious. I love your music.”

“You better, because I’d break up with you if you didn’t.” Mydei puts his plate into the dishwasher, then loads his silverware in as well.

“So we’re dating?”

Mydei sighs. “I’d hope so.”

“Is that a yes?”

“How about you answer that one for yourself?” Mydei asks, then leaves to unplug his phone from his room. Castorice texted that she’s on her way two minutes ago, so he needs to hurry up.

When he walks back to the kitchen, Phainon has finished as well, and is in the middle of clearing his plate away. “Yes,” he says, turning to look at Mydei.

“Yes…what?”

“We’re dating.”

Mydei snorts, putting his phone in his pocket as he goes to the front door to begin putting his shoes on. “Good to know.”

“You’re in a good mood today,” Castorice says, as Mydei climbs into the passenger side of her car.

“Yeah?” Mydei clicks in his seatbelt, and puts his bag on the floor between his feet. “What makes you say that?”

“I don’t know. You seem lighter.” Castorice shifts the gear of her car, and heads down the road. “Has anything happened with Phainon?”

Mydei sighs, leaning his head against the window. “Why is everyone saying that?” he mutters.

“You sang him the song you wrote about him last night,” Castorice says, shrugging. “I think he’s smart enough to figure it out.”

Mydei hums. Not quite, but it’s a kind thought.

“So?”

“So…?”

“So, did you talk with him?”

“About what?”

“Stop playing dumb, Mydei.”

Mydei laughs, sitting up straight. He can’t help but smile just thinking about it. “We argued,” he says instead, continuing to laugh a little at the memory. Phainon tended to jump to conclusions that Mydei didn’t even know were possible.

“So he did figure it out.”

“No, not really.”

“What?” Castorice turns to stare at him in bewilderment as her car rolls to a stop before a red light. “What did he *think* it was about?”

“Me moving on…I think.”

Silence falls between them. Castorice blinks at him, wide-eyed, before she snorts, and starts laughing. Mydei can’t help but join her, still in disbelief about the absurdity of it all. “You told him he was wrong, right?” she asks, through her laughter.

“Yes.”

“And now, you’re…?”

“Dating. Yes.”

The light turns green, and they start moving again, Castorice smiling a little. “That’s really great, Mydei. I’m happy for both of you.”

“I’m happy for you too, you know,” Mydei turns to her, watching her carefully as she continues to drive. “You’ve opened up a lot. It’s nice to see.”

“You think so?” Castorice asks. “I am happy,” she continues, shaking her head a little. “I was thinking last night that I don’t really care how well our album does. I just love making music with you guys.”

“Funnily enough, I was thinking something similar this morning,” Mydei admits. “Regardless, I’m sure it will do well. If it was bad, I hope someone would have told us by now.”

Castorice laughs again, as she pulls into the IPC parking lot. “Yeah. I’d hope so.”

They arrive first today, swiping into the building and heading up to their recording studio. Mydei stares at their white board, still with hardly any songs placed into spots on the setlist. They still have to record Castorice’s song, and after that, they have nothing.

It’s not like Mydei is lacking inspiration, though. He could have written a thousand songs about Phainon before they got together, and he still can today.

Perhaps spurred on by the overwhelming success of their Christmas special, they start what slowly but surely becomes their most productive day yet. Ratio joins them late, already a quarter into recording Castorice’s song by themselves. He enters quietly, in the middle of one of Mydei’s takes. He can’t quite get the tone of voice right. The song calls for something softer, something he’s not incapable of but is less used to.

Hyacine has told him they got a good take four times already. It’s Mydei’s fault alone that they’re dragging it out as long as they have.

Mydei pushes the headphones down to sit around his neck as the music stops, already frustrated. Castorice has handed Ratio a copy of their score, explaining it to him quietly during the last take.

“That was good, Mydei,” Hyacine’s voice is muffled from the outside of his recording booth.

“One more time,” Mydei calls back. He takes a sip of water, puts the headset back on, and picks up the score from off the music stand before him.

“Uh—the whole thing?” Hyacine sounds slightly concerned. Mydei doesn’t look up from the music, crossing out one of the notes he had written in previously.

“Yes, just the main vocal line, please,” Mydei answers.

“Alright…” A couple mouse clicks, and the beginning of the computerized instrumentals begin to play again. Mydei starts singing on his cue, careful to keep his voice as soft as possible this time.

Even on their less classic rock-adjacent tracks, Mydei has never had to fight to keep the roughness out of his singing voice before. It was part of their sound, and while Hyacine and Castorice would both probably tell him that it was okay for this song to sound as he usually does, he doesn’t entirely agree with that.

Castorice wrote this song for Cipher. For Mydei, it was about Phainon—but it wasn’t bitter, like *Deliver the Dawn.* He could be as angry as he wanted while performing that song because it only enhanced it. Castorice, discouraged as she might have been while writing it, would never write out of a place of anger. He doesn’t want to do that to her song.

He steps back once the vocal part is done, dragging a hand down his face. It was better that time. It will do, for now at least.

“Was that it?” Cipher asks. She sounds bored as ever.

“Yes,” Mydei answers. “Sure.”

Ratio speaks up next, the first he’s heard his input during this session. “*Sure* doesn’t sound too convincing to me.”

“Oh my god, that was the fifth fucking take,” Cipher groans. “He sounded good the first time.”

Mydei relents, setting down the headset and exiting the booth. “It’s enough for now,” he says, moving to collapse onto the couch. There are only so

many times he can sing the same song in a row before his takes stop improving entirely.

“Alright,” Ratio turns the page to the packet he’s been given, scrutinizing all the parts before he decides who should record what next. “Hyacine, let’s do both guitar parts.”

Mydei would usually record the acoustic guitar part, given that it’s the part he’d usually play for their tours, but Hyacine is perfectly capable of playing both. So he sits on the couch and observes, trying to finish his water bottle before it’s his turn again. He never does his best work when he’s annoyed.

Hyacine gets both parts done in a little under twenty minutes, given that it’s essentially her first time reading the music. Cipher and Castorice go together, which they usually do. Mydei loves listening to the rhythm section record. Those two always seem to be so in tune with each other, despite their glaring differences. Cipher might take pleasure in annoying Castorice to no end, but the second they’re playing together, it’s like they’re speaking a language only the two of them know.

“Good,” Ratio says, and they exit the booth. Cipher gives Castorice a high five she only half-heartedly returns, but it puts a smile on Mydei’s face anyways. “There are a lot of instruments here that could be added in production, then,” Ratio continues, clicking through his production software until all the recorded tracks are added to a new save. “Accordion, for example. If you really want to find someone to record that part for you—”

“God, no,” Cipher drawls, collapsing next to Mydei in a heap. “Accordion players are the last people in the world I’d ever want to interact with.”

“Accordion is not too different from piano,” Mydei retorts, shooting her a glance.

Cipher snorts. “Exactly.” Mydei should have expected that.

“Anyways, it doesn’t sound super artificial if I add it in here,” Ratio says. He clicks a few buttons, putting the part Castorice had written into the software, before clicking play.

It does sound good. Mydei turns to Castorice, and she's smiling. "I think that's perfect," she says, once it's over and Ratio looks at her expectantly.

"Alright," Ratio resumes his clicking, even though he can somehow talk through his focus. "Mydei, if you're ready to record again, you're up, and then we can do backing vocals."

Mydei nods, downing the rest of his water bottle before standing up.

"Won't you tell us what was so wrong with that take?" Hyacine asks.

"Too rough," Mydei says. Cipher snorts, and he shoots her a glare. "I don't know. I think my voice should be softer for this song."

"Aw," Cipher snickers. "So cute. What changed?"

"Can you shut up?"

"It's all ready for you, Mydei," Ratio says, giving him a small smile that's almost apologetic in its nature. "Just relax. That's all I can really tell you."

Mydei nods, and pulls on the headset as he steps into the booth. He has to note that as soon as the instrumentals start playing, he feels instantly better than he had before, when all he had was a computerized score to accompany him.

He closes his eyes as he starts singing. It's always better for him to pretend there's no one watching. By the time he's done, he's almost surprised at how that had been so difficult for him just an hour ago. Were he singing a song about unrequited love, still thinking Phainon had someone else in his heart, he thinks it would have been a hundred times more difficult to soften his vocals than it had been today. Now, there's no reason to worry anymore. Phainon had always been his.

"Yeah," he says, once the music cuts out. "That's the one."

"Fucking *finally,*" Cipher groans. He's honestly surprised at how impatient she's being today, given that six total takes was far from the most amount of times Mydei has asked to redo something.

“Cas? You’re good with that?”

“I think that was perfect.” Mydei has never seen a bigger smile on her face, and it doesn’t fail to put an equally big one on his own.

Hyacine is sent into the booth to record backing vocals next. There was a bit of debate about who should do it, between the three of them—Mydei was always an option, of course, to match his own voice, but sometimes the song sounded better with a different color behind it. In this case, Mydei thought Hyacine was the obvious choice, even though Cipher thought it should have been Castorice. Castorice was ultimately the tie-breaker, who agreed that Hyacine would fit better.

Backing vocals take almost longer than Mydei’s main vocals, with the amount of layers and retakes they have to do. Mydei coaches her a bit on how to phrase her harmonies. Ratio, as always, listens to every single request they make.

They break for lunch, Ratio promising to finish it up while they’re out. They pick a fast food restaurant to go to quickly, and Castorice drives all four of them.

Mydei’s quiet the whole drive there, while Phainon texts him about groceries. Despite how much he loves the band and the music they’ve been making recently, he wishes he had the day off.

“You miss him that much, huh?” Cipher asks, sitting down across from him after she picks up their orders. “Stop smiling at your dick, dude, it’s weird.”

Mydei makes a show of turning his phone off, placing it face-down on the table. “How do you even know who I was texting?”

“All three of us are here,” she scoffs. “The only other person you talk to is Phainon.”

“You make it sound so sad,” Mydei says, as Hyacine hands him the burger he ordered. He has fast food so rarely that he allowed himself something unhealthy, just this once.

“So it was him,” Cipher grins, and Mydei can see that her mouth is full of food. He shudders, turning back down to unwrap his food.

“Stop it, Cipher,” Hyacine says. Mydei thinks he can feel her kick Cipher under the table. “It’s none of our business.”

Cipher looks at him, raising an eyebrow.

“Fine,” he sighs, exasperated. “Yes. We’re dating. Is that what you want to hear?”

Hyacine gasps, but Cipher just looks unimpressed. “He told me that already, little prince. From *you,* I want the *details.*”

Mydei is going to kill Phainon for betraying him like that, but that’s for later. He pushes it aside. “If it’s details you’re after, I think you’re better off asking him.”

“And I’d prefer not knowing,” Castorice speaks up.

“Thank you, Cas,” Mydei says. He hides the way he blushes, even if slight, behind a bite of his burger.

Cipher huffs. “You all are so boring.”

“You just called your girlfriend boring,” Mydei points out.

“*You two* are so boring,” Cipher corrects, pointing at both Mydei and Hyacine.

“What did I do?!” Hyacine exclaims.

“Oh my god,” Cipher mutters. “Fine. Mydei, you are boring.”

All because he doesn’t want to share his sex life. He thinks that’s a little bit of an unfair accusation, but he’s willing to accept the insult for now.

“I’ll ask him, then,” Cipher adds, almost quiet enough that Mydei couldn’t hear it. But he does, and he immediately picks up his phone to tell Phainon

not to give her a single detail.

The entire building is nearly empty by the time they have a good idea. Usually, Mydei would be itching to leave—they rarely stay past five, especially during their recording sessions. And if inspiration wasn't striking, the best solution would be to go home and try again tomorrow.

Unfortunately, today is loads of fun. Ratio is gone by the time they get back, so they sprawl out on the floor together and bounce ideas off each other. According to the deadline set up by them months ago, they really only have a couple days to finish their album. But realistically, good art takes time. So no one in this room feels rushed to throw together a good song, because good songs are never thrown together.

"If you guys weren't musicians, what would you be?" Hyacine asks, filling up a moment of silence. It's questions like these that have been hindering the four of them from writing down an actual song idea.

"Pianist," Mydei says immediately.

"That's still a musician, dumb fuck," Cipher replies, smacking him in the back of the head. It actually hurts, but Mydei doesn't say anything.

"Historian, then."

"Ew, okay. Guess we know who's going broke out of the four of us."

"What would you do to make so much money then, Cipher?" Hyacine prompts.

"I don't know, rob a bank?"

"Like you'll get away with that. You're not nearly intelligent, intimidating, or agile enough." Mydei has never thought very in depth about robbing a bank before. But he thinks he could get away with it if he did.

“If I get caught, would you bail me out with daddy’s money?”

Mydei laughs so hard he shocks himself with it. “Maybe with my mother’s money.”

“What if I killed someone?”

Mydei squints at her. “Are you trying to see how far I would go for you?”

Cipher shrugs, leaning all the way back on the couch until her head hands off the arm rest. “I’m just saying, if you killed someone, I would help you cover it up.”

“Kind of you.”

By the time the sun has begun to set, Mydei isn’t quite sure why he’s exhausted enough to leave just yet. After all, Phainon is waiting for him, but Mydei knows that Phainon will understand.

Hyacine’s hair has started falling out of her ponytail, Cipher is on her third energy drink, and Castorice smells heavily of weed. The result of her last “bathroom break”, no doubt. But they sit in the darkening room, no one with any strong desire to leave.

“I love you guys,” Castorice confesses, into the carpet her face is pressed into. Mydei’s stomach tumbles with giddiness. He’s so overcome with joy that he almost can’t contain it in a normal way. Because he thinks that when he’s inevitably on his deathbed, it’s these moments that he will look back on and miss the most.

“I love you too, Cassie,” Hyacine says, patting Castorice’s shoulder lightly.

“Wait, idea,” Cipher suddenly sits up straight, eyes wide. “We should write a happy song.”

“What?”

“Come *on,*” Cipher says. “Every song on this album is bleak as fuck. Our audience will have no other choice but to believe we hate each other.”

“Will they…?” Hyacine asks, voice doubtful. Castorice has lifted her head now, and even with her eyes glazed over she looks like she might like Cipher’s idea.

“*Cat Food* isn’t bleak,” Mydei attempts, determined to disprove her. They recorded him laughing outside of the studio and added it to the track, what about that was bleak?

“Yes it is, if you’re less dense than a brick,” Cipher shoots back.

“*City of Thieves?*”

“Shut up, Mydei, it’s about the vibe. None of our songs *sound* fun.”

No one says anything, silently playing through the track list in their heads. She’s sort of right. There are very few songs on the album that Mydei would consider “fun”. But maybe that was for a reason. Maybe it just wasn’t for them.

“Fun,” Castorice mumbles. “Sure.”

Mydei doesn’t remember Hyacine getting a hold of her guitar, but all of a sudden she’s strumming a pattern off the top of her head on all open strings. It’s fast, much faster than any of the acoustic guitar parts they’d ever written. Honestly, Mydei didn’t even know she could do that. Her skills are so much more recognizable on electric guitar.

“Woah,” he says. That’s all it really took to be on board with Cipher’s idea.

“That is perfect, Hyacine,” Cipher scrambles to go unpack her bass, which she had never even opened until now.

“You think so?” Hyacine blushes a little. Mydei moves over to the piano.

“F sharp,” Mydei suggests, and Hyacine plays the same strumming pattern, this time on an F sharp chord. When she repeats it, he joins in on piano, playing a melody off the top of his head. When he switches to a G chord, it takes Hyacine moments to shift her chord to a G, as well. Mydei smiles

wide when he hears it. To think the three of them had such minimal theory knowledge just mere months ago, and now their ears are just as good as his.

“That is *it*,” Cipher cheers, while they continue. It doesn’t take long for them to fall apart, but it doesn’t matter. It’s more of a start than anyone was expecting.

Cipher writes a simple bassline to go underneath Hyacine. As they play together, Mydei hums the beginnings of a melody above them. He doesn’t even notice Castorice pulling herself off the floor and moving to the drum kit until she, too, joins in. The line she adds is much less polished than what she usually writes, shocking Mydei with how uncharacteristic it sounds. Her eyes are fully closed, and Mydei can tell that this is exactly what she *feels* at this moment. And it’s perfect.

Hyacine ditches her acoustic guitar, picking up her electric one to add a solo of her own. Inspired by all of it, Mydei joins back in on piano. Her solo ends, and he picks it up—playing whatever he wants, but remaining in the key. He thinks, unable to keep the smile off his face, that this *might* be the most fun he’s had in months.

Hyacine vocalizes on top of everything once he ends his piano solo, causing Mydei to join in on harmony. And then, *somehow*, they all cut out at the same time.

Mydei doesn’t know what to say. He doesn’t think anyone else does either, if the way they stare at each other in shock is anything to go off.

“I fucking told you we had it in us.” Cipher breaks the silence. “Are we *kidding?* That was amazing!”

Polishing it is a breeze. The lyrics come quickly, oddly enough, though no one is one hundred percent sure what it’s about. Maybe it’s about something different to everyone, and Mydei thinks that’s beautiful.

It’s nearly midnight by the time they finish. Mydei’s stomach hurts from how much he’s been laughing tonight. He can’t name a single thing in his

life that upsets him anymore, and the final recording of *Argonautica* (Castorice's title) perfectly expresses exactly how he feels now.

They part ways in the parking lot, saying their goodbyes for the next few days. Talks about spending New Year's together were already in question, but they all had prior plans for Christmas. Mydei didn't, when they had first talked about it, but now he supposed he would be with Phainon.

He wishes Castorice a merry Christmas as she drops him off outside his apartment building. His family had never been one to celebrate the winter holidays very much, but the festive decorations in the apartment lobby and overplayed Christmas music on the speakers somehow manages to fill him with a warm sort of contentment. He doesn't think he felt the same way about it a year ago, though.

The hallways are silent as he walks to his apartment, quietly humming the tune of *Argonautica*, which he was unable to get out of his head.

He's promised Phainon to play him the album before its release, but hasn't allowed him to hear a single studio recording, no matter how much he begs. While Phainon's input would be extremely valuable were he recording a collection of original classical pieces, the man doesn't know the first thing about rock music.

He's met with the unmistakable sounds of piano music gracing his ears the second he opens the door to his apartment. He's so shocked by the raw emotion that strikes him that he stands in the doorway for a second, afraid that moving will disturb Phainon into stopping. He rarely practiced with Mydei at home these days; Mydei knew from the sheet music piling up in the living room that he had been practicing, but Mydei rarely heard it.

He had no idea Phainon had improved this much. The last piece he knew of him working on was the medium-difficulty Chopin étude he had told him about at the grocery store, and now Mydei is met with an almost perfect piano rendition of Tchaikovsky's *pas de deux.*

It had always been Phainon's favorite piece from the Nutcracker. Mydei never quite understood his fixation on it. He wasn't a very big fan of large, emotional pieces when they weren't as fast as he might have liked it. Now, though, he thinks he knows perfectly well what Phainon was talking about.

He shuts the door as silently as he can, before bending down to untie his shoes. The music is almost enough to bring Mydei to tears—even when Phainon stumbles over the notes, even when he makes a mistake. He doesn't stop, or go back to correct himself, and when Mydei takes off his jacket and walks forward to see the inside of the living room, he can see Phainon with his eyes closed, no notes on the stand. He's playing from his head—or heart, maybe—and such a thing as an incorrect note is not enough to stop him.

Phainon isn't playing to learn the piece, he's playing because he wants to, because he loves it. A skill Mydei always wished he had. He wished he could play piano like Phainon did. He wished he loved it as much as Phainon did. But alas, there was little Mydei loved more than the music he made today—and even less that he loved more than Phainon.

The moon casts a silvery, ethereal sort of glow over the room. Phainon's hair shines white, glowing as if lit by a halo sitting behind his head. It's almost funny, how perfectly romantic this scene is. How Phainon looks when kissed by the moon is akin to Mydei laying his eyes on a god. The music he creates swirls around them, and Mydei has never felt like this in his life. Not when they were dating in college, not with any potential partner he had ever met between then and now. Loving Phainon was not foreign, but loving him this much was. Like he'd die for him. A thousand times, if that was what Phainon needed. A million, or multiple millions. Whatever Phainon asked for, whatever he wanted, Mydei would give. If it was something he could not give, then he would sooner cut his own throat out than give up trying.

Phainon stops, hands resting on the keys as he holds out the last note. And then his shoulders relax and his posture slumps, breathing out a soft sigh as his hands come to rest on his thighs. He flexes them once, twice. Mydei feels like he can't talk without crying.

He tries, anyway. “Phainon,” he murmurs, his voice catching a barely noticeable amount. He’s quiet, but the room is even quieter.

Phainon startles, nearly jumping out of his seat as he turns to Mydei. “Mydei,” he says, louder than he most likely intended. “I—I didn’t know you were here,” he continues, eyes wide. Then, quieter, “Why didn’t you tell me you were coming home early?”

Home. It’s such a simple word, the kind of thing that doesn’t really mean anything unless you choose to give it meaning. He had never thought, before today, that he would hear the word from anyone and allow it to affect him in such a way. Regardless, shivers run down his spine as he hears it. He would like Phainon to be home with him. For the rest of their lives.

“I’m in love with you,” Mydei confesses.

Phainon breathes out a little laugh. “I thought we clarified that already.” Despite his retort, he still blushes at Mydei’s words. Like he’s not used to hearing them.

“I don’t know how else to put it,” Mydei says. “I love you.”

“Did I put a spell on you with that piece, or something?”

“Was that what you were trying to do?” Mydei knows that’s not the case, but he wouldn’t be surprised if it was. He certainly feels like it worked, anyway.

“No,” Phainon frowns. “But I played it for you.”

“For me, when you didn’t even know I would be home.”

“For you, Mydei,” Phainon confirms. “I just. Thought of you, and played what I felt.”

The irony of Phainon throwing Mydei’s old words back at him isn’t lost on him, and he wonders if this is the way Phainon felt when he had said it to him, all those years ago. “*Pas de deux,*” he muses. “That’s quite an honor.”

“You know, I’ve listened to that song almost every day since you left me.”

“I just started to understand why you like it so much, the second I walked through the door.”

Phainon laughs, standing from the piano bench. “Did you ever wonder what such a piece is doing in the middle of an otherwise upbeat ballet?” Of course Mydei hasn’t. Phainon knows this, so he continues without waiting for an answer. “His sister died mid writing it,” he says. “It was to commemorate her.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “You are likening me breaking up with you to your sibling dying.”

“Stop it, Mydei,” Phainon huffs, moving forward until they’re mere inches away. “The point is the *loss*, not the relationship.”

“*You* could have reached out to me at any point,” Mydei says. He’s unable to stop his eyes from flicking down to Phainon’s lips. “That’s your fault. Not mine.”

“Stop it,” Phainon says again, and kisses him. It’s light, but Mydei’s lips still tingle from the loss when they break apart.

“You’re too stubborn,” Mydei says. “That’s what stopped you, wasn’t it?”

“You said I reminded you of everything you were trying to forget,” Phainon’s voice is heavy when he says it, and it sends a pang through Mydei’s heart. “I would have reached out to you in a heartbeat if I thought there was even a small chance you would respond.”

“I did not say that,” Mydei says, shaking his head. He’s pretty sure he didn’t, anyway. He thinks he would feel more guilty if he had really said something like that.

“The *point* is, I wanted to give you your peace,” Phainon argues. “I might have made more of an effort after Rach 2, if…” he trails off, expression hardening out of nowhere.

“If Phoebe wasn’t in the picture,” Mydei finishes for him.

“No,” Phainon says immediately. Then, something a little closer to the obvious truth, “Maybe.”

“You need to stop bringing her up,” Mydei says.

“*I* didn’t bring her up—”

“We both know I said what you wanted to.” Mydei shakes his head. “Phainon, Phoebe broke up with me because she could see that I was still in love with you.”

Phainon’s mouth parts, eyes widening. He shakes his head, like he doesn’t quite believe it, and Mydei shushes him.

“I didn’t believe her,” he says. “I let her go, obviously, because she wanted that, but it wasn’t until recently that I realized how right she was.” Mydei frowns. “And how blind I’ve been.”

Phainon looks distraught, taking a tiny step backwards as he begins to process everything. “Was she upset?” Is the first thing he asks. Mydei almost grimaces at such a reaction. It’s not what he was expecting at all.

“Of course she was,” he answers. “What I did was wrong. She reacted as anyone would.”

“And you haven’t spoken since.”

“No, Phainon. We were never really friends.”

“And *we* were?”

Those words catch Mydei off guard. He doesn’t really know what to say, opening and closing his mouth like a fish. “Yes,” he tries to say, but it sounds just as forced as it feels. He’d always thought Phainon was his best friend both before and during their relationship. He still thinks Phainon is his best friend today, but if he’s really being honest, they’ve always been something a little bit more than that. Even when their relationship wasn’t

inherently romantic, it was like their souls had been tied together somehow. Meeting Phainon for the first time felt, in retrospect, like every decision in his life had led him up to that point. He didn't feel that way with Hephaestion.

"Mydei," Phainon says, and Mydei can tell by the tone of his voice that he knows Mydei is lying. "It's why I never called," he continues. "Trying to reconnect could only mean…one thing, really. I didn't want to disturb what you had, or—or make you think I was trying to get in your pants, or something."

"I never called, because…" Mydei stops, chewing at his lip. "I don't know, I guess. I knew that if you never did, I never would have."

"But if I did," Phainon lifts his head, eyes swirling with desperation. "If I did, would you have picked up?"

"Of course," Mydei says without hesitation. "Would you?"

"Mydei." Phainon is near whispering, and Mydei knows exactly what he means. The answer is obvious. "I've loved you since the day I met you."

"You're lying," Mydei says, smiling. "You told me you thought I was arrogant."

"Did I say that?" Phainon jerks backwards, blushing. "I'm pretty sure I said your playing…sounded arrogant?"

Mydei laughs, tugging on Phainon's arm to bring him in closer. "*I'm* pretty sure you hated me," he whispers, teasing, into the side of Phainon's neck.

"What—don't even *say* that, Mydei," Phainon argues, pulling back to study Mydei's face like he's trying to drink all of him in. "Maybe I was intimidated. That's as far as it goes."

"Intimidated," Mydei muses, raising an eyebrow. "I think that's worse." Mydei has been called intimidating before. Even when he was a teenager, before the hair dye and tattoos and piercings, his mother had told him that

people probably were wary of him because of his perpetual scowl and blunt way of speaking. It was the case both inside and outside of Kremnos—even in his hometown, he was outcasted in the same way. From Phainon, though, it's new.

"You know I didn't mean it like that," Phainon says, as if vocalizing Mydei's thoughts. "I liked you…eventually."

"I know," Mydei responds. His arms come up on instinct, pulling Phainon impossibly close and slotting his chin against Phainon's neck, like two pieces of a puzzle coming together. Sometimes he thinks their bodies were molded with each other in mind.

Phainon sighs heavily, like the feeling of Mydei's arms around him have freed him from a weight on his shoulders. He presses his hands into Mydei's back, one of them coming to settle right over the spot on his spine. Mydei shudders at such a familiar feeling he didn't know he was missing. Perhaps it's subconscious when Phainon lifts one of his fingers, nail scratching directly over the bone as he'd done so many times.

"Phainon," he whispers, voice muffled with the fabric of Phainon's shirt.

"It doesn't hurt anymore," Phainon whispers back. "Right?"

"No," Mydei responds. He squeezes his arms even tighter around Phainon as his nail turns into the pad of his finger, soothing over the vertebrae, touch so light it's more a caress than anything. "Not since you've been back."

The room has dimmed significantly when they pull apart, the moon hidden behind a thick cloud. "Stay," Mydei requests, or demands. He regrets the words as soon as they leave his mouth, but doesn't take them back.

Phainon nods. They don't talk about the logistics of that. They don't bring up the flights that were already booked, or his belongings, or his dog. He nods, and Mydei knows they'll figure it out.

They buy a Christmas tree the next morning. Phainon's parents always had a live tree that they planted in the farm after it was up for a week. They would decorate it together on Christmas Eve, and take it down on New Year's. Mydei's mother had the estate decorated by her staff. The main tree was always massive, and fake.

Living in the city means they can't have either of these things, so they settle on a tiny potted cypress tree and each of them buy one ornament, since it can't handle much more than that. Phainon's is the head of a stupid stuffed animal—some blue creature with sunglasses and a sunhat. He calls it Bubbles and selects it the second he sees it, like it was meant to be. Mydei's is a sharp sphere of red crystals. Phainon says it looks like it could kill someone, but Mydei thinks it's pretty.

They set the tree on the living room coffee table. Not two minutes have passed before Kokopo III is chewing at the leaves, and Mydei scolds her before feeling bad and giving her a treat.

The next morning, it's knocked over, dirt spilling from the pot. Mydei's red ornament is shattered on the floor, and he's only irritated for a minute or so before he decides that it was his fault for foolishly buying a glass ornament.

It's snowing too heavily to leave, so he spends the morning super-gluing it back together and puts it back on the tree. This time, they set it on the kitchen island. Kokopo III isn't allowed up there, and she knows this, but Mydei supposes that won't stop her from going up there when she has the apartment to herself.

On Sunday, Christmas Eve, they attend the matinee showing of the Nutcracker. They had bought last minute tickets after Phainon saw an advertisement for it and begged Mydei to go. Mydei can only deny him so much, so of course he obliged.

They exchange gifts when they get back, instrumental Christmas music playing on the TV. Phainon's choice, not Mydei's, but again, he can only deny him so much. He makes two mugs of hot chocolate and they sit together on the couch, as more snow begins to fall outside.

They each get each other two presents. Phainon starts by handing Mydei a little box, which he opens to find a beautiful golden guitar pick.

“Gold,” Phainon says, suddenly sounding shy. “To match all the gold you wear.”

Mydei nods, but looking at it, he can’t help but be reminded of the little flecks of gold in Phainon’s eyes, or the way his hair looks under the sun. He turns it over in his hand, and almost drops it when he sees the little engraving on the back. *HKS*, it reads, above a little heart.

“Oh my god,” he laughs, at the old Kremnoan word, one of his favorite insults in college. “Thank you, Phainon. I’m never going to use any other pick.”

“I’ll hold you to it,” Phainon smiles. Mydei isn’t sure if Phainon knows that he rarely used the word on anyone else.

He gives Phainon his first present next, a set of piano finger trainers. It was advertised as being for pianists, to train dexterity and strength, so he tells him that. He doesn’t say it’s mostly to help him recover further from his injury. When Phainon thanks him, his voice is soft. They both know what it’s for, and Mydei thinks he appreciates the way he doesn’t bring it up outright.

Phainon’s next present is a beautiful leather bound notebook. When Mydei opens it up, he finds it filled with page after page of staff paper. He doesn’t know for sure, but he thinks Phainon might have replaced the original lined notebook paper with staff paper all by himself. Mydei thanks him, already knowing exactly what song he’s going to use it to write.

Mydei’s final gift to Phainon is an old wooden metronome he had found from an old antique shop. Phainon looks at it like it’s a treasure, before the wrapping paper is even fully off of it. “Holy shit, Mydei,” he breathes. “Where the hell did you find this?”

Mydei shrugs, leaning over the coffee table to take a sip of his hot chocolate. “It looks old, but I promise it works,” he says instead.

“Hm,” Phainon adjusts the weight, then pulls the bar to one side before letting go. Sure enough, it clicks out four steady beats before Phainon stops it. “This is amazing,” he says, turning it over. “I hate using my app.”

“I know,” Mydei says. “Also, you were rushing *pas de deux.*”

“*Mydei.*” Phainon turns, shooting him the meanest glare he can muster. Mydei smiles a little, before Phainon tackles him down, metronome discarded to the side. “Take it back.”

“Or what?” Mydei asks. “You’ll prove me wrong?”

“As much as I would love to, there’s something a little more pressing right in front of me.”

“Hm.” Mydei hums, then pushes him off, sitting up. “That’s unfortunate, because I’m not having sex with you until you play *pas de deux* in time for me.”

Phainon doesn’t say anything, staring at Mydei in disbelief. “You’re not serious.”

Mydei shrugs, and gestures over to the piano. “Go, maestro. Show me what you got.”

They spend New Year’s Eve in Cipher’s apartment, drinking shitty champagne and listening to even shittier music. She can afford better champagne and she can make better music, but Mydei doesn’t complain.

He allows himself no more than one glass of champagne, then fills his cup up with pomegranate juice she “happened” to have in her fridge. It’s a nice gesture, but Mydei knows that if he brings it up, she would just say something mean in response.

They play a game of cards that’s entirely luck-based and Phainon wins nearly every round. He smiles through it all, even as Cipher’s insults grow

more and more personal and even Castorice shows the first signs of irritation.

They switch to a video game after Phainon's fifth win, Hyacine's suggestion. It's a dancing game that Mydei thinks she might have picked on purpose, because Phainon is atrocious at it. He's dared to do one on his own, and Cipher cackles as she watches his stiff attempts at dancing. Mydei can't help but laugh at such a sight, either. He needs to move his hips more —it's truly a horrible sight.

Castorice and Cipher do a tango dance next, telling Phainon to "watch and learn." Mydei doesn't think their attempt goes much better than Phainon's, honestly. Cipher is just as confused, and Castorice has to keep directing her when they bump into each other and step on each other's toes.

Mydei and Hyacine go next, to a pop song Hyacine picks out. He's just comfortable enough to give it his all, determined to show up both Phainon and Cipher, and he and Hyacine tie with five stars each.

"Let's go, Mydei!" Hyacine squeals as their scores are calculated on screen, jumping up and down to give him a high five. Mydei looks over his shoulder to see Phainon and Cipher, both equally shell-shocked.

Midnight comes, everyone somewhat calmed down as the night grows late. Phainon is curled into Mydei's side, shaking Mydei's shoulder every time he laughs at something Cipher says. Mydei is mere seconds away from falling asleep as the clock resets, and nearly jumps out of his skin at the ensuing celebration. He hardly processes it until Phainon's lips are on his, a quick peck before he pulls back and wishes him a happy new year.

Mydei wakes up the next morning curled up with Phainon on Cipher's couch. Phainon is already awake, hands threading through Mydei's hair, and he can smell the beginnings of breakfast coming from Cipher's kitchen.

"Is Cipher cooking?" Mydei mutters groggily, rubbing at his eyes.

"Don't worry," Phainon reassures him, kissing the top of his head. "Hyacine is helping her."

That is enough to put Mydei's mind at ease, burrowing further into the blanket thrown over the two of them. It's freezing in Cipher's apartment. "Where's Cas?" he asks, voice muffled.

"Showering, I think," Phainon answers. "Do you guys have to go back to the studio tomorrow?"

"Yeah," Mydei says. "I have to write my song today."

"Your song," Phainon shifts beside him, lifting his head to look at Mydei properly. "About what?"

"Secret," Mydei murmurs.

Phainon frowns, about to say something, but they're interrupted by Cipher before he can. "Wakey wakey, lovebirds, breakfast is served!" She yells from the kitchen. Mydei groans, and he can vaguely hear Cipher yelp after Hyacine, most likely, hits her with something.

The two of them made pancakes, though Mydei thinks it was probably more Hyacine's doing than Cipher's, because they taste good. She doesn't have a dining table, so they stand around the kitchen as they eat. Cipher sits on one of her countertops, and Castorice joins her when she gets out of the shower.

They talk about the album for a while, all the things Aventurine has already scheduled for them once they finish recording. It's a conversation Mydei can tell Phainon is soaking in, given how little Mydei had told him about all of it so far.

They leave soon after that, Phainon complaining all the way to Mydei's car. "I mean, seriously, I think your fans know more about the album than me at this point," he says, exasperated. Mydei's car is covered in a layer of snow, having made the mistake of parking outside last night.

"Are you not a fan?" He asks, retrieving the brush from his trunk. He moves to the windshield first, brushing it off while Phainon watches.

“Um, I think you and I are a little closer than *artist and fan*,” Phainon pouts, crossing his arms. “Besides, you’ve barely posted about it. Your fans who follow *only you* probably have no idea.”

“Then there you go,” Mydei argues. “At least you know I’m recording an album.”

“Just *one* song,” Phainon begs. “Come on, Mydei.”

“You’ve heard one song,” Mydei deadpans. He opens the passenger door and slams it shut, watching the snow fall down to the sidewalk.

“That’s the same song everyone else has also heard,” Phainon says.

“You barely let me hear you practicing.” Mydei puts the snow brush away, then moves to the driver’s side to do the same before finally climbing in. Phainon does the same, blowing on his hands to warm them up. “Think of it as payback for that.”

Phainon groans in response to that, but he doesn’t say anything back, so Mydei considers it his win.

Mydei starts writing as soon as they get back, sitting in the living room as Phainon takes his usual spot at the piano.

He gets the lyrics done in under an hour, accompanied by the sound of Phainon’s practicing. He doesn’t recognize the piece he’s working on, but he hums the melody in his head on top of it. He thinks the two songs end up in the same key by accident.

When the room goes quiet, I can still hear you play
The music hangs in the air, I wish I never walked away
Because every road I took just led me back home

“I’ve been using the gift you gave me,” Phainon says, cutting through Mydei’s thoughts. “I think it’s helping. Watch this.” He proceeds to play the first few lines of *Moonlight Sonata*’s third movement, even faster than how Mydei remembers the written tempo.

“Hm,” Mydei looks back down at his notebook, hiding his smile. “Adequate.”

“Oh, fuck you,” Phainon says, laughing. “You couldn’t do that.”

Mydei shrugs. He’s right, but he’s not going to admit that.

However long it takes, I will always love you
Ten million heartbreaks, I will always love you

Mydei looks up, watching Phainon carefully. He pretends not to notice Mydei’s gaze, eyes too focused on the sheet music in front of him. He’s back to the piece Mydei doesn’t know, that he’s subconsciously harmonizing with.

“Phainon,” he says, and he stops. “Can you play this for me?” He hums a short piano melody that was in his head, after which Phainon looks down at the keys for a minute before playing exactly the notes Mydei was asking for. “Brighter than that,” Mydei guides, and Phainon does it perfectly the second time. “That’s good,” he grins, opening the notebook Phainon had gotten him for Christmas. “What notes were they?”

“Starts on an A,” Phainon answers. “It’s all whole steps from there, except the final interval is a second.”

Mydei haphazardly scribbles it into his staff paper, then looks over at his second notebook, where he had been writing the lyrics. “Thank you,” he says, reading over the lyrics one more time as Phainon resumes the piece he was working on before.

“Is your song in A minor?” Phainon stops halfway through a phrase to ask the question, like it had been forced out of him.

“I think so,” Mydei says, not looking up from his notebook. He scratches out one of the words, unsure what to replace it with just yet.

“That’s funny. So is my piece.” Phainon looks over at his sheet music for a split second, before focusing his gaze back on Mydei. “And it’s my favorite key.” It’s added quietly, like an afterthought.

“Huh,” Mydei mutters. “I thought C major was your favorite key.”

Phainon’s gaze loses any of the softness it just had, staring at Mydei as if he had just insulted his entire lineage. “Stop it, Mydei.”

“What? Aren’t they the same thing?”

“Oh my god.” Two very dissonant chords come out of the piano as Phainon rests his elbows on it, head falling into his palms. “You did not just say that to me.”

“No sharps or flats. Isn’t that the same thing?”

Phainon groans very loudly, so obviously irritated that Mydei decides to put him out of his misery and stop messing with him. They turn to their respective projects, Mydei finishing up the lyrics so he can go back to writing out the music in his new notebook.

When he’s done, he transports it into his computer so he can listen to it. Even though part of him doesn’t want to tune Phainon’s playing out, he plugs in his headphones anyways.

He emails a copy of the song to Ratio when he’s done, and copies the rest of the band. He asks them all to take a look at it and let him know if they like it or want to change anything.

He gets a text from Cipher first, which is surprising because Mydei didn’t think she checked her email very often. “wtf loverboy,” she writes. “and here i foolishly thought you’d lose ur magic touch when you fell in love.”

The rest of the responses trickle in while he cooks dinner, water boiling over on the stove as he rushes to defend himself in a minor argument over tempo with Castorice. Their fights over these things never last very long. They trust each other, and know that a music suggestion is never personal.

And then work resumes the next day, back to the studio as if nothing ever changed. In two days, the new song is recorded, and Ratio officially tells them that while his work is done, theirs is far from it.

They spend the rest of the week, and the week after that, pushing off Aventurine's incessant questioning about a release date while they find themselves in argument after argument over track order, minor tweaks, or things completely unrelated to their music altogether. Mydei has listened to the album so many times at this point—in different orders, or individual songs as they decide some need finishing touches—that he doesn't even know if he likes it anymore.

City of Thieves, the first song they wrote, is now his least favorite. It feels like an entirely different group of people wrote it, like it's not fully theirs anymore. Mydei spends hours at a time hunched over his laptop, messing with mixes and soundbites, until he feels like he's going insane. Phainon is constantly reminding him that it's okay, that music is something he loves and there's no point in agonizing over it to such an extent. Mydei would listen more if Phainon followed his own advice once in a while.

Phainon, finally cleared by his physical therapist, gets a job at a local cafe. It's temporary, and they both know this. Just a way to get his own money to spend as he works towards performing again. He insists upon paying Mydei back for rent, but the last thing Mydei wants is compensation for something that was never much of a burden on him.

It's nearly February by the time they finally finalize the track order. Mydei spent more time than he would like to admit fixating on the tiny details of every single track, but he thinks it pays off when he leaves the studio with a finished album saved to his files and officially sent to Aventurine.

They call it *Oracle,* after holding a vote on the top titles everyone had contributed during another session of brainstorming. The title is the last

thing they settle on, and the album is officially done.

Phainon gets home late from his shift, and he can somehow tell from the way Mydei looks at him what he means to say.

“You finished it,” he breathes, halfway through taking his shoes off.

Mydei nods.

Phainon wants to listen immediately. Mydei makes him wait until after they’ve both eaten dinner, and then he hooks his laptop up to the TV and they lay together on the couch as he broadcasts each file to the big screen.

Phainon clings to Mydei throughout all of it, like he’s afraid of him leaving, somehow. Mydei holds onto his shoulder and taps along to whatever part he likes the best. Sometimes it’s the bass, or the drums. Most of the time it’s the piano.

His face lights up with laughter when he hears Caelus’ trumpet solo in *City of Thieves.* A lot of the song had been touched up, but Mydei didn’t change a single second of that part. It was perfect from the first day he heard it in the studio.

He squeezes Mydei so tightly during the studio version of *Deliver the Dawn*, that Mydei can hardly breathe. He laughs at the piano part of *Cat Food*, but any of Mydei’s shared lightheartedness fades the second the beginning instrumentals of *Love Song* come on. It’s a stupid title. He had tried so many times to think of something better, but at the end of the day, listened to Hyacine when she told him the bluntness of it suited him.

Phainon catches on as soon as he hears what key it’s in. “A minor,” he whispers, lifting his head a little. His eyes are practically shining. Mydei can’t do anything but smile. “This one’s mine, isn’t it?”

Mydei pulls him back down. “They’re all yours,” he answers. “But yes.”

Phainon is near to tears by the end of that song, and Mydei would be lying if he said he wasn’t close. Somehow, he holds it together until the final

track, *Conqueror of Lions.* Phainon sucks in a breath as he hears the first piano chord ring out, and Mydei is glad that he can't see the pain so blatantly obvious on his face from the angle of his head.

He bites back his tears until the song ends, and the silence that comes with the final track fills the room. "Mydei," Phainon prods, sitting up. "That was beautiful."

Mydei doesn't trust himself to speak without crying, so he nods instead. He had avoided listening to that song for as long as he could for this exact reason. He trusted his earlier self for believing it was perfect and hadn't touched it. It remained the final track throughout all of their workshopping, and he always stopped when he got to the start of it.

"I'm so proud of you," Phainon continues. "You're just—god, I'm so lucky. I'm *so* lucky, Mydei."

Mydei nods again, biting his tongue. Phainon looks almost distraught at such a sight, and pulls him in so his head rests against his chest. "She would be so proud of you," he murmurs into his hair, as his free hand settles right against that vertebrae again. "You know that, right?"

Mydei thinks he does. He nods a third time.

The work doesn't stop. If anything, it gets a hundred times worse—they're even more busy than before, doing the worst part of the preparations.

They sit in stuffy meeting rooms, being talked at about creative ideas they have little say in. They've taken Castorice's original idea of modeling characters after old Amphorean myths, and ran with it. Mydei is at least happy they're following the idea instead of doing what they think would work better. They plan music videos for *Wrath of Man* and *Deliver the Dawn*, which are projected to be the highest charting songs off the album. *Wrath of Man* for being the first track, and *Deliver the Dawn* for being familiar.

Then the meetings talk about more boring things—their tour schedule, opening acts, interviews, photoshoots. Album cover designs. If they want it to be a photoshoot, or an artwork. For some reason, Mydei wants neither—he doesn't want to be in it, but he wants it to be some sort of shoot, anyway.

He spends a whole day doing fittings, and doesn't see a single member of the band once. He knows it's because they're off doing fittings of their own, but he feels like he's going insane after being surrounded by IPC workers the entire time.

For whatever reason, they seem to want him shirtless. Mydei thinks he might know why that is, but it doesn't bother him enough to protest. He worked hard for his body, so he might as well show it off.

The photoshoots are the worst part. Mydei has no idea why in the world they need so many promotional photos for one album—Cipher has plenty of candids in her camera roll that would do the trick just fine. But alas, it's not his decision to make. They take a hundred pictures of Mydei as "Mydeimos", and then they put the four of them in matching suits and take photos that Mydei is sure would belong more on the front of a program than the back of a CD.

Then they do weird ones. They put Mydei in heavy make-up and then make him stand under a sprinkler until his shirt is sticking to his stomach. They put the four of them in casual, grunge clothes and take pictures of them from above a staircase. They bring in props like monkey bars or chairs that are edited to look like they're in an empty movie theater. They make Castorice and Mydei pretend to arm wrestle while Hyacine and Cipher cheer in the background. Mydei *really* wants that one to be their new artist picture on music streaming platforms. He hopes he can convince the other three of this later.

Phainon spends hours laughing at him later that night, as Mydei clicks through the emailed files. They see all the outtakes, the ones where Mydei is blinking, or isn't making quite the right expression. And then, perhaps feeling bad for making fun of him, Phainon pulls out a few of the old photoshoots he had done with Aglaea the first time he'd played with her orchestra.

There are a few shoots Mydei has seen finalized versions of from Phainon's social media, but most of them are new to him. Aglaea seemed to have a very specific image with Phainon that she executed perfectly. Somehow, she managed to capture his charm in some shoots, and his beauty in others. Mydei’s favorites highlight both.

Until he swipes to one photo in particular, and Mydei feels like all the air is knocked out of his lungs.

He grabs the phone from Phainon’s hands instantly, so he can see the picture better. It’s absolutely ethereal, the kind of thing you’d see in an Okheman museum. Phainon’s arms are perpendicular to the rest of his body, head tipped back and turned to one side as if he’s mimicking a crucifixion. There are massive angel-like wings behind him, and the tip of a halo behind his head. He’s dressed in hues of white and gold, lit by raw sunlight filtering in from the bottom of the image. There are clouds all around him, like he’s rising from them.

Mydei has never seen anything like it in his life. “Phainon.” Is all he can manage, as he finds himself unable to tear his eyes away from the photo.

“What?” Phainon asks. “You like it?”

There’s only one coherent thought in Mydei’s head. *This is their album cover.*

It takes more convincing on Phainon’s end than the rest of the band. They all agree almost instantly, and when Phainon is finally on board after Mydei says they would edit it to make it more ambiguous about who it is, he says he would ask Aglaea to give the IPC the rights to use the photo.

Aglaea agrees with little trouble, and he sends it into Aventurine for editing. It’s finalized a few days later. The editors added even more of a golden hue to it, on the darker end of the original. The shadows and highlights are more pronounced, and there’s a grainy sort of filter over all of it. You can’t tell it’s Phainon in the final photo at all.

The music videos are filmed during what's close to the worst two weeks of Mydei's life. He's never been so busy, or so drained, in his life. A small part of him is undoubtedly glad that they're putting so much time into promotion for this album—more than they ever put into their projects in the past. He's glad they think it'll perform well.

Still, Mydei is shuttled around from set to set for these music videos. They film outside in short bursts, then move inside to perform in front of a green screen. By his tenth time summoning emotion for the shoot, Mydei doesn't think the songs mean as much to him as they once did. And he's okay with that. He's ready for them to mean something different to someone else now.

Aventurine pulls him aside after they finally wrap the music video for *Deliver the Dawn.* "The next few weeks are booked with interviews," he explains, just as corporate as ever. Mydei hasn't experienced the same camaraderie from him since he had Eurypon escorted out of the office. But true to his word, he hadn't heard a thing from the man since.

"Yes," Mydei says, wiping sweat from his forehead. "More travel."

Aventurine gives him a look Mydei could easily misread as apologetic. "There are always topics interviewers aren't allowed to ask about. I'm going to go through the questions tonight and over the weekend, and wanted to see if you had any requests first. I will ask your bandmates as well, I just thought this would be a better conversation to have one-on-one."

Mydei thinks carefully. He knows, now, that the dating rumors with Phainon are in full swing. Even when he doesn't check social media, Cipher makes sure to remind him of it. He hadn't confirmed nor denied this, and he had only posted something once or twice since Phainon started living with him. He was bound to get at least one question about it.

Now, though, he shrugs it off. Let them ask. He wasn't ashamed of Phainon—quite the opposite. If he confirmed the rumors, maybe he'd open up a whole new audience of listeners to Phainon's work that might not have checked it out otherwise.

“My father,” he says instead. “I don’t want to deal with a single question about him, or the company, or anything like that.”

Aventurine nods. “And you know what to say if they find a work-around.”

“Of course.” How could Mydei forget the weeks upon weeks of media training he had been put through when he was first signing with the label? He had almost spent the longest amount of time in those classes out of the four of them, second only to Cipher. It was practically torture, being forced to learn how to portray himself the way people who didn’t even know him wanted him to be portrayed.

All things considered, the interviews don’t end up being that bad in the beginning. They ask the same manageable questions a thousand times. Where did this album come from? How does it differ from the last EPs? Is this your most personal work yet?

They always give the same answers. It was the album they needed to make. They had the time of their lives writing it and can’t wait to do it again. Yes, absolutely.

It’s with the solo interviews that the worst questions start. They ask him about college. About piano. About how it feels coming back to it. And finally, one brave interviewer asks him about Phainon.

“I’m a big lover of classical music myself, you know,” he says, laughing a little. He had done an incredible job of making Mydei feel safe with him, and he wonders how much of what he says is actually true. “I loved Phainon Khaslana’s work before his injury.”

Mydei nearly jumps out of his skin, and he’s tremendously thankful that this isn’t a recorded interview. “Right,” he says awkwardly. *Where are you going with this* remains unsaid.

“It’s no secret the two of you have been living together lately,” he continues. “How did you meet? How long have you known each other?”

Mydei sighs. He knows the last time he knew he was photographed with Phainon wasn't the last, but he didn't care to investigate it further. To think it was common knowledge that they lived in the same apartment—the rumors would be hard to dispute, were he a fan.

"I met him in college," he says, swallowing a little before continuing. His heart is racing in his chest as he realizes he's doing this. "We…" he clears his throat. "We started dating at the end of my freshman year. And then we broke up when I dropped out, and reconnected after his injury." He hates how many people in the room he's confessing this to. Aventurine stands in the corner, with the band beside him and what seems like countless corporate workers as well. He hates how many more people will read this article, or learn of its contents one way or another.

The interviewer does a very good job of seeming impartial to this information, typing something in his laptop while nodding along calmly. "And the status of your relationship now…?"

Mydei smiles. He asks it almost like he feels like he shouldn't, and that somehow makes Mydei feel a little bit better about answering truthfully. "Yes," he confesses. "We got back together in December."

And with that, the worst of it's over. He won't have to hide Phainon anymore—not that he necessarily was in the past, but now he can freely post pictures of the two of them and the whole world would finally know that Phainon is *his.*

The interviewer continues to ask a couple more questions about Phainon's status and whether or not he would be returning to piano, which Mydei thinks are more self-indulgent than anything. He answers as truthfully as he can, which is that he is working towards making his debut with Aglaea's orchestra over the summer.

His favorite interviews are the ones where the four of them are asked to break down the music together. They talk about growth, collaboration, finding their sound through trial and error. They mention the inherent messiness of the album, despite its coherent sound. Mydei does not say *Conqueror of Lions* saved him, or that *Love Song* was a song his heart

yearned to write. Even though his relationship with Phainon will be public knowledge the second that article is released, he does not mention him once.

With the release date—May 4th, 3870—in sight, Mydei starts posting more on his social media. He asks Cipher for some of her candids and posts those, along with a few of his own. He even posts a picture she had taken of him and Phainon kissing at their New Year's party, not thinking about it very much until he sees the reception afterwards. They'll calm down about it eventually, though, and that's how Mydei wants it to be.

He even starts posting short-form content of classical piano songs played on electric guitar or rock songs played on piano, and he thinks Aventurine should be very proud of all the work he's putting in.

And then, finally, the night of May 3rd arrives.

Mydei doesn't think he could sleep if he tried. He's buzzing with anticipation, jittery and nervous as he types out the caption of his final post promoting the album that's about to drop.

He tells Phainon he'll be in bed soon. And then he sits in the living room, staring at the grayed out album on his music streaming app, the last time he'll ever see it grayed out. He had, in the end, successfully convinced the band to use the arm wrestling photo on their profile. Even now, with all his nerves, he's able to find it in himself to laugh at it.

He can hear Phainon open the door to their bedroom, before his footsteps grow closer and closer as he comes down the hallway. He's fully ready for bed as he appears in the doorway, hair damp with his horrendously ugly pajamas on.

Mydei smiles at him anyway, and he knows he must look exhausted. "You don't have to stay up."

"I know," Phainon says. He comes to sit next to Mydei, snuggling up beside him anyway.

The release is anticlimactic, all things considered. It happens from one page refresh to the next. One second it's still grayed out, the album cover the only thing fully visible. Next, all of the songs are posted, and instead of excitement, all Mydei feels is dread.

He presses play. The beginning bassline of *Wrath of Man* rings out around them, and Mydei starts to feel lightheaded. He pauses it almost instantly.

"Well?" Phainon whispers.

"I hope they like it," Mydei confesses. Somehow, it's the most vulnerable he's ever felt. Since when did he care about a thing like that?

Phainon sighs. "Does it matter to you if they like it?"

Mydei swallows. Phainon's words seem to ground him in an instant, and he shakes his head. "I guess it doesn't."

They fall asleep like that, Mydei's phone tossed aside. With Phainon next to him, he finds he doesn't care what the reception is. It's music he's endlessly, immensely proud of. It's music he loves, and he would never apologize for that.

Oracle
CALAMITY
Album • May 4, 3870

Wrath of Man
Berserker
Lies Are Lies
City of Thieves
Argonautica
Deliver the Dawn
Bleeding Out (Interlude)
Cat Food
Love Song

Fever
Epitaph
Conqueror of Lions

12 songs • 51min

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Reception is relatively slow, at first—even though when Mydei wakes up in the morning, he wouldn't say that at all. Phainon is still asleep beside him, so he reaches for his phone as discreetly as possible.

It feels like forever before he reaches the end of his new notifications. There's what seems like thousands of them for him to sift through. His follower count has skyrocketed, and his most recent post has millions of likes.

The album already has over a million streams. They taper out towards the end of the album, with *Wrath of Man* and *Deliver the Dawn* having the most, as expected. But Mydei can't find anything to complain about.

He has emails from brands reaching out to do advertisements, and a couple from Aventurine regarding the tour. He puts that away to read for later and goes to his messages, met with hundreds of new messages ranging from friends to people he hasn't spoken to in years. Serval tells him it's his best work yet. His old group chat with his high school friends was revived with all of them expressing their earnest congrats. He even has a text message from Madam Herta, which is somehow the scariest part of it all.

It doesn't end there, though. Songs go viral. The music videos start raking in views, their Christmas special gets popular again. His follower count effectively quadruples in three weeks. Phainon sends him edits of himself and Mydei wonders why they're being recommended to him in the first place.
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The work doesn’t end, either. The band is shuttled around even more than they were in the weeks leading up to the album release. They have more photoshoots, though this time for outside companies that want to put them on an advertisement, or a magazine cover. They have more interviews, where they’re forced to do challenges or showcase how much they know about each other.

Some of it is fun. A lot of it is incredibly overwhelming. The album reaching these levels of success was unprecedented to him—he’d never thought he wouldn’t be able to leave the house without getting recognized. It’s like his band became a household name overnight.

His favorite thing, out of all of it, is getting to see the different ways people connect with their music. *Wrath of Man* and *Deliver the Dawn* are the most popular songs, but they’re not the only songs people like. A teenage girl at a meet and greet tells him *Cat Food* is his favorite, which he can’t help but make a confused face at. The moment gets clipped online and even more people come forward to say that their favorite was *Cat Food* too. It’s not that Mydei doesn’t think the song is good—if it wasn’t, he would never have allowed it to make the final cut—but it’s far from *favorite* material.

He gets private messages from people telling him *Conqueror of Lions* saved their life. He doesn’t reply, but takes their words to heart. Cipher tells him she received similar messages from people saying *Lies Are Lies* either healed their relationship with loved ones, or forced them to realize it was unstable and leave. As for her and Aglaea, she reveals very little, but something about her demeanor is lighter now. He doesn’t know if it’s because of the album’s success or something more specific than that.

Mydei is no longer worried about putting his heart out into the world. It’s clearer to him than ever before that this album was just as much what people needed to hear as it was what he needed to write.

Most of their tour sells out before it starts, in June. Mydei regrets doubting Aventurine for booking arenas, because it turns out some locations might have sold out a stadium. To think that the IPC’s generous predictions of their album reception would turn out to be an underestimate makes Mydei’s head hurt.

June 1st, 3870. One month after the release of Oracle.

It’s not until their first show, right here in east Penacony, that all of it finally starts to sink in.

They sit in the green room as the opening act begins. Cipher paces back and forth like a metronome, hair already messed up from when the stylists had fixed it up. She talks faster than Mydei has ever heard. He loses track of what she’s saying somewhere after *did you see the line outside?* It’s the most nervous Mydei has ever seen her.

Hyacine is the exact opposite, unable to stop moving as she bounces on the balls of her feet with excitement. She plays through her *Wrath of Man* guitar solo on her unplugged guitar, faster than what the original tempo is. Mydei would be more impressed if he wasn’t already so nervous.

And then Castorice sits beside him, one hand propped up on her knee as she chews at her freshly painted fingernails. “I need a gummy,” she mutters, when Mydei places a hand on her shoulder. He laughs at that, though it very quickly brings with it a fresh wave of nausea.

Aventurine claps his hands together as he enters, dressed in a suit that makes him look incredibly out of place between all of their concert outfits. “Alright,” he says, voice carrying more than it needs to in a room so small. “As always, feel free to interact with the audience as much as you want. The security guards are here for a reason. Maybe no crowd surfing though, at least not you, Mydei.”

Mydei almost groans. He really wasn’t planning on it, but in saying that, Aventurine basically just gave Cipher the go-ahead.

“And drink water. Mydei especially, but I don’t want any one of you passing out on me.”

“Yes, dad,” Cipher mutters, leaning against the wall. Mydei doesn’t know why she’s acting so annoyed, since all of his rules were just targeted at Mydei specifically. Even though he’s not even close to the worst behaved person on stage.

“I’ll take that as a yes from all of you,” Aventurine says, taking the time to look at each band member sternly.

It feels like an eternity before it’s finally their time to go on stage. The crowd is deafening as Mydei has his in-ears put in for him, and the crew rushes around doing finishing touches to their costumes and makeup. One crew member messes with Cipher’s hair for too long, trying to get every strand back into place. It’s no use, because her hair will be even more of a mess by the end of the show regardless.

The cheers grow to ear-splitting levels, even with his in-ears in, as they walk onstage and take their places. Mydei almost freezes when he stops in front of the mic stand, unsure what to do when faced with a crowd this large. He doesn’t know if it’s more or less than the people that were present at the festival Robin headlined, but it doesn’t even matter. This time, they’re all here for him.

He doesn’t say anything. He thinks he might breathe into the mic a little too loud, but he gets little warning as Cipher instantly launches into the opening bassline of *Wrath of Man.*

That’s all it takes to snap him out of his haze. Castorice joins in, and then Hyacine, and as soon as Mydei steps up to the microphone and sings the first lyric, everything is perfect.

Performing used to be an outlet for him. A way for him to release all of the anger he had without hurting anyone, like his father always had. He didn’t know what would happen to him if his music was taken away. He thinks he’d find a way to manage himself anyway. Because his father wasn’t half the man that he was.

Now, though, it’s perfect. He loses himself in the song, in the energy of the crowd and of his band, like it’s second nature. He has never felt more like

he belongs somewhere as he does now.

It’s all perfect. Hyacine, bouncing side to side as she plays her flawless guitar solo. Cipher right in front of her, the two of them grinning at each other with a freedom Mydei rarely sees. Even Castorice is in her element, loose hair flying around her like a halo as she keeps the three of them perfectly steady.

And then there’s the crowd. Jumping up and down, hands in the air, screaming every single one of Mydei’s lyrics like they know the song by heart. He thinks of Phainon, somewhere in the audience, watching him like he’d promised all those years ago. It all feels so worth it. Mydei doesn’t know if he’s felt true happiness until this very moment.

The rest of the concert is just as perfect. They fly into *Berserker* with little pause after *Wrath of Man*, which is just as electric. Only after that do they stop to greet the audience, Cipher making her usual conversation while Mydei pauses to drink some water.

“Good evening, Penacony!” Cipher is saying, as he walks back over to his mic stand. “Alright guys, cheer if you want Mydei to take his shirt off.”

The resulting screams are deafening. Mydei winces a little bit as he lifts his hand to adjust one of his in-ears, but there’s no problems with it.

“Cheer if you want Mydei to keep his shirt on,” Hyacine adds, and Mydei actually laughs out loud at the subsequent silence.

“Can we stop suggesting that?” Mydei asks. “Why don’t you take your shirt off, Cipher?”

“Don’t test me, pretty boy,” Cipher wiggles her eyebrows.

“Do it,” Castorice deadpans from the back.

“Yeah?” Cipher turns around, shooting Castorice a blindingly bright grin. “Well if Cassie suggests it, it’s bound to be a good idea—”

“This is *Child’s Play*,” Mydei cuts in. Hyacine, always perfectly loyal, instantly strums out the first chord. The rest of the band has no choice but to join in.

Despite their best efforts to avoid performing some of their old songs, Aventurine had unfortunately insisted. Mydei has no qualms with *Child’s Play*, though. It’s one of their originals, that they wrote in Aglaea’s basement, and he’s always more or less enjoyed performing it.

He ties his hair back when the song ends, already overheating from the hot stage lights. The best part about being a rock musician, no longer tied down by classical concert etiquette, is that he can be as messy as he wants. Hell, he can even take his damn shirt off, and no one will complain at the end of the day. That’s the sort of thing that would only get clipped and reposted to virality, anyways. Not that Mydei particularly cares about virality. If anything, he just wants Phainon to lose his mind.

They play *The Undying* next, and then *Epitaph*. It’s quite the switch between those two songs, but Mydei likes the idea of keeping his audience on their toes. Hyacine harmonizes perfectly during *Epitaph*, and it’s likely the calmest song Mydei has ever performed at a concert. He can hardly suppress his grin as he sees the audience wave their phone flashlights in the air, turning the arena into a night sky full of stars. He thinks you could hear the way he smiles come through the speakers.

“Thank you,” he says, as they finish. “Cas wrote that one. Isn’t it such a beautiful song?” The crowd cheers in agreement and he turns back to his water bottle, tossing it to Cipher when he finishes.

“Ow!” She yelps, as it hits her in the back of the head. “What the fuck is your problem?”

“What happened to your feline reflexes?”

“Just because I evolved from primordial beastkin doesn’t mean I still *am* one, dipshit,” Cipher hisses, bending down to pick up the water bottle. She drinks from it anyway.

“Cheer if you think Cipher is still beastkin.”

There’s a couple of unsure whoops from the audience. Mydei laughs at that, too.

“You’re abusing our crowd, Mydei,” Hyacine scolds him.

Mydei has something about how surreal a crowd so big is sitting on the tip of his tongue, but he doesn’t say it. “I just forced Cipher to hydrate for a very special reason,” he explains. “Cheer if you’re excited for us to play the next song.”

“Okay, enough of that,” Cipher yells over the ensuing screams. “All you, Mydei.”

He slings his acoustic guitar over his shoulder, and starts to play the introductory chords of *Lies Are Lies.*

Cipher’s stage presence has always been electrifying, likely the best out of the four of them. When she’s singing, though, it’s a thousand times more pronounced.

Mydei sings with her, at least until the bridge, and even Hyacine and Castorice have some occasional backing vocals. But he tries to stay more or less out of her way, and she thrives in the spotlight.

Despite all the times Mydei has found her irritating beyond belief, all the times she inconvenienced him and pissed him off, he’s never been prouder as he steps away from the microphone and lets her take it away during the bridge of the song.

She never loses rhythm once. He wonders how long she’s practiced this, singing while keeping the bassline perfectly intact the whole time. Mydei knows, without a doubt, he couldn’t do what she does now in a million years.

And then the instruments cut out, and Mydei steps back up to the microphone to deliver his one solo line. He looks over at Cipher as he

finishes, and she looks back at him, and a million words could pass between them with just that one look.

It's not just Phainon he loves, he realizes. It's all of them. Cipher, Castorice, Hyacine. His best friends, his sisters, his family.

The concert continues. They perform *Anything Goes*, and Mydei loses his shirt somewhere between that song and the next. He says it's because it's too hot, but really, he doesn't mind the "fan service", or whatever Cipher liked to call it.

Taxidermy is next, and then *City of Thieves.* Then they spend some time talking to the audience, before moving closer together to sit in a tight-knit circle. Cipher exchanges her electric bass for an upright one, and they sing *Bleeding Out* as something closer to an acapella group than a rock band.

Mydei apologizes to the audience before he sits at the piano for the first time that night and they play *Cat Food.* It's fun to perform, mostly because of Cipher's involvement with her obnoxious backing vocals that she translates to a live show perfectly. Mydei can't keep the laughter out of his voice as he plays the ridiculous piano part he had written just for the song.

"Are you proud of me, Herta?" he asks when he's done. He knows no one in the crowd will understand the reference. He knows it's even less likely that she's watching. He doesn't care. *Cat Food* was exactly the kind of piano music that she would hate, but he still can't imagine that she would watch him play it and feel disappointed.

Fever is next, and then Mydei goes back to the piano for *Conqueror of Lions.*

"This song is for my mom," he says before he starts, talking into the microphone propped up on the piano lid. "In releasing it, I realize I'm not the only one to go through something like this. I guess it was stupid of me to think it was, though."

It gets a couple laughs. He moves on. "To anyone whose experience I may have helped by releasing a song like this," he says, then pauses. "Thank

you. That’s what all of this is really for.”

He looks over at his bandmates, all three of them giving him similar looks. “Right guys?” he prompts, which gets a couple scattered laughs.

“Anyways.” He turns back to the piano. “This is *Conqueror of Lions.*”

He wastes no time in playing the opening chords to the song. He doesn’t look into the audience until after the first verse, and instantly feels like it’s a mistake when he sees that their flashlight stars are back. His eyes are already starting to burn, and then Hyacine joins in on acoustic guitar, as if reminding him that they’re all still there.

Castorice and Cipher join together, along with the string part on the backing track. He wonders how he got so lucky.

No matter how close he gets to crying, he doesn’t stop. It’s the exact thing he was worried about, but he doesn’t let his tears fall. The point of the song is not to mourn, but to celebrate the life that was lived anyway.

He remembers Phainon telling him, *she would have been proud of you* the first time Mydei played the song for him.

He knows he was right. Of course she would have been proud of him.

Hyacine comes up behind him as the song comes to an end, placing her hand on his shoulder. It’s such a simple gesture, but it grounds him just enough.

Mydei is happy again. He had felt it in bursts, through the years, but never like this. Never like it might actually be permanent. Until now.

“Thank you,” he says to the crowd, a little sheepish at their reception to the song. “Well.” He jumps up from his seat, moving back to his main mic stand at the front of the stage. “Quite the transition, we probably could have workshopped the setlist a little further,” he laughs. Thankfully, they join him.

“I don’t know where he is, right now,” Mydei continues. “But how many of you know Phainon?”

If the amount they had cheered at their previous prompts was a lot, this is on a whole new level. Mydei has to take a step back to soak it all in, staring at Cipher in disbelief.

And then a group of people near the middle of the pit start making even more noise, pointing to someone specific.

“Is he actually there?” Mydei asks, a little taken aback. Someone screams *yes*, and Mydei exhales slightly. “Hi, Phainon,” he says, a little quieter than usual. “This song is for you.”

They scream even louder at that, so loud that Mydei doesn’t even think they can hear the opening instrumentals. Mydei sings the beginning verse, and then moves over to the piano during the short breakdown so he can play the quick part he had hummed for Phainon what feels like an eternity ago.

When he sings, he addresses one person in the crowd. He can’t quite see Phainon, but they all know exactly who he’s singing to. And he means every word he says.

Cipher starts to derail the audience for a bit as Mydei takes another break, telling a story about Castorice despite her desperate attempts to get Cipher to stop. Mydei’s not fully paying attention, drinking water and setting up at the piano for the final non-encore song of the night.

They’re supposed to think it’s the last one, though, so he does his best to sell the story. “Funnily enough, our last song of the night is also about—”

“Last two,” Cipher cuts in.

“*Cifera,*” Mydei hisses, still into the microphone. The crowd snickers. “Stop spoiling it.”

“Oh shit.” Cipher steps away from her mic stand, clapping her hands over her mouth. Mydei knows she doesn’t actually care that much.

“As I was saying,” Mydei continues, with mock irritation. “Our last song of the night is also about Phainon.” They cheer again. Mydei can’t help but feel warm inside at the idea that they love him so much. “On a different note from *Love Song*. This one was from when he was being an asshole.” They scream at that. “Okay. *Deliver the Dawn.*”

Hyacine starts, as Mydei takes a deep breath and turns back to his piano. When the rest of the instruments kick in and he starts singing, the audience follows every single lyric.

It’s a completely different experience from the way he had performed it during the mini concert. He knows, deep down, that that previous performance is the one that will go down in history—as either the most iconic performance of *Deliver the Dawn*, or the most iconic CALAMITY performance of all time. Still, he doesn’t think he can emotionally handle a hundred more *Deliver the Dawn* performances just as upset as he was during that first one.

He thinks, as he goes into the bridge, that there’s probably a good amount of people in the audience feeling every lyric as deeply as he was back then. He can only hope it ends just as well for all of them as it had for him. But there was only one Phainon in the world, and Mydei didn’t think it was possible for anyone else to compare.

They say their goodbyes when *Deliver the Dawn* finishes, and walk off stage without much fanfare. Hyacine is bouncing up and down when they get back into the green room, Cipher and Castorice chattering endlessly about how well it all went. But they still have an encore to do, so Mydei simply puts his guitar down briefly and gulps down some more water.

“How long do we have?” he asks one of the crew members handing out towels to wipe the sweat from their faces.

“No more than five minutes, and you should be back out there,” she responds.

“Alright. I’m going to the bathroom,” he says, and leaves.

It’s almost freakishly empty outside of the green room. He turns a corner, headed to the men’s restroom, and nearly barrels directly into Phainon himself.

“Mydei!” he gasps. “I was going to…surprise you…” His eyes are wide, face flushing ever so slightly.

Mydei’s heart is still pounding from the adrenaline as he pulls Phainon into the restroom with him, locking the door and kissing him against it like they’ve been apart for weeks and not hours.

“Mmf—*Mydei*—” Phainon manages, breathless as Mydei shoves him impossibly further into the door and nips at his jaw, down his neck, behind his ear, wherever he can reach.

“I love you,” he confesses, voice muffled against Phainon’s skin.

“You’ve told me that a hundred times already,” Phainon answers. “Somehow, I think saying those words is the least romantic way you’ve ever done it.”

Mydei pulls back, taking in the sight of him. He doesn’t know what it is. Phainon only seems to be getting more beautiful by the day, an impossible feat for someone with his looks to begin with. “Should I stop, then?”

“*Never,*” Phainon insists. Mydei kisses him again, shivering as Phainon’s hands trail behind his back and slip beneath the waistband of his pants. And then Mydei sinks to his knees, and Phainon pulls him away as far as he’ll go by his hair. “What are you doing?” he hisses, eyes wide.

“What does it look like I’m doing?” Mydei reaches for his fly, and Phainon slaps his hand away.

“Your *voice*, Mydei—”

“I can still sing,” Mydei rolls his eyes. “It’s just *Don’t Cry.*”

“*Don’t Cry* is vocally challenging,” Phainon argues, biting at his lip with a look of desperation that Mydei knows exactly how to read. “How long do

you have, anyway?”

Mydei shrugs. “Three minutes, maybe.”

“Okay, enough. You need to go back there.”

Mydei stands up, pushing his hands beneath the waistband of Phainon’s pants instead. “You can come in three minutes.”

“*Mydei*—” Phainon starts, leaning his head against the door in frustration. “I —” he’s starting to get worked up. Mydei can feel him on the cusp of agreeing, and then he presses one final, quick kiss to his lips.

“After,” he promises.

“Mydei—*fuck*,” Phainon groans, as Mydei pulls away and moves to stand in front of the mirror. He looks fine. Tired, and a mess, but fine.

“I’ll be quick,” Mydei says, as he unlocks the door and slips outside.

“You better,” Phainon’s muffled retort comes from inside the bathroom, and Mydei laughs to himself as he heads back in the direction of the green room.

He walks back in just late enough for him to earn a stern look from Aventurine, before someone tosses him his shirt and he pulls it back over his head. He wipes his lips, fixes his hair, and pretends not to notice the unimpressed look Cipher is giving him.

The crowd is screaming for an encore as they walk back towards the stage. No one says anything as they approach, Mydei’s whole body buzzing with electricity. He’s not nervous anymore. With the way he’s feeling now, he’s not sure he ever will be again.

“Let’s go,” he mutters, barely audible over the screams of the crowd.

“Delivery boy fire you up?” Cipher asks.

Mydei glares at her. “Shut up.”

If he thought the screams were loud when he was offstage, they grow a thousand times louder when they walk out. He tries hard to contain his smile, and fails.

“We lied,” Cipher says, as the cheers begin to subside. Mydei grabs his electric guitar and slings it over his shoulder, looking at Hyacine for the cue. She plays out the first note, and instantly the crowd erupts back into their screams as they recognize the introductory guitar solo of *Don’t Cry.*

Mydei has never liked performing *Don’t Cry* that much. It didn’t bring him back to a very fun time in his life, even though the tone of the song is generally accepting. In the last three years since it had been released, performing it always reminded him of Phainon, and now, he can’t bear the thought of singing this song while Phainon stands off stage, watching him —while Mydei knows how much he hates the song.

He sings it anyway, in the same melancholic tone of voice that he recorded it in. He always imagined the song to be a comforting one, but never thought Phainon might take it the way that he did.

But he has to sing it. It’s their most popular song from before the album, the one that longtime fans would be waiting for him to perform. And now they sing it back to him, and Mydei thinks that it’s not so bad, after all.

One day, if everything went his way, he’d have another hit they wanted him to play—one that he actually loved. And they wouldn’t be screaming for him to play *Don’t Cry* anymore, but something new.

“Thank you,” Mydei says, once the song is over and their cheers have calmed down enough for him to be heard over it.

Cipher yells something like “I love you” as they walk back off stage, for the last time.

The end of it all is surprisingly calm. It feels surreal as Mydei watches his bandmates celebrate, Hyacine jumping up and down while tugging on Castorice’s sleeves and Cipher gushing about how that was the best show of their lives. They’re ushered out the back of the venue before the traffic gets

bad, equipment already loaded into the van. Tomorrow, they drive five hours to their second Penacony show.

The drive back to his apartment is equally calm. Mydei leans against his window, closing his eyes as Cipher's chatter to no one in particular fades into soft background noise. He's dropped off before he knows it, and even from the outside of his apartment building, he can tell that Phainon is already home from the way his windows are lit up.

Mydei smiles to himself as he enters, making his way over to the elevator. It feels so surreal. To have just experienced that, and come home like it was nothing but another day of work.

Phainon greets him instantly, like he had been pacing and bolted to the door at the first sounds of keys jingling. He's in Mydei's space without giving him a second to react, pushing him against the now-closed door and swallowing any protests Mydei might have had with his mouth. His hands are everywhere—under the sweatshirt he had changed into, tangling through his hair, still as scalding as ever as he meets Mydei's bare skin.

Mydei returns in kind like he's starving, because he thinks he might have been. He's not sure how or when, but his shoes are kicked off somewhere along the way to the bedroom, and Phainon pushes him into his own bedsheets before he knows it.

They don't speak very much. Phainon tells him everything he feels with his lips on Mydei's throat, with his fingers brushing through Mydei's hair, with his hand on Mydei's back.

And then he lies curled into Mydei's side, both of them unclothed but neither of them cold enough to reach for the blankets. Mydei has never felt warmth so overpowering in his life. Sometimes he thinks that Phainon's body heat alone could be enough to burn him.

Phainon idly traces the patterns on Mydei's chest with his pointer finger, the sensation of it almost enough to lull Mydei to sleep.

“Mydei,” Phainon says suddenly. His voice is too loud, like he actually has something to say and isn’t just whispering more affirmations.

Mydei hums back. His eyes are already closed. Whatever Phainon has to say couldn’t possibly be enough to rouse him from his drowsiness.

“I’m leaving.”

Mydei stands corrected. He opens his eyes, awake but not fully processing the full picture. “What?” he says, blinking away the remnants of sleep.

Phainon swallows. Mydei can feel the full motion. “I’m going back to Okhema.”

“When?”

“Tomorrow.”

“Oh.” Mydei sits with it, and then pushes himself up onto an elbow so he can look at Phainon properly. “I thought you were coming with me.”

“I know,” Phainon blinks up at him, the sorrow palpable in his eyes. “I’m sorry. I just—I’m not really, you know…*part* of all this.”

“Yes you are,” Mydei argues, placing one of his hands over Phainon’s shoulders. “They know you, Phainon, I wrote about you—”

“That’s not what I meant,” Phainon corrects gently. “You know what I meant.”

Mydei swallows this time, unable to deny it. Today, Mydei and Phainon’s dreams don’t align like they used to. The only one they might share is their dream of being with each other. But the rational part of Mydei reminds him that regardless, he’s not going to lose him anymore. They’re adults now. They’ll figure it out.

“Look,” Phainon says, sitting up fully. “It’s just Okhema. I’ll stay with Cyrene and take all my stuff back to your apartment when I come back.”

Mydei huffs. “And your dog.”

“*Stop* with that, Mydei,” Phainon shakes his head, but the tiniest of smiles now lights up his face. “I’ll be there for your last show. I promise.”

Their closing show was in Okhema, in four months. Phainon would be there, at the beginning and at the end. After all, he had never broken a single one of his promises.

Mydei nods, and pulls him back to settle on his chest.

Okhema, he thinks.

That’s not so bad. He can make it that far.

Chapter End Notes

happy monday yall sorry for the late upload :/ i went to a scary ass movie with my friend last night and i was way too freaked out when i got back home to finish editing the chapter.....
speaking of late uploads, next week probably won't be on time either...i only have very little of ch12 written so far so i REALLY am gonna have to lock in to finish it on time. idk when it will be uploaded but it hopefully wont be too late. it's not like i have anything better to do (like a j-o-b)
and speaking of ch12, most of the main storyline is probably tied up with this chapter, but i just felt like there were too many things i still wanted to address, hence the 12th chapter. so it probably wont be too crazy but i did feel like it was necessary.

▶ oracle's real world track list + comments

tysm for reading :)))

Chapter 12: Finale (from the top, with feeling)

Chapter Notes

and yk what? happy freaking pride month

See the end of the chapter for more notes

albumoftheyear.org

CALAMITY - **Oracle**

Critic score: **88**
Based on 33 reviews

User score: **91**
Based on 9,637 reviews

DETAILS
May 4th, 3870 / release date
LP / format
IPC / label
Alternative Rock, Art Rock
Progressive Rock, Folk Rock / genre
Veritas Ratio, Mydeimos Nikador, Cifera Mnestia, Hyacinthia Seliose, Castorice Thanatos / producer
Mydeimos Nikador, Castorice Thanatos, Hyacinthia Seliose, Castorice Thanatos / writer

TRACK LIST
1. Wrath of Man **93**
2. Berserker **68**
3. Lies Are Lies **85**
4. City of Thieves **89**
5. Argonautica **84**

6. Deliver the Dawn **96**
7. Bleeding Out Interlude **75**
8. Cat Food **81**
9. Love Song **96**
10. Fever **89**
11. Epitaph **93**
12. Conqueror of Lions **89**

USER REVIEWS

User: *deliverthedawn*
Rating: 100

Oracle is a perfect album in every sense of the word. It has everything I look for in a project: perfect balances between highs and lows, creative risks, they had a vision and they stuck to it. The musicality of this album is unlike anything I've heard before. Mydei brings his classical training back into rock, and it works beautifully.

Favorite tracks: Love Song, Epitaph, Argonautica

Least favorite tracks: Deliver the Dawn

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June 2nd, 3870.

Okhema doesn't feel like home anymore.

Phainon steps out of the airport hit with blistering heat, so intense he instantly breaks out a sweat. He squints as he takes in his surroundings, trying and failing to remember where he was supposed to go. To think it had almost been a year since he was back here. A *year* with Mydei. He misses him immensely.
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“Phangry!” He turns at the sound of the nickname, unable to prepare himself as a ball of pink hits him square in the chest, nearly tackling him to the ground with the sheer force of it. He laughs as he hugs Cyrene back, squeezing her almost as tightly as she squeezes him.

“Have you gotten taller?” She asks, hands on her hips as she pulls away. “Ugh, that’s so unfair. I don’t even look older than you anymore.”

“You won’t complain when I’m old and wrinkly, and—”

“Ew, stop. I don’t even want to imagine that.”

Phainon laughs, his chest squeezing a little as he takes her in. Her hair is still dyed the same shade of pink—it had been since they were kids, for so long that he had forgotten what her natural hair color even was. She looks the same, and yet so different, like she had matured a hundred years in the length of one. The same kindness still lights up her eyes, but now they shine with the faintest hint of wisdom, too.

“So, you and Mydei,” she says mischievously, as she latches onto Phainon’s arm and drags him in the direction she had come from, presumably her car. “You need to tell me *everything.*”

Phainon sighs. “I already told you most of it.”

“Not enough,” Cyrene shakes her head. “How is it? How is *he?* How does it feel to finally get the love of your life after years of—”

“He’s great,” Phainon cuts her off before she embarrasses him, even though there’s no one but the two of them to listen to their conversation. “I couldn’t ask for a better partner.”

“Ah,” Cyrene sighs wistfully. “You’re practically living in a romance novel. How lucky.”

“Stop,” Phainon says, shooting her a glare he doesn’t mean. “It’s not…like that.”

“It’s not?” Cyrene raises an eyebrow as she clicks the unlock button on her keys. A few feet away, her tiny pink car beeps twice.

“It’s normal,” Phainon argues. “Not…I don’t know. I don’t read romance.”

“Right. You only read erotica.”

“*Cyrene*.” Phainon lifts his suitcase into the trunk of the car after Cyrene opens it, thankful that he can turn away so she can’t see how furiously he’s blushing.

There’s a bit of silence as they both climb in, Cyrene giggling quietly as her phone automatically connects to the speaker to reveal that she had just been listening to Mydei’s new album. She keeps it on, at a low volume as she pulls out of the parking lot.

“I read other genres,” Phainon says, too loudly in the space between them as she slows to a stop at a light.

Cyrene bursts out laughing. “*Right,* right.”

“I like to read about antiques,” Phainon continues, like it’s a good argument.

Cyrene giggles at that, too, and Phainon’s face flushes even further. “Antique appraisal and erotica,” she tuts. “What an interesting man you are. It’s no wonder you’ve scored a man like Mydei.”

“How’s your new novel going, Cyrene?” Phainon asks, overdoing the brightness of his voice to force the subject to change.

“It’s still in the planning stages right now. You can’t rush perfection.”

“Of course,” Phainon says. Her debut novel was successful enough that Phainon figured she was probably making enough money from it to support her lifestyle by now. When they were kids, she was always telling him the stories she made up in her head. She had no shortage of ideas, Phainon was sure.

They had seldom gone longer than a week without talking to each other during his stay in Penacony, but that didn't mean he hadn't missed her all the same. Even when they lived apart, he would still make time to visit as often as he could.

"So, Eve moved out?" He asks, as Cyrene parks her car in the closest spot she can find to her place, which is still quite a walk away. Okhema's streets were always bustling, so much so that he'd been disappointed by how tame Penacony was in comparison.

"A few months ago," Cyrene answers. "She moved in with March. It's so lonely now."

"You should go out," Phainon suggests. "Meet some new people, you know?"

"I know plenty of people," Cyrene protests. "And I don't like going out."

"Hm." Phainon shrugs. "Work on getting a girlfriend, then, yeah?"

Cyrene doesn't say anything for a moment, as they approach the front of her house. "Phainon, love comes when you're not looking for it." she says, after her moment of deep thought.

Phainon snorts, stepping forward to help her with the door after she unlocks it, keys jingling with all the trinkets she attached to it. "Well. There's always that girl from the ranch."

Cyrene blushes instantly, pushing him inside. "Phainon!" She hushes, eyes wide.

"What? It's not like she's gonna hear you all the way from over here."

Cyrene flicks the lights on, and Phainon only has a few minutes to take in his surroundings before he's nearly tackled to the ground *again*, this time by a big ball of white fur. He laughs as Snowy licks at his face, somewhat relieved that he had remembered him after all this time.

“I’m ready to have your dog out of here,” Cyrene mumbles as she reaches down to unbuckle her sandals.

“You love Snowy,” Phainon argues, ruffling the fur on his head.

He carries his suitcase upstairs after Snowy has calmed down, navigating to his old room like it’s second nature. Cyrene changed it into a guest room years ago, after he’d moved out, and had mentioned working on turning Eve and March’s room into an office in the last couple of months.

Everything is exactly how he remembered it. The double bed with more pillows than Phainon would ever need, made perfectly with Cyrene’s spare pink bedsheets. There’s an indent in the center of it, littered with sparse white fur, where Snowy had presumably been sleeping.

He puts his suitcase down and takes in the silence surrounding him as soon as the door shuts. Everything is the same, and yet it feels so different. He’s back home, but it’s only temporary, and he hates that. As much as he can’t wait to move in with Mydei officially, he doesn’t think he’s ready to live in Penacony for the rest of his life.

“Stop by the market on your way home, yeah?” Cyrene calls from the living room as Phainon pauses to put his shoes on by the door. “I’ll text you a list of groceries I need.”

He has a meeting with Aglaea today, who he had reached out to weeks ago when he was first planning his stay in Okhema. Cyrene had already been awake when Phainon came downstairs, meticulously painting the world map of her next book.

He agrees, and leaves. It’s only noon, and the sun is already beating down on him. *This* part of Okhema, he certainly didn’t miss.

Okhema is a walkable city—Cyrene only got her car recently, and he sold his parent’s old car for extra money when he initially moved here. He used

to take Snowy for walks through the market, until all the shopkeepers knew his name.

It's a fifteen minute walk to Aglaea's concert hall, and Phainon is almost sweating from the heat by the time he arrives. The doors are as grand as they were the first time Phainon walked through them, with *Marmoreal Palace* engraved in elegant cursive into the rich mahogany wood.

The inside is empty, with no shows or rehearsals today, so he navigates his way through the front lobby and into the backstage area, finding his way to Aglaea's office.

"Phainon," she says, as she hears him open the door. "It's nice to see you again." She sits at her polished wooden desk, and not a single piece of furniture has budged since Phainon was in here last.

"Miss Aglaea," he responds. He can't help but notice the way she doesn't stare directly at him, like she used to. She faces him, but her eyes seem to be unfocused and glazed over. He swallows down the dread he feels. "Hi. You look well."

She smiles a little, but it doesn't quite spread to the rest of her face. "Thank you, Phainon. Have a seat." He obliges, sinking into the leather armchair across from her desk. "As I'm sure you've heard, my illness has only gotten worse since you've left."

Phainon nods. "Right."

"My eyes are not what they used to be," she continues. "But this must be an unforgettable performance. If not, I will be forced to retire." Her face sours at the word, lips curling as she says it.

"What?" Phainon demands, pulling backwards in shock. "You're quitting?" He remembers what Mydei said to him nearly half a year ago, in that grocery store. Aglaea was not the kind of woman who would let something like this stop her.

Aglaea's frown deepens even further. "Terminated would be a more accurate word for it."

"They're going to fire you because you're sick? Didn't you *found* this place? Who would be firing you?"

She sighs deeply, closing her eyes as her head drops forward. One of her perfectly styled curls falls out of its hold, bouncing in front of her face. "Cease your questioning, Phainon. I have everything under control."

"Do you?"

Aglaea lifts her head, silencing Phainon with an icy stare. "I do."

"Right…" Phainon swallows. "Okay."

She takes her time choosing her next words, hands clasped so tightly in front of her that her knuckles are turning white. "A blind conductor," she begins, voice strained, "is nothing to a sighted one."

"That's bullshit—"

"Let me finish, Phainon," Aglaea is the closest to snapping that Phainon had ever seen her. "The council funding this organization simply believes their money would be better off going to a more reliable conductor. At the end of the day, I do not have much power over their decisions."

Phainon bites his tongue, so he doesn't say something that might frustrate her even further.

"Of course, you and I both know that one does not need to *see* the music to *know* it," Aglaea says, "but they will not budge. So I have decided that my next concert simply must be outstanding." She picks her loose curl up from in front of her face, tucking it back into place behind her ear. "With you here, I know I have nothing to worry about."

Phainon's throat has gone incredibly dry, and he swallows thickly as he tries to process all of this. A year ago, he would have accepted in a heartbeat. Post his injury, though, he's not so sure. "I don't know," he confesses,

unable to look at her head on. “I’m flattered that you think I’m right for this, but…I don’t think I can deliver the expectations you have of me. Not anymore.”

Aglaea doesn’t react to that. It was an impressive quality of hers, the inability to show very strong emotions past mild discontent and slight humor.

“Are you sure this is the only solution?” He continues. “I—I could try to convince them to let you stay. Caenis is dead anyways, right?”

Aglaea’s jaw twitches. “That old hag was long overdue as it was. And your arguments will make no difference, Phainon.”

“Well…” Phainon starts, unsure what else to say. “I could try?”

She shakes her head. “If it makes you feel any better, I did assume you would think you couldn’t do it.” That doesn’t make Phainon feel better at all, but he doesn’t say anything as she continues. “Which is why I’ve hired someone to help you.”

“What?”

Aglaea’s lips curl. “Anaxa.” She says his name like she’s spitting out poison. “He refused to see me in person—an issue I did not press any further, I suppose—but he has agreed to take up teaching you again. With little trouble.”

“You…” Phainon squints at her, unsure what to make of this situation. “You two are talking again?”

“Desperate times,” Aglaea mutters, voice sour.

Phainon had planned to pay Anaxa a visit soon anyways, given that he was also back in Okhema after the spring semester at Paperfold ended. He wonders why Anaxa hadn’t reached out about this, if it was something he and Aglaea were planning.

Unfortunately, it is convincing. He wants to help Aglaea, after all.

“I just…” he fiddles with his hands under Aglaea’s desk. “I can’t understand why you don’t just want to hire a reliable pianist to do this for you.”

“It’s simple. Your recovery and comeback will have a reception around the world. If you do this, it will be that much more successful.”

He knows that sort of means she’s using him, but he’s surprised to realize how little this bothers him. “Um,” he starts. “Can I think about it?”

Aglaea smiles—or rather, musters up the closest thing she can to a smile. “Of course,” she says. “But I thought I might pitch some repertoire before you make your decision.”

Phainon curses in his head, because he knows that no matter what Aglaea is about to pull out, it will convince him. There’s only a handful of pieces he’d say no to, and Aglaea is aware of all of them.

“First,” she says, ruffling through one of her cabinets. “I thought Tchaikovsky might be nice.”

“Fuck,” Phainon says, out loud this time. Sure enough, she places sheet music he instantly recognizes before him: Tchaikovsky’s first piano concerto. Playing this would mean that he’s played two out of his three favorite piano concertos of all time: Rachmaninoff, Moszkowski, and Tchaikovsky. He would love nothing more than to play this piece.

“I also have a Brahms,” Aglaea places another option in front of him, “or Prokofiev.”

“Fuck,” Phainon says again. Only good options are being laid before him, and it upsets him deeply that he can only choose one for this concert.

“If this goes well, we can always prepare the ones you don’t choose for concerts in the future.”

“Oh my god,” Phainon mutters. “You’re joking.”

“Is that a yes?”

“Yes,” Phainon says, without much further thought. “That one. The Tchaikovsky.”

Phainon is in the middle of brushing his teeth, getting ready for bed when Mydei calls him. His phone lights up with Mydei’s profile photo, and he rushes to pick it up with the toothbrush still hanging out of his mouth.

“Hello?” He asks as Mydei’s face comes into view. His voice is muffled as he tries to talk with his mouth full of toothpaste froth.

Mydei cracks up when he sees him. He’s in a black hoodie Phainon has never seen before—new CALAMITY merch, upon closer inspection—and his phone is propped up on some kind of table. There are two boxes of sushi in front of him, and he holds a pair of chopsticks haphazardly in his hands. “*You could’ve picked up when you were done brushing your teeth, you know,*” he says when he’s done laughing.

“And miss your call? Nuh uh,” Phainon turns back to the mirror, finishing up what he was doing as he hears Mydei crack open both of his lunch containers on the other end.

“*We just got to our hotel for the night,*” Mydei explains. “*Big show tonight. I’m nervous.*”

Phainon raises an eyebrow, though he knows Mydei can’t see him as he leans forward to spit into the sink. “You’re nervous?” He asks, mid rinsing his mouth out with water.

“*Sold out arena.*”

“So?” Phainon pats his mouth dry with a nearby towel. “Your last show was a sold out arena too.”

“*Yeah, but that was opening night.*”

“I’m not understanding your logic.” Phainon picks up his phone, exiting the bathroom and heading down the hall to the guest bedroom.

Mydei sighs and puts a piece of sushi in his mouth. Phainon could comment on his poor chopstick skills, but his aren’t much better, so he opts to stay silent. “*How’s Okhema?*” He asks, through a mouthful of food.

“Lively.” Phainon turns on the lamp on his bedside table and pulls his sheets aside, crawling in.

“*Aglaea is well?*”

Phainon takes a deep breath. “Well…” he starts, turning to the side and resting his phone against the other pillow in the bed. It’s not a very flattering angle of him, but it will do. “She’s dealing with a lot right now.”

“*Oh yeah?*” Mydei eats another piece of sushi. “*Besides her illness?*”

“That’s the main problem,” Phainon swallows, and explains everything to him. The source of her funds, her eyesight, the ultimatum, and Tchaikovsky.

Mydei has stopped eating entirely when he finishes. He looks hard into his phone, like he’s trying to get something out of Phainon through the screen. “*And you said yes, right?*”

Phainon looks down. “I…yeah, I did.”

Mydei exhales, leaning back in the chair he sits in and running a hand through his hair. “*Thank god.*”

“It’s not like I wanted to,” Phainon protests, which has Mydei glaring at him. “I just couldn’t pass up this opportunity, for Aglaea.”

“*But it’s going to be fine, and you have nothing to worry about,*” Mydei says. He’s picked up his chopsticks again, and stabs a piece of sushi with both of them. He might as well just use his hands at this point. “*You said Anaxagoras is helping you?*”

“Anaxa,” Phainon says, laughing. “And yes.”

Mydei whistles. “*Looks like you have your work cut out for you, then.*”

Phainon knows he’s right. Herta was cruel to Mydei, but none of the music teachers at Paperfold were exactly kind. Anaxa would draw the line at a lot of things Herta chose to do, but he wasn’t above being a harsh teacher by any means. “Yeah, well, so do you.”

Mydei shrugs. “*It hasn’t been that bad so far.*”

“Because you’ve played one show. Just wait.”

“*Like you’d know.*”

“I’ve been on tours before!” Phainon bursts, offended.

“*Where you only played weekends. Not the same.*”

They talk for another hour, before Mydei eventually hangs up. He needs to be at the venue soon, and Phainon needs to fall asleep. As much as he would like to stay up into the early hours of the morning to watch Mydei’s concert, he has his first meeting with Anaxa tomorrow. To say he’s excited would be overselling it.

Anaxa’s house is a disaster.

From the moment Phainon steps inside, everything immediately makes sense to him. Of course the man would live in a place like this. His walls are lined with bookshelves stuffed to the brim with books about everything from astrophysics to music theory. There’s loose paper everywhere, some of them filled with frantic scribbling that vaguely resembles sheet music.

He had known Anaxa’s head was somewhat of a mess, but his house seems to emulate exactly what his mind is like. Nothing shocks him quite like the eye patch he wears when he answers the door, though.

“Woah,” Phainon says. “What happened to your eye?”

“I cut it out and mailed it to Aglaea,” Anaxa says bitterly. “Come in.” He doesn’t give Phainon any more of an explanation than that. It leaves Phainon wondering if he should really enter this man’s house.

“Um, what?”

Anaxa rolls his eyes—eye, now—in frustration. “I said come in.”

Phainon listens, stepping inside gingerly. It had only been a little over a year since he graduated with his master’s degree at this point, meaning it hadn’t been that long since he’d seen Anaxa last. He didn’t think he was crazy enough to do anything of the sort.

With a small, terrifying realization, Phainon wonders if this has something to do with Aglaea’s illness, and the way she’s losing her own eyesight. Maybe he was rubbing his vision in her face. Or maybe it was an act of solidarity. Neither of those options make any sort of sense to him.

Despite Phainon’s wariness, Anaxa does nothing to clear anything up. He’d cut out his own eye and mailed it to Aglaea, and that was that. Anaxa isn’t one to jest, so Phainon has no choice but to take him at his word.

There’s little fanfare in this reunion. Anaxa brings him to his “living room”, which is filled with more books and papers, the only piece of furniture being the oldest piano Phainon has ever seen in his life. He wonders if it’s in tune, and presses middle C. It is. Anaxa gives him an unimpressed look, like he knows Phainon had doubted him.

He tosses the Tchaikovsky onto the rack, pulling up a chair from his kitchen to sit beside him as Phainon takes a seat on the bench.

“You haven’t practiced,” he says, crossing one leg over the other. He leans back, arms crossed, like he’d rather be anywhere else.

“Obviously.” Phainon opens the book, flipping to the first page. He can’t help the grin that breaks over his face as he sees the opening chords. “Cyrene doesn’t own a piano.”

“You need to find a way to get one, then,” Anaxa yawns. “I want you practicing at least forty hours a week outside of our lessons.”

Phainon swallows. It’s actually less than he was expecting Anaxa to say. They only have a few months to prepare this piece, anyways. He nods, thinking he could probably just practice at the Marmoreal Palace in a private room.

The first lesson is brutal, infinitely worse than Phainon remembers his teaching to be. He wonders if Anaxa was always like this and he had merely forgotten, or if he had gotten stricter over their time apart.

Part of it is that Phainon has never sightread during a lesson before. The expectation throughout his school years was always that he would arrive at the lessons with the piece practiced, and Phainon followed this rule religiously. Now, he didn’t have a chance to practice beforehand, but Anaxa isn’t any kinder to him because of it.

It also might be worse than Phainon remembers because Phainon *is* worse than he remembers. The piece is difficult, easily the most difficult thing he’s played recently. Piano had just been a hobby to him for the last few months. This is unlike anything he’s had to learn for a long time, and it shows.

He leaves Anaxa’s house feeling discouraged all over again. Anaxa hadn’t said anything like that outright, but it doesn’t stop the way he ends up feeling. He’s not sure if he can do this. He used to be able to, sure, but all the evidence before him only points to one outcome: he hasn’t made a full recovery, after all, and this is it for him.

He heads to the Marmoreal Palace immediately after, using the old code he had to Aglaea’s practice rooms to get into one. She’s not there today, but the place is crawling with musicians regardless. He tries to sneak in without getting caught, but it’s fruitless. Every musician in Okhema knows who he is. Today is the first time he wishes they didn’t.

He spots Tribios before she sees him, standing in the door of her practice room as she struggles to get her horn case over her shoulder. He intends to

hurry past her, but she calls out his name just as he turns his back, and he has no choice but to greet her.

“Oh! It’s really you!” She exclaims, coming over to greet him with her case successfully slung over one shoulder. “Aglaea mentioned you were going to play with us again. I told her I’d believe it when I saw it!” She laughs heartily, and as always, it doesn’t fail to put a smile on Phainon’s face, too.

“Tribios,” he says, and she pulls him into a hug. “It’s been a while, hasn’t it?”

“So, you are really going to be the soloist for the Tchaikovsky?”

Phainon nods. “For some reason,” he says, laughing awkwardly. She doesn’t laugh back. “Miss Aglaea already mentioned it to the rest of you?”

“Just me,” she winks. “An email will be sent out with seating and parts for the rest of the orchestra in the next few days. We don’t rehearse until next week.”

“Ah,” Phainon says. That makes it real. It’s already real, now, but once the rest of them know, it’s really going to be solidified.

“Well, it was so nice to see you, Phainon, but I really have to go,” Tribios says, glancing at her watch. “I need to pick up the triplets from their lesson. Can you believe they’re old enough for those now?”

“Seriously?” Phainon’s eyes widen. He’d met Tribios’ children a few times, when they were mere toddlers. He supposes they wouldn’t be much older than that, now, but it’s still surprising. “What are they playing?”

“Piano, for now.” Tribios rolls her eyes. “They’re not old enough for anything else. But Tribbie is set on clarinet, Trinnon on flute, and Trianne on trumpet…so we’ll see how it plays out.”

“Wow, all winds,” Phainon huffs. “Hopefully at least one of them will stick with piano…”

Tribios laughs. “No, Phainon, we’re a wind family. Sorry.”

“Clearly,” Phainon eyes her horn. “I’ll see you around then, Tribios?”

“I’m so, *so* happy you’re back, Phainon,” she says, bowing her head to him slightly. It’s a gesture that thoroughly throws Phainon off. “We all are.”

Phainon gives her his thanks, and she hurries off towards the elevator. He’s not sure why he was trying to avoid her so hard earlier. She was one of the longest members of the Marmoreal Orchestra, and helped Aglaea a lot with planning and selecting repertoire. It was just as much her orchestra as it was Aglaea’s, and everyone loved her. Phainon was not excluded from this.

“Oh my god, *Phainon?*”

He takes a deep breath before he turns around. He recognizes that voice as one of his old classmates, Piso. He and another classmate, Livia, were both summer session percussionists in Aglaea’s orchestra after they’d graduated from the Grove. The three of them were never best friends by any means, but shared a lot of classes and had gotten to know each other well as musicians.

He doesn’t say anything at first, meeting both of them for the first time in a few years. He hadn’t played for Aglaea during the summer in a while, and is surprised at how different both of them look.

“Holy shit,” Livia says. “You look *good,* Khaslana.”

“Are you playing?” Piso asks, eyes wide. “We heard about your injury. Everyone was heartbroken that you might never come back.”

Phainon shows them his scarred hands, and they both wince. “I’m back, though,” he reassures them. “But no spoilers. You’ll get the email in a few days, I hear.”

“Oh, we know about the Tchaikovsky,” Livia waves him off. “What’s in question is the soloist. Some people were saying Caenis, like she’d crawl out of her grave—”

“What—” Phainon chokes. “Who told you?!”

“Oh, um…” Livia rocks back and forth on her heels. “Was it Chartonus?” She asks, turning to Piso.

“*Chartonus?*”

“Oof, yeah, it might’ve been,” Piso winces. “He definitely didn’t say that about Caenis though.”

“I heard that part from Bartholos.”

“Are you—Livia!” Piso lightly smacks her shoulder. “And you *believed* it?”

“I mean…there was some doubt in my mind, for sure…”

Phainon snorts. Being a temporary member of the orchestra, he’s not fully involved in the interpersonal drama between members, much as he’d like to be. All that he knows is that Chartonus is a near mute bassoon player and Bartholos pops in occasionally to cover a piccolo part.

From what he’s heard from Hysilens, drama between string players might be a whole different beast that neither Livia nor Piso know much about, or have any desire to tackle.

“Anyways,” Piso says, resting his hands on his hips. “*I* heard you’re dating Mydei.”

Phainon sighs. “Guys…”

“Is it true?” Livia asks, eyes glimmering. “Maybe you could get him to do a show with us…he’s never played for Miss Aglaea before…”

“He’s not going to do that.”

“Are you sure? There was quite a bit of piano on that new album of his. Plus, we haven’t seen Cifera or Castorice in so long.”

“I really hate to burst your bubble, but I think they’re all pretty satisfied with the kind of music they’re making right now.”

“I told you, Livia…” Piso groans.

“But is it true?” Livia continues, shushing him. “Are you two really together?”

Phainon scratches the back of his neck awkwardly. “Hasn’t he been pretty open about it online?”

“She’s convinced he’s doing it as fan service,” Piso mutters under his breath.

“Uh, no.” Phainon crosses his arms. “We’re together.”

“Will he be here?” Livia demands. “For the Tchaikovsky?”

“Hopefully.”

“Okay, Livia, I think we should go.” Piso grabs her arm, pulling her away. “Stop fangirling dude, he’s a real person,” he mutters as he drags her down the hallway.

Phainon snickers under his breath as he lets himself into the nearest practice room, finally clear of all the people he used to know.

Conflicting emotions swirl through his brain as he sits on the piano bench. He’s still discouraged, but the unconditional support from his old friends has motivated him like nothing else could. He doesn’t want to let them down.

He doesn’t allow himself to practice for too long. He’d already witnessed how that could ruin someone firsthand during Mydei’s sophomore year of college. If he’s going to see this through, he can’t let this piece destroy him.

Okhema is filled with music lovers. Phainon has been aware of this for many years, but had forgotten just how deep it runs in his absence. As the weeks pass, people recognize him more and more. The whole orchestra

knows of his return now, and word is beginning to spread throughout the townspeople.

Market owners thank him as he visits their shops for putting in the work to ensure Aglaea stays in business. Phainon wonders how she had gotten to the point of potentially stepping down when most of the public opinion was in her favor to begin with, but he knows most of her funding has come from the Council of Elders in the past. They have all the real power here, and it upsets Phainon to his core.

An old violinist, the concert master before Hysilens took her spot, finds him one day and offers to buy him a coffee. He accepts, of course, not one to pass up a free meal. She recoils when she sees his hands. Phainon knows they're ugly, but they work. That's all that matters to him.

The weirdest interaction he has happens nearly a month after he first returned to Okhema, though. He's eating lunch by himself in the Marmoreal Diner. He had just gotten out of his fourth lesson with Anaxa, which left him requiring some serious recovery time.

A group of four men he's never seen before approach him. They all seem to be Phainon's age or older, and they somehow know who he is. If they're members of Aglaea's orchestra, they're recent.

"...Hello?" Phainon asks. He holds his sandwich awkwardly in the air, not quite having made it to his mouth before they stopped by his table.

"Excuse me, are you Phainon Khaslana?" One of them says. He has a heavy Kremnoan accent, but his Okheman is extremely polished.

Phainon nods. If they are Kremnoan, then Mydei must know them, somehow. He supposes that might be a gross generalization, but he's not sure why they would approach him for any other reason.

"I'm Ptolemy," he continues. "This is Peucesta, Leonnius, and Perdikkas… we're Mydeimos' friends from high school. I'm not sure if he's mentioned us before."

“Oh,” Phainon puts his sandwich down. “He, um, he might have…” he says quietly. Mostly, he’d mentioned Hephaestion. But Phainon isn’t sure if that’s something they would like to hear right now.

Leonnius clicks his tongue, and mutters something under his breath in Kremnoan. The only word Phainon picks up on is *Mydeimos.*

Perdikkas nudges him with his elbow, giving him an equally incomprehensible response.

“I apologize,” Ptolemy says, flashing Phainon a reasonably apologetic grin. “Anyways, we heard you were playing with the Marmoreal Orchestra this session as a soloist, so we thought we’d come say hello.”

“What brings you guys to the area, then?” As far as Phainon knew, the group of them had met each other in Kremnos and rarely left. He figured they still played for a Kremnoan orchestra.

“We play for Miss Aglaea now,” Peucesta speaks up. “We found out that our orchestra was being funded by Mr. Nikador, so we quit.”

“Mydei’s father,” Phainon says slowly. He doesn’t know how that man is doing now. He hopes it’s terrible.

Leonnius has something to say about that, too—this time, the only word he recognizes is *Mydei.* Perdikkas mutters “stop” in Okheman. Phainon doesn’t really like those two.

“Yes,” Ptolemy says. “Anyways, we thought we might ask you how he’s doing. We haven’t really heard from him ever since Hephaestion…oh, um, did he mention that?”

“Hephaestion’s death broke Mydei’s heart,” Phainon says softly. “Of course I know about that.”

“Doesn’t give him an excuse to cut the rest of us off,” Leonnius rolls his eyes. So he *did* know Okheman. Interesting.

“Speak for yourself. He *answered* my text congratulating him on the new album,” Perdikkas shoots back.

“So this is a competition, now? Whose shoulder did he cry on when Hephaestion died, huh?”

“Okay, I’m sure Mydei still cares about all of you deeply,” Phainon says, trying to stop whatever is going on between all of them. “He’s busy, and hasn’t been to Kremnos in years. I think there’s a lot of bad memories associated with that place.”

Ptolemy sighs, rubbing both his hands down his face. “Ignore them. I was trying to have a friendly conversation here.”

Phainon snorts. “He’s happy,” he says, and that causes all four men to stop talking over each other and look at him. “Mydei, I mean.”

“Really?” Peucesta asks, blinking. “His album was concerningly melodramatic.”

“Because he deals with shit by writing songs about it,” Phainon explains. “He loves his band. They’ve given him the world.”

“He does look like he’s having the time of his life in his performances,” Perdikkas points out.

“I don’t understand why he ever gave up piano,” Leonnias sighs, slumping into the spot next to Phainon. Alright, then. Phainon tries to inch away as discreetly as possible. “The six—five—of us could’ve been something, man.”

“No we couldn’t. No cellist.” Ptolemy crosses his arms, giving him a stern look. “And you *do* know why he quit. He told us. After Gorgo died.”

“Look, Mydei is still the same person he was six years ago. He still overworks himself. He still cares too much about being perfect. But he wasn’t just your friend because of Hephaestion or because he was unhappy, he genuinely liked you guys.” Phainon stirs around his drink mindlessly.

He’s not sure if what he’s saying is even true, given how rarely Mydei spoke about them. But he’s sure it is. Mydei isn’t a fake friend, and he never would be. “Seriously, reach out. It’s not that hard.”

Peucesta sighs heavily, then comes to sit across from Phainon. It’s not long before the other two are sitting down too, filling up Phainon’s booth.

“I always thought he was going to marry you,” Peucesta confesses.

Phainon’s eyes go wide. “*What?*”

“Ugh, enough of this, Peucesta,” Perdikkas scoffs. “Mydeimos is only—how old? Twenty-three?”

“Doesn’t matter,” Peucesta shrugs. “I think you two are soulmates.”

“Oh,” Phainon’s not really sure what to make of that. “Not Hephaestion?”

This gets laughter out of three of them, the only one remaining silent being Ptolemy. He doesn’t seem like the type to laugh very much.

“Hephaestion and Mydeimos were like oil and water,” Leonnias explains. “It never would’ve worked out.”

“Wait, what?!” Phainon chokes out, bewildered. “Mydei never said anything like that?”

“Because they loved each other,” Ptolemy chimes in. His voice has gotten notably sadder. “You can love someone and be incompatible.”

“Also, Mydeimos would beat our ass if he heard us say that,” Perdikkas adds. “That’s what almost happened the last time one of us brought it up.”

“What made them so incompatible?”

“Hephaestion was…spirited,” Ptolemy says carefully, like he’s trying to put it as kindly as possible.

“He was arrogant,” Leonnias cuts in. “His family was full of Kremnoan traditionalists. Well—most of ours were, honestly, but he didn’t really lose those beliefs somewhere along the way like we did.”

“Mydeimos has always been a lot more sensitive than he seems when you first meet him,” Peucesta continues. “Don’t tell him we said that, though.”

Phainon laughs. He supposes that much is true. And he’d never call Mydei sensitive to his face.

“Hephaestion would have made fun of him like crazy if he saw how Mydeimos reacted when he died,” Leonnias explains. “Anyways. That’s just what we think.”

“*Ew, are you crying?*” Perdikkas mutters, in a mock voice that Phainon can only assume is his best Hephaestion impression. It sends the three of them into a fit of laughter again. Ptolemy cracks a smile this time, but that’s it.

“Anyways, if you want to marry him, you have our blessing,” Peucesta finishes.

“That’s…kind of you,” Phainon says. He’s still not sure what to make of this entire interaction. “But that probably won’t happen for many years.”

Peucesta shrugs. “Still.”

Mydei’s old group of friends aren’t the only people who want to talk to him. CALAMITY is a popular band all throughout Amphoreus, and while Okhema never really knew Mydei, they did know Cipher and Castorice. Phainon isn’t sure where Hyacine grew up, but is realizing quickly that it wasn’t in Okhema. She attended the Grove, but graduated before Phainon, Cipher, and Castorice did. So they’d never crossed paths until they happened to attend the same college in Penacony.

Everyday when Phainon leaves Cyrene's house, he runs into at least one person that wants to talk to him. Sometimes they keep him for a while, sometimes they just ask how he is. Most of the time, they congratulate him on recovering from his injury. Phainon smiles and doesn't say anything about how doubtful he still feels about the whole situation.

He's used to Anaxa's harsh teachings now, and doesn't take the insults to heart anymore. He knows Anaxa only wants the best for him, and that it would only do Phainon good to listen to what he has to say.

In late July, Phainon attends his first rehearsal with the Marmoreal Orchestra. It's held on a hot Tuesday evening. Everyone has stopped playing by the time Phainon walks on stage, at exactly seven PM. A few people clap. Phainon wants to disappear at the first moment of applause.

"Enough," Aglaea says, shutting them down instantly. "He's late."

"I am on time," Phainon argues. Getting to rehearsals early was much more important for the others than for the pianist.

As if proving his point, the strings proceed to tune for two minutes. He doesn't know why, but the humidity was rough for string players. Hysilens had once told him she would take summers off, if it didn't hinder her playing.

"Ladies and gentlemen, Phainon Khaslana." Aglaea says, once they finish. No one claps this time. "As you know, he will be our soloist for the Tchaikovsky this season. If you wish to welcome him back, do so during our break and please refrain from interrupting the rehearsal to catch up. Thank you."

Phainon has already run into most of these people—except for Hysilens, surprisingly. She sits right behind him, in first chair, and it makes him a little nervous. He doesn't think his arrival is a surprise to anyone at this point. Still, he never fails to be flattered by the overwhelming kindness with which they welcome him back. He hadn't thought he was this big of a deal to the people of Okhema until now.

“Today will likely be tedious and frustrating, as we need to work out the cues and get used to playing alongside our soloist. If I hear a single complaint out of anyone’s mouth, you will be asked to leave until next season. I have replacements on standby for every part.”

Phainon thinks back to his time playing with Herta’s orchestra at Paperfold. If she were the conductor today, this would be a genuine threat she would make. In Aglaea’s case, it’s merely her idea of a joke.

“Alright. Movement one, please.” Phainon scrambles to open his sheet music, finding his spot on the keys. The nerves hadn’t quite gotten to him until right now.

Aglaea gives them a measure of rest before they’re cued in. The opening horns blare throughout the concert hall, shocking Phainon with their volume. When the rest of the orchestra joins in shortly after, Phainon shakes his head in disbelief. The first rehearsal always had this sort of effect on him. He can hardly handle the euphoria it brings him to be in a room full of equally talented and devoted musicians, coming together to perfect one of his favorite pieces of all time.

He almost misses his entrance, it being as early into the piece as it was, but he gets there just in time. The strings play above his opening chords, and much as he wants to look around him, he doesn’t dare take his hands off the keys.

He catches Aglaea gesturing to stop just before his first solo part starts, and everyone immediately stops. He sighs lightly, marking something into his music. He’d missed a couple notes. Probably the nerves, because the beginning was straightforward enough where that shouldn’t be happening.

“Yes, thank you,” Aglaea puts her baton down, tucking her hair behind her ears as she thinks. “Phainon, you nearly missed your entrance. Be more attentive next time.” Phainon nods. He’d foolishly thought she hadn’t noticed that. “Strings, let’s do that again. It was messier than I would like.”

Phainon didn’t think so, but that’s why Aglaea is the conductor, and he is not. She has an ear for the details of things that he lacks when it comes to

orchestral pieces.

They run the main melody with just strings once. Aglaea deems it acceptable this time, but Phainon knows they will likely have to run that more after he leaves.

“From the top, please,” Aglaea continues. “I won’t stop this time, unless we fall apart.”

Phainon nearly cringes at the sound of that. He can play the whole piece at this point, but not well. Aglaea knows it will be rough, but that won’t stop her from ripping him to shreds. Even in that perfectly composed manner of hers.

True to her word, Aglaea doesn’t stop. Not when he misses half the notes in his hardest runs, not when the timpani misses their entrance by a beat or the strings turn into a jumbled mess of notes. It’s just as messy as you would expect the first full rehearsal of a piece to be.

Silence settles over the hall as Aglaea lowers her baton, each musician instantly relaxing. Phainon rests his forehead on the sheet music rack, dejected. The orchestra was beautiful, even if it wasn’t perfect. But it had been horrible on his part.

“Alright,” Aglaea says quietly. Phainon watches her put on glasses out of the corner of his eye, holding up the score so she can study it to the best of her ability. “Phainon.”

His heart lurches. He’s not ready for whatever she has to say to him.

“You rushed every solo.”

Phainon exhales.

“Your octave jumps were dragging. Work on getting up there quicker.”

Phainon nods, biting the inside of his cheek. He hopes he hadn’t disappointed the rest of the orchestra. They were so excited to play with him again, only for him to bring them *that.*

“You need to count your triplets better. You didn’t get a single one right.”

Phainon nods again.

“...The cadenza was good.”

Phainon looks up. Compliments from Aglaea were rare, though not unheard of. She only gave them when she truly meant it.

“I do think you have improved.”

Now Phainon sits up, furrowing his brows. “What?”

Aglaea lifts both her hands up to the orchestra, palms clasped together. “Applause, everyone.”

Some people clap. The rest of them slam their feet on the ground, with enough vigor to make the whole room shake. Phainon has never been this confused in his life. Once it subsides, he doesn’t have anywhere to hide his rapidly reddening face. “Thank you,” he says sheepishly.

“Don’t thank us,” Aglaea says. There’s clearly something else she wants to say, but she holds herself back. *Thank Anaxa,* Phainon thinks. That must have been what it was.

“Alright.” Aglaea picks up her baton again. “Let’s work backwards. Rehearsal J.”

The rest of the rehearsal is the most productive three hours Phainon has had in a long time. They break for fifteen minutes halfway through, which flies by with how many people approach Phainon to talk to them. None of them say he sucked. Although he supposes that if they thought that, they probably wouldn’t say it to his face. He can only hope they’re not saying it behind his back, either.

He leaves Marmoreal Palace at ten on the dot, feeling better than he has in weeks. His back hurts, and he’s exhausted, but he’s also filled with giddiness that he doesn’t think will go away for multiple days.

He notices he has a missed call from Mydei from an hour ago, so he pulls out his headphones and calls him back during the walk back to Cyrene's place.

Mydei picks up on the third ring, from somewhere in the Luofu. Phainon isn't sure what the exact time difference is, but he knows it must be late there.

It certainly looks like it. Mydei is sprawled across his hotel bed, hair still damp from the shower. "*What's up?*" He says, through a yawn.

"You called me," Phainon answers. "You look exhausted."

"*You look…*" Mydei pauses, staring into the screen for a moment. "*Good.*"

"Thank god," Phainon laughs. "Seriously, though. How are you?"

Mydei yawns again. "*I'm thriving.*"

"Are you really?"

"*No. I miss my cat.*"

Phainon snorts, thinking about Kokopo III. He couldn't take her with him to Okhema, so Mydei had to hire a catsitter. He doesn't think Kokopo III minds very much.

"*How was rehearsal?*"

"Um," Phainon can't stop the grin that breaks out over his face, just thinking about it. "Really good, actually. If you'd believe it."

"*I wouldn't believe it if you said it was bad.*"

"Aglaea said I improved."

Mydei gasps. "*No way. Say it.*"

"Say what?"

“*That I was right.*”

“No.”

Mydei lets it go, and the conversation drifts elsewhere. Phainon talks about his latest lesson with Anaxa. Mydei still can’t get over the fact that he cut out his own eye, and doesn’t understand how Phainon can. But he’d never known Anaxa to the extent that Phainon had. It didn’t seem all that uncharacteristic.

Mydei explains how Aventurine put Cipher on “hotel arrest” after she nearly died on their day off in the Luofu. He talks about culture shocks, the newest venues, how amazing everything has been. He still looks exhausted, and Phainon can tell he’s overworked right now, but he’s undeniably happy. The sort of happiness that Phainon has yearned for his whole life.

“*Oh, also…*” Mydei trails off. When Phainon looks down at him, he’s chewing on his lip. “*Never mind.*”

“Mydei.”

“*Fuck, stop.*” Mydei breaks out into a grin, unable to stop himself. “*Stop. It’s a surprise.*”

“You’re writing a new song?” Phainon asks. Mydei’s almost always writing something. It wouldn’t be much of a secret if he was.

“*No.*”

Phainon raises an eyebrow.

“*Okay, maybe.*”

“The fuck does maybe mean?”

Mydei laughs once, stretching himself out along his mattress. He rolls over, now on his elbows, holding his phone up in front of him. “*I was inspired.*”

“By?”

“*You.*”

Phainon sighs. “Stop, Mydei.” He doesn’t think he can handle another song written for him. *Love Song* was already too much.

“*I haven’t started writing yet,*” Mydei continues. “*I just have ideas.*”

“Oh my god.”

“*I didn’t think this was such a big deal to you.*”

“I don’t need all these songs written in my honor,” Phainon says quietly. “Even the one was unnecessary.”

“*Too bad. I’ll write whatever I want.*”

Phainon groans, tilting his phone down so Mydei can only see the top of his forehead.

“*Too late. I already saw you blushing.*”

Phainon immediately disconnects the call, laughing to himself as he thinks about Mydei’s reaction. Five seconds later, he gets another call.

The next week flies by. He goes to his lesson with Anaxa, where they work on the long list of things Aglaea had told him to improve. The next rehearsal on Tuesday goes by slower than the first one had, and Phainon is only there for half of it this time. But as he leaves, he opens his phone to a text message from Mydei.

He’s sent Phainon an audio file, along with one text that simply reads “how’s this?”

Phainon sighs, connecting his headphones again, and plays the audio file.

The song is undeniably beautiful, even at the demo state it exists in right now. The audio quality of Mydei's message is rough and grainy, and seems to have been recorded with his phone propped up on one end of the piano. His voice barely comes through in the background, and Phainon can only hear snippets of lyrics.

It's subdued, and not very upbeat. Phainon chalks that up to the level of production that's been done on it thus far. He thinks if Mydei were to play any other song on the album with just him and a piano, they were bound to sound much more melancholic and relaxed than they do on the record.

Still, Phainon replies telling him he loves it so far. He gives him a suggestion to shift to a major key. Mydei responds seconds later, saying "hell no. shut up and focus on your own shit."

Phainon snorts, hearting the message and putting his phone back in his pocket.

The weeks continue to pass, and that's the last time he gets any sort of update on the song. Whenever Phainon asks, Mydei remains intentionally vague. He tells him it's coming along and that he thinks Phainon will like it. But he doesn't send him any more demos. When Phainon asks his band mates, they say they've barely worked on it and that Mydei has sworn them to secrecy.

As August starts to come to a close, Phainon has already accepted that he's going to hear the song when everybody else does. Which is fine. Obviously, he'd prefer to be a little more special than that, but Mydei has never really been one to share his early or in-progress versions of things.

The Tchaikovsky has started to come together better than Phainon could have ever anticipated. The first movement is already perfect, and they've set it aside in the last few weeks to focus closer on things from the second and third movements. One rehearsal, Phainon stays past when they need him and sits in the audience to listen to their other repertoire.

The strings are opening the concert with Dvorak's Serenade for Strings in E Major. It's exactly the kind of thing Aglaea liked to pick back when

Phainon was younger—lithe, and graceful. The second movement is a beautiful waltz that gets stuck in Phainon's head for hours afterwards.

After the Tchaikovsky, the full orchestra is closing the concert with Prokofiev's fifth symphony. It looks incredibly challenging for the violins. Phainon knows this piece, of course, but hasn't ever seen it live, and the fourth movement leaves him slack-jawed when they do a run through.

He can't wait for the concert now. He doesn't think he's ever been this excited for a show before, and he's done some incredible shows. Somehow, this tops even Rach 2—but he thinks that's only because Rach 2 wasn't done with the right orchestra.

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September 3rd, 3870.

Phainon sits backstage, waiting for the strings to finish up the Serenade. He's dressed in his nicest suit, the Tchaikovsky sheet music resting open in his lap. He's using his last few moments to study it, before he plays it all from memory. He's been looking forward to this for months now, sure, but that does little to quell his anxiety.

Tribios sits next to him, fanning herself off with her own folder of music. She's already said several things meant to calm him down. None of them have worked.

Mydei is out there. The whole band is. He didn't get a chance to see them with his early call time, and the fact that they almost didn't make it on time. But they had. Mydei had pulled strings to shift their departure from Castrum Kremnos to be a day earlier, rather than on the day of their closing show in Okhema. Just so they could make it to the concert.
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The time comes for the rest of the orchestra to join the strings on stage, leaving Phainon in an empty room. He takes a deep breath, one that's shaky on the exhale, as he gets to his feet. His knees shake so violently he fears he might lose his balance.

Aglaea enters, dressed in a simple black suit. She nods at Phainon, and takes his hand. "You worked so hard for this," she says, in the kindest tone Phainon has ever heard from her. "You're about to make it all worth it."

Phainon nods, allowing himself to be led right outside the side doors to the stage. They listen to the full orchestra tune for a few moments, before they eventually fall silent.

"Good luck," Aglaea whispers.

Phainon pushes the doors open, and the applause starts.

He puts the most charismatic grin he can muster on his face as he walks out towards the piano. He bows before them, then turns to shake Hysilens' hand before they both sit down.

Moments later, Aglaea walks out, too. She bows before the podium as the audience claps for her, too, then steps up to face the orchestra. Phainon watches her closely as she feels out the tempo in her head. She picks up her baton, and the orchestra lifts their instruments. A measure of rest later, the horn solo sounds out around them, and Phainon places his hands on the keys in position for his entrance.

The moment he starts playing, all of his nerves dissipate. He and the orchestra are one, and he's never felt like he belongs more than he does at this moment.

He thinks of Mydei in the audience, but not enough to allow it to distract him. He's playing for Mydei, sure, but he's also playing for Aglaea. He plays for all of Okhema. For every fan that's ever attended one of his shows. For everyone that's ever loved this piece, and for everyone that's ever loved classical music as a whole. What he really wants is to do one of his favorite pieces of all time justice.

Not once does he mess up. His fingers don’t slip, he doesn’t miss notes. He times all his solos perfectly, his hands jump between octaves easily, and his triplets are all the right rhythms. Most importantly, though, his cadenzas are perfect.

By the end of the third movement, he doesn’t even feel tired. In fact, he can’t believe how much time has passed, despite how short it feels. As the last notes ring out throughout the concert hall, he finds that he wishes he had savored the moment more than he had. It all came to an end too quickly.

As soon as he takes his hands off the keys, the audience erupts. People are cheering. More than half the concert hall is already on their feet. Phainon feels like he wants to cry.

Aglaea motions for him to stand up. For a moment, Phainon thinks he is hallucinating, but the closer he looks, the more he can tell that there really is a small smile on her face.

He stands, bowing deeply as he faces the audience. It sounds like thunder behind him when the orchestra joins in, slamming their feet on the ground. When he rises, he clasps his hands to his chest. He can’t believe this level of support. He doesn’t think he’s ever experienced anything like it.

The orchestra stands next, and another wave of cheers sounds out from the audience. He’s supposed to shake Hysilens’s hand and leave the stage soon, but he’s way too giddy to follow the formalities. So he steps around the piano bench and pulls her into a hug instead.

“Okay, this is weird,” she says into his ear. He can only barely hear it over the sounds of the audience. “Okay. Enough. Leave.”

Phainon lets go, and she shakes her head as she sits back down. He then reaches over the piano to shake Aglaea’s hand, too, thinking that it might not go over very well if he hugged her, too.

The audience is still applauding for them as he walks off stage. He faces them, waving with both of his hands all the way until the doors, where he

finally disappears backstage.

There's a sound worker back there who shakes his hand, too, and congratulates him. Phainon is so filled with happiness that he feels like he could explode.

He waits back there for them to play through the Prokofiev. He can barely sit still, but manages regardless. The worker gives him a copy of the program, and he stares at his headshot underneath the blurb about the Tchaikovsky in disbelief. He can't believe he actually did it.

Nearly forty-five minutes later, Aglaea comes offstage first. Phainon can hear the applause as the door opens, but it quickly fades out as it closes behind her.

"Come on," she says, pulling him up to his feet. "One more time."

Phainon follows her out the doors again. The applause hasn't even subsided a little bit—if anything, when he comes back out, it only gets louder.

He bows again, unsure what else he can do to convey how grateful he feels. He wishes he could give a speech, but it's not that kind of show. He also wishes he had prepared an encore. But nearly all of his time for the past four months was spent preparing the Tchaikovsky, and that had obviously paid off.

After what feels like an eternity, the applause finally subsides. Phainon waves at the crowd again as he walks off, retreating to the green room where he had left his sheet music.

The rest of the orchestra files in shortly after. They swarm him, clapping him on the back and giving him gracious handshakes. Half of them don't even wait to put their instruments away before they approach him to offer their congratulations.

It feels like an eternity before he finally makes it out. He intends to give Aglaea her sheet music back, and finds her in the lobby stuck in a conversation with Anaxa, of all people. He spots Phainon first, stepping

away to shift Aglaea's attention. She looks irritated when she first turns around, but beams when she sees Phainon.

"Bravo, Phainon," she says, shaking his hand one more time.

"Yes, bravo," Anaxa chimes in. Aglaea shoots him her most venomous glare. Phainon supposes that despite working together for this concert, they still failed to reconcile their differences. Oh well.

When he hands her the sheet music, she pushes it back towards him and tells him to keep it. He shrugs, not wanting to press the issue. Aglaea has her ways of getting more library copies, anyway.

As soon as Phainon steps away, he hears them instantly resume their bickering. He doesn't care to listen to the basis of their argument. It was more than likely that it wasn't anything remotely important, anyway.

He's stopped a few more times as he tries to scan the crowd to find Mydei. He finally spots him in the corner, grouped up with the rest of his band and Cyrene. He seems to be arguing with Cipher. Castorice and Cyrene are catching up off to the side, and Hyacine appears to be searching for Phainon. They make eye contact, and she turns to get the others' attention.

Phainon rushes over before anyone else can stop him. Mydei turns, and his eyes light up when he spots Phainon. He pushes Cipher off to the side and comes forward, pulling Phainon into a tight hug.

Neither of them say much of anything. Phainon buries his face into Mydei's neck, and they squeeze each other so tightly that neither one of them can breathe.

Mydei smells nice. Fruity, like pomegranate. It's probably a new cologne, but it makes perfect sense on him, and Phainon can't figure out why.

"I missed you," Mydei says quietly.

"I missed you more," Phainon answers. His voice is muffled against Mydei's shirt.

Mydei kisses him as they pull away. “That was incredible,” he says. He looks teary-eyed. Phainon thinks he might be, too. “I knew you could do it. I knew you’d get through it, Phainon.”

“Stop,” Phainon whispers, waving him off. He looks at the three girls behind him, all of them waiting their turn to congratulate Phainon, too.

Hyacine comes up to hug him, next after Mydei steps aside. “I’m so proud of you,” she nearly squeals. “You made a full recovery, didn’t you?”

“I…” Phainon shakes his head. He can hardly believe it, too. “I guess?”

Cyrene says something about how she can’t wait for him to move out of her house. Phainon doesn’t think she actually feels that strongly about it. Castorice gives him her heartfelt congratulations next, with Cipher speaking up last. She mumbles something about how she “actually” enjoyed it.

“Don’t listen to her, Phainon,” Mydei groans, rubbing at his temples. “She was yawning the whole time and kept saying, ‘I could do that’.”

“Oh my god, I was not,” Cipher rolls her eyes.

“Isn’t there someone you should be talking to?” Mydei asks, turning on her fully.

“Wait, who—oh, fuck.” Cipher leans backwards, slamming her head against the wall. “Mydei, don’t make me do that.”

“I’ll go with you,” Castorice says. She pulls Cipher away, who protests the whole time. Phainon isn’t sure who they were talking about until he sees them disappear in Aglaea’s general direction.

“Well,” Hyacine says brightly, looking between Phainon and Mydei. “We’re staying at Cyrene’s tonight. So I guess we’ll be going?”

“Wait, what? What about my room?” Phainon demands.

Cyrene shoots him a deeply unimpressed look. “Sorry. Girl’s night.”

“*You’re kicking me out?!*”

“No,” Mydei cuts in. He crosses his arms, raising an eyebrow as he looks at Phainon. “You’re coming with me.”

“Oh. That’s fine, actually,” Phainon decides. He can’t believe he needed that to be spelled out for him so explicitly.

Hyacine and Cyrene head outside to wait for Cipher and Castorice to finish up. Phainon doesn’t know how long that would take, with Cipher speaking to Aglaea for what, as far as Phainon knows, is the first time in several years.

Mydei tags along as Phainon searches throughout the concert hall, finding everybody he needs to say his goodbyes to. He meets Tribios for the first time, and signs Livia’s shoe. Then, Phainon drops him off with his old group of friends and leaves them to catch up by themselves.

People mainly want to speak with both him and Aglaea. It takes far too long for the lobby to clear out, and by the time it does, he’s lost track of all the papers he’s signed and conversations he’s had. There are few that stick with him like the children who claim he’s inspired him.

He meets back up with Mydei when he’s done, snaking his hand around his shoulders. He’s in some kind of conversation with his old friends, all of them laughing—even Ptolemy. So he really did have it in him, then.

“Ready?” Phainon asks.

Mydei nods. He promises his friends he will keep in touch—to Phainon’s relief—and they bid him goodbye as both Mydei and Phainon finally head towards the doors.

“Good?” Phainon asks him. The hotel is in walking distance, so Mydei merely grabs his hand and starts guiding him there.

“It was nice to speak with them again,” Mydei admits. “Thank you.”

“So, how have you been?”

Mydei sighs heavily. “You know how I’ve been.”

“Yeah,” Phainon says, shrugging. “One more show.”

Mydei turns to look at him. “You’re going, right?”

“Of course.”

“Okay, good. If you weren’t, all my plans would fall through.”

“Your *plans?*”

“Stop asking questions.”

Phainon has a sneaking suspicion this has something to do with the song he wouldn’t reveal anything about. But Mydei has never been one to give away information when he doesn’t want to, so Phainon listens to him and shuts up.

The next morning, Phainon wakes up sweating. He groans as he sits up, rubbing his eyes to adjust to the bright morning light filtering in through the open windows. He smells terrible, and doesn’t immediately recognize the room he’s in, until he remembers the events of last night.

It’s Mydei’s hotel room. Why in the world he had decided to open the windows during an Okhema summer, he has no idea.

He rolls over to check the time on his phone. It’s nearly ten in the morning, and Mydei is nowhere to be seen. He had a habit of sneaking off in the mornings if he got bored when Phainon didn’t wake up early enough.

Phainon pays it no mind, pulling himself out of bed. He needs a shower, badly. He doesn’t think Mydei would care.

He can’t find Mydei’s toiletries, so he showers with the ones provided by the hotel. They’re terrible, but at least Phainon is clean.

The only clothing he has is the suit he wore last night, which just so happens to be strewn across the floor. So he rummages through Mydei's suitcase and throws on a pair of shorts and a CALAMITY t-shirt that he is honestly offended he doesn't own yet.

When he emerges from the bathroom, Mydei is back. He sits at the hotel desk, writing something in his notebook. He looks up when he hears the door open, and immediately lets out a deep sigh.

"You stole my clothes."

"What did you expect? I'm not wearing that suit again."

Mydei sighs again, turning back down to his notebook. "Come here."

Phainon doesn't need to be asked twice. He's peering over Mydei's shoulder in an instant, making sense of the music he appears to be writing out. It looks like a piano part, and vaguely familiar. He hums, thoughtful, and leans even closer.

"Can you play this?" Mydei asks. "Or—I mean, I know you can," he tries again. "I meant…can you play this, tonight?"

Phainon tears his eyes away from the sheet music, looking at him now. "What?"

"For my show," Mydei tries. He looks sheepish, unwilling to make eye contact with Phainon for longer than a second at a time. "I want you to play with me."

"At your show," Phainon says slowly. "Tonight."

"Yes, that's what I said."

Phainon takes the notebook in his hands, backing up until he sits at the end of the bed. "This is…" he starts, as he starts to be able to hear the melody Mydei has written in his head. It sounds achingly familiar, and sends chills down his spine. "Tchaikovsky."

“It’s in a different key…” Mydei says, like he’s been caught doing something he shouldn’t.

It is, but that doesn’t make much of a difference to Phainon. Mydei’s song is in C minor, while Tchaikovsky’s piano concerto is in B-flat minor. Regardless, the melody is the same. “When did you write this?” Phainon asks.

“Today.”

“You wrote this…*today*, and want me to play it *tonight.*”

“Yes, everything else in the song is the same. It’s just the piano solo that I switched for one inspired by your performance.”

Phainon is in disbelief. He flips through the previous few pages, scanning the rest of the song that Mydei had written. He can’t play it in his head unless he really focuses all his attention on it, but it looks promising nonetheless. The bridge builds more around the piano than the vocals. He had written this song with Phainon in mind, likely struck by more inspiration during Phainon’s concert last night. It nearly brings tears to his eyes.

“Mydei…”

“So can you do it?”

Of course Phainon can do it. The music is simple enough that he could sightread it right now with no problems. But that wasn’t what caused Phainon to hesitate.

“You don’t have to,” Mydei adds, when left with Phainon’s silence. “I just thought…I don’t know what I thought. I missed you.”

He doesn’t need to say much more than that. Phainon understands, and he knows Mydei doesn’t want to elaborate any further than he already has. He had thought Phainon was going to come on tour with him, and now, on his final show, he wants to share a bit of both of them with the audience. This

song was the perfect mix of the two of them. Phainon can't imagine anything better.

"When do we rehearse?"

Mydei grins, taking his notebook back out of Phainon's hands. "Now."

"What?"

"You heard me. We can take the bus."

"Take the bus *where?*"

"The venue is ours until four. Get your shoes."

The stage crew barely looks up when Mydei waltzes inside, merely giving him small nods. So he did have permission, but that didn't make Phainon feel any better about being here right now.

"Did you book this?" Phainon asks, just to make sure.

"Oh, come on," Mydei says, pulling him out on the stage. Phainon has been to this arena before, but he's never seen it in this state. Nor has he been on the stage before, staring out into thousands of empty seats. It feels surreal.

The rest of the band is already there. Cyrene sits in the first row of chairs, their only audience member. She waves at Phainon when he walks out.

Cipher gags as he passes. "Ew. You smell like him."

"I didn't have any clothes," Phainon protests. She plays something on her bass in lieu of a response, and pretends she hadn't heard him.

"Okay, positions," Mydei says, clapping his hands together like he's a show director. "Phainon, your sheet music is on the piano. Go."

“How long did you have this planned?”

“Months,” Hyacine answers. “We were really hoping you’d say yes.”

Phainon shakes his head, going to sit at the piano. It’s much worse quality than the one he had been playing last night. It’s not a full grand, for one, and it has a shitty sound to it that Phainon doesn’t particularly like. But it’s in tune, so he can’t complain too much.

The first run through sucks, and there’s no other way to put it. Phainon had thought he understood Mydei’s vision for the song through the sheet music he had scanned earlier, only to find that he was completely wrong. He gets lost just before his entrance and comes in unsure, which causes Mydei to forget the lyrics because now everyone else is confused and not just him.

“Phainon, what was that?” Mydei asks, turning to face him with one hand on his hip. “I thought you said you could play it?”

Phainon flips back to his first entrance, playing through his entire part at double speed just to prove that he knows how to play it. “*Clearly* it’s everybody else’s fault,” he says once he’s done.

Mydei shakes his head. “Again.”

Unfortunately, the four of them have all developed a language between each other that they can communicate with. They know each other’s playing styles better than anything, they know each other very well as both musicians and people, and they’ve already spent years working together to create music.

Phainon is new. He knows all of them, sure, but he hasn’t really worked with any of them. He doesn’t know how to read what everybody else is thinking and hasn’t perfected communication with everyone mid-song like he has with someone like Hysilens.

It takes a while before the music starts sounding like something. It’s a lot of trial and error, and little arguments between band members. Phainon observes from the side and notices that arguing seems to be the main form

of communication, especially between Mydei and Cipher. But neither Hyacine or Castorice stay quiet when they have something to say, either. When they direct their criticisms towards Phainon, too, he starts to think his feelings of inadequacy were asinine.

It's nearly three in the afternoon when they get it perfect for the first time. As the last strum of Hyacine's guitar rings out into the arena and eventually fizzles into nothing, nobody dares to be the first to say something.

Mydei is staring into space, Hyacine wipes at the corners of her eyes. From far out in the audience, Cyrene starts clapping enthusiastically.

"Okay, yeah, that was good." Cipher finally says.

"Fluke," is Mydei's response. "Two more times."

Phainon nearly slams his head into the keys. He's not certain, but he has a sneaking suspicion that this was something Madam Herta used to say to him.

He thinks he was joking, but then Mydei really does make them play it through two more times. The lack of comments the rest of the band have on this makes Phainon think this is something Mydei does to them often.

"Please don't say one more time," Phainon says, after the third time.

Before Mydei can, if he even wanted to, one of the sound workers comes onstage and asks them if they're ready to do a sound check now.

Phainon jumps offstage, into what will soon be the pit of the audience in just a few hours, and walks all the way back to where Cyrene is sitting while they start their sound check.

It's surprisingly fun to watch. Mydei is the pickiest, to no one's surprise, and keeps asking them to adjust things, especially on the piano. He supposes it's difficult to get the piano to stand out against the much louder instruments.

"I'm happy for you," Cyrene says, yawning. "You've really made it now."

Phainon sighs wistfully, propping his feet up onto the chair in the row before them. “I’m going to miss Okhema,” he admits. “Do you think Mydei would be okay with moving here eventually?”

“Oh, Phainon.” Cyrene rolls her eyes as she turns to look at him. “Mydei would do anything for you.”

“Anything?” Phainon raises an eyebrow. “I don’t know. He has so many more opportunities in Penacony.”

“Not after this album,” Cyrene says. “He can go wherever he wants. Success will follow.”

Phainon swallows. CALAMITY was extremely popular in Penacony, but they loved the band in Amphoreus just the same, since each of the members came from there. And moving didn’t necessarily mean he had to cut ties with his record label. Phainon supposes they can just communicate virtually.

At the end of the day, though, there were orchestras in Penacony that Phainon could play for—not to mention, there were orchestras in Penacony he’s played for before. And he has connections after graduating from Paperfold. It was just Aglaea’s orchestra that he wasn’t ready to cut ties with.

Phainon knew this was a small conflict compared to what they’ve already gotten through together. In the grand scheme of things, it wasn’t a very big deal at all.

Phainon waits backstage for most of the show. From behind the door, he hears everything: the screams of the crowd, the way Mydei talks to them in between songs, and Cipher’s bass. He hears her bass most of all.

He watches from a tiny screen they have so the workers can monitor the stage from inside. Mydei has changed since opening night. His stage

presence is electrifying. He exudes confidence—he's been overly confident since the day Phainon met him, but this is on a whole new level. He looks like he's exactly where he belongs.

By the time they've reached the final few songs on the setlist, the energy inside the arena feels uncontainable. Phainon isn't even on stage, and he can feel it. Adrenaline pumps through his veins like it never has before.

Mydei steps up to the microphone after a few moments basking in their cheers. His hair is damp with sweat, and three of the buttons on his shirt are undone. Phainon can't wait for this show to be over, so he can finally have him to himself.

"Before we finish up tonight, I want to play something new."

Their cheers nearly have the floor beneath Phainon's feet shaking. He can feel his heart beating in his throat as he prepares himself to walk out on stage. He doesn't know if he can handle a crowd this large. He's performed in his fair share of pretentious concert halls, but this is a different situation entirely.

"It's, um," Mydei starts, and the cheering instantly subsides. Everyone is listening carefully to what Mydei has to say. "A love letter to music…and the person who reminded me why I fell in love with music in the first place. I call it *Play It With Feeling*."

Phainon wishes the floor would swallow him whole. He can barely handle it when Mydei says things like this to his face, never mind to an audience of thousands.

"And he happens to be in the area, so I asked him to join me tonight."

The crowd explodes. Phainon thinks he can hear Hyacine say something in response to the volume, but it barely registers over the sounds of their screams.

"Phainon?"

He isn’t sure what to expect as he pushes the door open and walks out on stage, but they somehow get even louder. He tries to look into the crowd and wave, but the spotlight in his eyes is blinding.

Mydei finds him, used to stages like these, and wraps an arm around his shoulders. He’s wet. Phainon doesn’t know what it says about him that it doesn’t disgust him.

Mydei asks him something, but Phainon can’t quite make out what it says. The microphone rests at his side, hanging from his free hand. It doesn’t pick up what they say to each other.

Phainon turns to him. He looks even more stunning from up close, in his stage makeup. “You’re beautiful,” he whispers in Mydei’s ear, unable to say anything else.

Mydei doesn’t say anything to that, merely nudging him towards the piano. “I guess he’s nervous,” he says, to the crowd this time. A mix of laughter and cheering sounds in response.

Phainon sits at the piano, lighting tapping one of the keys. It plays much louder than he was expecting around them, and he nearly jumps. He supposes that makes sense, though.

Mydei spends some time connecting his microphone back to the stand. “Are we ready?” He asks, voice a little quieter than before as he turns to look at each of the band members.

Phainon gives him a thumbs up. He’s not sure if there’s an agreed upon gesture between them, but he supposes a thumbs up is pretty much universal.

With little warning, Hyacine plays the opening riff.

The audience falls into dead silence. Phainon is impressed at how easily they seem to be able to wrangle a rowdy crowd into obedience.

When Mydei starts singing, Phainon feels as though he could hear a pin drop in the audience. They all hang onto his every word as no one but him and Hyacine play the opening verse of the song.

In fact, it's so quiet that Phainon feels afraid to breathe, for fear of ruining what they have. And then Castorice joins in on light, barely there taps of her drums. Cipher's part is equally subtle. When Phainon finally starts, it's behind all of them, only growing into a crescendo as the rest of the band fades away.

And then Mydei finishes, and Phainon takes over, with the chords leading into the part he's sampled from Tchaikovsky. He plays it just as he had last night. It doesn't feel any different, playing with Mydei's band versus playing with Aglaea's orchestra.

Mydei starts singing again, and the rest of the band comes back a thousand times louder. Phainon feels like he's fighting to be heard on top of their instruments. The climax is much more exciting live than it had been in their rehearsals.

He takes his hands off the keys just as all the other parts fade out, too. Silence falls around them as Mydei pulls his microphone off the stand, bringing it close to his lips as he finishes the final verse, with no one but Hyacine accompanying him. Just as they had in the beginning.

He turns to Phainon as he sings the final line of the song. Phainon holds his eye contact, afraid of what might happen if he didn't.

For a brief, terrifying moment, it feels like no one but he and Mydei are on stage. The rest of the lights fall into darkness, illuminating just the two of them.

And then all the lights are on again, and the crowd's roaring sounds in the background, breaking Phainon out of his thoughts. He had been so focused on Mydei alone that he didn't register the song ending.

Mydei pulls him to his feet, bringing him to the front of the stage and forcing him to bow. He didn't even know they did that at rock concerts.

“Phainon Khaslana, everybody,” Mydei nearly yells into his microphone. They get impossibly loud at that. Phainon isn’t used to hearing applause this rowdy.

Mydei pulls him into a hug, mic once again discarded at his side. “I love you,” he says into Phainon’s ear. Just loud enough for him to hear it this time.

Phainon pulls away. “I love y—”

Mydei surges forward, kissing him on the lips. Phainon can faintly hear the crowd lose their mind.

He doesn’t care. He has never cared about any of them. Here, with Mydei, making music, is exactly where he’s meant to be his whole life.

He’s never been so sure about anything else.

Chapter End Notes

this is the first ever chapter that has been beta read. as in a whole second real person beta read it, and it wasnt just me. bit late isnt it.

anyways. this is it! i know ive talked a lot of shit about this fic while posting it but just know that its out of love. i am very proud of myself for finishing it (first thing ive finished in years) and am happy with the work ive done here. i wanted to spread my love of music through my favorite ship of all time. and im glad that its reached all the people it has.

but thank you thank you thank you for reading my writing and for all the comments and kudos :) i appreciate them all very much.

▶ eee

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